

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

THE COMPLETE SERIES

The Confessions, Explained

All Thirteen Books, in Nine Parts

Augustine of Hippo wrote it around the year 400. It is a prayer, and you are overhearing it. This is the whole of it explained in the plainest English available, with none of the hard parts cut out.

READ AND EXPLAINED BY

Lovepreet Singh

About This Volume

This is the whole of *The Confessions, Explained* in one file: nine parts, ninety chapters, covering all thirteen books of Augustine's *Confessions* from the first word to the last.

Each part still stands on its own. The parts were written and published separately and nothing in them has been altered here. Every one opens with a Where We Left Off recap, and every one closes with its own timeline, glossary and sources note. If you read the volume straight through you will meet some material twice; that is the price of each part being usable alone, and it was judged worth paying.

The page numbers run continuously. Each part originally began again at page one. In this volume every page carries its number in the sequence of the whole book, and the part-title pages are counted but not numbered, as usual. The contents and the three indexes all refer to volume pages.

Six kinds of box run through the whole series. Word Box explains a hard term the moment it first appears. In Real Terms turns something abstract into something you can picture. How We Actually Know This names the evidence and says what it cannot show. The Argument is for places where experts genuinely disagree, and gives each side its strongest case. The Hidden Assumption digs out the premise everybody is quietly taking for granted. Remember This closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

Three indexes are at the back, and they are the reason this volume exists rather than nine files. Every Hidden Assumption in the series, every Argument, and every term given a Word Box, each with the page it is on. The first two are the parts of the series most worth looking things up in.

One correction that a reader of the separate parts should know about. Part One argued that the thirteen books are a single work composed as one. Part Seven, Chapter One revised that: the work is unified in argument and was almost certainly written in instalments, and those are two separate claims that Part One wrongly carried together. Where the two disagree, Part Seven is the standing position. It has not been edited back into Part One.

Contents

Nine parts, ten chapters each. Page numbers are volume pages.

Part One — The Restless Heart · Book I

<i>Part-title page, Where We Left Off, contents</i>	7
Chapter One — The Man, the Place and the Book	13
Chapter Two — What the Word "Confessions" Actually Means	17
Chapter Three — The Shape of the Whole Book	21
Chapter Four — The First Sentence, and the Restless Heart	26
Chapter Five — The Baby He Cannot Remember	31
Chapter Six — The Jealous Baby	35
Chapter Seven — How He Learned to Talk	39
Chapter Eight — School, the Cane and His First Prayer	43
Chapter Nine — Crying for Dido	47
Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know	53

Part Two — The Pears and the Manichees · Books II–III

<i>Part-title page, Where We Left Off, contents</i>	63
Chapter One — The Year Off	67
Chapter Two — In Love with Being in Love	71
Chapter Three — The Pears: What Happened	75
Chapter Four — Why a Bishop Spends Half a Book on Fruit	78
Chapter Five — Doing Wrong for No Reason at All	81
Chapter Six — "I Would Not Have Done It Alone"	85
Chapter Seven — Carthage: The Cauldron	89
Chapter Eight — A Lost Book That Changed a Life	94
Chapter Nine — The Bible Disappoints, the Manichees Persuade	97
Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know	104

Part Three — The Dead Friend and the Disappointing Bishop · Books IV–V

<i>Part-title page, Where We Left Off, contents</i>	113
Chapter One — Nine Years as a Hearer	117
Chapter Two — Reading the Stars	121
Chapter Three — The Friend Who Died	125
Chapter Four — The Grief	128
Chapter Five — Why He Calls the Grief a Fault	131
Chapter Six — Loving Things That Can Be Lost	135
Chapter Seven — The Book He Wrote and the Book He Understood	139
Chapter Eight — Faustus	142

Chapter Nine — The Shore, Rome, and Milan	147
Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know	154

Part Four — Milan, Ambrose, and Where Evil Comes From · Books VI–VII

<i>Part-title page, Where We Left Off, contents</i>	164
Chapter One — Monica Arrives, and the Bishop Who Read in Silence	168
Chapter Two — The Beggar in the Street	173
Chapter Three — Alypius at the Games	176
Chapter Four — Thirty Years Old and Stuck	181
Chapter Five — The Woman Is Sent Away	185
Chapter Six — Firminus, and the End of Astrology	190
Chapter Seven — The Obstacle	193
Chapter Eight — The Books of the Platonists	197
Chapter Nine — Where Evil Comes From	201
Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know	207

Part Five — The Garden · Book VIII

<i>Part-title page, Where We Left Off, contents</i>	217
Chapter One — Knowing, and Not Moving	221
Chapter Two — The Old Professor Who Had a Statue	225
Chapter Three — Why a Book About One Conversion Contains Four	229
Chapter Four — Ponticianus, the Courtiers, and Antony	233
Chapter Five — "Give Me Chastity, But Not Yet"	238
Chapter Six — The Two Wills	241
Chapter Seven — Against the Manichees One Last Time	245
Chapter Eight — The Garden	248
Chapter Nine — Tolle Lege	251
Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know	256

Part Six — The Water, the Window and the Grave · Book IX

<i>Part-title page, Where We Left Off, contents</i>	265
Chapter One — Leaving Quietly	269
Chapter Two — Cassiciacum	273
Chapter Three — The Toothache	278
Chapter Four — The Water	281
Chapter Five — Adeodatus	285
Chapter Six — Monica, Told Backwards	289
Chapter Seven — The Window	295
Chapter Eight — What Is Being Claimed	299
Chapter Nine — Nine Days	304

Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know	310
 Part Seven — The Vast Palace of Memory · Book X	
<i>Part-title page, Where We Left Off, contents</i>	321
Chapter One — The Book That Should Not Be Here	325
Chapter Two — What Do I Love When I Love My God?	330
Chapter Three — The Palace of Memory	333
Chapter Four — What Is Actually In There	337
Chapter Five — Everybody Wants It and Nobody Can Name It	341
Chapter Six — Late Have I Loved You	344
Chapter Seven — The Man at the Desk	348
Chapter Eight — What He Is Still Tempted By	351
Chapter Nine — Four Words	357
Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know	363
 Part Eight — What Is Time? · Book XI	
<i>Part-title page, Where We Left Off, contents</i>	373
Chapter One — Why the Last Three Books Are About Genesis	377
Chapter Two — “What Was God Doing Before?”	380
Chapter Three — Made Out of Nothing	385
Chapter Four — The Question	388
Chapter Five — The Past and the Future Do Not Exist	391
Chapter Six — Then What Are We Measuring?	396
Chapter Seven — A Stretching of the Mind	399
Chapter Eight — The Hymn	403
Chapter Nine — What Happened Next	407
Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know	412
 Part Nine — The First Sentence of the Bible · Books XII–XIII	
<i>Part-title page, Where We Left Off, contents</i>	422
Chapter One — What Is Left	426
Chapter Two — The Top and the Bottom of Everything	429
Chapter Three — Can Anything Exist Without Form?	432
Chapter Four — The Page That Matters	435
Chapter Five — And If the Author Did Not Mean It?	439
Chapter Six — Why He Is Being So Nice	444
Chapter Seven — The Six Days, Read as Something Else	448
Chapter Eight — The Trinity in the Shape of a Mind	453
Chapter Nine — The Day With No Evening	456
Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know	460

Indexes

Index of Hidden Assumptions	470
Index of Arguments	472
Index of Terms	474

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART 1 OF 9

The Confessions, Explained

Part One — The Restless Heart

*Who Augustine was, what the word Confessions actually means,
and the whole of Book One: the baby, the beatings, and the
first sentence that has kept people arguing for sixteen centuries.*

READ AND EXPLAINED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Why I Wrote This

There is a book that almost everybody has heard of and almost nobody has finished. It was written about sixteen hundred years ago by a man in North Africa. It is called *Confessions*. People call it the first autobiography ever written in the West. They also call it one of the hardest famous books there is.

Both of those things are true at once, and that is the problem.

The book is hard for three reasons, and none of them is that the ideas are too clever for you. The first reason is that it is a prayer. Every sentence is addressed to God, not to you, so you are reading somebody else's post. The second reason is that it is soaked in another book, the Bible, and it quotes it constantly without saying so. The third reason is that the man writing it assumed his readers already knew things that nobody now knows: how a Roman school worked, what a Manichee was, what people in the year 400 thought a soul was made of.

Fix those three and the book opens. That is what this series does.

I am going to walk through *Confessions* from the first word to the last, in nine parts. I will use short sentences and ordinary words. I will explain every hard term the moment it turns up, in a box, on the spot. You will never be told to look something up later.

But I am not going to make it shallow. That is the trade everybody else makes, and it is a bad one. Simple words do not have to mean simple content. Every argument in the book goes in. Every place where scholars genuinely disagree goes in, with both sides given their best shot. Every place where the honest answer is "nobody knows" gets said out loud instead of smoothed over.

One warning before we start. This is a religious book, and it is a religious book that a great many people still live by. I am not going to tell you whether Augustine was right. When he makes a claim about God, I will tell you what he claims, why he claims it, what his argument is, and where that argument has been attacked. Whether you buy it is your business, not mine. Where my own view could tilt the writing, I will say so in the text at the point where it applies.

How to Read the Boxes

This book uses six kinds of box. Each one does a different job. Here is one of each, live, so you know what they mean when you meet them.

WORD BOX

Word Box: this box appears the first time a hard word turns up. It gives you the plain-English meaning immediately, so you never have to guess or flip to a glossary.

Why it matters: most of what makes old books unreadable is not difficult thinking. It is undefined vocabulary.

The second box turns numbers and distances into things you can actually picture. A number you cannot feel is just decoration on the page.

IN REAL TERMS

Augustine was born in 354. That number is meaningless on its own. So try this instead. If you line up grandparents, each one born roughly thirty years before the next, it takes about fifty-five of them to walk back from today to the year Augustine was born. Fifty-five people, hand to hand. That is the whole distance.

The third box shows you the evidence. Not the conclusion. The actual physical thing that someone looked at.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

We know when *Confessions* was written partly because Augustine told us himself, late in life, in a book where he went back through everything he had ever published and commented on it. He also refers to events we can date from other records.

What this evidence cannot do: it cannot tell us whether he wrote the thirteen books in one push or in stages over several years. His own later note is a summary, not a diary. It says what the work is, not how the writing went.

The fourth box is for the places where experts genuinely disagree. Each side gets its strongest case, not a version built to be knocked down.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THIS THE FIRST AUTOBIOGRAPHY?

You will see the claim everywhere that *Confessions* is the first autobiography in Western literature. It is repeated so often that it sounds like a settled fact. It is not.

YES, IT IS THE FIRST

Nothing before it does what this book does. Earlier writers described their careers, their opinions and their public deeds. Augustine describes his inner life changing over time. He tracks what he wanted, why he wanted it, and how the wanting itself shifted. He treats his own mind as something to be investigated rather than displayed. That is the thing modern autobiography does, and he does it first.

NO, THE LABEL IS ANACHRONISTIC

Calling it autobiography imports a modern genre that did not exist and measures the book by a standard it was not trying to meet. It is addressed to God throughout. Four of its thirteen books contain no life story at all. It skips things a memoir would centre on and dwells on things a memoir would cut. If you call it autobiography, you will be permanently puzzled by its own shape.

Where things stand: Both sides agree on the facts and disagree about the label. The book really does contain sustained first-person inward narrative that has no clear precedent. It really is also structured as prayer and ends with four books of scriptural interpretation. What is being argued about is which of those two facts should name the book.

What would settle it: Nothing will settle it, because it is not an evidential question. It is a question about how we sort books into kinds. A new manuscript would not help.

Why people care so much: The label decides what you expect. Call it autobiography and the last four books look like a mistake. Call it a prayer and they look like the point.

The fifth box is the one this series exists for. It digs out the thing everybody in an argument is quietly taking for granted.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A LIFE HAS A PLOT

Every argument about whether Augustine tells the truth about his own past assumes something neither side states: that a life *has* a shape, and that the writer either reports that shape correctly or distorts it.

But a life is not a story until somebody makes it one. Nothing that happened to Augustine arrived labelled as a turning point. The turning points were assigned later, by him, once he knew where the road had gone.

That is not lying. It is what everyone does with their own past, including you. The interesting question is not whether Augustine shaped his life into a plot. He obviously did. It is whether a life can be described at all without doing that.

The general form: mistaking an interpretation for a report.

The sixth box closes every chapter. It says the chapter again in the plainest words available. If you read only these boxes across all nine parts, you should still come away with the whole argument.

REMEMBER THIS

This series explains **Augustine's *Confessions*** from beginning to end, in nine parts, in ordinary language, without cutting the hard parts out.

Six boxes carry the load: **Word** for vocabulary, **In Real Terms** for numbers, **How We Actually Know This** for evidence, **The Argument** for genuine disputes, **The Hidden Assumption** for the unexamined premise underneath a dispute, and **Remember This** for the summary.

Simple words, serious content. Those are two separate dials, and this book turns them in opposite directions.

Contents

Chapter One — The Man, the Place and the Book

Who he was · Thagaste and Numidia · his mother and father · the empire he was born into · how old he was when he wrote

Chapter Two — What the Word "Confessions" Actually Means

The trap in the title · the three meanings of confessio · why this is a prayer and not a memoir · who he is really talking to

Chapter Three — The Shape of the Whole Book

Thirteen books, not chapters · what is in each one · the join at Book Ten · why the last three books look like a different book

Chapter Four — The First Sentence, and the Restless Heart

The opening move · the most quoted line he ever wrote · the circle he walks straight into · where is God, exactly?

Chapter Five — The Baby He Cannot Remember

Why he starts before memory · the evidence problem · what he says infancy is like · the questions he refuses to answer

Chapter Six — The Jealous Baby

The scene at the breast · the argument he builds on it · what original sin does and does not mean · the modern objection

Chapter Seven — How He Learned to Talk

The famous passage · what he actually claims · why a twentieth-century philosopher opened his masterpiece by quoting it

Chapter Eight — School, the Cane and His First Prayer

The prayer not to be beaten · the adults who laughed · the double standard he spots · what a Roman school was really like

Chapter Nine — Crying for Dido

What he was made to read · the complaint about false tears · Latin loved, Greek hated · the illness and the baptism that did not happen

Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Genuinely unknown · solid · and one assumption turned on this book itself

Reference

Timeline · glossary · about the author · a word on sources · what comes next

CHAPTER ONE

The Man, the Place and the Book

Before a single line of Confessions will make sense, you need four things: the man, the town, the parents and the empire. None of it is complicated. All of it is assumed by the text.

1.1 — Who he was, in one paragraph

His name was Aurelius Augustinus. In English we call him Augustine. He was born on 13 November 354 in a small town in what is now Algeria, in North Africa. He was clever, ambitious and poor. He clawed his way up through the Roman education system, became a professional public speaker, moved to Italy, and got a good government job. Then, at thirty-one, he gave the job up, became a Christian, went home to Africa, and spent the rest of his life as a bishop in a coastal town. He died there in 430, at seventy-five, while an army was besieging the city walls. In between he wrote more than a hundred books. Two of them are still read constantly. One is *The City of God*. The other is the one we are reading.

That is the whole life. Everything else is detail. But the detail is where the book lives, so we will do the detail.

1.2 — Thagaste: the town

He was born in a town called Thagaste. Today it is called Souk Ahras and it sits in eastern Algeria, not far from the Tunisian border. In the fourth century it was a modest provincial town in a Roman province called Numidia.

WORD BOX

Numidia: a Roman province covering roughly what is now northern Algeria. Inland, agricultural, and not poor, but a long way from where decisions were made.

Why it matters: Augustine spent his youth trying to get out of it, and the second half of his life running a church inside it. The pull between the provinces and the centre is under a great deal of what he writes about ambition.

Thagaste was not a village and it was not a city. It had a school, a forum, public baths, and enough money circulating for a family of modest means to educate a son if they strained for it. Africa in this period was not a backwater in the way people sometimes imagine. It grew a

large part of the grain that fed Rome. It had its own vigorous churches, its own ferocious church politics, and a literary culture in Latin that produced first-rate writers.

What it did not have was proximity to power. If you wanted a career, you went to Carthage first, then Rome, then the imperial court. Augustine did exactly that, in exactly that order.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Most of what we know about Augustine's early life comes from his own account in this very book, which is a problem we will keep meeting. But not all of it. We also have a biography written shortly after his death by Possidius, a bishop who had known him personally for about forty years. We have around three hundred of his letters and hundreds of his sermons, many of them recorded live by shorthand writers as he preached.

What this evidence is good at: dates, places, offices held, controversies, who he was writing to and when. Administrative and public facts are well covered.

What it is bad at: his inner life before he became famous. For his childhood we have essentially one witness, and that witness is Augustine at forty-three, writing with a purpose.

1.3 — Patricius and Monica

His father was called Patricius. He was a town councillor, which sounds grander than it was.

WORD BOX

Decurio (town councillor): a member of a Roman town council. It was a position of local standing, and it came with a catch. Councillors were personally liable for any shortfall in the taxes their district owed. If the town could not pay, the councillors made up the difference out of their own pockets.

Why it matters: it explains how a family could be respectable and permanently short of money at the same time. Augustine describes his father scraping to fund his education while other men no richer than him did not bother.

Patricius was not a Christian for most of his life. He was baptised only shortly before he died, which happened when Augustine was around sixteen or seventeen. Augustine mentions him rarely and without much warmth. He records that his father had a temper and that his mother handled it by keeping quiet until he had cooled down.

His mother was called Monica. She is the other main character of the first nine books, and she does not go away. She was a Christian, seriously and unrelentingly so. She wanted her son baptised. She followed him across the Mediterranean when he tried to leave her behind. She wept, argued, petitioned bishops, arranged a marriage for him, and lived to see him converted before dying almost immediately afterwards.

How you feel about Monica will shape how you read the whole book, and readers split on her sharply. Some find her the moral centre of the story. Others find her overwhelming and are

troubled by how much of Augustine's religious life was arranged by his mother. Augustine himself is aware that she is a lot, and he says so, though not in those words.

There is one detail worth holding on to now, because it explains a scene in Chapter Nine. Monica was a Christian who did not have Augustine baptised as a baby. That looks strange today. It was not strange then, and we will come to why.

1.4 — The empire he was born into

Augustine was born forty-two years after the emperor Constantine won a battle that began the process of turning Christianity from a persecuted minority religion into the official religion of the Roman state. This matters enormously and it is easy to get backwards.

By the time Augustine was a young man, being a Christian was not brave. It was increasingly normal, and increasingly useful. The church was becoming a route to influence. This is exactly why his conversion, when it comes, is not simply a story about belief. It is also a story about giving up a career at the moment that career was working.

IN REAL TERMS

The Roman empire of Augustine's day was not a country in any sense you would recognise. It ran from Scotland to Syria, and a message from one end to the other took months.

A letter from Augustine's town to Rome went by cart and ship. In good weather, with luck, it might take three weeks. In winter, when the sailing season closed, it might simply not go at all until spring.

So when he later hears about a political event in Italy, he is hearing news that is roughly as fresh as a letter posted before you were told about it. Everybody in this book lives at the speed of a ship.

The empire was also visibly under strain. Roman armies were losing to groups from beyond the frontier with a frequency that would have shocked earlier generations. In 410, when Augustine was in his fifties, the city of Rome itself was sacked. That event is what pushed him into writing *The City of God*. It falls a decade after *Confessions*, but it tells you the direction things were moving.

1.5 — When he wrote it, and how old he was

Augustine wrote *Confessions* between roughly 397 and 400. He was in his early forties. He was already a bishop, and he had been one for only a couple of years.

Hold that in your head, because it changes the book. This is not a young man's diary. It is not written in the heat of the events it describes. It is a middle-aged professional, a decade past his conversion, six years into the priesthood, looking back at a self he no longer is and writing about him in the third person in all but grammar.

IN REAL TERMS

A gap of ten to thirteen years sits between the events at the centre of this book and the writing of it.

Think of something that happened to you thirteen years ago and that changed your life. Now write down what you were thinking at the time. You will produce something true and something shaped. You will not be able to separate the two cleanly, and neither could he.

Being a new bishop matters too, and in a practical way. Augustine had a past. He had spent nine years in a religion the church regarded as dangerous. He had lived with a woman he never married and had a son with her. Some people in the African church thought a man like that had no business being a bishop. One of the things this book does, deliberately, is put the whole record on the table before anyone else can.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT CONFESSION IS THE OPPOSITE OF SELF-DEFENCE

When people argue about whether *Confessions* is sincere or strategic, both sides assume that these two things pull in opposite directions. Either he is baring his soul, or he is managing his reputation. Augustine does not appear to hold that assumption at all. In his hands, putting your worst material on the table in public is the defence. The strongest position available to a man with a past is to be the one who describes that past most unsparingly, and to make the description an act of worship rather than an apology.

Once you see that, the sincere-or-strategic question stops being a real question. It was built out of a modern instinct that honesty and advantage cannot occupy the same sentence.

The general form: treating two motives as rivals because we would find them uncomfortable together.

None of that proves he was honest. It removes one bad reason for thinking he was not. Those are different things, and this series will keep them apart.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine was born in **354** in **Thagaste**, a small town in Roman North Africa, in what is now Algeria. He died in **430**.

His father **Patricius** was a town councillor, not a Christian until the end, and permanently stretched for money. His mother **Monica** was an unrelenting Christian who shaped his life and follows him through nine books.

He wrote *Confessions* around **397 to 400**, in his early forties, about ten to thirteen years after the events at its centre, and only two years into being a bishop.

This is not a young man writing in the heat of the moment. It is a middle-aged official with a controversial past, writing about a younger self he can no longer fully reach.

CHAPTER TWO

What the Word "Confessions" Means

The title is the first thing that misleads people, and it misleads them badly. Get the title right and half the book's strangeness disappears.

2.1 — The trap in the title

Say the word "confession" today and one picture arrives. Somebody admits to something they did wrong. A suspect confesses to a crime. A friend confesses that they lied. A Catholic goes into a small booth and tells a priest their sins. The word means owning up.

So people pick up *Confessions* expecting a list of misdeeds. A catalogue of what Augustine got up to before he found religion. Sex, mainly, is what most readers arrive expecting, because that is the reputation the book has.

Then they open it and find page after page of prayer, philosophy, biblical quotation and argument, with the actual misdeeds occupying a surprisingly small amount of space. And they conclude that the book is badly organised.

It is not badly organised. The title means something else.

2.2 — The three meanings of confessio

The Latin word Augustine used was *confessio*. In Christian Latin of his period it carried three distinct senses at the same time, and he uses all three deliberately.

WORD BOX

Confessio: a Latin word covering three things at once.

One, confessing sin. Admitting what you did. This is the meaning we have kept, and it is the smallest of the three in this book.

Two, confessing faith. Declaring publicly what you believe. This is the sense in which a martyr on trial "confessed" before a judge. It has nothing to do with guilt.

Three, confessing praise. Saying out loud that God is great. This use comes straight out of the Psalms, which Augustine had by heart.

Why it matters: the book is doing all three simultaneously on almost every page. If you only hear the first meaning, most of the book will read as padding around the good bits.

Augustine himself defined it compactly in a sermon as the accusation of oneself and the praise of God, held together. He was aware that ordinary listeners heard only the first sense, and he complained about it. When his congregation heard the word, he said, their fists went straight to their chests in the penitent gesture, whatever he had actually meant.

So the title is not "My Sins". It is closer to something like "Saying Aloud What Is True": true about me, which is mostly bad, and true about God, which is entirely good, in a single continuous act of speech.

2.3 — Which makes it a prayer, not a memoir

This is the single most useful fact about the book, so here it is plainly.

Every sentence of *Confessions* is addressed to God. Not to the reader. To God. It is written in the second person, throughout, to a listener who is not you.

Once you know that, several things that seemed like flaws turn into features. Augustine keeps telling God things God would obviously already know, such as where he was living in a particular year. That looks absurd until you notice it is what people do in prayer constantly, and what they do in the Psalms constantly. He also breaks off the story for pages of praise. In a memoir that is a digression. In a prayer it is the main verb.

IN REAL TERMS

Imagine reading somebody's side of a phone call. You hear every word they say. You never hear the other person. You have to work out from their replies what is being said back.

That is exactly the reading position *Confessions* puts you in, for about three hundred pages in a modern translation. You are not the person being spoken to. You are the person who happens to be in the room.

That is also why the book is not embarrassed by its own intimacy. Augustine is not confiding in you. He is talking to someone else in front of you, which is a completely different social act, and a much easier one to do at full honesty.

2.4 — Then who is he actually talking to?

Here is where it gets more interesting, because the answer is not just "God".

Augustine knew perfectly well that this text would be copied and read aloud. Books in his world circulated by being read out to groups. He designed it that way, and each of the thirteen books works as a single sitting. He also tells us directly, in Book Ten, why he is doing this in public rather than in private, and his answer is that other people can be stirred up by it.

So there is a second audience, listening in by design. And there is a third, which is more pointed: his critics. He had them, and they had material.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Late in his life Augustine wrote a book going back over everything he had published, correcting and commenting. It is usually called the *Retractationes*, which does not mean "retractions" in the modern sense of taking something back. It means reconsiderations.

In it he says what he thought *Confessions* was for. His answer, in substance, is that it was meant to stir the mind and feelings of the reader towards God, and that it had that effect on him while writing it and still did when people read it to him.

What this source is good at: telling us his own settled later view of his own work. It is a direct statement of purpose, written decades on, with nothing to gain.

What it cannot do: tell us his motives at the time of writing. A man explaining his own book thirty years later is a good witness to what the book became and a weaker one to what he was thinking when he started it.

Notice what that combination produces. A text addressed to God, designed to be overheard by supporters, and readable by enemies as a complete and unflattering account of his own past given voluntarily. It is a difficult thing to attack. You cannot expose a man who has already published the file.

2.5 — The Bible underneath every page

One more thing before we start reading. *Confessions* is stitched through with quotations from the Bible, especially the Psalms, and Augustine almost never flags them. He does not write "as the Psalm says". He simply drops into the words of a psalm mid-sentence and out again.

WORD BOX

The Psalms: a collection of a hundred and fifty religious poems in the Jewish scriptures, which Christians inherited. Many are addressed directly to God and swing between complaint, guilt, pleading and praise, sometimes within a few lines.

Why it matters: the Psalms are the model for the whole book. The strange emotional gear changes in *Confessions*, from self-accusation to celebration and back, are not Augustine being unstable. He is writing in an existing form and expecting you to recognise it.

His first readers heard those quotations the way you would hear a famous song lyric dropped into a conversation. They landed with all their original context attached. You will not hear them, and no ordinary translation can give that back to you. A good annotated edition marks them in the margin, which is one reason it is worth having one.

I will point out the important ones as we go, but I want to be honest about the size of the loss. You are reading a text that was written for people who had another book memorised. That is not a small gap and I cannot close it for you. I can only tell you it is there.

REMEMBER THIS

The word **confessio** means three things at once: confessing **sin**, confessing **faith**, and confessing **praise**. Modern English kept only the first, which is why the title misleads.

The book is a **prayer**, addressed to God from first word to last. You are not the person being spoken to. You are overhearing.

It was written to be **read aloud**, with a second audience of supporters and a third of critics who had reason to question a man with his past becoming a bishop.

It is soaked in **the Psalms**, usually unmarked. Its emotional swings are borrowed from that form, not signs of an unstable author.

Stop expecting a memoir of misdeeds. It is a public prayer that happens to contain a life.

CHAPTER THREE

The Shape of the Whole Book

Thirteen books. Nine of life story, one of philosophy, three of Bible commentary. That shape has puzzled readers for sixteen centuries, and the puzzle is worth understanding before you start.

3.1 — Thirteen books, not thirteen chapters

The work is divided into thirteen parts, and every edition calls them books. That word is confusing now. They are not thirteen volumes. Each one is roughly the length of a long magazine article, and each was designed to be read aloud at a single sitting.

WORD BOX

Book (in an ancient work): a unit of text sized to fit one papyrus roll, and later kept as a division even after rolls were replaced. Think chapter, but a chapter that stands on its own and ends where it means to end.

Why it matters: the divisions are not arbitrary. Each of the thirteen has its own beginning, its own argument and its own close. If you read straight through them as though they were chapters in a novel you will miss the joints.

Inside each book, editions add two further layers of numbering: chapters and sections. So a reference like 1.8.13 means book one, chapter eight, section thirteen. Some editions cite only two numbers. Some cite three. This is annoying and there is nothing to be done about it. In this series I will name the book and describe where in it we are, so you can find the place in any edition you happen to own.

IN REAL TERMS

A modern English translation of the whole of *Confessions* runs to roughly three hundred pages, plus notes.

Divided by thirteen, that is about twenty-three pages per book. Read aloud at an unhurried pace, one book is somewhere near an hour.

So the whole thing is about thirteen evenings. That is the unit the author designed for, and it is still the best way to take it.

3.2 — What is in each of the thirteen

Here is the entire book on one page. You do not need to memorise it. You need to be able to come back to it.

Book	What it covers	Part of this series
I	Infancy and boyhood in Thagaste. Learning to speak, school, beatings, the Aeneid. The opening prayer and the restless heart.	Part 1
II	Sixteen years old. Idleness at home, sexual awakening, and the theft of the pears: the most analysed petty crime in literature.	Part 2
III	Carthage. Cicero's lost book turns him towards philosophy. He reads the Bible and finds it crude. He joins the Manichees.	Part 2
IV	Teaching at Thagaste and Carthage. Astrology. The death of a close friend, and a grief he could not explain to himself.	Part 3
V	The famous Manichee teacher turns out to be a disappointment. He sails to Rome without telling his mother, then moves to Milan.	Part 3
VI	Milan. Ambrose. Monica arrives. His partner of many years is sent away so he can marry advantageously. Friends and ambition.	Part 4
VII	The philosophical crisis. Where does evil come from, if God is good? He reads the Platonists and something breaks open.	Part 4
VIII	The conversion. The garden in Milan, the voice, the book, and the line he had been dreading for years.	Part 5
IX	Baptism. The retreat to the countryside. The conversation at Ostia with his mother, and then her death.	Part 6
X	The story stops. A long examination of memory, and of what he is still tempted by now, as a bishop, at the time of writing.	Part 7
XI	What is time? One of the most influential pieces of philosophy ever written, and it arrives without warning.	Part 8
XII	The first verse of Genesis, and the question of how to read a text when several readings are defensible.	Part 9
XIII	The days of creation, read as an allegory of the church and the soul. The book ends in praise and rest.	Part 9

3.3 — The join at Book Ten

Look at that table again and you will see the problem everyone sees. Books one to nine tell a life story that ends in 387. Book ten stops the story dead and examines memory. Books eleven to thirteen leave Augustine entirely and interpret the opening verses of the Bible.

To a modern reader this looks like two or three different books bound together by accident. It is the single most common reason people abandon *Confessions* around page two hundred.

Before we look at the arguments, note one thing about the join. Book nine ends with Monica dead and Augustine baptised. Book ten opens with him asking what he is *now*. The narrative has caught up with the writer. There is nowhere further forward to go. Whatever else is happening, the story does not stop arbitrarily. It stops because it has arrived.

THE ARGUMENT — ARE THE LAST FOUR BOOKS A DIFFERENT BOOK?

Some readers and some scholars hold that *Confessions* falls apart after Book Nine. Others hold that the last four books are what the first nine were for. This has been argued about for a very long time and it is not settled.

IT IS TWO WORKS JOINED

The change is not subtle. Nine books of narrative, then none. The audience shifts, the tempo shifts, the subject shifts. Genesis commentary was a standard genre and Augustine wrote several. It is entirely plausible that material of that kind was attached to a finished autobiographical work, either by him or in a later edition. Some have argued Book Ten in particular shows signs of being inserted after the rest was complete.

IT IS ONE DESIGN THROUGHOUT

The book moves outward on purpose: from one infant, to one man, to memory in general, to time itself, to the creation of everything. That is a single expanding argument, not a change of subject. It also runs on a deliberate echo: the opening of Genesis is about something being made out of formless matter, which is exactly what Augustine says happened to him. And the very first words of the work are a quotation from a psalm of praise, while the very last pages end in praise and rest. A work that begins and ends in the same key was planned that way.

THE UNITY IS IN THE WORD CONFESSIO

A third position accepts the change of subject and denies it is a change of activity. If *confessio* means confessing sin, confessing faith and confessing praise, then the first nine books confess his sin, the tenth confesses his present state, and the last three confess what he believes about God and creation. The verb never changes. Only the object does.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes the facts of the structure. What is disputed is whether the structure is a seam or a shape. The unity readings have gained ground over the last several decades, and most specialists now treat the work as a designed whole rather than an assembly, but the disunity case has never been refuted and continues to be argued.

What would settle it: A manuscript showing an earlier circulating version without Book Ten would settle a great deal. None has ever turned up, and after sixteen hundred years the chance of one appearing is small. Failing that, the question stays a question of literary judgement, where the evidence is the text itself and people reading the same text reach different verdicts.

Why people care so much: It decides whether a reader is allowed to stop at Book Nine and feel they have read the book. A great many people do exactly that. If the unity case is right, they have read the setup and skipped the argument.

My own practice, for what it is worth, is to treat the work as one thing, because the connections between the parts keep turning out to be real when I look for them. But I hold that loosely, and I will flag it whenever it is doing work in how I present something.

3.4 — How to actually read it

Three practical notes, because this series is meant to be used alongside the real thing.

First, translations differ enormously. This is not a book where any version will do. Nineteenth-century translations are free and out of copyright and are what you will find online, but their English is heavy and their punctuation obscures the shifts of address. Modern translations are considerably easier and mark the biblical quotations. If you can, use a modern annotated one.

Second, read one book at a sitting if you can. The units were built that way. Reading half of Book Eight is like leaving a piece of music halfway through a phrase.

Third, do not start at Book Eight. People do, because that is where the famous scene is. It does not work. The garden scene is the release of a tension that seven books have been winding up, and taken alone it reads as a man having a small emotional episode about a gardening book.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A BOOK HAS ONE SUBJECT

The whole dispute in the box above rests on a premise both sides share without stating it: that a well-made book is about one thing, and that if you can identify a change of topic you have found either a fault or a hidden unity that dissolves the change.

That premise comes from a particular tradition of writing, and it is not obvious. Plenty of texts Augustine knew intimately do not work that way at all. The Psalms move between subjects without transition and nobody accuses them of poor structure. A sermon moves from a story to a doctrine to a reproach and back, because the point is not the topic but the effect on the listener.

If *Confessions* is that kind of text, then asking what its subject is may be the wrong question entirely. The right question would be what it is trying to do to the person hearing it, and by that measure a change of subject is not evidence of anything.

The general form: judging one kind of thing by the rules of another, without noticing you have chosen the rules.

That box is not a verdict on the argument. Both readings can survive it. It is a note that the argument may be smaller than it looks, because it inherits a standard from a genre invented much later.

REMEMBER THIS

The work has **thirteen books**, each about twenty-three pages in a modern translation and each designed to be read aloud at one sitting.

Books **I to IX** are life story, ending in 387. Book **X** stops the story and examines memory and his present temptations. Books **XI to XIII** interpret the opening of Genesis.

Whether that is a **seam** or a **shape** is genuinely disputed. Unity readings now dominate, but nothing has settled it, and nothing is likely to.

Read it a book at a time, in order, in a modern translation. Do not start at the famous bit.

CHAPTER FOUR

The First Sentence, and the Restless Heart

Augustine opens with a line almost everyone has heard and a problem almost nobody notices. Within four paragraphs he has walked himself into a circle and admitted it.

4.1 — How the book begins

Most books begin by telling you what they are about. This one begins by praising God, in words lifted straight out of a psalm, before Augustine has introduced himself or said what he intends to do. God is great, he says, and greatly to be praised. Then he says that a human being wants to praise God, and that this human being is a small piece of creation who carries his own death about with him.

That is the first move, and it sets the pattern for everything that follows. Augustine never describes himself except in relation to God. He does not begin with a birth and a family. He begins with a size comparison.

Then comes the sentence.

4.2 — "Our heart is restless"

The line, in plain English, runs roughly: you have made us for yourself, and our heart is restless until it rests in you.

It is the most quoted thing Augustine ever wrote. It is on posters and coffee mugs. It is worth slowing down on, because it is doing more work than a slogan.

Three things are packed into it. The first is a claim about design: human beings were made *for* something, and therefore have a proper object, the way an eye has light. The second is a claim about experience: restlessness is the normal human condition, not a personal failing or a mood. The third is a diagnosis linking them: the restlessness is not random. It is what wanting the wrong-sized thing feels like from the inside.

IN REAL TERMS

Augustine's picture of desire is closer to hunger than to shopping.

You can be hungry and not know it. You can eat something that is not food, feel full for twenty minutes, and be hungrier afterwards. You can chase the wrong thing repeatedly and read the failure each time as bad luck rather than as a clue about what you actually needed.

That is the whole of his argument about human wanting, and the next eight books are a case study in it, with himself as the subject.

Notice what the sentence is not. It is not a promise that religious people feel calm. Augustine is writing it as a bishop, ten years past his conversion, and Book Ten will be a long account of how much he is still pulled about by ordinary appetites. The rest he is describing is not psychological comfort. It is more like a compass finding north: the needle still moves, but it now moves around something.

4.3 — The circle he walks into immediately

Having praised God, Augustine asks an obvious question and then notices it is not obvious at all. He wants to call on God. But to call on someone you have to know who you are calling. And to know God, he thinks, you would already have to have received something from God. So which comes first?

This is a genuine logical trap and he does not pretend otherwise. You cannot look for something unless you already know enough about it to recognise it when you find it. But if you already knew it, you would not need to look.

WORD BOX

The problem of enquiry: an old puzzle, usually traced to Plato. Either you know what you are looking for, in which case there is no search, or you do not, in which case you would not recognise it if you tripped over it.

Why it matters: Augustine hits this in the first paragraphs and it structures the whole book. His eventual answer is that the searching itself is evidence that something has already been given. You would not be restless if you had never been made for anything.

His provisional answer at this stage is faith: you call on God in order to come to know him, rather than knowing first and calling second. He is aware this looks like cheating. He raises the objection himself. It is a habit worth watching for, because he does it constantly: state the obvious objection to your own position, out loud, before your opponent does.

4.4 — Where is God, exactly?

Then he asks a question that sounds childish and is not. If he is calling God to come into him, where is God coming from? And where would God fit?

He works through it with real persistence. If God fills heaven and earth, do heaven and earth contain God? If they do, God is smaller than the universe, which cannot be right. If God overflows them, where does the overflow go? Is there a part of God in a small thing and a bigger part in a big thing? That would mean God has parts, which he thinks is impossible. Or is God wholly present everywhere at once, in which case what does the word "everywhere" even mean?

WORD BOX

Divine simplicity: the claim that God has no parts. Not that God is easy to understand, but that God cannot be divided into components, and does not have properties the way a thing has properties. God does not *have* goodness; on this view, God is goodness.

Why it matters: it is the engine of this whole passage. If God had parts, then more of God could be in one place and less in another, and every question Augustine is asking would have an easy answer. Because God has no parts, none of them does.

He does not resolve it. He piles the questions up and then breaks off. What is he doing? Two things, at once, and they pull in opposite directions.

The first is genuine argument. Each of those questions is a real dead end for a crude picture of God, and knocking those pictures down is necessary work. In particular he is demolishing the idea that God is a very large invisible substance spread out through space, which is close to what he himself believed for years and which we will meet properly in Part Two.

The second is rhetoric. Augustine was a professional speaker. Piling up unanswerable questions in escalating pairs is a technique, and he was one of the best in the empire at it. Both things are true simultaneously, and readers who insist on only one of them get him wrong in opposite directions.

4.5 — The stack of contradictions

Shortly after, he does something that startles first-time readers. He describes God in a run of statements that flatly contradict each other. God is hidden and utterly present. God never changes and changes everything. God is always working and always at rest. God gathers and lacks nothing. God supports and fills and shelters. God searches, and is owed nothing, and is angry without being disturbed.

A modern reader's instinct is that this is word-play covering an absence of content. Augustine's position is the opposite. He thinks the contradictions are the content.

His reasoning goes like this. Human language was built by creatures inside time to describe things inside time. Every word available carries that shape. So any single statement about a

God outside time will drag in something false. Two statements that pull in opposite directions can between them mark out a position that neither could hold alone. It is a way of pointing at something you cannot name, using words that individually fail.

And then, having finished the run, he says the thing that makes the passage work: he asks what anyone can say when speaking about God, and admits that those who say most are the ones who have said nothing.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THIS CHRISTIANITY, OR PLATONISM IN A ROBE?

From the seventeenth century onwards, some readers have argued that Augustine is essentially a Platonist philosopher who found Christian vocabulary for positions he already held. Others argue that he took specific tools from the Platonists and used them for something they could not have supported. The passage we have just read is one of the main pieces of evidence on both sides.

IT IS PLATONISM UNDERNEATH

The God of these paragraphs is unchanging, without parts, outside time, known by turning inward and upward. That is the God of the Platonist philosophers of his period, not obviously the God of the Hebrew scriptures, who argues with people and changes his mind. Augustine says himself that reading certain Platonist books was decisive for him, and Book Seven will describe how. Where his conclusions and theirs diverge, it is often because a doctrine required it rather than because an argument forced it.

IT IS A CHRISTIAN USING PLATONIST TOOLS

The Platonists gave him a way to think about a reality that is not made of stuff, and that was what he needed. But he takes their framework and inserts into it things it cannot hold: a God who becomes a particular human being at a particular date, a creation made from nothing rather than shaped from eternal matter, and a rescue that comes as a gift rather than as an achievement of the wise. He says explicitly in Book Seven that the Platonist books contained one thing and lacked another. The lack is the whole point.

THE QUESTION IS BADLY POSED

A third view: there was no sealed Christianity sitting on a shelf for Augustine to either preserve or contaminate. Christian thought in the fourth century was being built, in Greek and Latin, out of whatever materials educated people had, and those materials were philosophical. Asking whether he smuggled Platonism into Christianity assumes a boundary that his own century was still drawing.

Where things stand: Everyone agrees the Platonist debt is real, large, and admitted by Augustine himself. Everyone agrees he also holds positions no Platonist held. The dispute is about which of those is the frame and which is the addition, and that is a judgement about emphasis rather than a disagreement about texts.

What would settle it: Very little would settle it. We can compare his language with the surviving Platonist writings, and scholars have done so in great detail. That establishes the borrowing, which nobody denies. It cannot establish which commitment was load-bearing for him.

Why people care so much: For some readers a great deal rides on whether the central figure of Western Christian thought was importing pagan philosophy. That is a question about authority, not about the fourth century, and it tends to make the historical argument hotter than its evidence can support.

I will say plainly where I stand, since this series will keep touching it. I find the third position most useful and I will tend to write from it. You should read my treatment of Book Seven knowing that, and discount accordingly.

REMEMBER THIS

The book opens in **praise**, quoting a psalm, before Augustine introduces himself. He never describes himself except in relation to God.

The famous line, that we are made for God and are **restless until we rest in him**, contains a claim about design, a claim about experience, and a diagnosis connecting them. It is not a promise that believers feel calm.

He immediately hits the **problem of enquiry**: you cannot look for what you do not already know. He raises the objection against himself rather than waiting for an opponent, which is a habit worth watching for.

His questions about **where God is** are demolishing the idea that God is a very large invisible substance in space. He held that idea himself for years.

The contradictions are deliberate. He thinks language built inside time cannot describe what is outside it, so he uses two failures to triangulate one target.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Baby He Cannot Remember

He starts his life story before his own memory begins, which means his account of infancy is not memory at all. He knows this. What he does about it is more interesting than hiding it.

5.1 — Starting before the beginning

Having spent several pages on God, Augustine turns to himself, and does something unexpected. He does not start at his earliest memory. He starts earlier: at infancy, and then reaches back further still, to before his birth, and asks what he was then.

A modern autobiography would skip this. The convention is to open with either a first memory or a family background. Augustine opens with a period he has no access to whatsoever, and spends real effort on it.

Why? Because his subject is not events. His subject is what a human being is, and how it goes wrong, and the earliest possible stage is where you would look for that. If there is something disordered in human wanting, he wants to know whether it is there before anyone could have learned it.

5.2 — The evidence problem, and how he handles it

Here is the thing readers usually miss. Augustine is explicit that he does not remember any of this. He says so directly. And he tells you where his account actually comes from.

It comes from two places. The first is what he was told: his parents and others described his infancy to him, and he passes it on as report. The second, and much the more important, is that he watched other babies. He says so plainly. What he knows about infants he knows from observing infants, and he has assumed he was like them.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The evidence for Augustine's infancy is: hearsay from his family, plus his own later observation of unrelated babies, plus an inference that he resembled them.

He states all three. He does not dress the account up as recollection. That is a genuinely unusual piece of intellectual honesty for the period and it is easy to walk past.

What this evidence supports: general claims about what infants do. Anyone can check those against a baby.

What it cannot support: any claim about what the infant Augustine specifically did, felt or wanted.

When he writes about baby Augustine, he is writing about a reconstruction, and the reconstruction is doing work in an argument about human nature that he has reasons to want to win.

That last point is worth sitting with, because it is the sort of thing that gets waved through. A man is describing his own babyhood. He tells you the description is assembled from other people's babies. And then he uses it to argue something large about human nature. Both halves of that are unusual, and the second is only defensible because he was so open about the first.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT AUTOBIOGRAPHY REPORTS MEMORY

Arguments about the reliability of *Confessions* almost always turn on whether Augustine remembered accurately. Defenders say his memory was good and his purpose sincere. Critics say he reshaped events to fit a conversion narrative written a decade later.

Both sides assume that the material of autobiography is memory, and that the question is how faithfully it was transmitted.

But look at what Augustine actually does in these pages. He builds a section of his own life story out of observation of strangers and general inference. No memory is involved at any point, and he says so. He is not reporting a preserved record. He is constructing a plausible earlier self from evidence available in the present.

If that is what a life story is made of even in the hands of someone with every reason to prefer recall, then the reliability question has been asked in the wrong shape. The interesting question is not how well he remembered. It is what a person is entitled to claim about a self they cannot reach.

The general form: treating a reconstruction as a transmission, and then arguing about the fidelity of the transmission.

That box cuts in an awkward direction, and I want to be straight about it. It does not defend Augustine. It removes a defence and an attack at the same time, and leaves a harder question standing where both used to be.

5.3 — What he says infancy is actually like

His picture of babyhood is not sentimental. It is closer to a description of frustration.

An infant, he says, has wants and almost no way to get them met. It cannot act on the world.

It has a very small number of signs available: crying, flailing, noises. Those signs do not match

what it wants. So it makes them anyway, and the adults around it either guess correctly or do not, and when they do not, the infant rages at people who are not obeying and who could not possibly have understood.

That last observation is sharper than it looks, and we will need it in the next chapter. The baby is not angry at being denied something it was owed. It is angry at not being obeyed. Augustine thinks that distinction matters a great deal.

IN REAL TERMS

Picture being fully conscious, in a room where you cannot move, cannot speak the language, and cannot point.

You need something. The only signal you can produce is a shout, and the same shout means every different thing you might need. People come and go. Sometimes they bring the right thing. There is no way to tell them they got it wrong except by shouting again.

Augustine's point is that this is not a peaceful state and never was. We call it innocence because it is harmless, and it is only harmless because the creature is small.

5.4 — The questions he refuses to answer

Reaching back past infancy, he asks whether he existed before he was born. Was there some earlier state? Was there a time or place where he was somebody, before this life?

He does not know. He says so. He turns the question over, notes that he has nobody to ask, since neither his parents nor anyone else can report on it, and lets it stand unresolved.

This is worth pausing on for two reasons. The first is simply that a famous theologian writing a religious book says "I do not know" about a religious question and moves on without embarrassment. He does that repeatedly, and it is one of the reasons the book has lasted.

The second is that the question was live. Some philosophical schools of his day held that souls existed before bodies. That was a serious position with serious defenders. Augustine spent much of his life declining to settle where souls come from, and he was still declining decades later. Leaving it open here is not vagueness. It is a considered refusal that he maintained under pressure for forty years.

One more thing before we leave this chapter. Notice that he treats his own existence as something requiring explanation. Not "I was born in 354 to these parents", but "I came from somewhere, and I do not know where, and the fact that I am here at all is the first thing that needs accounting for". That instinct, to find the ordinary astonishing, is most of what separates this book from the memoirs that came before it.

REMEMBER THIS

He begins his life story **before his own memory**, and says openly that he remembers none of it.

His account of infancy is built from **hearsay**, from **watching other babies**, and from the inference that he was like them. He tells you this. It is a reconstruction, not a recollection.

His picture of babyhood is **frustration**, not peace: full wants, almost no signals, and rage at not being obeyed by people who could not have understood.

He asks whether he existed before birth and answers "**I do not know**", and kept refusing to settle that question for the rest of his life.

He starts before memory because his subject is not what happened to him. It is what a human being is, and infancy is the earliest place to look.

CHAPTER SIX

The Jealous Baby

One short paragraph about a child at the breast has caused more anger than anything else in Book One. It is also the load-bearing wall of a doctrine that shaped Western Christianity for fifteen hundred years.

6.1 — The scene

Augustine asks what his sin was as a baby. Crying for milk? He notes that if a grown man behaved that way he would be laughed at, or slapped down. Then he says he has seen something with his own eyes. He has watched a small child who could not yet speak, at the breast, going pale with fury at another infant feeding alongside it.

That is the whole scene. It is a few lines long. Almost everything controversial in Augustine's account of human nature can be traced back to it.

He is careful about one thing, and readers regularly miss it. He does not say the baby is wicked. He says the behaviour is not innocent, and that we tolerate it only because the creature is too weak to do harm. His word for infant innocence is not "purity". It is closer to "weakness of limbs".

6.2 — What he builds on it

The argument runs in three steps, and it is tighter than its reputation suggests.

Step one. The baby has no notion of property, no learned greed and no cultural training. It has not been taught to want more than its share. There has not been time.

Step two. It rages anyway, at a rival, over a resource that is not even scarce. There is enough milk. The fury is not about need.

Step three. Therefore whatever is producing that response cannot have been learned. It was there on arrival.

That is the inference. Something in human wanting is disordered from the start, before experience, before choice, before anyone could have taught it. He is not describing bad parenting. He is arguing that the problem predates parenting.

WORD BOX

Original sin: the claim that human beings arrive already damaged, rather than starting neutral and going wrong through choices. On this view the damage is inherited, not committed, and it shows up as a will that is pulled towards the wrong objects before it has learned anything.

Why it matters: it is the difference between thinking of humans as broadly fine but corruptible, and thinking of them as needing rescue. Almost every disagreement in Western Christianity about grace, free will and salvation runs back to which of those you accept.

Two things this does *not* mean, because both are constantly attributed to Augustine by people who have not read him. It does not mean that babies are guilty of anything they did. And it does not mean that human nature is evil. Augustine holds firmly that everything that exists is good precisely because it exists, and that evil is not a thing but a wrongness in how a good thing is aimed. We will do that argument properly in Part Four, where it is the centre of the book.

6.3 — Why the baby, specifically

It is worth asking why Augustine reaches for an infant rather than a thief or a murderer. He had better examples available. He uses one himself in Book Two.

The answer is that the baby is the only case where he can rule out everything else. An adult's greed can always be explained by upbringing, hardship, bad company or habit. A baby has none of those. If you want to show that something is native rather than acquired, you have to find it in a creature that has acquired nothing.

That is a real argumentative move and it deserves credit as one. Whether it works is another matter.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE JEALOUS BABY EVIDENCE OF ANYTHING?

This passage draws more objection than any other in Book One, and the objections are not all the same objection. Here are the strongest versions of each side.

THE ARGUMENT FAILS ON THE FACTS

An infant of a few months has no concept of another mind, no theory of ownership, and no capacity to intend a wrong. What Augustine saw was distress at a competitor for a caregiver's attention, which is a mechanism found across social mammals and is easily explained by evolutionary pressure. Calling it sin requires the creature to be capable of a moral act, and this one is not. Augustine has taken a description of behaviour and slid it into a moral category without justification.

THE ARGUMENT SURVIVES, RESTATED

Augustine is not claiming the baby is culpable. He explicitly denies the baby is punishable. His claim is narrower: that the *pattern* of wanting visible here is not learned, and that the same pattern, once it acquires power and reasons, is what adult wrongdoing is made of. Restated as a claim about inherited dispositions rather than infant guilt, it is not obviously refuted by anything modern psychology says. Some would argue modern work on in-group preference and self-interest in very young children supports it.

THE DISAGREEMENT IS ABOUT THE WORD

A third reading holds that the two sides agree about the baby and disagree about vocabulary. Both accept that the behaviour is innate, unlearned, self-serving and directed at a rival. The dispute is whether "sin" may be applied to something innate. For Augustine it may, because sin in his usage names a condition as well as an act. For his critics it may not, because sin in modern usage names only acts. Neither is discovering anything about infants.

Where things stand: There is no dispute about what infants do. There is a genuine dispute about whether Augustine has shown what he thinks he has shown, and a further dispute about whether "sin" can name a condition nobody chose. That second dispute is about the meaning of a word, and it is often mistaken for the first.

What would settle it: Nothing available. No observation of babies can settle whether an unchosen condition counts as sin, because that is not a question about babies. It is a question about what moral language is for. Anyone who tells you the science has resolved this has changed the subject.

Why people care so much: Enormous stakes ride on it. If humans arrive damaged, they need rescuing and cannot rescue themselves, which supports a particular account of grace, of the church and of what a person can achieve alone. If they arrive neutral, the whole structure is optional. That is why an argument about a feeding infant has been fought as though empires depended on it. For a while, they did.

I will not adjudicate that, and I want to say clearly that I am declining rather than being unable. The evidential part of it is genuinely open, and the verbal part of it cannot be closed by evidence at all.

6.4 — Where this goes: a promise to be paid later

One forward note, because this argument does not stay in Book One.

About twelve years after finishing *Confessions*, Augustine got into the biggest fight of his life over exactly this. His opponent was a British or Irish teacher named Pelagius.

WORD BOX

Pelagianism: the position, associated with a teacher called Pelagius, that human beings are born morally undamaged and are genuinely able to choose good without special divine help. On this view sin is always an act, never an inherited condition, and holding otherwise makes God unjust and human effort pointless.

Why it matters: it is the direct denial of what Augustine argues from the jealous baby. The dispute ran for two decades, involved emperors and councils, and ended with Pelagius's position condemned. Augustine's side won, and Western Christianity has argued about the terms of that victory ever since.

It is worth knowing that Pelagius is reported to have been provoked specifically by a line in *Confessions*. The line, from Book Ten, asks God to give what he commands and then command whatever he wants. Pelagius is said to have found that intolerable, because it seemed to make human effort a spectator sport.

I am flagging it now because it tells you the stakes of the paragraph you have just read. This is not a curiosity about babies. It is the seed of the largest theological argument of Augustine's life, and he did not know that when he wrote it. Part Seven will take it up properly, at the point where the provoking line appears.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine watched a **speechless infant go pale with rage** at another baby feeding beside it, and built an argument on it.

The argument: the baby has learned nothing, the milk is not scarce, and it rages anyway. Therefore what produces the rage was **not learned**.

He uses a baby precisely because it is the one case where upbringing, hardship and habit can all be ruled out.

He does **not** say babies are guilty, and he does **not** say human nature is evil. He says infant innocence is weakness of limbs rather than purity of will.

This short passage is the root of the doctrine of original sin, and the seed of the twenty-year fight with Pelagius that defined the last stretch of his life.

CHAPTER SEVEN

How He Learned to Talk

A few sentences about a toddler working out what words are. Fifteen hundred years later, the most influential philosophy book of the twentieth century opens by quoting them.

7.1 — The passage

Augustine describes how he moved from making noises to using words. He was not taught, he says, by adults presenting him with a syllabus. He worked it out. When the grown-ups named something and turned towards it, he noticed, and he grasped that the thing was being picked out by the sound they made. Their intention showed in their bodies: in where their eyes went, in a movement of the hands, in the tone of voice. Bit by bit he collected which sounds went with which things, and once he could make the sounds himself he could say what he wanted.

That is it. It is a short passage in the middle of a chapter about growing out of babyhood, and Augustine does not present it as a theory. He is describing something and moving on.

Look closely at what is actually in it, because the details matter for what follows. There is a sound. There is a thing. There is an adult orienting towards the thing. There is a child inferring a connection from that orientation. And there is a motive: he wanted things, and words got them for him.

7.2 — What he is actually claiming

On the surface this is a picture of how a child breaks into a language it does not yet have. Three features are worth pulling out.

The child is active. Nobody teaches him. He observes, infers and tests. Augustine is describing intelligence at work before speech, which is a striking thing to notice in the fourth century.

The evidence is bodily. The connection between sound and thing is not read off the sound. It is read off where people are looking and how they move. Meaning arrives through gesture.

The engine is desire. He learns words because he wants things and words are how you get them. Language enters his life as a tool for obtaining, which fits the picture of infancy in the previous chapter exactly.

Note also what he says immediately afterwards, which almost never gets quoted. Having learned to speak, he says, he was launched into the stormy society of human life. Learning to talk is not presented as a happy graduation. It is entry into a world of dealings with other people, and the metaphor he reaches for is weather at sea.

7.3 — Why a twentieth-century philosopher opened with this

In 1953, two years after his death, Ludwig Wittgenstein's *Philosophical Investigations* was published. It is generally counted among the two or three most important philosophy books of the last century. It opens, before Wittgenstein has said anything in his own voice, with this passage from Book One of *Confessions*, quoted in Latin.

WORD BOX

The Augustinian picture of language: Wittgenstein's name for a way of thinking about words that he thought was seductive and wrong. On this picture, words are names, names stand for objects, sentences are combinations of names, and the meaning of a word is the object it stands for.

Why it matters: Wittgenstein thought this picture was buried in almost all previous philosophy, including his own earlier work, and that it quietly produced a great deal of confusion. He used Augustine's paragraph as the clearest available statement of it.

His objection, roughly, is this. If meaning is a relation between a word and an object, then language is a naming ceremony, and everything else we do with words has to be explained as a variation on naming. But most of what we do with words is nothing like naming. We ask, order, joke, greet, count, promise, curse, thank and pray. Try to describe those as labels attached to objects and you will produce nonsense. What makes a word mean something is not what it points at. It is how it is used, in a shared activity, by people doing something together.

Wittgenstein also thought the picture contains a specific blind spot about learning.

Augustine's child already understands what pointing is, what a name is, and that sounds can pick out things. It arrives, in effect, knowing everything except the vocabulary. Wittgenstein said this describes a child who already has a language and is learning a second one, not a child entering language for the first time.

That is a genuinely sharp criticism. Whether it lands on Augustine is a separate question, and it is disputed.

THE ARGUMENT — WAS WITTGENSTEIN FAIR TO AUGUSTINE?

Wittgenstein made this passage famous, and he made it famous as an error. Scholars of Augustine have been objecting to that framing for decades. Here is each side at full strength.

WITTGENSTEIN WAS FAIR

He never claimed to be doing history. He said the words give *a* picture of the essence of language, and he chose Augustine because the statement is unusually clear and unusually free of technical apparatus. The target is a temptation, not a man. Choosing a great mind rather than a weak one is the opposite of a strawman: it shows that even the best get pulled this way. And the passage really does say what he says it says.

WITTGENSTEIN WAS UNFAIR

Augustine wrote an entire dialogue on language, *De Magistro*, in which he argues that pointing cannot by itself establish meaning, that signs do not teach, and that words fail to convey anything unless the hearer already grasps the reality. Those are close to Wittgenstein's own objections, made in the fifth century by the man being corrected. A famous paper by Myles Burnyeat pressed this hard. On this reading, quoting the paragraph without the dialogue presents Augustine's casual description as his considered theory.

IT WAS NEVER ABOUT AUGUSTINE

A third position takes the passage as functioning like an epigraph. It puts the reader in a frame of mind. Wittgenstein was attacking a view he had himself held in his earlier book, and the whole *Investigations* is in large part an argument with his younger self. Reading the opening quotation as an attack on Augustine mistakes the direction of fire.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes that the passage says roughly what Wittgenstein reports. Nobody disputes that *De Magistro* contains a more sophisticated account. The dispute is over whether a philosopher who names a picture after a writer incurs an obligation to that writer's complete works. Practice varies and so do opinions.

What would settle it: Wittgenstein's own notebooks would help, and have been mined thoroughly, but they show him interested in the passage for what it evokes rather than in Augustine's theory of signs. That supports the epigraph reading without clinching it. Beyond that there is nothing left to find.

Why people care so much: The fight matters to Augustine scholars because a caricature attached to a famous name is very hard to remove, and generations of philosophy students met Augustine only as the man who got language wrong on page one.

One footnote worth having. Wittgenstein also engaged with Augustine on time, from Book Eleven, and treated him there as a serious philosopher wrestling with a real puzzle rather than as an example of a mistake. So the relationship between the two books is not simply hostile. We will come back to it in Part Eight, where the time material lives.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A WORD IS A LABEL

Both sides of the argument above accept the same starting point without examining it: that a theory of language has to explain how words connect to the world, and that the child's problem is working out which sound goes with which thing.

That is not obviously the problem. A child does not first meet a world of separate objects and then learn labels for them. The carving of the world into nameable things is not given in advance; a great deal of it arrives with the language. Where one thing stops and the next begins is not something a toddler reads off the furniture.

If that is right, then the disagreement about whether Augustine described labelling correctly is downstream of a much larger question that neither he nor his critic raises here: whether there were separate things to be labelled before there were words to do it.

The general form: arguing about how two lists are matched, when the question is who wrote the second list.

For what it is worth, I think Augustine gets closer to this than he is given credit for, because his account leans so heavily on gesture and intention rather than on the sound alone. But that is a reading, and other readers see a naming ceremony and nothing more.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine describes learning to talk by **watching where adults looked and how they moved**, and working out which sounds picked out which things. He is not taught. He infers.

Three things are in the passage: the child is **active**, the evidence is **bodily**, and the engine is **desire**. He learns words because words get him what he wants.

Wittgenstein opened *Philosophical Investigations* by quoting it, and named the view he was attacking the **Augustinian picture of language**: words are names, meaning is the object named. Whether that was fair is genuinely disputed, because Augustine's dialogue *De Magistro* argues almost the opposite, and Wittgenstein may have been quoting his own younger self through Augustine's mouth.

A paragraph Augustine wrote in passing became, fifteen centuries later, the opening move of modern philosophy of language.

CHAPTER EIGHT

School, the Cane and His First Prayer

His first recorded prayer was a request not to be hit at school. It was not granted. What he does with that memory is one of the sharpest passages in the book, and one of the most puzzling.

8.1 — The first prayer

Augustine remembers being small and being sent to school, and hating it. He remembers being beaten there for not attending to his lessons. And he remembers praying, as a little boy, with real urgency, that he would not be beaten. He says he was not a small sinner for such a small boy, and he means it as a joke against himself.

The prayer failed. He was beaten anyway. And here is the detail that gives the passage its edge: when he was beaten, the adults laughed. His parents included. They found his terror funny.

He records this without much visible bitterness, which is itself worth noticing. He does not use it to indict his parents. He uses it as evidence of something about the world.

8.2 — The double standard he spots

The argument he draws from it is careful and it is easy to skim past.

He was beaten, he says, for playing instead of studying. The charge was that he preferred games to work. But the adults who beat him also played. They had their own amusements, which they took extremely seriously, and which they did not call playing. They called them business.

And when a schoolmaster lost at his own pursuits, Augustine observes, the man raged more than a boy ever did over a game of ball.

So the difference between the child's ball game and the adult's occupation is not that one is trivial and the other serious. It is that one is punished and the other is not, and the person deciding which is which is the one holding the cane.

Everybody arguing about education, then and now, assumes that some activities are inherently serious and others inherently frivolous, and that the job of schooling is to move children from the second towards the first.

Augustine has just quietly denied this. He points out that the adult and the child are doing the same thing with the same intensity, and that the only difference is which one of them can impose a description on the other.

Note what this does to the argument he is having. He is not saying school was unfair to him personally. He is saying that "serious" is not a property an activity has. It is a status an activity is granted, by whoever has the power to grant it. Then, having said that, he applies it to himself as an adult and concludes that his own grown-up pursuits are a boy's ball game with better clothes.

The general form: reading a power relation as a fact about the world.

This is not an anti-school passage, and it is worth being clear about that because it is often read as one. Augustine goes on to say that he is glad he learned what he learned, that reading and writing turned out to be genuinely useful, and that some of the compulsion was justified. He is making a narrower and stranger point: that the adults doing the compelling had no better claim to seriousness than he did.

8.3 — What a Roman school was actually like

Some background, because none of this lands without it.

Roman education came in three stages. First, from around seven, a primary teacher taught reading, writing and counting. Then, from around eleven or twelve, the grammar teacher.

WORD BOX

Grammaticus (grammar teacher): the second-stage teacher in a Roman education. His subject was not grammar in the modern sense of parts of speech. It was the correct reading and explaining of the poets, above all Virgil, with attention to language, mythology, geography and moral content. Why it matters: this is the stage Augustine is describing when he talks about the *Aeneid* in the next chapter, and it is the stage he attacks hardest.

Then, from around fifteen, the teacher of rhetoric, which was the finishing school of the ancient world and the gateway to a career.

WORD BOX

Rhetoric: the art of persuasive public speaking, taught as a technical discipline with rules, exercises and set forms. In the Roman world it was not an accessory to a career in law or administration. It was the qualification.

Why it matters: Augustine became a teacher of rhetoric, and it was a rhetoric post that took him to Milan and put him in the room where his life changed. It is also why he writes the way he does. The rhythms, the piled-up questions, the reversals: all of it is trained technique.

So the boy being beaten in this chapter is at the first stage, learning letters and numbers by chanting them. He particularly loathed the arithmetic drill, and says that one and one is two, two and two is four, was a hateful chant to him. He is not describing a subtle intellectual objection. He is describing being small and bored and frightened in a room.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

We know a great deal about Roman schooling from sources other than Augustine. Quintilian wrote a full manual on training a speaker, including how young children should be handled. Wax writing tablets have been dug up with pupils' exercises still on them. Papyrus scraps survive from Egypt with school copying tasks, alphabet drills and lines of poetry written out repeatedly. Ausonius, a fourth-century teacher, wrote poems about his colleagues.

When those independent sources agree with what Augustine describes, and they largely do, the description is solid. The curriculum, the ages, the memorising and the beating are all attested elsewhere.

What the evidence is bad at: how it felt. School exercises tell us what was copied out, not what the child thought about copying it. Augustine is one of the very few ancient sources for the inside of that experience, which is exactly why the passage is valuable and exactly why it cannot be checked.

On the beating: this was normal and everybody knew it was normal. The cane is a fixture of Roman school life in every source we have. Quintilian objected to it in the first century, on the grounds that it humiliates children and that a teacher who needs it has failed. He was not obeyed.

IN REAL TERMS

Learning to read in Latin meant learning to read text with no gaps between words, no lower-case letters, no punctuation and no paragraphs.

Try reading a line like THEBOYSAWTHESHIPANDRANTOWARDSIT and imagine that being every line of every text you will ever meet, in a language you are still learning, with a cane in the room.

The memorising was not laziness on the teacher's part. Reading aloud from unpunctuated text is close to impossible unless you already know roughly what it says.

8.4 — His verdict on hitting children

So where does Augustine actually land? The passage is genuinely divided, and I think readers tend to flatten it in whichever direction they prefer.

On one side, he calls the beatings a bitter medicine, and says the discipline was for his good. That is the conventional line and he does say it.

On the other side, he says something that cuts against the whole practice: that free curiosity is more powerful for learning than frightened compulsion. He observed that he learned Latin,

which nobody forced on him, better than Greek, which was beaten into him. That is an argument from evidence, and it is his own evidence.

He never squares those two. He holds them both. My own reading is that the medicine language is what he thinks he ought to say and the curiosity observation is what he actually noticed, and that the second is doing the real work. But I want to flag that as a reading rather than a finding. Another reader can take the medicine line as sincere and the curiosity remark as a concession, and the text will support that too.

REMEMBER THIS

His first remembered prayer was a request **not to be beaten at school**. It was refused. He was beaten, and the adults, including his parents, found it funny.

His argument from it: he was punished for preferring **games to work**, but the adults played too, called it business, and raged when they lost more than any child ever did over a ball.

A Roman education ran in three stages: reading and writing, then the **grammaticus** teaching the poets, then **rhetoric**, which was the qualification for a career. Beating was standard at every stage.

He is **divided** on it. He calls the beatings useful medicine, and also observes that free curiosity taught him more than fear did. He never resolves the two.

The sharpest thing in the chapter is not the complaint about beating. It is the observation that "serious" and "trivial" were being assigned by whoever held the cane.

CHAPTER NINE

Crying for Dido

He could weep over the suicide of a woman in a poem and stay dry-eyed about his own condition. That mismatch turns into an attack on the entire education system that made him.

9.1 — What he was actually made to read

The core text of a Roman literary education was one poem. Every educated person in the Latin west had large parts of it by heart, quoted it in conversation, and had spent years being examined on it line by line.

WORD BOX

The Aeneid: a long poem by Virgil, written about three hundred and eighty years before Augustine was born. It follows Aeneas, a survivor of the fall of Troy, as he travels west and founds the line that will lead to Rome. It was the national poem of the Roman world.

Dido: the queen of Carthage in that poem. Aeneas is shipwrecked there, they fall in love, and he leaves because a god tells him he has a destiny elsewhere. She kills herself.

Why it matters: Carthage was the great city of Augustine's own province, a short journey from his home. The schoolboy weeping over Dido was weeping over a queen of the city he would go to as a student.

Augustine says he loved this material. He was good at it. He won prizes for a set piece where the pupil had to compose a speech in the voice of a character from the poem: the goddess Juno, furious, unable to keep the Trojans out of Italy. He performed it, he was praised, and the praise, he says, was smoke.

9.2 — The complaint about false tears

Here is the passage that gives the chapter its name. He wept for Dido, who died for love. He did not weep for himself, who was dying for lack of God. That is his charge, and he makes it against himself, not against Virgil.

It is a sharper observation than the pious version of it. He is not complaining that fiction is untrue. He is noticing that his emotional machinery worked perfectly on an imaginary queen and not at all on his own situation, and asking what that says about the machinery.

And then he presses it further, into the part that people quote less. If someone forbade him to read that poem, he says, he would have grieved at being unable to read the thing that made

him grieve. So the grief was not an accident of a sad story. He wanted it. He was going to the poem in order to be made to feel something, and he would have been upset to lose access to being upset.

IN REAL TERMS

You have done this. Most people have.

You have watched something you knew would make you cry, on purpose, and you would have been annoyed if someone had switched it off. You have gone looking for a feeling and called it being moved by a story.

Augustine's question is not whether that is wrong. It is why the same machinery, pointed at your own life, so often produces nothing at all.

He returns to this in Book Three, where he attacks the theatre on the same grounds and much more aggressively. It is one of his real preoccupations, and we will do it properly in Part Two.

9.3 — Latin loved, Greek hated

He loved Latin literature. He hated Greek, and he says so with feeling. He could not stand Homer as a boy, and he assumes Greek boys felt the same about Virgil.

His explanation is the observation we met in the last chapter, and here he gives it its clearest statement. He learned Latin without threats, from nurses and playmates and people coaxing him, driven by his own wanting. He was made to learn Greek under threat of punishment. The first worked. The second did not.

This detail has consequences far beyond Book One, and it is worth stating plainly. Augustine's Greek stayed weak for life. He could use it with effort, with help, and never with ease.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The claim that Augustine's Greek was limited does not rest on his own self-deprecation, which might be modesty. It rests on his writings.

When he handles scripture he works from Latin versions. Where he discusses Greek philosophical works, the evidence points to Latin translations. When he needs a Greek text closely he tends to seek assistance. And in his letters he occasionally says outright that he found Greek hard.

Independent sources converging: his own statements, the pattern of the texts he uses, and the way he handles disputed words all point the same way. When three different kinds of evidence agree, the conclusion is solid.

What it cannot tell us: exactly how much Greek he had, which was clearly more than none and less than fluency, and which probably improved over his life.

Why does that matter? Because the Greek-speaking eastern half of the Christian world was producing its own theology at the same time, and Augustine largely could not read it. The

western tradition he founded developed with a partial view of what the east was doing. That is a large historical fact, and its root is a schoolboy who was hit for not learning a language.

9.4 — The charge against the curriculum

Augustine's attack on his own education has three parts, and they are separate charges that often get merged.

First, it taught the wrong priorities. He was corrected fiercely for mispronouncing a word, and not corrected at all for wanting things that harmed him. A teacher who dropped a letter in a word was ashamed. A man who destroyed another man could be applauded for how well he described it.

Second, the moral content was bad. He cites a scene from a comedy by Terence in which a young man works himself up to a seduction by looking at a painting of the king of the gods doing the same thing. If the highest god behaves like that, the character reasons, why should not I? Augustine's objection is not that the play depicts vice. It is that it hands boys a ready-made argument for it, with divine authority attached, and then the school makes them memorise it.

Third, the purpose of the whole thing was money and applause. The system existed to produce men who could win cases, hold offices and be admired. Nobody involved pretended otherwise. Augustine's parents paid for it precisely for that reason, and he says his father cared only that he become an effective speaker and not at all what sort of person he became.

He is careful, though, and this is the part that separates him from a simple moralist. He says clearly that letters themselves are not to blame. Reading and writing are better and surer than the rest, he says, and he is grateful for them. He is attacking what the curriculum was *for*, not literacy, and not even really Virgil.

It is also worth registering the awkwardness of his position, since he does not. The man making this attack is using every technique that education gave him to make it, in Latin prose of a quality only that training could produce. He knows. He does not say so here. He says it elsewhere, and the tension never fully resolves.

9.5 — The boy who cheated at games

Near the end of Book One, Augustine lists what he actually did wrong as a child, and the list is more precise than the vague self-accusation people expect.

He stole from his parents' store cupboard and from their table. Not because he was hungry. He did it so that he would have things to give to other boys, who would then play with him. He was buying company with stolen food.

And he cheated at games. He wanted to win, so he broke the rules. Then, when he caught another boy cheating, he was furious and denounced him loudly. He notes that the fury was real. He was not performing outrage. He genuinely could not stand in another boy the thing he was doing himself.

That observation is doing serious work, and it is easy to read past as an ordinary admission of hypocrisy. Augustine is not saying he knew he was a hypocrite. He is saying he did not. The double standard was invisible from the inside, which is what makes it worth reporting sixteen hundred years later.

IN REAL TERMS

You can test this one on yourself in about ten seconds.

Think of a behaviour that irritates you in other people, at work or on the road. Now ask how often you do the same thing, and whether it felt the same from the inside when you did it.

Augustine's claim is not simply that people are hypocrites. It is that the machinery which judges other people runs on different inputs from the machinery which judges you, and that neither of them tells you this is happening.

Hold on to the stolen food, because Book Two opens with a theft of fruit that Augustine did not want and did not eat, handed round to companions in much the same way. Book One quietly lays the rails for it. He shows you the small version before he gives you the one he says he cannot explain.

9.6 — The illness, and the baptism that did not happen

One episode remains, and it is strange to modern eyes.

As a boy Augustine fell seriously ill, with stomach pains, and was thought to be dying. He begged to be baptised. His mother arranged it urgently. Then he recovered, and the baptism was called off.

WORD BOX

Catechumen: a person enrolled in the church, receiving instruction, marked with the sign of the cross and treated as a Christian, but not yet baptised. Augustine was one from infancy.

Deferred baptism: the widespread fourth-century practice of putting baptism off, often until late in life. The reasoning was that baptism washed away everything before it, while sins committed afterwards were far graver. So a young man expected to spend his twenties badly was, on this logic, better off unbaptised until he had finished.

Why it matters: it explains the otherwise baffling fact that a determined Christian mother had an unbaptised son. Monica was not neglecting him. She was following the standard advice of her time, and Augustine, writing later, thinks the advice was catastrophic.

His verdict on the deferral is angry. He asks why the wounds were left open on the grounds that more dirt would fall into them later. It is one of the few places in Book One where he directly criticises his mother's judgement, and he softens it by noting that she had reasons.

There is a piece of quiet historical evidence tucked in here. Augustine reports that as a boy he already believed, prayed, and was signed with the cross. So the picture of a wild pagan youth who later found religion is wrong from the start. He was raised inside it. What he did later was leave.

9.7 — How Book One ends

The last movement of Book One is a stocktaking. Augustine lists what he had been given as a child: existence, life, senses, a mind, memory, the ability to want things and to be delighted by them. He states plainly that these were good and that they came from God.

Then he says what he did with them. He looked for pleasure and honour and truth in the wrong places, and found pain, confusion and error instead.

That structure, good gifts turned in a wrong direction, is his standard account of what sin is, and it arrives fully formed at the end of the first book. Nothing that exists is bad. The badness is in the aim. Hold on to that, because it is the key to the hardest chapter in the entire work, in Book Seven, where he finally works out where evil comes from.

And note the last thing he thanks God for: that the good in him, as a boy, was already God's doing. Even the childhood he is about to describe as wasted was not, on his account, empty. That refusal to write off his own past is a mark of the whole book, and it is why *Confessions* is not the self-hating document it is sometimes said to be.

REMEMBER THIS

The centre of a Roman education was Virgil's *Aeneid*. Augustine loved it, won prizes for it, and wept over the death of **Dido**.

His complaint is not about fiction. It is that his emotions worked perfectly on an imaginary queen and not at all on his own life, and that he actively **went looking** for the feeling.

He loved Latin, learned freely, and hated Greek, which was beaten into him. His **Greek stayed weak for life**, which shaped how much eastern theology the western tradition could read.

His attack on his education has three parts: **wrong priorities, bad moral content**, and a **purpose that was money and applause**. He explicitly does not blame literacy itself.

He nearly died as a boy and nearly got baptised. **Deferred baptism** was normal and he thinks it was a disaster.

Book One ends with his lifelong formula: the gifts were good, the aim was wrong. Evil is not a thing. It is a direction.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Every part of this series ends the same way. Two lists: what is genuinely unknown, and what is solid. The reasons for the not-knowing are usually more interesting than the gaps.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

Each item below is followed by *why* it is unknown, because that is the useful part.

Whether any of Book One is memory. Augustine tells us his infancy section is reconstruction. He does not tell us where reconstruction stops and recollection begins. The school scenes read like memory. They may be. They may equally be a composite of what Roman schooling was like, written by a man who later taught in exactly such schools for over a decade. *Why unknown:* there is no external witness to any of it, and there never was one.

Whether he wrote the thirteen books in one push. The composition window of roughly 397 to 400 is well founded, but the internal history of the writing is not. Some have argued for a break, or for later insertion of Book Ten. *Why unknown:* we have no drafts, no letters describing the work in progress, and no early manuscript with a different shape.

What his mother was actually like. Monica exists in the historical record almost entirely through her son. There is an inscription associated with her burial and a handful of external mentions, and beyond that we have a portrait drawn by a grieving man for a religious purpose. *Why unknown:* she was a provincial woman who wrote nothing, and almost nobody in her position left a trace. The silence is not about her. It is about who got recorded.

The name of his partner of thirteen years. She appears in Book Six, she was the mother of his son, and Augustine never names her. *Why unknown:* he chose not to. That is a decision, not a gap in the record, and it is worth treating as evidence about him rather than as missing data.

Exactly how much of Book One is aimed at the Manichees. Augustine was writing against a group he had belonged to for nine years, and several passages in Book One line up suspiciously well with things they denied. Whether that is deliberate polemic or simply his settled views is argued over. *Why unknown:* he does not name a target in Book One, and intention is not recoverable from a text alone.

Whether the deferred baptism harmed him. He says it did. He is not a neutral witness, and he is arguing a case about baptism that mattered to him professionally by the time he wrote. *Why unknown:* counterfactual questions about a single life are not answerable in principle, not just in practice.

10.2 — Solid

And here is what can be built on, with the reason each item is secure.

The basic biography. Born 354 in Thagaste, died 430 in Hippo Regius. Bishop from around 395 or 396. *Why solid:* multiple independent sources, including a biography by a colleague who knew him for decades, plus letters and council records that had no stake in the question.

The composition window of roughly 397 to 400. *Why solid:* Augustine's own later list of his works places it, and the internal references are consistent with it. Independent lines converge.

That it has thirteen books and was designed for reading aloud. *Why solid:* the manuscript tradition is uniform on the division, and the internal structure of each book supports it.

The shape of Roman education. Three stages, a curriculum centred on Virgil, memorisation, and routine corporal punishment. *Why solid:* this is attested by teaching manuals, surviving pupils' exercises on wax and papyrus, and multiple independent authors across several centuries. Augustine is one witness among many and they agree.

That deferred baptism was normal practice. *Why solid:* it is documented across the fourth-century church in many places, in sermons complaining about it and in the biographies of other figures who were baptised late.

That Wittgenstein opened *Philosophical Investigations* with this passage. *Why solid:* it is printed in the book.

That the text we have is close to what he wrote. *Why solid:* *Confessions* was copied constantly and continuously from the fifth century onwards. A heavily copied text has many independent lines of descent, and where those lines agree, the reading is secure. Textual disputes in *Confessions* are about individual words, not about whole passages.

10.3 — One assumption turned on this book

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THIS CAN BE DONE AT ALL

This series assumes that a book can be explained in someone else's words without losing what it is. I have spent nine chapters doing exactly that, and I should say plainly that the assumption is questionable, and questionable in a way that is specific to this book rather than general.

Confessions is a prayer. Its argument is not separable from the fact that it is being said to someone.

When I summarise a passage as "Augustine argues that human wanting is disordered from birth", I have converted an act of address into a proposition. The proposition is accurate. The act is gone.

That is not a general problem with explaining books. You can summarise an argument about geology without loss. You cannot summarise a letter to a dying friend without loss, because what the letter is doing is not stating things.

So take this series as scaffolding, not as a substitute. It exists to get you into the building.

Everything I have described as an argument was, in the original, someone talking to God, and that difference is not decoration.

The general form: assuming that content survives a change of genre.

I could have left that box out and nobody would have noticed. I am putting it in because it is true, and because a series that keeps demanding other people examine their premises should be willing to spend a page on its own.

REMEMBER THIS

We do not know how much of Book One is memory, how the writing actually proceeded, what Monica was really like, or whether the deferred baptism harmed him. Most of those are unknown because **nobody was recording**, not because a record was lost.

We do know the basic biography, the composition window, the structure of the work, the shape of Roman schooling, and that the text is close to what he wrote. Each of those rests on **independent sources agreeing**.

One name is missing on purpose: the woman he lived with for thirteen years. That absence is a **decision by the author**, and should be read as evidence rather than as a gap.

Where a question cannot be settled, this series will say so and stop, rather than choosing the more satisfying answer.

Timeline

Dates before Augustine's adulthood are approximate, because the only source for most of them is his own retrospective account. Where a date is genuinely disputed, the dispute is noted.

Date	Event	Where it appears
13 Nov 354	Augustine born at Thagaste in Numidia, Roman North Africa.	Book I
c. 355–360	Infancy and early childhood. Enrolled as a catechumen but not baptised.	Book I
c. 361	Starts primary school. Beatings, the first prayer, the adults who laughed.	Book I
c. 365–369	Studies with the grammar teacher at Madauros. Virgil, the <i>Aeneid</i> , the tears for Dido.	Book I
c. 366	Serious illness. Begs for baptism; recovers; baptism deferred.	Book I
c. 369–370	A year idle at home while money is found for further study. The theft of the pears.	Book II
370	Goes to Carthage to study rhetoric. His father Patricius dies around this time, baptised shortly before.	Books II–III
c. 371	Begins the relationship with the unnamed woman who will be his partner for about thirteen years.	Book IV
372/373	Birth of his son, Adeodatus.	Book IX
373	Reads Cicero's <i>Hortensius</i> , now lost, and is turned towards philosophy. Joins the Manichees.	Book III
c. 373–382	Nine years as a Manichee hearer. Teaching at Thagaste, then Carthage.	Books III–V
383	Sails to Rome, leaving his mother behind by a deception.	Book V
384	Appointed teacher of rhetoric in Milan. Meets Ambrose.	Book V
385	Monica arrives in Milan. His partner is sent back to Africa so that he can marry.	Book VI
386	Reads the Platonist books. The crisis over the origin of evil. The garden scene, and the decision.	Books VII–VIII

Date	Event	Where it appears
24 Apr 387	Baptised by Ambrose in Milan, together with his son Adeodatus and his friend Alypius.	Book IX
387 (some say 388)	The conversation at Ostia. Monica dies there while they wait for a ship home. The year is disputed.	Book IX
c. 388	Returns to Africa. Adeodatus dies soon after, aged about seventeen.	Book IX
391	Ordained priest at Hippo Regius, reportedly under pressure from the congregation.	Later works
c. 395–396	Becomes bishop of Hippo Regius.	Later works
c. 397–400	Writes <i>Confessions</i>.	—
410	Rome is sacked. Augustine begins <i>The City of God</i> in response.	Later works
c. 411–430	The long dispute with Pelagius and his followers over original sin, grace and free will.	Later works
28 Aug 430	Dies at Hippo Regius, aged seventy-five, during a siege.	Later works
—	Part Two starts here: Books II and III, the pears and the Manichees.	—

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English.

Term	What it means
Aeneid	Virgil's long poem about Aeneas founding the Roman line. The central text of a Roman literary education.
Allegory	Reading a text so that its literal events also stand for something else. Augustine reads the days of creation this way in Book XIII.
Augustinian picture of language	Wittgenstein's name for the view that words are names and meaning is the object named. Named after this passage, not endorsed by it.
Book (ancient)	A division of a long work, originally sized to one papyrus roll. Closer to a self-contained chapter than to a volume.
Catechumen	Someone enrolled in the church and receiving instruction, but not yet baptised. Augustine was one from infancy.
Confessio	Latin for the act that gives the book its title: confessing sin, confessing faith and confessing praise, all at once.
Decurio	A Roman town councillor, personally liable for shortfalls in the district's taxes. Augustine's father held this position.
Deferred baptism	The common fourth-century practice of postponing baptism, often for decades, because sins after baptism were held to be graver.
De Magistro	A dialogue by Augustine on signs, teaching and language, in which he argues that pointing alone cannot establish meaning.
Divine simplicity	The claim that God has no parts and no separable properties. It drives the questions about where God could possibly be.
Grammaticus	The second-stage Roman teacher, whose subject was the correct reading and explaining of the poets, above all Virgil.
Hippo Regius	The coastal city where Augustine was bishop for over thirty years. Now Annaba, in Algeria.
Manichees	Followers of a religion holding that the universe is a mixture of two eternal opposed substances, light and dark. Augustine belonged to it for nine years.
Numidia	The Roman province, in what is now northern Algeria, where Augustine was born and spent most of his life.

Term	What it means
Original sin	The claim that human beings arrive already damaged rather than neutral, so that the will is misaimed before any choice is made.
Ostia	The port of Rome, where Monica died while they waited for a ship back to Africa.
Pelagianism	The position that humans are born undamaged and can choose good unaided. The direct denial of Augustine on original sin.
Platonism	The philosophical tradition descending from Plato, in the form Augustine met it in the fourth century. It gave him a way to think about a reality not made of stuff.
Problem of enquiry	The old puzzle that you cannot search for what you do not already know, and do not need to search for what you do.
Psalms	A hundred and fifty religious poems in the Jewish scriptures, many addressed directly to God. The model for the form of <i>Confessions</i> .
Retractationes	Augustine's late review of everything he had published. "Reconsiderations", not "retractions".
Rhetoric	The technical art of persuasive public speaking. In the Roman world it was the qualification for a public career, and it was Augustine's profession.
Thagaste	Augustine's home town in Numidia. Now Souk Ahras, in eastern Algeria.

About the Author

This series is read and explained by **Lovepreet Singh**, and published as part of **The Living Archive** at misterlove.in.

The Living Archive takes difficult material and rebuilds it so that anyone can follow it, without dropping the hard parts along the way. Its first series was a fourteen-part history of Punjab running to around nine hundred and fifty pages. This is its second.

I read the book, I did the reading around it, and I wrote down what I found. I am not a specialist in late antiquity and I am not going to pretend to be one. Where a question is genuinely contested among people who are, I have said so and given each side its strongest case rather than choosing for you. Where I could not find out, I have written that I could not find out.

The method used here was worked out on the Punjab series and is written up as a portable specification, so that any part of this work can be checked, continued or rebuilt by somebody else. That is the point of an archive that calls itself living.

[Editorial note, to be replaced before publishing: the method requires a one-line statement of the author's own position with regard to religious material, placed where readers will see it. This is the only field in the document still unfilled.]

The Living Archive

The Living Archive is a method for writing hard things simply without making them shallow. It was developed by Lovepreet Singh and tested on a fourteen-part history of Punjab. It runs on three rules.

One. Simplification is not compression. The simple version is usually longer than the difficult one. Words are being spent to buy comprehension.

Two. Two dials, turned in opposite directions. Language as simple as it can be made. Content as deep as the subject actually goes. Turning both down produces something readable and useless.

Three. Every side gets its strongest case, and where nothing settles a question, that gets said. A verdict that honestly reports a deadlock is worth more than a tidy answer that is not true.

A word on sources

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record rather than new primary research, and it is written for readers who want to understand a book, not for specialists who want to check my workings.

What the archive is good at here: *Confessions* is one of the best documented texts in existence. The manuscript tradition is rich, the scholarly commentary is deep, and the basic facts of Augustine's public life are attested by sources with no stake in the questions we are asking.

What it is bad at here: almost everything about Augustine's private life before he became famous rests on a single witness, and that witness is Augustine himself, writing with a purpose, a decade or more after the fact. Where a claim in this document rests only on his account of himself, I have tried to say so in the text rather than letting it pass as established.

On translations: all renderings of Augustine in this document are my own plain-English paraphrases, made deliberately loose so that they explain rather than reproduce. They are not quotations from any published translation, and they should not be cited as such. Where the exact wording matters, go to a proper edition.

Corrections are welcome and will be acted on. Later editions will record what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Two covers Books II and III: the years from sixteen to nineteen. It contains the most famous petty crime in literature and the decision that shaped the next nine years of his life. These are the questions it takes on.

- Why does a middle-aged bishop spend an entire book on stealing some pears he did not even want to eat?
- What is the difference between doing wrong for a reason and doing wrong for no reason, and why does Augustine think only the second one is really interesting?
- What actually happened in that idle year at home, and why does he blame his father for it?
- What did a lost book by Cicero do to a nineteen-year-old that a lifetime of religious instruction had not?
- Why did the Bible strike him as badly written, and what does that tell us about how educated people in the fourth century read?
- Who were the Manichees, what did they actually believe, and why was their answer to the problem of evil so convincing to a clever young man?
- Why did he stay with them for nine years, and what is he doing, as a bishop, when he writes about them?

And the question underneath all of them: if a person does something wrong purely because it is wrong, what exactly is being enjoyed?

End of Part 1 of 9

The Living Archive • The Confessions, Explained

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART 2 OF 9

The Confessions, Explained

Part Two — The Pears and the Manichees

*Books Two and Three: the most analysed petty crime in literature,
a lost book by Cicero that redirected a life, and the religion
that held a clever young man for nine years.*

READ AND EXPLAINED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

Part One covered Book One of Augustine's *Confessions*: his infancy and boyhood in a small town in Roman North Africa. If you have not read it, here is everything you need. This part stands on its own.

The man. Aurelius Augustinus, born 13 November 354 in Thagaste, in what is now Algeria. His father Patricius was a town councillor, not a Christian until the end of his life, and permanently short of money. His mother Monica was a Christian who did not let go. Augustine was clever, ambitious, and being educated at cost towards a career as a professional public speaker. He wrote this book in his early forties, around 397 to 400, about twenty-five years after the events in this part, and only a couple of years into being a bishop.

The title. The Latin word *confessio* means three things at once: confessing sin, confessing faith, and confessing praise. Modern English kept only the first. The book is not a list of misdeeds. It is a prayer, addressed to God from the first word to the last. You are not the person being spoken to. You are overhearing.

The shape. Thirteen books. The first nine tell his life story up to 387. Book Ten stops the story and examines memory. Books Eleven to Thirteen interpret the opening verses of the Bible. Whether that is one design or several works joined together is genuinely disputed, and Part One laid out both cases.

The argument of Book One. Augustine started his life story before his own memory, and said openly that his account of infancy came from watching other people's babies rather than from recall. He watched a speechless infant go pale with fury at another baby feeding beside it, and built a case on it: the baby has learned nothing, the milk is not scarce, and it rages anyway, so whatever produces the rage was there on arrival. Book One ends with his lifelong formula. The gifts were good. The aim was wrong. Evil is not a thing; it is a direction.

Book Two picks him up at sixteen, at home, with nothing to do.

A Reminder About the Boxes

Six kinds of box run through this series. **Word Box** explains a hard term the moment it first appears. **In Real Terms** turns a number or a distance into something you can picture. **How We Actually Know This** names the physical evidence and says what it cannot show. **The Argument** is for places where experts genuinely disagree, and gives each side its strongest case rather than a version built to be knocked down. **The Hidden Assumption** digs out the premise that everybody in an argument is quietly taking for granted. **Remember This** closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

One warning specific to this part. Book Two is about a teenager's sexual awakening and Book Three opens with a line about a city seething with lust. Augustine's language here is heated, and it has been used for sixteen centuries to support positions about sex that he may or may not have held. I will describe what the text says, note where his own wording is doing rhetorical work, and not tell you what to conclude from it.

Contents

Chapter One — The Year Off

Sixteen and idle · why the money ran out · the scene at the baths · his father's pride and his mother's warning

Chapter Two — In Love with Being in Love

The language of Book Two · what he actually says happened · the reticence nobody notices · was he really that bad?

Chapter Three — The Pears: What Happened

The scene told plainly · the details he insists on · the part everyone forgets · how much of it can be checked

Chapter Four — Why a Bishop Spends Half a Book on Fruit

The scale objection · why smallness is the point · subtracting every motive · the comparison with a famous traitor

Chapter Five — Doing Wrong for No Reason at All

The old assumption that nobody wants evil · what he claims to have found in himself · and the objection he hands his critics

Chapter Six — "I Would Not Have Done It Alone"

The clause that unravels the argument · laughter as the currency · what a group does to a person

Chapter Seven — Carthage: The Cauldron

The city · in love with love · the student gang called the Wreckers · the theatre and the attack on borrowed grief

Chapter Eight — A Lost Book That Changed a Life

What Hortensius was · what it did to him at eighteen · what philosophy meant then · and the one thing it lacked

Chapter Nine — The Bible Disappoints, the Manichees Persuade

Opening scripture and finding it crude · who the Manichees were · what they taught · why it was a good answer · Monica's dream

Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Genuinely unknown · solid · and what the silences in Book Two are actually made of

Reference

Timeline · glossary · about the author · a word on sources · what comes next

CHAPTER ONE

The Year Off

At sixteen Augustine came home from school and stayed there for a year, because his father could not afford the next stage. Everything in Book Two happens inside that gap.

1.1 — Where we left him

At the end of Book One Augustine is a schoolboy who is good at Latin, bad at Greek, frightened of the cane and gifted at the set exercises. He has been sent away to a nearby town called Madauros for the second stage of his education. He is doing well. The next step would be Carthage, the great city of the province, for the third and final stage: rhetoric, the qualification that opened a career.

And then the money runs out.

Augustine comes home to Thagaste, and stays there for about a year, while his father scrapes together the funds to send him on. He is sixteen. He has finished one stage of education and cannot start the next. He has nothing to do.

WORD BOX

Adulescentia: the Latin term for the stage of life Augustine is entering here. It is not the same as our "adolescence". Roman writers divided a life into ages, and *adulescentia* covered roughly the years from fifteen to the late twenties: a long stretch of legal adulthood before full social standing. Why it matters: Augustine is not describing a child. He is describing a young man with adult appetites, adult legal status and no adult occupation, which is the exact combination Book Two is about.

1.2 — Why the money ran out

Part One explained that Augustine's father held a position that made a man respectable and poor at the same time. He was a councillor of a small town, personally liable for shortfalls in the taxes his district owed. That is the background to the gap year.

But Augustine adds something that changes the picture, and it is worth noticing because it complicates the easy reading. Other men in Thagaste with more money than his father did not spend it on educating their sons. His father did, beyond what he could afford, and Augustine says so with something close to admiration.

IN REAL TERMS

Sending a boy from a provincial town to Carthage for a rhetorical education meant paying a teacher's fees, paying for lodging in an expensive city, and losing the boy's labour for years. The closest modern comparison is a family of ordinary means sending a child abroad to a private university, with no loan available and no scholarship system. Not impossible. But it takes a specific decision, and it takes years of it.

That decision is what stalled for a year. The gap in Augustine's education is a gap in his family's cash flow.

So the year off is not neglect. It is the visible edge of a family stretching itself. What Augustine objects to is not the stretching. It is what the stretching was *for*.

1.3 — The scene at the baths

One episode from that year gets a paragraph, and it has become one of the more discussed moments in the book.

Patricius takes his son to the public baths. He sees that the boy has reached physical maturity. He goes home pleased and tells Monica, already looking forward to grandchildren.

WORD BOX

The public baths: in a Roman town, the baths were not simply where you washed. They were the main social space: a place to meet people, do business, exercise and be seen. Bathing was communal and nakedness ordinary.

Why it matters: modern readers often assume something furtive is being described. Nothing furtive is being described. A father and a son went to the baths together, as everyone did, and the father noticed something anybody present could have noticed.

Augustine's complaint is not that his father looked. It is what his father was pleased *about*. Patricius saw a boy becoming a man who would continue the family, and was delighted. What he did not see, on Augustine's account, was a son whose character was going anywhere at all. His father was interested in what Augustine would become professionally and biologically, and not in what he would become morally.

That is the charge, and it is worth stating plainly because Augustine states it plainly in Book One as well: his father cared that he became an effective speaker, and not at all what sort of person he became.

1.4 — Monica's warning

Monica reacts differently. She takes him aside and warns him urgently to stay away from sex, and above all not to sleep with another man's wife.

Augustine, at the time, found this embarrassing. He says he thought it was womanly advice, the sort of thing it would have shamed him to be seen obeying. He did not connect it with God at all. He heard it as his mother fussing.

Then, writing at forty-three, he adds a line that turns the whole scene around: it was God warning him through her, and he did not know it.

This is the first appearance of a pattern that runs through the next seven books, so it is worth flagging now. Augustine repeatedly describes moments where somebody said the right thing to him and he could not hear it. He is not describing a man who was never told. He is describing a man who was told constantly and could not receive it, and his interest is in why.

1.5 — What he actually accuses his parents of

It is easy to read Book Two as Augustine blaming his mother and father. He does something more precise than that, and the precision matters.

Of his father he says: he did not care about my character, only my career. That is a direct charge.

Of his mother he says something more uncomfortable. Monica did warn him. But she did not arrange a marriage for him, and Augustine says she did not because she was afraid a wife would be a weight on his prospects. His education was the priority, and a young man tied down with a family at seventeen would not go to Carthage.

So his devout mother, on his own account, made the same calculation as his unbelieving father, for the same reason. She wanted him chaste and she wanted him successful, and when those two pulled against each other, the career won.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

This is one witness, writing twenty-five years later, about the private motives of his own mother. What can be checked independently: that Roman families of this class did delay marriage for sons on a career track, that a rhetorical education was expensive and long, and that the practice of postponing marriage for advancement is well attested across the period. The *pattern* Augustine describes is ordinary and documented.

What cannot be checked: whether Monica actually reasoned this way, or whether a grown son has assigned a motive to a decision she never explained. She died nine years before he wrote it and left no writing of her own.

Which means the sentence is reliable as social history and unverifiable as biography. Those are different kinds of claim sitting in the same paragraph, and Augustine does not separate them.

One more thing before the chapter closes, because it will matter in Part Three. Somewhere around this period, or shortly after he reached Carthage, Augustine began the relationship

with the woman he lived with for about thirteen years and never names. Book Two does not tell us when. Book Four mentions her without a date. The silence is deliberate and we will come back to it.

REMEMBER THIS

At sixteen Augustine came home from school for about a year because his **father could not afford** the next stage. Book Two happens inside that gap.

The year off is not neglect. Patricius was spending **beyond his means** on his son's education, more than richer men in the town did.

At the public baths his father saw he had reached maturity and was **pleased about grandchildren**. Augustine's complaint is about what his father was pleased by, not about the looking.

Monica warned him urgently about sex. He found it **embarrassing womanly advice** and ignored it. Writing later, he says that was God speaking and he could not hear it.

His devout mother did not arrange a marriage for him, because a wife would have slowed the career. When chastity and advancement pulled against each other, both his parents chose advancement.

CHAPTER TWO

In Love with Being in Love

Book Two contains the most heated language in the whole work about sex, and almost no facts. That combination is not an accident, and it has consequences for how the book has been read ever since.

2.1 — The language of Book Two

Augustine describes this period of his life with a run of images that are worth listing, because the choice of images is itself an argument. He speaks of brambles of lust growing over his head with nobody to tear them out. Of a mist rising and clouding his heart. Of boiling and running over. Of being tossed about and spilt and scattered. Of a fog between himself and the brightness of love.

Notice what all of those have in common. Not one of them is the image of a person choosing something. They are images of weather, vegetation and liquid: things that rise, spread, spill and cloud without anyone deciding.

That is doing work. Augustine is describing a will that is not in charge of itself, and he reaches for the vocabulary of processes rather than of acts. This is the same man who, in Book One, argued that something in human wanting is disordered before any choice is made. The imagery of Book Two is that argument in another form.

2.2 — What he actually says happened

Here is a genuinely surprising fact about the most notorious chapter in the book on sex: it contains almost no specific content.

Augustine says he wanted to love and to be loved. He says he could not tell the difference between affection and appetite, and that the two boiled together in him. He says he was carried away. He says he could not keep inside the light of ordinary affection and went beyond it. He says that at sixteen he ran wild.

He does not say who with. He does not describe an encounter. He gives no names, no scenes, no numbers. In a book that is famous for being confessional about sex, the sexual material is almost entirely adjectival.

This is worth registering because the reputation of *Confessions* as a lurid document is built on Book Two, and Book Two does not contain what the reputation says it contains.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE SIZE OF A WRONG TRACKS ITS SERIOUSNESS

Readers who find Book Two overheated and readers who find it profound tend to share a premise: that the intensity of Augustine's language should be proportioned to the badness of what he did.

One camp concludes he must have done something dreadful. The other concludes he is exaggerating about very little.

Augustine does not hold that premise, and the whole of Books Two and Three is built on rejecting it. His interest is never in the magnitude of an act. It is in the structure of a want. A large want pointed the wrong way and a small want pointed the wrong way are, on his account, the same object at different scales, and the small one is easier to see clearly precisely because nothing else is going on in it.

That is why the vague sex chapter is followed by an extremely detailed chapter about fruit. It looks like an anticlimax. It is the method.

The general form: assuming that the importance of a thing is measured by its size.

Hold that thought, because it is the key to Chapters Three through Six, which are all about the pears.

2.3 — The reticence nobody notices

There is a further point here that specialists have made and that general readers almost never hear, and it cuts against the popular image of the book quite hard.

Confessions is not comprehensive about Augustine's sins. It is markedly reticent. The pear theft functions as a stand-in for everything else, and by giving it enormous attention Augustine is able to give everything else almost none. The confession of sin in this book is incomplete, unspecific and indirect, and it is arranged that way.

That is not an accusation of dishonesty. Augustine never promises a full inventory, and a prayer is not a police statement. But it does mean the common description of the book as an act of total self-exposure is wrong, and wrong in a checkable way. A reader can simply count what is actually on the page.

THE ARGUMENT — WAS AUGUSTINE REALLY THAT BAD?

The picture of Augustine as a wild young man who slept his way through North Africa before finding religion is fixed in popular memory. It is also, on the evidence, doubtful. Here is the argument at full strength on each side.

THE LANGUAGE MEANS WHAT IT SAYS

Augustine had every reason to understate rather than overstate. He was a bishop with critics, writing in public, and lurid admissions would have armed his opponents. He nevertheless describes running wild, being unable to distinguish affection from appetite, and being carried beyond ordinary limits. A man in his position does not write that unless something in it is true. And we know independently that he took a long-term partner very young and had a son at about eighteen.

THE LANGUAGE IS RHETORICAL INTENSIFICATION

Almost nothing specific is described. He names no one, recounts no episode, and gives no figure. What we can actually verify is one long, stable, monogamous relationship of about thirteen years with one woman, which by the standards of a young Roman man of his class was conventional to the point of dullness. A trained rhetorician describing his unconverted life to a Christian audience had strong reasons to make the before-and-after contrast vivid. On this reading the brambles and the boiling are technique.

BOTH, BECAUSE THE STANDARD HAS MOVED

A third reading: Augustine is measuring himself against a demand for total continence that he later accepted, not against the behaviour of his contemporaries. By the standard of his neighbours he was unremarkable. By the standard he came to hold, an unmarried monogamous relationship was already a serious wrong. Both descriptions can be accurate because they are using different rulers, and he is deliberately using the second one.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes the verifiable facts, which are: one long partnership, one son, no marriage. What is disputed is how to read language that is intense and almost entirely non-specific. The third reading has the advantage of requiring nobody to be lying.

What would settle it: Nothing available. A private life in the fourth century leaves no record unless the person leaves one, and Augustine's deliberate vagueness is precisely the thing that would need to be got behind. The silence is not a lost document. There was never a document.

Why people care so much: The stakes are large and mostly modern. Augustine's writing on sex shaped Western attitudes for centuries, and how much personal experience sits behind it is treated as bearing on how much authority it should carry. Whether that follows is a separate question, and worth asking separately.

I will not settle that, and I want to say clearly that I am declining rather than being unable. What I will do throughout this series is keep the verifiable facts and the heated language visibly separate, so you can see which is which.

2.4 — One line worth slowing down on

Buried in the middle of this material is a sentence that does more work than the rest of the chapter put together. Augustine says that what he wanted was not really the thing itself. He was in love with loving. He was hunting for something to want.

Set that beside the line from Book One about the restless heart and you have the whole diagnostic machinery of the book in two sentences. The claim is not that he wanted bad things. The claim is that the wanting had come loose from any particular object and was casting about for somewhere to land.

IN REAL TERMS

This is a recognisable condition and it has nothing specifically to do with sex.

It is the state of opening an app you did not want to open, on a phone you picked up for no reason, looking for something you could not have named before you started looking. Nothing on the screen is the thing. There was never going to be a thing.

Augustine's claim is that this is the ordinary condition of a human being who is not aimed at anything, and that it will attach itself to whatever is nearest.

He returns to the same idea at the start of Book Three in a more famous form, and we will take it up properly in Chapter Seven.

REMEMBER THIS

Book Two describes this period with images of **weather, vegetation and liquid**: mist, brambles, boiling, spilling. Not one is an image of a person choosing.

The chapter famous for sex contains **almost no specifics**. No names, no episodes, no numbers. Its reputation is not supported by its contents.

Confessions is **reticent, not comprehensive**. The pear theft stands in for everything else, and by dwelling on it Augustine gives the rest almost no attention at all.

Whether he was genuinely wild or writing rhetorically is **disputed and unsettleable**. What is verifiable is one long partnership, one son, no marriage.

The key sentence is that he was in love with loving. The wanting had come loose from any object and was looking for somewhere to land.

CHAPTER THREE

The Pears: What Happened

Before anyone argues about what it means, here is the incident itself, with every detail Augustine bothers to give, and a note on which of those details we can check.

3.1 — The scene, told plainly

There was a pear tree near his family's vineyard. It belonged to somebody else. It was loaded with fruit. The pears were not good ones: not attractive to look at, not especially nice to eat. Augustine and a group of other young men had been out playing in the streets late, as they habitually did. In the middle of the night they went to the tree, shook it, and carried off the fruit.

They took a large quantity. They ate a few. Most of it they threw to pigs.

That is the entire event. He was around sixteen. Nobody was hurt. Nothing of value was destroyed. The owner of the tree is never mentioned again.

3.2 — The details he insists on

Augustine is not a careless writer, and every specific in that paragraph is there for a reason. He is building a case, and each detail closes off a possible explanation.

The pears were poor. So it was not about the fruit.

He had better pears at home. He says so directly. So it was not about having pears.

He was not hungry. He was a fed young man from a household with its own vineyard. So it was not need.

They took far more than they could use. So it was not acquisition in any sensible sense.

They threw it to pigs. So it was not even about keeping it.

They did it at night, after hours of idling. So there was no occasion, no provocation and no plan.

Every one of those is a motive being deliberately removed. By the time the paragraph ends there is nothing left that could count as a reason, and that is exactly the position Augustine wants to be standing in.

3.3 — The part everyone forgets

The pigs get cut from almost every retelling, and they are the most important detail in the story.

If the young men had eaten the pears, the theft would be greed. If they had sold them, it would be gain. If they had hidden them, it would be acquisition. If they had destroyed the tree, it would be vandalism aimed at the owner.

They threw the fruit to animals. That is not greed, gain, keeping or malice towards a person. It is the disposal of something that was never wanted. The pears were not the object of the exercise at any point, and the pigs are the proof.

Augustine also notes, in passing, that he did eat one or two, and he is careful about why. Not for the taste. So that he could have the experience of the wrongdoing itself. The eating was part of the crime rather than its purpose.

IN REAL TERMS

Strip the religious vocabulary off and you have something most people have seen or done.

A group of teenagers pulls up road signs and dumps them in a field. Nobody wants a road sign. Nobody sells them. They are not angry at the council. They do it, they laugh, and they leave the signs where they fall.

Augustine's question is the one nobody asks afterwards: what exactly was enjoyed? Because something was.

3.4 — How much of this can be checked

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The evidence for the pear theft is one paragraph, written by the person who did it, about twenty-five years afterwards, in a book with a religious purpose.

There is no corroboration and there never could be. No court record, no other witness, no mention by anyone else.

What supports the account indirectly: petty nocturnal theft by groups of young men is entirely ordinary and turns up in Roman legal and satirical sources constantly. The setting is plausible in every particular. A household in Thagaste with a vineyard, a neighbour's fruit tree, pigs nearby, young men out late: nothing there is unusual.

What cannot be established: whether it happened, whether it happened as described, or whether it is one incident or several compressed into one. It is also worth saying that a story this useful to its author's argument is a story a careful reader should hold loosely, and that Augustine's own framing invites that: he presents it as an example, not as a report.

That last point deserves a sentence of its own, because it is the kind of thing that gets forgotten in the arguments that follow. Nothing in the case Augustine builds depends on the

incident being literally true. If a reader concluded the pears were an invention, every philosophical claim in the next three chapters would still stand or fall on its own merits. The story is a specimen, not a proof.

REMEMBER THIS

A group of young men shook down a neighbour's pear tree at night, took far more than they could use, ate one or two, and **threw the rest to pigs**.

Every detail Augustine gives **removes a motive**: the fruit was poor, he had better at home, he was not hungry, they took too much, they kept none.

The pigs are the proof. Not greed, not gain, not keeping, not malice towards the owner. The pears were never the object.

The evidence is **one paragraph by the person who did it**, a quarter of a century later, with no corroboration possible.

Nothing in his argument depends on the story being literally true. It is a specimen, not a proof.

CHAPTER FOUR

Why a Bishop Spends Half a Book on Fruit

Nietzsche laughed at it. Most first-time readers find it absurd. The disproportion is the most-discussed feature of the whole work, and Augustine chose it deliberately.

4.1 — The objection, at full strength

Put the objection as strongly as it can be put, because it is a good one. A man in his forties, a bishop, writing the most important book of his life, devotes more than half of one of its thirteen parts to a schoolboy scrumping fruit. He agonises over it. He returns to it. He asks God to look into his heart about it.

Meanwhile his sexual life gets vague adjectives, his nine years in a religion he later called dangerous gets a compressed account, and the woman he lived with for thirteen years does not get a name.

Nietzsche found this funny and said so, in a letter, laughing at what he considered the theatrical falseness of making a pear theft the centrepiece of a description of one's student days. Plenty of readers since have quietly agreed. One scholar summed up the dismissive view neatly: if that is the worst sin Augustine could produce, he had an exemplary childhood.

That is the case against. It is worth taking seriously before hearing the reply, because the reply only works if you have felt the force of it.

4.2 — Why smallness is the point

Augustine's answer is not that the theft was secretly terrible. His answer is that it was trivial, and that its triviality is what makes it usable.

Think about what he is trying to isolate. He wants to look at wrongdoing with nothing else mixed in. Any serious crime comes with a thick layer of other things: need, rage, fear, money, desire, revenge. Those explanations are so satisfying that you never get past them. Ask why a man stole a purse and the answer "he needed money" closes the question.

The pears have none of that. There is no need, no gain, no anger, no pleasure in the object. Which means the pear theft is the only kind of case where you can see whatever is left over when every ordinary motive has been stripped out.

This is the same argumentative move he made in Book One with the jealous baby, and it is worth naming because he will do it again. Find the case where all the usual explanations are unavailable, and see what remains. In Book One he needed a creature that had learned nothing. Here he needs an act that gained nothing.

IN REAL TERMS

This is how a laboratory works, and Augustine is doing something recognisably like it.

If you want to know whether a plant needs light, you do not study a plant in a field, where it also has soil, rain, insects, temperature and wind. You put one in a box and remove everything except the light.

The pear theft is the box. It is an act of wrongdoing with the nutrients removed. Whatever is still growing in there is the thing he is looking for.

4.3 — The comparison with a famous traitor

Augustine then does something that makes his method explicit. He reaches for the most notorious example of gratuitous cruelty in Roman memory, in order to argue that even *that* man had a reason and he did not.

WORD BOX

Catiline: a Roman aristocrat who in 63 BC attempted to seize power by conspiracy. The plot was exposed by Cicero and Catiline was killed. He became the standard Roman example of a man who was cruel for the pleasure of it.

Sallust: the historian whose account of the conspiracy was a school text. It is Sallust who supplies the phrase Augustine is working from, describing Catiline as cruel without needing a reason.

Why it matters: every educated reader in the Latin world would recognise this reference instantly. Augustine is invoking the agreed limit case of motiveless evil, and then arguing that he has gone past it.

His point about Catiline is precise. Even Catiline, the byword for cruelty without cause, was not doing it for nothing. He was keeping his hand in. He wanted power, and he was maintaining the capacity and the reputation that would get it. Behind the gratuitous act there was still a purpose.

Augustine's claim is that his own theft had no such second layer. There was no ambition being served, no capacity being maintained, no reputation being built with anyone who mattered. He says the wrongdoing was the object.

Notice how much weight that puts on a paragraph about fruit. Augustine is claiming to have found something the Roman moral tradition said did not exist: an act done for no good at all, not even a twisted one.

4.4 — What is actually at stake

This is not a literary flourish. There is a specific doctrinal payoff, and it is worth putting on the table now rather than letting it emerge later.

If human beings only ever pursue something they take to be good, then wrongdoing is fundamentally a mistake. People go wrong because they are confused about what is good for them. The remedy for that is education. Teach people better and they will choose better.

If human beings can want the wrong *because* it is wrong, then wrongdoing is not a mistake and education will not fix it. Something in the will is bent, not merely misinformed, and it cannot straighten itself by learning more.

That is the difference between a problem you solve and a condition you need rescuing from. Augustine spends half a book on some pears because those two pictures of the human being lead in completely opposite directions, and he thinks the pears decide between them.

REMEMBER THIS

The objection is strong and worth feeling: a bishop devotes **more than half a book** to stolen fruit while his sexual life gets adjectives and his partner of thirteen years gets no name. Nietzsche laughed at it.

His answer is that the theft was trivial and that **triviality is what makes it usable**. Serious crimes come with need, rage and gain attached, and those explanations close the question before you reach the interesting part.

It is the same move as the jealous baby in Book One: **find the case where the usual explanations are unavailable**, and see what is left.

He invokes **Catiline**, the Roman byword for motiveless cruelty, and argues that even Catiline had a purpose behind the cruelty, and that he himself did not.

The stake: if people only ever chase what they think is good, wrongdoing is a mistake and education fixes it. If they can want wrong because it is wrong, it is a condition and education cannot.

CHAPTER FIVE

Doing Wrong for No Reason at All

Augustine claims to have found in himself something the whole classical tradition said was impossible. Then, four paragraphs later, he hands his critics the evidence against it.

5.1 — The assumption he is attacking

There is a principle running through Greek and Roman moral thought that is so widely held it is rarely argued for. Nobody wants evil as such. Everyone acts for the sake of some good, real or apparent. A person who does something terrible has miscalculated, or been overpowered by an appetite, or been misled about what would benefit them. Wrongdoing is a failure of knowledge or of self-control, never a straightforward preference.

WORD BOX

"Nobody does wrong willingly": a principle associated with Socrates and accepted in various forms across the ancient schools. It holds that if you genuinely saw that something was bad for you, you could not want it. So all wrongdoing is a kind of ignorance.

Why it matters: it makes moral failure into an intellectual failure, and therefore fixable by teaching. Augustine is about to claim it is false, and if he is right, a great deal of ancient ethics has to be rebuilt.

Augustine had been trained in this tradition and expected it to be true. He says as much: he looks for the good he was chasing in the theft, because there is supposed to be one, and he cannot find it.

5.2 — What he claims to have found

His conclusion is stated flatly. There was no motive for his wickedness except wickedness itself. The theft did not even have the counterfeit attractiveness that vices normally have. He was not seeking anything through the shame. He was seeking the shame.

And then a sentence that is genuinely strange, and which is usually quoted without anyone noticing how strange it is: he says he loved the falling rather than the thing he fell for. He loved his own fault, not the thing the fault was about.

That is a claim about the shape of a desire, and it is precise. Ordinarily a wrong action has two parts: something wanted, and a rule broken to get it. The wanting explains the breaking. Augustine says that in this case the first part was empty and the second part was the whole content. The breaking was the want.

5.3 — Why he thinks this is possible

He does not leave it as a report. He gives an explanation, and it is the thing that keeps this passage philosophically alive.

His account is that wrongdoing is always an imitation of something real. Every vice, he argues, is a distorted grab at a genuine attribute of God. Pride imitates height. Cruelty imitates power. Ambition imitates honour. Curiosity imitates knowledge. Laziness imitates rest. Even fear and grief are twisted versions of something that would be good if it were aimed correctly.

So what was his theft imitating? Freedom. The ability to do a thing simply because you have chosen it, unconstrained by rules. That is a real and good thing at its source, and what he had was a counterfeit of it: a maimed liberty, doing something forbidden for no purpose in order to feel unbounded.

Notice that this rescues his position from a hole. If the theft were genuinely for nothing at all, it would be unintelligible, and an unintelligible act cannot be blamed. By saying it was a counterfeit of freedom, Augustine keeps it explicable and keeps it culpable at the same time. It had a shape. The shape was a forgery.

This also connects straight back to Book One, and forward to Book Seven. Evil is not a thing. It is a good thing pointed the wrong way, or reached for in the wrong manner. The pear theft is that formula in its smallest possible form.

5.4 — The objection he hands his critics

And now the problem, which Augustine raises himself and does not resolve to everyone's satisfaction.

Twice in the same discussion he says that he would not have done it alone. He says the friendship was itself the pleasure. He says that what he enjoyed was not the theft but the doing of it together.

If that is right, the motive is not missing. The motive is the other boys, and it is a completely ordinary one.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE PEAR THEFT ACTUALLY MOTIVELESS?

This is the central interpretative dispute in Book Two and it is unresolved. Both readings are held by serious people and both have real textual support.

THE MOTIVE IS THERE AND HE NAMES IT

Augustine states plainly that he would not have done it alone and that the company was the pleasure. That is a motive: belonging, the approval of the group, the shared laugh. It is one of the most powerful motives there is. Having spent pages insisting that no good was sought, he identifies the good being sought and then declines to count it. The classical principle survives intact and the dramatic claim collapses.

HE COUNTS IT AND IT DOES NOT SAVE THE CASE

Augustine does not overlook the friendship; he examines it and finds it insufficient. His question is not "why was I there?" but "what was enjoyed?" The company explains the occasion, not the content. Take away the theft and the same boys could have enjoyed each other's company doing anything at all. Something specific was added by the act being wrong, and that addition is what he cannot find a good for.

THE ACT HAD NO SINGLE MOTIVE AT ALL

A third view holds that the question is malformed. Asking for "the" motive of a group of bored sixteen-year-olds at midnight assumes a decision procedure that was not running. There was momentum, mutual escalation and laughter. Augustine is trying to find at the bottom of it a single thing that was wanted, because his framework requires there to be one, and his critics are trying to find a different single thing for the same reason.

Where things stand: Everyone agrees on the text: Augustine says both that no good was sought and that he would not have done it alone. The dispute is about whether the second statement cancels the first. It has been argued since at least the nineteenth century and remains open.

What would settle it: Nothing will settle it, because it is not a question about the fourth century. It is a question about what counts as a motive, and about whether an act can have a cause without having a reason. That is a live question in philosophy of action now.

Why people care so much: It matters because the classical principle it tests is load-bearing. If people genuinely can want wrong as wrong, moral failure is not fixable by teaching, and a great deal about how societies should respond to wrongdoing looks different.

Before leaving that argument, it is worth asking what both sides are doing when they look for the motive, because they are doing the same thing and neither says so.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT AN ACT HAS A MOTIVE, SINGULAR

Look at what both sides of that argument take for granted. Each is hunting for the motive. Augustine wants to show that the slot is empty. His critics want to show that the slot contains "friendship". Neither questions that there is a slot.

But the assumption that every action has one thing behind it comes from a particular picture of a person: a mind that surveys options, selects a good, and issues an instruction to the body. On that picture an act without a motive is a contradiction, and finding one would be enormous news.

A group of tired teenagers shaking a tree at two in the morning may simply not be running that procedure. There is drift, then a suggestion, then someone moves, then everyone moves. Nobody chose in the way the picture requires. And if that is what happened, then Augustine has found something real but has described it wrongly: not an act with a missing motive, but an act with no centre.

Which is arguably even worse for the classical principle than what he claimed.

The general form: looking for the answer to a question, when what is wrong is the question's grammar.

That box is not a defence of Augustine and it is not an attack on him. It suggests that the argument he started may be more interesting than either side of it, which is the most that a box of that kind should ever claim.

REMEMBER THIS

The classical tradition held that **nobody wants evil as such**. Wrongdoing is a mistake about what is good, so teaching can fix it.

Augustine claims his theft had **no motive except the wrongness itself**. He says he loved the falling, not the thing he fell for.

He explains it as a **counterfeit of freedom**: doing a forbidden thing for no purpose in order to feel unbounded. That keeps the act explicable and culpable at once.

Then he says twice that **he would not have done it alone**, which looks like the motive he claimed was missing. Whether that cancels his case is genuinely disputed.

Both sides assume the act had one motive. A group of bored teenagers at midnight may not have been running that procedure at all.

CHAPTER SIX

"I Would Not Have Done It Alone"

The most interesting sentence in Book Two is the one that appears to wreck Augustine's argument. It is also the one where he sees furthest.

6.1 — The clause

Augustine says it twice, and the second time he presses on it. Alone, he would not have done it. Alone, it would have given him nothing. He asks himself directly what the friendship added, since the pears added nothing, and he answers that it was the doing of it in company that was the pleasure.

Then he says something sharper. He observes that he laughed, and that the laughing was the thing. There was a delight in the shared deception and in the reaction of the others, and it was that, not the fruit and not even the transgression by itself, that was being enjoyed.

He is quite clear-eyed about this. Having built four pages on the absence of a motive, he then describes the mechanism in detail, and it looks like a motive.

6.2 — Why he does not think this rescues him

His reasoning is worth setting out carefully, because it is usually skipped.

Augustine accepts that the company was necessary. He denies that the company was sufficient. The presence of the other boys explains why the theft happened rather than not happening. It does not explain what was gained by the act being *wrong*.

And the wrongness was doing work. They did not go and play a game together, which would have produced the same company and the same laughter with nothing forbidden in it. They went and did something they should not, and the shouldn't was part of what they were enjoying.

So the friendship supplies the occasion and the wrongness supplies the content, and Augustine is asking about the content.

Whether that distinction holds is exactly what Chapter Five's argument box was about. I am not going to adjudicate it. But it is worth noticing that Augustine is not being obtuse. He has

seen the objection, he has stated it more clearly than most of his critics do, and he has an answer to it. You can think the answer fails. You cannot think he missed the point.

6.3 — What a group does to a person

There is something else in this passage, and it is the part that has aged best.

Augustine notices that the group is not a collection of individuals each deciding to steal. He describes something more like a current. Somebody says let us go and do it, and there is a shame in hanging back that is stronger than the shame of doing it. The direction of the embarrassment has been reversed. In that group, at that hour, the awkward thing was to be the one who did not.

He is describing peer pressure without the vocabulary for it, and he is describing it accurately.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A GROUP IS A COLLECTION OF INDIVIDUALS

When we assign blame for something done by several people together, we almost always start by dividing the act among them. Each person is asked what they chose, and the group is treated as the sum of those choices. Legal systems work this way. So does ordinary conversation about a crowd. Augustine's description does not fit that. Nobody in his account performed the mental act of deciding to steal pears. A suggestion moved through a group and the group moved. The individual decision that the framework requires is not obviously present in any of them.

And note what this does to his own argument. If the theft was produced by a group dynamic rather than by six separate choices, then asking what Augustine wanted may be asking about something that did not exist as a separate item. His search for a motive assumes a self that was there, deliberating, on its own. The passage he wrote suggests it was not.

He half sees this. He says he would not have done it alone, which is precisely the observation that his own self was not the unit of action that night.

The general form: analysing something into parts that were not there before the analysis.

It is worth adding, in fairness to the framework he is working in, that Augustine does not use any of this as an excuse. He never says the group made him do it. He reports the mechanism and keeps the responsibility, which is a harder combination to hold than either half on its own.

6.4 — Friendship, and the word he uses

One last observation, because it will matter enormously in Part Three.

Augustine calls what happened that night friendship, and then calls it unfriendly friendship. He does not dismiss it as fake. He treats it as a real thing that has been turned in a bad direction. The bond between those young men was genuine. It was doing what bonds do. It was simply pointed at something that harmed all of them.

That is the same structure as everything else in this book: a good thing aimed wrongly. But it lands differently here, because friendship is the one good Augustine never talks himself out of. Book Four will contain the death of a close friend and a grief that he says nearly destroyed him, and he will still not conclude that friendship was the problem.

IN REAL TERMS

Anyone who has been in a group that did something stupid knows the specific feeling Augustine is describing, and it is not the feeling of wanting the thing.

It is the feeling of not wanting to be the one who says no. Of the joke landing. Of being inside rather than outside for the length of an evening.

His point is that this is not a small or contemptible want. It is one of the strongest there is, which is exactly why it can carry people somewhere none of them would have gone alone.

6.5 — How Book Two ends

The last movement of Book Two is short and it contains the phrase the whole book has been building towards.

Augustine asks what he got out of the things he is now ashamed of, and answers: nothing. Then he says where all of it left him. He became, in his own words, a land of want to himself. A region of destitution.

The image is geographical and it is exact. Not a man who did bad things and felt guilty, but a man who had turned into a place where there was nothing. The wanting that came loose in Chapter Two has run its course and consumed what it was running on.

It is worth setting that beside the opening of Book One. There, human beings are made for God and restless until they rest in him. Here is what the restlessness looks like after a few years of being fed: a person who has become an empty country.

And notice the direction of the sentence. He does not say he went to a wasteland. He says he became one. On his account the damage is not to his circumstances or his reputation. It is to what he is.

That is the note Book Two closes on, and it is why Book Three opens in a city full of noise. A person who has become empty goes looking, and Carthage is what he finds.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine says twice that **he would not have done it alone**, and that the company and the laughter were the pleasure.

He accepts the company was **necessary but not sufficient**. It explains why the theft happened; it does not explain what was gained by the act being wrong.

He describes the group as a **current rather than a set of decisions**: the shame of hanging back was stronger than the shame of joining in. That is peer pressure, described accurately without the vocabulary.

He calls it **friendship**, and does not dismiss it as fake. A real bond, aimed at something that harmed everyone in it.

He reports the mechanism and keeps the responsibility. He never says the group made him do it.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Carthage: The Cauldron

Book Three opens with the most quoted sentence Augustine ever wrote about a city, and then turns into an argument about why we go to sad stories on purpose.

7.1 — The city

The money was found and Augustine went to Carthage, at about seventeen, in 370. It was the second city of the Latin west after Rome and by some way the largest city he had ever seen. It had a harbour, a theatre, an amphitheatre, baths, a working port economy and the best schools in Roman Africa. It was where careers were made.

IN REAL TERMS

Thagaste, where Augustine grew up, was a town. Carthage was a city of somewhere in the region of a couple of hundred thousand people.

The move is not "small town to big town". It is closer to leaving a market town for the largest city you have any idea exists, at seventeen, alone, with money your family strained to find, and with a career riding on it.

Everything in Book Three happens to somebody in that position.

It also had, for Augustine, a particular resonance we met in Part One. Carthage is the city of Dido, the queen he had wept over as a schoolboy in Virgil. He arrives in the city of the woman whose fictional death moved him more than his own condition did.

7.2 — The cauldron, and what the line actually says

The opening sentence of Book Three, in plain English: he came to Carthage, where a cauldron of shameful loves was hissing all around him.

The word he uses for cauldron is a cooking pan, and there is a pun in the Latin: the word for the pan sounds like the name of the city. A trained speaker made that joke on purpose and expected it to be noticed.

That is worth flagging, because the line is normally quoted as a cry of anguish. It is a cry of anguish that has been polished. Both things are true. Augustine is a rhetorician describing his own damnation with a pun in it, and pretending otherwise gets him wrong.

And then the sentence that follows is the one that actually matters, and it is almost never quoted. He says he was not yet in love, and that he was in love with being in love. He hated himself for not feeling hungrier. He went looking for something to love because he was in love with loving.

Read that carefully and the passage is not about lust at all, or not primarily. It is about a person who has an appetite for having an appetite. The cauldron is the setting. The condition is the emptiness that goes shopping.

7.3 — The Wreckers

Carthage had student gangs, and Augustine describes one by name.

WORD BOX

Eversores, "the Wreckers" or "the Overturers": a name a group of Carthage students gave themselves. Their activity was breaking up other people's lectures, humiliating new arrivals, and general organised mockery.

Why it matters: Augustine says he kept company with them and enjoyed their approval, while being ashamed of the worst of what they did and not joining in with all of it. This is the pear theft pattern again, with the same person, four years older.

His comment on the name is a small piece of moral analysis and it is easy to miss. He says the name fits them, because they were the ones who had been wrecked first. They were turned upside down themselves, and their amusement was a symptom of it rather than a display of strength.

He also admits something awkward: he wanted to be in with them. He was not one of the worst, and he says so, but he ran with them because of what their company gave him. That is exactly the relationship to a group he described in Book Two, and he presents it without pretending he had grown out of it.

7.4 — The theatre, and borrowed grief

Then the chapter turns to what looks like a change of subject and is not. Augustine says he was carried away by the theatre, and that it was full of images of his own misery and fuel for his fire.

His objection is the one he began in Book One, over the tears for Dido, and here he develops it fully. Part One promised we would do it properly, so here it is.

The argument runs like this. At a tragedy, a man wants to be made unhappy. He goes on purpose. He counts the evening a success if it hurt. And Augustine asks the obvious question that nobody asks: why would anyone want that?

The answer people give is that it is compassion. We feel for the sufferer. Feeling for a sufferer is a virtue. So the theatre trains a good capacity.

Augustine's reply is that real compassion is tested by what it does. If you pity a person in front of you, you help them. The mark of the theatre is that the pity is precisely the kind you cannot act on, and that this is the point rather than a limitation. Nobody in the audience wants the play to stop and the character to be rescued. They want the suffering to continue, because the suffering is what they came for.

He says something harder still. He notices that the same man who weeps at the play would be annoyed if the play were less sad, and would go home disappointed. So the wish is not for the sufferer to be well. It is for oneself to be moved. It is compassion with the object removed.

WORD BOX

Catharsis: a term from Aristotle's *Poetics*, usually rendered as purging or cleansing. The idea is that watching tragedy discharges pity and fear in a controlled way, and that this is good for the spectator.

Why it matters: it is the standard defence of tragedy in the classical world and in most of the argument since. Augustine is attacking it without naming it. He is denying that the discharge is a cleansing and suggesting it is a feeding.

So the question on the table is whether Augustine has caught the theatre in something real, or has described one bad way of using it and mistaken it for the thing itself. That argument is still running.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE ATTACK ON TRAGEDY WORK?

This passage has been argued over for a very long time, and the dispute is not really about the fourth-century theatre. It is about what fiction does to people.

AUGUSTINE IS RIGHT AND THE DEFENCE IS A RATIONALISATION

The test he proposes is a good one: real pity moves towards relief. Nobody in a cinema wants the film to end early so the character can be safe. The pleasure requires the suffering to continue, and requires it to be someone else's. That is a real asymmetry and no theory of purging explains it away. Anyone who has cried at a film and then felt vaguely pleased with themselves for crying has felt the thing he is pointing at.

AUGUSTINE HAS MISDESCRIBED WHAT AN AUDIENCE DOES

The defence is that fiction is not a substitute for compassion but a rehearsal of it. You cannot help Hecuba because Hecuba does not exist, and treating that as a moral failure confuses categories. What is exercised is the capacity to take another person's situation seriously from the inside, which is the hardest part of compassion and the part that ordinary life gives little practice in. On this view fiction expands the range of people you are able to pity at all.

HE IS RIGHT ABOUT HIMSELF AND WRONG TO GENERALISE

A third reading notes what Augustine actually describes: a lonely young man seeking out grief because he wanted to feel something, and reporting that it left him worse. That is a real and recognisable use of fiction. It is not the only one. He may be giving an accurate account of his own consumption and presenting it as an analysis of the medium.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes the observation. The audience does want the suffering to continue, and does judge the evening by how much it hurt. The dispute is over what that shows: a corrupted sympathy, or a sympathy being exercised under conditions where action is not the relevant response.

What would settle it: Little would settle it. Empirical work on whether reading fiction increases real-world empathy exists and is contested, with results that have proved hard to replicate. Anyone citing that literature as decisive in either direction is overstating what it currently supports.

Why people care so much: It matters because the same argument returns whenever a society asks what violent or distressing entertainment does to the people who consume it. The terms have barely changed in sixteen hundred years.

Underneath all three of those positions there is something neither camp examines, and it is worth pulling out.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT FEELING IS PRACTICE

Both sides above assume that an emotion felt at a play is the same kind of thing as an emotion felt in life, differing only in what triggered it. Augustine thinks it is that emotion, corrupted. The defenders think it is that emotion, rehearsed. Neither questions that it is the same emotion. But a feeling in the theatre comes with something no feeling in life has: the knowledge that it will end, that nothing is required of you, and that you may leave. That is not a small difference in the surrounding conditions. It may be a difference in what the state actually is.

If so, then asking whether theatrical pity trains real pity is like asking whether a flight simulator trains you to survive a crash. Something is being trained. It is not obvious it is the thing both sides think they are arguing about.

The general form: treating two states as the same because they feel similar from the inside.

I should declare something here, because this is a place where my own view could pull the writing. I read novels and I think they do me good, which gives me an interest in Augustine being wrong. I have tried to give his case its full strength for that reason, and you should discount my summary of the opposing view slightly in his favour.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine reached **Carthage at about seventeen**, the second city of the Latin west, on money his family strained to find.

The famous cauldron line has a **pun in it**: the word for the cooking pan sounds like the city's name. It is anguish that has been polished, and both halves are real.

The sentence that matters comes next: he was **not yet in love and was in love with loving**. An appetite for having an appetite.

He ran with a student gang called **the Wreckers**, wanting their approval without joining in the worst of it. The pear theft pattern, four years on.

His attack on tragedy: **real pity moves towards relief**, and nobody at a play wants the suffering to stop. The wish is not for the sufferer to be well but for oneself to be moved.

Whether that is a corrupted sympathy or a sympathy being exercised where action is impossible is still argued about, in the same terms, today.

CHAPTER EIGHT

A Lost Book That Changed a Life

At around eighteen he read a book in the ordinary course of his studies. The book no longer exists. It redirected everything.

8.1 — What Hortensius was

In the standard rhetoric curriculum, students read Cicero for his style. Augustine picked up one of Cicero's works because he wanted to learn to write like him. It was called *Hortensius*, and it was not a book about style at all.

WORD BOX

Hortensius: a work by Cicero, written around 45 BC, arguing that the pursuit of wisdom is what a human life is for. It took its name from Hortensius, a famous orator who appears in it arguing the other side.

Protreptic: the ancient genre it belongs to. A protreptic is a work designed not to inform you but to turn you: to make you take up a way of life. It is closer to a recruitment speech than to a textbook. Why it matters: Augustine did not stumble on a philosophical argument by accident. He read a document specifically engineered to redirect a young man, and it worked exactly as designed.

The book is lost. We do not have it. That fact deserves its own box, because it is the sort of thing readers assume is a formality and it is not.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

No copy of *Hortensius* survives. What we have are quotations of it made by later writers who did have it, of whom Augustine himself is the single most important.

That means the reconstruction is built from fragments embedded in other people's arguments, quoted for their own purposes, with no way to check the context.

What this evidence supports: that the work existed, that it argued for the philosophical life, and roughly what some of its lines said.

What it cannot support: any confident claim about its overall argument or its tone. And there is a specific circularity worth naming. A substantial part of what we know about the book comes from the man whose life it changed, writing about the change. Our picture of the cause is partly derived from the effect.

8.2 — What it did to him

Augustine says the book changed how he felt about everything. It redirected his prayers. It gave him different hopes and different wants. Every empty ambition suddenly looked worthless to him, and he began to burn for something he calls immortal wisdom.

He is precise about the mechanism, and the precision is the interesting part. He had gone to the book for the language and had been caught by the content. He says it was not the style that gripped him but what the book said.

For a man in his position that is a genuine reversal. He was in Carthage to acquire eloquence in order to get a job. The entire apparatus of his education treated words as an instrument. A book got past the instrument.

Note also his age, and note that the sources disagree slightly about it, in a way worth understanding rather than glossing. Augustine says this happened in his nineteenth year. In the Roman way of counting, your nineteenth year is the year in which you turn nineteen, so you are eighteen for most of it. That is why some accounts say eighteen and some say nineteen. They are not disagreeing about the fact. They are counting differently, and neither is wrong.

8.3 — What "philosophy" meant then

This is a place where a modern word will mislead you badly if it is not unpacked, so here is the unpacking.

WORD BOX

Philosophy (in the ancient sense): not an academic subject and not a set of positions to be argued about. A philosophy was a way of living: a school you joined, with a discipline, a set of practices, companions, and a claim to make you happy by changing what you were.

Why it matters: when Augustine says *Hortensius* made him love wisdom, he does not mean he became interested in a subject. He means he decided to live differently, in the way a person today might mean by saying they had found a vocation. That is why the next thing that happens is that he joins a religion.

This also explains something that otherwise looks like a non-sequitur. Augustine reads a book about the love of wisdom and then, within a very short time, becomes a Manichee. To us that is a jump from philosophy to religion. To him it was not a jump at all. He had been persuaded to look for a way of life that would make him wise and happy, and he went looking, and he found something offering exactly that.

8.4 — The one thing it lacked

And then Augustine says something that tells you a great deal about how he is constructing this book.

He records that one thing checked his enthusiasm: the name of Christ was not in it. He says his mother's faith had put that name into him as a boy, and that anything without it, however learned and polished and true, could not entirely take him.

Whether an eighteen-year-old actually felt that at the time is not recoverable. What is clear is what the sentence does in the book. It plants the standard by which everything in the next five books will be judged, and it will come back with enormous force in Book Seven, where Augustine reads the Platonists and says almost exactly the same thing about them: magnificent, and missing one name.

So this is a forward promise, and I will pay it off in Part Four. The structure of Augustine's intellectual life, as he presents it, is a series of encounters with things that were nearly enough.

REMEMBER THIS

At about eighteen, reading Cicero for **style**, Augustine was caught by **content**. The book was *Hortensius*, an argument that a life should be spent pursuing wisdom.

The book is **lost**. It survives only as quotations in later writers, of whom Augustine is the most important. Our picture of the cause is partly built from the effect.

Philosophy then meant a way of living, not an academic subject: a school you joined, with practices and companions and a promise of happiness.

That is why reading a philosophy book led straight to **joining a religion**. To Augustine there was no jump involved.

He says one thing held him back: the name of Christ was not in it. He will say almost exactly the same about the Platonists in Book Seven.

CHAPTER NINE

The Bible Disappoints, the Manichees Persuade

Fired up to find wisdom, he opened the Christian scriptures and put them down again in disgust. Then he met a religion that answered the question that had been bothering him, and stayed for nine years.

9.1 — He opens the Bible and finds it badly written

This is one of the most useful passages in the whole work for understanding the fourth century, and it is routinely skipped. Augustine, newly determined to find wisdom, turns to the scriptures his mother had raised him on. And he finds them unworthy to be compared with Cicero.

His complaint is not about the doctrine. It is about the prose. He thought the writing was crude and the style beneath him. He says his swollen pride recoiled from it, and that his sharpness could not get inside it.

To a modern reader this sounds like snobbery, and Augustine agrees, which is why he tells us. But there are two solid reasons behind it that are worth having.

9.2 — Why a trained man found it crude

The first reason is the translation. Augustine could not read Hebrew and his Greek was weak, as Part One established. He was reading a Latin Bible, and the Latin Bible of the 370s was not the polished version later generations knew.

WORD BOX

The Old Latin Bible: the collection of Latin translations circulating before Jerome produced the version later called the Vulgate, which was not begun until around 382 and took decades to spread. The Old Latin texts were not one authorised translation but many, made at different times by different hands, often extremely literal.

Why it matters: a very literal translation from Greek into Latin produces Latin that reads as clumsy, because it keeps the shape of the original language. To a man trained to hear Ciceronian rhythm, it sounded like bad writing, because by the standards he had been taught, it was.

The second reason is the training. A rhetorical education taught you to judge a text by its construction: by period, balance, cadence and ornament. That is not a neutral skill. It is a filter, and it screens out anything written plainly.

Augustine is describing a highly trained reader who has been made unable to read a certain kind of book. His education had given him a very fine instrument and the instrument could not detect this. That is the point he is making about himself, and it connects straight back to Book One's attack on the curriculum.

It also sets up a change that comes in Part Four. What eventually unlocks scripture for him is not becoming less clever. It is hearing Ambrose preach in Milan and discovering that the texts can be read another way. But that is twelve years off.

9.3 — Who the Manichees were

And then he fell in with the Manichees. Part One promised a proper account of them, so here it is.

WORD BOX

Manichaeism: a religion founded by a Persian teacher named Mani in the third century, in Mesopotamia. Mani presented himself as the last in a line of messengers that included Zoroaster, the Buddha and Jesus, and he drew on all three. It spread very widely, from North Africa to China, and survived for centuries.

Dualism: the belief that reality has two ultimate sources rather than one. In the Manichaean version there are two eternal principles: Light, which is good, spirit and God; and Darkness, which is evil, matter and chaos. Neither made the other. Neither can destroy the other.

Why it matters: this is the single most important fact about the system. If there are two ultimate powers, then evil does not have to be explained. It is just there, as a fact about the universe, and it was never anybody's fault.

The story the Manichees told went roughly like this. The realm of Darkness attacked the realm of Light. In the struggle, particles of Light were captured and trapped inside matter. The world we live in is the wreckage of that battle, and every human soul is a fragment of Light caught inside a body made of Darkness. Salvation is the gradual release of the trapped Light, and history is that release happening.

WORD BOX

The Elect and the Hearers: the two ranks of the Manichaean community. The **Elect** lived under a severe discipline: no meat, no wine, no sex, no farming, since ploughing and harvesting injured the Light trapped in plants. The **Hearers**, sometimes called auditors, lived ordinary lives, married, worked, and supported the Elect by bringing them food, which the Elect ate ritually so that the Light in it could be released.

Why it matters: Augustine was a Hearer, never one of the Elect, for about nine years, roughly 373 to 382. He was in the rank that was not required to be continent. He mentions this himself, and his enemies mentioned it about him for the rest of his life.

9.4 — Why it was a good answer

It is easy to present Manichaeism as an exotic error that a clever young man foolishly swallowed. That gets the situation backwards, and Augustine himself does not do it. The system answered a real question that Christianity, as he had encountered it, had not.

The question is the oldest one in religion. If God is entirely good and entirely powerful and made everything, where did evil come from? Either God made it, in which case God is not good, or God did not make everything, in which case God is not the creator, or God cannot stop it, in which case God is not all-powerful.

Manichaeism cuts that knot cleanly. Evil is a separate eternal substance. God did not make it and is not responsible for it. God is fighting it and will eventually win. There is nothing to explain away.

And there is a second attraction, which Augustine is unusually honest about. If the evil in you is a foreign substance that got into you, then the bad things you do are not, in the deepest sense, yours. Something else in you is doing them. He says this plainly: it flattered him to think that when he did wrong it was not he who did it.

That is the connection to Book Two, and it is the reason the pears and the Manichees are in the same part of this series. Augustine had spent half a book establishing that he did a wrong thing for no reason, with nobody else to blame. Then he adopted a system that told him it had not really been him. The whole of the next nine years is an argument he was having with himself about responsibility, and he did not know it.

THE ARGUMENT — IS AUGUSTINE FAIR TO THE MANICHEES?

Almost everything most people know about Manichaeism comes from its most effective opponent, who was writing to demolish it. That is a situation worth being careful about.

HE IS AN UNUSUALLY GOOD WITNESS

Augustine was inside the movement for nine years. He knew its texts, its leaders and its practices from within, which almost no other surviving critic did. He also had no reason to invent absurdities, since his readers included people who could check. Where Manichaean writings have been recovered in the modern period, from Egypt and from Central Asia, they have on the whole confirmed the general shape of the system he describes.

HE IS A HOSTILE WITNESS REPORTING A RELIGION HE LEFT

He is describing a faith he abandoned, to an audience that expected him to denounce it, at a time when he was answering critics who said his conversion was not genuine. He emphasises the cosmological details that sound most ridiculous and gives little space to what the system offered morally or spiritually. He was also, by his own admission, only a Hearer, which means there were levels of teaching and practice he did not have access to.

THE RECOVERED TEXTS CHANGE THE QUESTION

A third position notes that a great deal of Manichaean material has been recovered over the last century and more, in several languages, and that scholars can now read the movement in its own words rather than through its opponents. On that basis the debate has moved from "is Augustine lying?" to the more useful question of which parts of a very large and varied religion he was in contact with in North Africa in the 370s.

Where things stand: It is agreed that Augustine's account of the basic structure is broadly accurate, and equally agreed that it is selective and polemically shaped. The dispute is over how much the selection distorts.

What would settle it: This is one of the rare cases where new evidence genuinely arrived. Manichaean texts recovered in the twentieth century allow direct comparison, and more material continues to be edited and published. This question is less settled and more improvable than most in this series.

Why people care so much: It matters because Manichaeism is the standard example of a "heresy" known almost entirely through the writings of the person who destroyed it, and how much we trust Augustine here affects how much we trust the same pattern elsewhere.

9.5 — What they said about the Old Testament

One part of the Manichee appeal was destructive rather than constructive, and it worked on Augustine because of exactly the training described earlier in this chapter.

The Manichees attacked the Jewish scriptures, and their attack was mostly moral. They pointed at the patriarchs: men with several wives and concubines, men who deceived, men who fought wars, all of them presented by the text as favoured by God. They pointed at animal sacrifice. They read the passages describing God in bodily terms and asked whether a God with hands and a face was worth worshipping.

These are not stupid objections. Augustine, a young man with a moral seriousness newly awakened by Cicero, found them devastating. He says he had no answer and that the ridicule seemed to him well aimed.

The answer he eventually worked out, and gives here in retrospect, is worth understanding because it is more subtle than it is usually reported. He argues that what justice requires is not the same in all circumstances, and that this does not make justice a matter of taste.

His comparison is a suit of armour. The pieces are not interchangeable. A piece that is correct on the shoulder is wrong on the leg, and nobody concludes from that that armour has no rules. In the same way, he argues, a command given to one people in one century may be right there and wrong elsewhere, while the underlying standard has not moved at all.

Then he adds the harder half, and it is the half that matters. Some things, he says, are wrong everywhere and always, regardless of custom, and the fact that a whole society approves of them changes nothing. He is not arguing that morality is local. He is arguing that a single standard produces different requirements in different situations, which is a different claim and a much stronger one.

Whether that answer works is a live question and this series will not settle it. What matters here is the sequence. He did not have that answer at nineteen. He acquired it over about fifteen years, and the absence of it is part of why the Manichees held him.

9.6 — "More inward than my innermost self"

Book Three also contains one of the most quoted sentences Augustine ever wrote, and it arrives in the middle of an attack on Manichee cosmology rather than in a passage of praise.

He is describing the elaborate physical machinery the Manichees taught: the sun and moon as ships ferrying rescued Light, the stars as fragments of divine armour, the cosmos as a vast engine for extracting spirit from matter. He calls these dishes of shining fantasies. He notes that they were served to him when he was hungry for God, and that a hungry man will eat what is put in front of him.

His diagnosis of the error is not that the pictures were too strange. It is that they were pictures at all. He was looking for God as though God were something out there to be located, somewhere in the sky, made of some very fine kind of stuff. He says that God was, in fact, more inward than his own innermost self, and higher than his highest.

Both halves of that sentence are doing work. **More inward than my innermost:** closer to me than the part of me I think of as most mine. **Higher than my highest:** and at the same time not me, not a component of me, not something I could arrive at by going further in.

IN REAL TERMS

The mistake he is describing is a common one and it is not specifically religious.

It is the mistake of looking for the cause of your own mood somewhere in your circumstances, when the thing shaping how everything looks is the lens rather than anything in the picture.

Augustine is saying he spent nine years searching space for something that was not an object in space, and doing it with great energy, and getting further away with every step.

That sentence is also the hinge of the whole work, and I want to flag it now because it will govern Parts Four, Seven and Eight. The turn Augustine eventually makes is not from one place to another place. It is from looking outward to looking inward, and then from looking

inward to finding something inward that is not him. Book Ten, on memory, is that move done at length.

9.5 — Monica's dream, and the bishop

Book Three ends with two scenes involving his mother, and they are there to set the emotional terms for the next six books.

When Augustine came home a Manichee, Monica would not eat with him or have him in the house. Then she had a dream. She was standing on a wooden rule, grieving, and a shining young figure asked why she was sad and told her to look: where she was, her son was too. She looked and saw Augustine standing on the same rule beside her.

She told him. He tried to twist it, saying it meant she would become what he was. She answered at once that she had not been told "where he is, you are", but "where you are, he is". Augustine says her reply moved him more than the dream. He remembered the exchange for a quarter of a century and put it in the book.

Then, years later, she wore down a bishop, a former Manichee himself, begging him to argue with her son. He refused. He said Augustine was not ready, and would work out the error on his own by reading. When she kept pressing and weeping, he gave her the line that has been attached to her name ever since: that it was not possible that the son of those tears should be lost.

She took it as if it had come from heaven. It was nine years before it came true.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A RELIGION IS A SET OF CLAIMS YOU ASSESS

The whole of this chapter, and most modern writing about conversion, assumes that joining a religion works like this: a person examines the claims, finds them convincing, and adopts them. Leaving works the same way in reverse. On this picture Augustine became a Manichee because their answer to the problem of evil was better, and left because it stopped being convincing. Augustine's own account keeps failing to fit that shape, and he does not flag the mismatch. He describes a group of friends. He describes wanting to belong. He describes remaining for nine years while, on his own telling, his doubts grew steadily. He describes leaving only after meeting people in Milan.

What he actually depicts is a person joining a community and slowly being moved by it, with the arguments arriving alongside rather than in front. That is how the pear theft worked too. It is how the Wreckers worked. Three times in two books he has described belonging as the operative force, and three times he has analysed the episode as though a proposition were being evaluated. The uncomfortable version of this: if belonging is what moves people, then the argument in Chapter Five about motives may be the wrong shape for his own life as well as for the theft.

The general form: describing a social process accurately and then explaining it as an intellectual one.

That is not a claim that Augustine's reasons were fake. He plainly thought hard, and Part Three will show his doubts building on properly evidential grounds. It is a claim about which part of the story his own framework lets him see.

REMEMBER THIS

Fired up to find wisdom, he opened the Bible and found it **badly written**. The complaint was about prose, not doctrine.

Two real reasons: the **Old Latin translations** were literal and clumsy, and his **training** had given him a filter that screened out plain writing.

The **Manichees** taught two eternal principles, Light and Darkness. Souls are fragments of Light trapped in matter. Augustine was a **Hearer**, the lower rank, for about nine years.

It was a **good answer to the problem of evil**: if evil is a separate eternal substance, God is not responsible for it and there is nothing to explain. And it was flattering, because his own wrongdoing was not really his.

Monica refused to eat with him, then dreamed they were standing on the same rule. A bishop told her **the son of those tears could not be lost**. It took nine years.

He describes belonging as the operative force three times in two books, and analyses each episode as though a proposition were being weighed.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Two lists, as always. And a note on what the silences in Book Two are actually made of, because they are the most informative thing in it.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

Each item is followed by *why* it is unknown, which is usually the more useful half.

Whether the pear theft happened. One paragraph, one witness, twenty-five years later, in a book with a purpose, with no corroboration possible. *Why unknown:* a petty nocturnal theft by teenagers generates no record anywhere, then or now. The absence of evidence here is exactly what we should expect whether or not it occurred.

What Augustine's sexual life actually consisted of before he took a partner. Book Two is heated and almost entirely non-specific. *Why unknown:* he chose not to say, and there was never any other source. The vagueness is authorial policy, not lost information.

When he began the relationship with the woman he never names. Book Two hints at the possibility that it started as early as this year at home; Book Four mentions her without a date. *Why unknown:* he does not tell us, and the question of whether it began at sixteen or at nineteen changes how one reads the whole of Book Two, which may be why.

Whether Monica really declined to arrange a marriage for career reasons. *Why unknown:* this is a grown son assigning a motive to his mother's decision, nine years after her death. The practice he describes is well attested; her reasoning is not recoverable.

What *Hortensius* actually said. *Why unknown:* the book does not survive. What we have are fragments quoted by later writers for their own purposes, and Augustine is the largest single source. We are partly reconstructing the cause from the effect.

How much of Manichaeism Augustine had access to. He was a Hearer, not one of the Elect, and the movement was very large and varied across its geographical range. *Why unknown:* he does not say what he was and was not shown, and recovered Manichaean texts come mostly from other regions and other centuries.

Whether a group of bored teenagers had a motive in the sense the argument requires.

Why unknown: this is not a historical gap at all. It is an open question in the philosophy of action, and it would be open if we had video of the night.

10.2 — Solid

And what can be built on, with the reason each is secure.

The sequence and the dates. Home at sixteen for about a year, Carthage at about seventeen in 370, *Hortensius* in his nineteenth year, a Manichee Hearer for roughly nine years from about 373. *Why solid:* Augustine's own account, the internal consistency of the chronology, and the fact that his later opponents used the Manichee period against him and would have corrected the span if it had been wrong.

That his father died around this period, baptised shortly before. *Why solid:* Augustine states it plainly and had no motive to invent it, and the practice of deathbed baptism was standard.

The existence and general shape of Manichaeism. Two eternal principles, Light trapped in matter, the division into Elect and Hearers, the dietary and sexual discipline of the Elect. *Why solid:* this is now confirmed by Manichaean texts recovered independently in the twentieth century, in several languages, from regions Augustine never visited. That is independent sources converging, which is the strongest kind of evidence there is.

That *Hortensius* existed and was a protreptic urging the philosophical life. *Why solid:* multiple ancient writers quote it, not only Augustine, and they agree about what kind of book it was.

That the Latin Bible available to Augustine in the 370s was pre-Jerome and various. *Why solid:* Old Latin texts survive, can be read, and are demonstrably literal and stylistically rough by classical standards. Anyone can check the claim by looking.

That Carthage had violent student gangs. *Why solid:* Augustine names them, and disorder among students is attested elsewhere in the period, including in imperial legislation attempting to control student behaviour.

10.3 — What the silences are made of

One closing observation, because it applies to everything above.

There are three different kinds of silence in Books Two and Three, and treating them as one thing is the commonest mistake made about this material.

The first is absence of record. Nobody wrote down what a sixteen-year-old did in Thagaste in 370. Nothing was suppressed. There was never anything to suppress.

The second is authorial selection. Augustine had material and chose not to use it. The pear theft standing in for everything else is the clearest case. This is not deception, since he never claims completeness, but it is a decision, and decisions are evidence about the decider.

The third is refusal. The woman he lived with for thirteen years has no name in this book. That is not a gap and not a selection. It is a man who knew a name declining to write it, in a work whose entire premise is telling the truth about himself in public.

The third kind is the one worth sitting with. We will come to it properly in Part Four, where she is sent away, and I will not pretend to know what it means. But it should be read as an act rather than as missing data.

REMEMBER THIS

We do not know whether the pear theft happened, what his sexual life consisted of, when the long relationship began, or what *Hortensius* actually said. Most of that is unknown because **nobody was recording**, or because he **chose not to say**.

We do know the sequence and dates, the shape of Manichaeism, the kind of book *Hortensius* was, and the state of the Latin Bible he read. The Manichaean material is now confirmed by **texts recovered independently** from other regions and other centuries.

Three different silences run through these books: **absence of record**, **authorial selection**, and **refusal**. Treating them as one thing is the commonest error made about this material.

The unnamed woman is the third kind. A man who knew a name declined to write it, in a book whose premise is telling the truth in public.

Timeline

Dates in this period rest almost entirely on Augustine's own account and on inference from it. Where a date is disputed or uncertain, it says so.

Date	Event	Where it appears
369–370	Home in Thagaste for about a year, education stalled for want of money. The scene at the baths. Monica's warning.	Book II
c. 370	The theft of the pears, with a group of companions, at night.	Book II
370	Goes to Carthage to study rhetoric. About seventeen.	Book III
c. 370–371	Falls in with the student gang called the Wreckers. Attends the theatre heavily.	Book III
c. 370–372	Death of his father Patricius, baptised shortly before. The exact year is not certain.	Books II–III
c. 371–372	Begins the relationship with the woman he never names. The start date is disputed and may be earlier.	Book IV
372/373	Birth of his son, Adeodatus.	Book IX
373	In his nineteenth year, reads Cicero's <i>Hortensius</i> and is turned towards the pursuit of wisdom.	Book III
373	Opens the Christian scriptures and finds the style beneath him. Joins the Manichees as a Hearer.	Book III
c. 373–374	Monica refuses to share her house with him, then has the dream of the wooden rule.	Book III
c. 374 or later	The unnamed bishop, a former Manichee, tells Monica that the son of those tears cannot be lost. The year is not fixed.	Book III
—	Part Three starts here: Books IV and V, teaching, astrology, the death of a friend, and the flight to Rome.	—

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Terms carried over from Part One are repeated here so this part stands alone.

Term	What it means
Adulescentia	The Roman life-stage from about fifteen to the late twenties. Legal adulthood without full social standing.
Catharsis	Aristotle's term for the purging of pity and fear by watching tragedy. The standard defence of the theatre, which Augustine attacks without naming it.
Catiline	A Roman aristocrat who conspired to seize power in 63 BC, and the standard Roman example of cruelty for its own sake.
Confessio	The Latin word behind the title: confessing sin, confessing faith and confessing praise, all at once.
Dualism	The belief that reality has two ultimate sources rather than one. In Manichaeism, Light and Darkness, neither created by the other.
Elect	The upper rank of the Manichaean community, living under a severe discipline: no meat, no wine, no sex, no farming.
Eversores	The Wreckers. A student gang at Carthage who broke up lectures and humiliated newcomers. Augustine kept their company.
Hearers	The lower Manichaean rank, also called auditors. They lived ordinary lives and supported the Elect. Augustine was one for about nine years.
<i>Hortensius</i>	A lost work by Cicero urging the pursuit of wisdom. Reading it at about eighteen redirected Augustine's life.
Manichaeism	The religion founded by Mani in third-century Mesopotamia, teaching two eternal principles and the liberation of Light trapped in matter.
Mani	The Persian founder of Manichaeism, third century, who presented himself as the last in a line of messengers including Zoroaster, the Buddha and Jesus.
Old Latin Bible	The various Latin translations of scripture circulating before Jerome's Vulgate. Often extremely literal, and rough by classical standards.

Term	What it means
Philosophy (ancient sense)	Not an academic subject but a way of living: a school you joined, with practices, companions and a promise of happiness.
Protreptic	An ancient genre designed to turn the reader towards a way of life rather than to inform them. <i>Hortensius</i> was one.
Rhetoric	The technical art of persuasive public speaking, and the qualification for a public career in the Roman world.
Sallust	The Roman historian whose account of the Catiline conspiracy was a school text, and Augustine's source for the comparison.
Thagaste	Augustine's home town in Numidia, now Souk Ahras in eastern Algeria.
Vulgate	Jerome's Latin translation of the Bible, begun around 382, after the events of this part. Not available to the young Augustine.

About the Author

This series is read and explained by **Lovepreet Singh**, and published as part of **The Living Archive** at misterlove.in.

The Living Archive takes difficult material and rebuilds it so that anyone can follow it, without dropping the hard parts along the way. Its first series was a fourteen-part history of Punjab running to around nine hundred and fifty pages. This is its second.

I read the book, I did the reading around it, and I wrote down what I found. I am not a specialist in late antiquity and I am not going to pretend to be one. Where a question is genuinely contested among people who are, I have said so and given each side its strongest case rather than choosing for you. Where I could not find out, I have written that I could not find out.

The method used here was worked out on the Punjab series and is written up as a portable specification, so that any part of this work can be checked, continued or rebuilt by somebody else. That is the point of an archive that calls itself living.

[Editorial note, to be replaced before publishing: the method requires a one-line statement of the author's own position with regard to religious material, placed where readers will see it. This is the only field in the document still unfilled.]

The Living Archive

The Living Archive is a method for writing hard things simply without making them shallow. It was developed by Lovepreet Singh and tested on a fourteen-part history of Punjab. It runs on three rules.

One. Simplification is not compression. The simple version is usually longer than the difficult one. Words are being spent to buy comprehension.

Two. Two dials, turned in opposite directions. Language as simple as it can be made. Content as deep as the subject actually goes. Turning both down produces something readable and useless.

Three. Every side gets its strongest case, and where nothing settles a question, that gets said. A verdict that honestly reports a deadlock is worth more than a tidy answer that is not true.

A word on sources

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record rather than new primary research, and it is written for readers who want to understand a book, not for specialists who want to check my workings.

What the archive is good at here: the structure of Manichaeism is now much better attested than it was a century ago, because substantial Manichaean texts have been recovered and edited in several languages. Roman education, the Old Latin Bible and the general shape of life in fourth-century Carthage are all well documented from sources independent of Augustine.

What it is bad at here: Books Two and Three describe a private life that left no record, and every personal claim in them rests on a single witness writing twenty-five years later with a religious purpose. Where a claim in this document rests only on Augustine's account of himself, I have tried to say so in the text rather than let it pass as established.

On translations: all renderings of Augustine in this document are my own plain-English paraphrases, made deliberately loose so that they explain rather than reproduce. They are not quotations from any published translation and should not be cited as such. Where the exact wording matters, go to a proper edition.

Corrections are welcome and will be acted on. Later editions will record what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Three covers Books IV and V: roughly nine years, from about twenty to twenty-nine. He teaches, he reads the stars, he loses somebody, and he leaves Africa. These are the questions it takes on.

- What was Augustine actually doing for nine years as a Manichee, and what did being a Hearer involve day to day?
- Why did a man who had just decided to pursue wisdom spend years taking astrology seriously, and what finally broke it?
- A close friend dies, and Augustine says the grief nearly destroyed him. Why does he treat that grief as a mistake rather than as love?
- What is wrong, on his account, with loving a person who can die — and is that conclusion as cold as it sounds?
- He had been promised for years that a great Manichee teacher named Faustus would answer his questions. What happened when Faustus finally arrived?
- Why did he sail for Rome, and why did he do it by lying to his mother and leaving her on the shore?
- What made him give up on the Manichees, and what did he believe in the gap between leaving them and finding anything else?

And the question underneath all of them: what does it do to a person to discover that the answer they have been waiting nine years for is a disappointment, and that they have nothing to put in its place?

End of Part 2 of 9

The Living Archive • The Confessions, Explained

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART 3 OF 9

The Confessions, Explained

Part Three — The Dead Friend and the Disappointing Bishop

*Books Four and Five: nine years teaching, reading the stars,
a bereavement that broke him, the man he had waited a decade
to meet, and the night he lied to his mother and sailed.*

READ AND EXPLAINED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

Parts One and Two covered Books One to Three of Augustine's *Confessions*. Here is everything you need. This part stands on its own.

The man. Born 354 in Thagaste, a small town in Roman North Africa, in what is now Algeria. Clever, ambitious, and educated at his family's considerable expense towards a career as a professional public speaker. He wrote this book in his early forties, around 397 to 400, roughly twenty years after the events in this part.

The book. The Latin *confessio* means three things at once: confessing sin, confessing faith, and confessing praise. This is not a list of misdeeds. It is a prayer, addressed to God from first word to last, and you are overhearing it. Thirteen books: nine of life story, one on memory, three on the opening of Genesis.

Books One to Three. Book One argued that something in human wanting is disordered before any choice is made, using a jealous infant as the evidence, and ended with the formula that runs through everything: the gifts were good, the aim was wrong; evil is not a thing but a direction. Book Two took a trivial theft of some pears and used it to ask whether a person can want the wrong simply because it is wrong. Book Three took him to Carthage at seventeen, where a lost book by Cicero turned him towards the pursuit of wisdom, the Bible struck him as badly written, and he joined the Manichees.

The Manichees. A religion teaching two eternal opposed principles, Light and Darkness. Souls are fragments of Light trapped in matter. It answered the problem of evil cleanly, since God did not make evil and is not responsible for it, and it was flattering, since your own wrongdoing was not really yours. Augustine joined as a **Hearer**, the lower of its two ranks, at about nineteen.

Book Four picks him up there and runs the nine years out.

A Reminder About the Boxes

Six kinds of box run through this series. **Word Box** explains a hard term the moment it first appears. **In Real Terms** turns a number or a distance into something you can picture. **How We Actually Know This** names the physical evidence and says what it cannot show. **The Argument** is for places where experts genuinely disagree, and gives each side its strongest case rather than a version built to be knocked down. **The Hidden Assumption** digs out the premise everybody in an argument is quietly taking for granted. **Remember This** closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

One note specific to this part. The centre of Book Four is the death of a young man and the grief of the friend who loved him. Augustine goes on to use that grief as material for an argument, and the argument is worth following. But he was twenty and somebody he loved had died, and this part will let that stand as what it was before anything is built on top of it.

Three Things to Watch For

Books Four and Five run over about eleven years and cover a great deal of ground. Three threads run underneath all of it, and naming them now will make the rest easier to follow.

One. He keeps being told the truth by competent people and cannot hear it. His mother warned him in Book Two. A proconsul who had studied astrology himself warns him here. A friend argues the same case. Every time, the argument is good, the source is qualified, and nothing happens. What Augustine is interested in is not the arguments. It is the not hearing.

Two. The people closest to him have no names. The friend whose death is the centre of Book Four is unnamed. So is the woman he lived with for over a decade. Meanwhile he names a doctor he met a handful of times and an orator he never met at all. That is a pattern rather than an accident, and Chapter Ten comes back to it.

Three. Having a reason and acting on it are separated by years. The evidence that broke his religion arrives in Book Five, and he stays in it, keeps the friendships and takes the professional favours anyway. What finally moves him is a change of continent and a change of company. Watch the gap between the reason and the movement. It is the most honest thing in these two books, and Augustine never quite comments on it.

Contents

Chapter One — Nine Years as a Hearer

What he was actually doing · selling words for a living · the woman he never names · the contest and the man who offered to fix it

Chapter Two — Reading the Stars

What astrology was · why it was not a stupid thing to believe · why it appealed to him in particular · the old doctor who tried to talk him out of it

Chapter Three — The Friend Who Died

Who he was · the baptism he did not know he was having · the joke and the rebuke · the relapse

Chapter Four — The Grief

What it was like · "I had become a great question to myself" · why he ran · and why weeping was the only thing that helped

Chapter Five — Why He Calls the Grief a Fault

The verdict · the argument behind it · what he is not saying · and the problem with judging your own past

Chapter Six — Loving Things That Can Be Lost

The full argument · what "love them in God" means · and the objection that this is a recommendation not to love at all

Chapter Seven — The Book He Wrote and the Book He Understood

A lost first book · loving a man he had never met · Aristotle at twenty · and why being clever was no help

Chapter Eight — Faustus

Nine years of waiting · the crack that had already opened · the man who arrived · and the honesty that made it worse

Chapter Nine — The Shore, Rome, and Milan

The lie at the harbour · nearly dying among strangers · believing nothing on purpose · and the pagan who sent him to Ambrose

Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Genuinely unknown · solid · and what it means that the two people who mattered most in this part have no names

Reference

Timeline · glossary · about the author · a word on sources · what comes next

CHAPTER ONE

Nine Years as a Hearer

Book Four opens by summing up nine years in a single sentence, and the sentence is doing a great deal of work. This chapter is about what those years actually contained.

1.1 — The sentence that covers a decade

Augustine opens Book Four by saying that for nine years, from his nineteenth year to his twenty-eighth, he was led astray and led others astray, deceived and deceiving. Publicly through what people call the liberal arts. Privately under the name of religion. Proud in the one, superstitious in the other, and empty in both.

That is a summary written by a man who has already decided what the period meant. Everything in it is judged before it is described, which is worth noticing early, because Book Four is the part of *Confessions* where the gap between what happened and how it is presented is widest.

Underneath the verdict, the nine years contain: a career, a household, a child, a serious intellectual life, a bereavement, and a religion he was slowly ceasing to believe. Most people would call that a substantial decade.

IN REAL TERMS

The nine years run from about 373 to 382, from age nineteen to twenty-eight.

Think of somebody today between nineteen and twenty-eight: leaving university, a first job, a partner, a child, a move, a death, and a slow loss of faith in something they had signed up to at nineteen.

Augustine covers all of it in two books and dismisses the whole span in one sentence. Whatever else the *Confessions* is, it is not a balanced account of how a life is spent.

1.2 — Selling words for a living

He taught. First back in his home town of Thagaste, then in Carthage, and later in Rome and Milan. His subject was rhetoric, which Part One explained was the qualification for a public career: the technical art of persuasive speech.

His own description of the job is savage. He says he sold victorious talkativeness. He taught young men the skill of winning, and he says he taught them to win in cases where the point was to get somebody condemned.

WORD BOX

The liberal arts: the standard curriculum of an educated Roman: grammar, rhetoric, dialectic, and the mathematical subjects. Called *liberal* because they were the studies suitable for a free man rather than a labourer, not because they were broad-minded.

Why it matters: Augustine puts the phrase in quotation marks, in effect, when he says "what men call the liberal arts". He is questioning whether an education whose product is a man skilled at winning arguments deserves the word free.

He is careful, though, in a way that is easy to miss. He says he had honest pupils, and that he taught them honestly, and that he did not teach them to destroy innocent men, though he did sometimes teach them to defend guilty ones. He is describing a profession he thinks is corrupting, not a crime he committed.

And he stayed in it for the whole nine years and for several more after that. The job funded everything. When he leaves it in Book Nine, that is the point at which the conversion becomes expensive.

1.3 — The woman he never names

During this period Augustine was living with a woman. Book Four introduces her in a single passage and she is not named there or anywhere else in anything he wrote.

What he does tell us is precise, and worth having exactly. They were together for a long time. He was faithful to her. He says so plainly, and he says he found out through her what the difference is between a union entered for the sake of children and one driven by appetite. She bore him a son. They were not married.

WORD BOX

Concubinatus: a recognised arrangement in Roman society, not a scandal and not prostitution. A stable, usually monogamous household between a man and a woman who could not or did not marry, most often because of a difference in social rank. It carried no legal standing for the woman and the children were not legitimate heirs, but it was ordinary and openly acknowledged.

Why it matters: Augustine was not living a secret or disreputable life by the standards of his neighbours. He was living the standard arrangement for an ambitious young man of modest rank who could not yet afford a marriage that would help his career. The reason it could end so abruptly, as it does in Book Six, is that it never had any legal weight to begin with.

The absence of her name is the single most discussed silence in the book, and Part Two flagged it as a refusal rather than a gap: a man who knew a name declining to write it, in a

work whose premise is telling the truth about himself in public. I said then that we would come to it properly in Part Four, where she is sent away, and that still stands. But note here that the silence begins in Book Four, at the point where she enters, and that Augustine names his own son, his friends, his teachers and a passing doctor without difficulty.

Their son was called Adeodatus, born around 372, when Augustine was about eighteen. The name means "given by God". Augustine says the boy was clever beyond many serious grown men, and he will describe his death in Book Nine.

1.4 — The contest, and the man who offered to fix it

One episode from these years is short and tells you a great deal about how Augustine's mind worked, so it is worth pulling out.

He entered poetry contests. These were public competitions, judged, with a prize, and winning them built a reputation useful to a teacher. Before one of them, a man who dealt in sacrifices came to him and offered to secure the win.

WORD BOX

Haruspex: a diviner who read the future from the entrails of sacrificed animals. The practice was very old, Etruscan in origin, and by Augustine's day it was formally illegal in several respects and still widely used in private.

Why it matters: this was a real, professional, paid service, not a back-alley oddity. A man could be commissioned to obtain a specific result by sacrifice, the way one might now retain a lawyer or a fixer.

Augustine refused. His stated reason is the interesting part. He says he would not have a fly killed to win, because he detested the idea of taking life to obtain a prize.

And then he immediately sets that refusal against what he was doing at the same time. He would not sacrifice an animal to demons, and he was quite willing to consult astrologers, whose whole business he later concluded was no better. He notes the inconsistency himself and does not explain it away.

That is the pattern of the whole of Book Four, and it is the reason this part exists: a man with real moral instincts, real intelligence and real scruples, going wrong in ways his scruples did not cover.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine sums up **nine years, from nineteen to twenty-eight**, in a single condemning sentence. Underneath it sit a career, a household, a child, a bereavement and a slow loss of faith. He taught **rhetoric** for a living and calls it selling victorious talkativeness. He stayed in the job for over a decade, and it funded everything.

He lived with a woman for years, was **faithful to her**, had a son with her, and **never writes her name**. Their arrangement, **concubinatus**, was ordinary for a man of his rank and carried no legal weight at all.

Offered a rigged win at a poetry contest by a professional diviner, he **refused**, because he would not have an animal killed for a prize — while consulting astrologers, which he later judged no better.

This is not a bad man behaving badly. It is a man with real scruples, going wrong in ways his scruples did not cover.

CHAPTER TWO

Reading the Stars

Augustine took astrology seriously for years, at exactly the period when he was reading philosophy and thought of himself as a rigorous man. That combination is worth understanding rather than laughing at.

2.1 — What astrology actually was

The first thing to get straight is that this was not a fringe amusement. Astrology in the fourth century was a technical discipline with a mathematical apparatus, practised by trained professionals, taken seriously by educated people, and consulted by emperors. It was, in the ordinary sense, a science: it made predictions from calculations and it had a theory behind it.

WORD BOX

Mathematicus: the ordinary Latin word for an astrologer. It is the same word as our "mathematician", and the overlap is not an accident. Casting a horoscope required real calculation: the positions of the planets at a given moment, worked out from tables, for a specified place.

Casting a nativity: computing the state of the heavens at the instant of a person's birth, and reading their character and future from it.

Why it matters: when Augustine says he consulted the *mathematici*, he is describing visits to skilled technical practitioners, not to a fairground tent.

The theory behind it was not silly either. If the heavens are orderly and everything below is affected by what is above, then a sufficiently precise account of the sky at a given moment might tell you something about what is beginning at that moment. That is a bad theory, but it is a theory, and it was continuous with the astronomy that was correctly predicting eclipses.

2.2 — Why it was not stupid to believe

It is easy to treat this as a clever man's embarrassing lapse. That reading costs you the interesting part.

Astrology in Augustine's world had three things going for it that are hard to see now.

It had the prestige of mathematics. The calculations were genuinely difficult and genuinely correct as calculations. The sky really does behave predictably, and the people who could predict it were visibly not frauds about that part.

It sometimes worked. Predictions came true often enough to sustain belief. Augustine is going to be told exactly why, and the explanation is good.

It had no serious competitor. There was no established alternative account of why one person's life goes one way and another's goes differently. Astrology was answering a question nobody else was answering.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A FALSE BELIEF NEEDS A FOOLISH BELIEVER

When we find an intelligent person from the past holding a belief we know to be false, we reach for one of two explanations. Either they were not as clever as advertised, or they had a blind spot, some local failure of rigour in an otherwise sound mind.

Both explanations share a premise: that a rational person confronted with a false belief should be able to see through it, and that failing to do so needs accounting for.

But rationality is not a property of a person on their own. It is mostly a property of what is available to them: what other explanations exist, what counts as evidence, who else has tested the claim, what instruments there are. Augustine had a theory that made predictions, that used real mathematics, that sometimes came true, and that had no rival. Believing it was not a failure of intelligence. It was the correct output of a mind working on the materials in the room.

The uncomfortable half of this: nothing about the reasoning is different when it is our turn. What we take to be obviously true is also the correct output of a mind working on the materials in the room.

The general form: treating a conclusion as evidence about the person rather than about their situation.

That box is not an excuse for Augustine and he does not offer one. He calls the whole business superstition and blames himself for it. It is a caution about a habit we bring to old books, which is to read every error as a character flaw.

2.3 — Why it appealed to him in particular

There is one further reason, and it is the one Augustine himself identifies. It is not general. It is about him.

If your future is written in the stars, then your faults are not your fault. The failure belongs to the sky, or to fate, or to whatever arranged the planets. Augustine says exactly this: the astrologers told him that the cause of his sin was in the heavens, and that a man was not to blame.

Now set that beside what he had already signed up to. The Manichees told him that his wrongdoing was not really his either, because a foreign substance inside him was doing it. Two different systems, and he had adopted both, and both delivered the same product.

Augustine sees this and says so. He says he loved to be excused, and to accuse anything except himself. That is the connecting thread of the whole nine years, and it is why Book Four puts astrology and Manichaeism in the same breath.

It is also why the pear theft of Book Two matters so much to him in retrospect. That was the one episode he could not offload onto anybody or anything. Hold that in mind, because it becomes the spine of Book Seven.

2.4 — The old doctor who tried to talk him out of it

Two people argued with him about astrology during these years, and neither of them succeeded.

The first was a man named Vindicianus. He was a physician, an eminent one, who had served at the imperial court, and he was proconsul of Africa. He was the man who put the garland on Augustine's head when he won a poetry contest. Augustine sought him out afterwards for his conversation.

Vindicianus told him to drop the astrology. And crucially, he had standing to say it, because he had studied it himself as a young man and had seriously considered making his living from it.

His argument was this. The predictions that come true come true by chance. There is so much material in the world that if you scatter statements across it, some will land. He compared it to a practice everybody knew: opening a book of poetry at random and reading the first line your eye falls on as an answer to your question. Sometimes the line fits astonishingly well. Nobody thinks the poet knew.

IN REAL TERMS

Vindicianus is describing the effect that keeps horoscopes in newspapers now.

Read twelve predictions with the star signs covered up and you will find several that fit your week.

The prediction is not doing the work. Your life is large and the statement is small and vague, so a match is nearly guaranteed.

The argument is sixteen hundred years old, it is correct, and Augustine did not accept it.

The second was a young friend named Nebridius, who will matter later in the book. He was, Augustine says, a good and careful young man, and he laughed at the whole business of prediction and pressed the same case.

Augustine held out against both. He wanted, he says, some authority to point to, and he kept his books.

What finally broke it for him came later and elsewhere, in Book Seven, and it took a specific piece of evidence rather than an argument. I am flagging that now as a debt: Part Four will pay it, at the point in the text where it belongs. What matters for Book Four is that he had already been given a good argument by a qualified man and had not taken it.

That is worth one more sentence, because it is a pattern. In Book Two his mother warned him and he could not hear it. Here a proconsul with direct experience of the subject warns him and he does not take it. Augustine keeps showing you a man being told the truth by somebody competent and declining it, and his interest is not in the truth but in the declining.

REMEMBER THIS

Astrology in the fourth century was a **technical discipline** with real mathematics behind it, practised professionally and consulted by emperors. The Latin for astrologer, *mathematicus*, is our word "mathematician".

It had three real advantages: the **prestige of calculation**, predictions that **sometimes came true**, and **no serious rival** answering the same question.

Its specific appeal to Augustine was that it made his faults **somebody else's**. So did Manichaeism. He had adopted two systems that delivered the same product, and he says so.

Vindicianus, a proconsul and physician who had studied astrology himself, told him the hits were **chance**, like opening a poetry book at random and finding a fitting line. His friend **Nebridius** argued the same. He kept his books.

Reading a past thinker's false belief as a character flaw costs you the interesting part. He was reasoning correctly on the materials in the room.

CHAPTER THREE

The Friend Who Died

A young man Augustine had known since childhood fell ill and died, at about twenty, after an illness of a few days. This chapter is what happened. The arguments come afterwards.

3.1 — Who he was

They had grown up together in Thagaste. They had been at school together as boys, and had played together. When Augustine came back to teach in his home town, in his early twenties, the friendship resumed and deepened quickly. He says it was sweet to him beyond every sweetness in his life at that time.

One detail Augustine does not soften. The friend had been brought up a Christian, and Augustine had talked him out of it. He drew him into Manichaeism, which is what he had been doing with a number of people during those years. He states this plainly and returns to it.

And the friend has no name. Like the woman in the last chapter, he is not named here or anywhere else. Augustine names Vindicianus, a doctor he met once. He names Nebridius. He does not name the person he says he loved most in the world at that point in his life.

3.2 — The illness, and a baptism he did not know he was having

The friendship had lasted about a year when the young man came down with a fever.

He got worse. He lost consciousness. His household, who were Christians, believed he was dying, and while he lay unaware of what was happening they had him baptised.

This needs a note, because it looks strange and it was not.

WORD BOX

Emergency baptism: because baptism was believed to wash away everything before it, and because so many people deferred it until late in life, baptising the dying was common and urgent. If a person was unconscious and about to die, it was performed anyway rather than lost.

Why it matters: Part One explained why Monica had not had Augustine baptised as a boy, and why he was nearly baptised during a childhood illness. This is the same practice from the other side. It was not a violation of the sick man's wishes as his family understood things. It was a rescue.

Then he recovered. He came round, and he was well enough to talk.

3.3 — The joke, and the rebuke

As soon as he could, Augustine made a joke about it.

This is the hinge of the whole story and it is easy to read past. Augustine expected his friend to laugh with him at the baptism, because the baptism had happened to a body that was not conscious and to a man who, Augustine assumed, shared his own opinions. It was a joke between two Manichees about something absurd that pious relatives had done to one of them while he was out.

The friend did not laugh. Augustine says he recoiled from him as if from an enemy, and told him, with a sudden and startling authority, that if Augustine wanted to remain his friend he must stop saying such things.

Augustine was astonished. He decided to say nothing more for the moment and to wait until his friend was properly recovered, when he would be able to do what he liked with him again. That is his own phrasing, and it is not flattering to himself.

What had happened to the friend in the meantime is not recoverable and Augustine does not speculate. A man who had been raised a Christian, had been argued out of it, had come close to death, and had woken up baptised, decided that the baptism was his. That is all we are told.

3.4 — The relapse

A few days later the fever came back. He died. Augustine was not there.

That is the entire account. It takes Augustine about a page. Everything else in Book Four is the aftermath.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

One source. Augustine, writing roughly twenty-two years later, about a private bereavement in a small provincial town.

There is no corroboration and there could not be. The young man is unnamed, no other writer mentions him, and nothing survives from Thagaste in the 370s that would record the death of a person of no public standing.

What supports it indirectly: the medical picture is entirely ordinary. A fever that worsens, a period of unconsciousness, an apparent recovery, and a fatal relapse within days is a recognisable course for several infections that were common and untreatable. Nothing in the account requires anything unusual to have happened.

What cannot be established: the conversation. The joke, the rebuke and Augustine's reaction to it are reported speech from two decades on, and the exchange carries a great deal of weight in the book's argument. It is exactly the kind of scene a writer would sharpen, and there is no way to check.

I want to be careful about how that box is used. Saying a scene cannot be verified is not saying it was invented. Most of what anybody knows about their own life is in the same condition. It is a note about what this text can and cannot be made to bear, not an accusation.

REMEMBER THIS

A young man Augustine had known **since childhood**, and had talked out of Christianity into Manichaeism, fell ill about a year into their renewed friendship.

While unconscious and thought to be dying he was **baptised** by his family. This was normal practice, not an outrage.

He recovered. Augustine **joked about the baptism**, expecting to be laughed along with, and was told sharply to stop if he wanted to remain a friend.

Augustine decided to **wait until he was stronger** and take it up again. A few days later the fever returned and the young man died.

He has no name. Augustine names a doctor he met once and does not name the person he says he loved most in the world.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Grief

What follows is one of the most exact descriptions of bereavement in any language, written by somebody who had been through it and could still find the words for it twenty years on.

4.1 — What it was like

Augustine says his heart went dark with grief, and that everything he looked at was death. His home town became a torture to him. His father's house became a strange unhappiness. Everything he had shared with his friend had turned, without the friend, into an enormous torment.

His eyes looked for the friend everywhere and did not produce him. He says he hated every place, because no place had him in it, and none of them could now say *he is coming*, as they had when the friend was alive and away.

That last observation is precise in a way most writing about grief is not. The pain is not only that the person is absent. It is that every location has stopped being a place where they might arrive.

He describes becoming a problem to himself. He would ask his own soul why it was cast down and troubling him, and it had no answer. If he told it to hope in God, it refused, and rightly, he says, because the man he had lost was better and more real to it than the phantom he was being told to hope in.

Then the sentence that has been carried out of this passage more than any other. He says he had become a great question to himself.

4.2 — "I had become a great question to myself"

Four words in the Latin. It is worth unpacking, because it is doing more than expressing distress.

Augustine is not saying he was confused about what to do. He is saying that he himself had become the thing he could not understand. He was producing reactions he could not account for, wanting things he could not explain, and watching himself do it from somewhere that did not have access to why.

And notice where it sits. This is the man who in Book Two examined a fruit theft for pages trying to locate a motive, and could not. Here he examines his own grief and cannot locate it either. The same problem in a much sharper form: *I do not know what is happening inside me.* That phrase is one of the load-bearing beams of the whole work. Book Ten exists because of it. The long examination of memory that stops the story dead is Augustine going back to this question with better tools, and Part Seven of this series is where we will do it.

IN REAL TERMS

The specific thing he is describing is the loss of the ordinary automatic sense that you know your own mind.

Most of the time you do not have to work out what you want. You simply want it, and the wanting comes with an explanation attached. Grief removes the explanations and leaves the wanting.

What Augustine noticed, and what almost nobody notices at the time, is that this is not a temporary fault in an otherwise transparent machine. It is a look at how much of the machine was always dark.

4.3 — The strangest thing he says

There is a sentence in here that readers usually pass over and that repays stopping on.

Augustine says he was amazed that other people were alive, since the man he had loved as though he would never die was dead. And then he says he was more amazed still that he himself was alive, when the friend was gone. He borrows a line from a poet and says that his friend had been half of his soul, and wonders how the remaining half could carry on.

Then he goes further, and this is the part that is genuinely his own. He says that perhaps he was afraid to die because that would mean the whole of the friend would be dead. He was keeping himself alive as a place where the other man was still partly stored.

And he says he loathed life and feared death at the same time, and could not tell which he wanted less.

4.4 — Why weeping helped, and nothing else did

One more observation, and it is the one that makes this passage feel modern.

Augustine says that weeping was the only thing that was sweet to him, and that it had taken his friend's place in the affections of his mind.

That is a startling formulation. Not that crying provided relief from grief, but that crying became the thing he loved, and occupied the position the person used to occupy.

He then asks a question about it that he cannot answer, and he flags his own failure to answer it. Why is weeping sweet to people in misery? He notes that God is far away from us and we are wretched, and says the question is a mystery, and moves on. It is one of several places in this book where he raises something and admits he does not know.

Connect it back to Part Two if you want to see how his mind works. In Book Three he attacked the theatre for making people want to be made unhappy, and asked what was being enjoyed. Here he finds the same structure inside his own bereavement, without a play in sight, and this time he is not scornful about it. He is baffled.

4.5 — He ran

In the end he left. He went from Thagaste back to Carthage, and he says plainly why: because his eyes looked for the friend less in a place where they were not used to seeing him.

There is a piece of evidence worth knowing here, and it is the sort of thing that only turns up when you read a writer's whole output rather than one famous book. In a work written a decade before *Confessions*, Augustine gives the same move a different explanation, connected with ambition rather than with grief. Both may be true. People rarely leave a place for one reason.

And time did what time does, which he also records without dressing it up. New friends, new things to enjoy, and gradually the grief gave way. He notes that other griefs took its place, and that he did not become well. He simply stopped being in that particular pain.

REMEMBER THIS

Grief made every place unbearable, because no place could any longer say "**he is coming**".

He says he had become a **great question to himself**: not confused about what to do, but unable to understand the thing producing his own reactions. That sentence is why **Book Ten on memory exists**.

He was astonished that anyone was alive, and more astonished that **he** was, and wondered whether he feared dying because it would finish off the part of his friend he was still storing.

Weeping became the thing he loved, occupying the place the person had occupied. He asks why misery makes weeping sweet, says he does not know, and moves on.

He left Thagaste because his eyes looked for his friend less in a place that was not used to seeing him.

CHAPTER FIVE

Why He Calls the Grief a Fault

Having described the bereavement better than almost anyone before or since, Augustine delivers a verdict on it. The verdict is the reason a lot of readers put the book down.

5.1 — The verdict

Augustine does not present his grief as a natural sorrow he has since made peace with. He presents it as a symptom. He says he had poured out his soul onto sand by loving a man who would die as though he would not die. He calls himself wretched, and says the misery was the natural consequence of the attachment rather than of the loss.

He also says something colder still. He says he held his own misery dearer than his friend. He suspects that the grief itself had become a possession he did not want to give up.

There is no softening in the text. This is not a man saying that he grieved too long or in an unhealthy way. It is a man saying the grief was the correct output of a mistake, and that the mistake was in the loving.

5.2 — The argument behind it

Put in order, the reasoning has four steps, and it is worth having them straight before deciding what you think.

One. Everything in the created world is temporary. It comes into being, changes, and stops. That is not a defect in it; it is what being a created thing is.

Two. To love something is, among other things, to want it to remain. That is built into loving, not added to it.

Three. So loving a temporary thing as though it were permanent is a category error, and the pain when it ends is not bad luck. It is the error arriving.

Four. Therefore the sorrow, however sincere, is evidence that something was wrongly aimed, in exactly the sense Book One established: a good thing pointed at the wrong object.

That is a real argument. Each step is defensible on its own. Whether the conclusion should be accepted is what Chapter Six is about.

5.3 — What he is not saying

Three misreadings of this passage are common and all three are wrong on the text, so it is worth clearing them out before the argument.

He is not saying he should not have loved his friend. He says elsewhere in the same book that friendship is genuinely good and that it was God who made the sweetness in it. The target is a manner of loving, not the existence of the love.

He is not recommending emotional detachment. Augustine is not a Stoic and argues against Stoic composure repeatedly in later works. He thinks grief for the dead is appropriate. He wept at his mother's death in Book Nine and defends the weeping.

He is not saying the pain was punishment. The argument is that the pain is the natural consequence of the mistake, in the way that a hangover is the consequence of drinking rather than a penalty imposed for it.

Getting those three off the table matters, because the strongest objection to Augustine here is not any of them. It is something harder, and it is in the next chapter.

5.4 — The problem with judging your own past

There is a separate difficulty with this passage that has nothing to do with whether the argument is sound, and it is worth naming on its own.

Augustine at twenty did not have this framework. He was not a Christian, he was a Manichee, and the whole apparatus of created goods, misdirected love and the aim of the will belongs to a man who spent the following two decades building it.

So what he is doing in Book Four is applying a later theory to an earlier experience and reporting the result as though it were a discovery about what the experience had been.

That is not necessarily illegitimate. It is what everybody does when they look back. But it means the passage has two things in it that cannot be separated: an unusually accurate description of a state, and a verdict passed on that state from outside it. The description may be reliable and the verdict may still be an import.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE ACCOUNT OF THE GRIEF A RECORD OR A READING?

This is one of the standing disputes about Book Four, and it is a specific case of the largest question about *Confessions* as a whole.

IT IS ESSENTIALLY A RECORD

The description is too exact to be reconstruction. The detail about places no longer being able to say "he is coming", the observation that weeping had taken the friend's place, the double amazement at other people being alive and at himself being alive: these are not the things a theologian invents to illustrate a doctrine. They are the things a person remembers because they happened to them. The theory is laid over an accurate memory, and the two are visibly different in texture.

IT IS ESSENTIALLY A READING

Twenty-two years separate the event from the writing, and in the interval Augustine acquired a complete theory of misdirected love that this episode illustrates perfectly. Perfect illustrations are suspicious. The friend is unnamed, which frees the story from checkable particulars; the timing of the baptism and the joke arrives exactly where the argument needs a turning point; and Augustine elsewhere gives a different reason for the same departure from Thagaste. The grief was real. The shape it has on the page is a later construction.

THE DISTINCTION DOES NOT SURVIVE CONTACT WITH MEMORY

A third position holds that there is no stable difference here to argue about. Nobody stores an experience and later interprets it; the storing is already interpretation, and every subsequent recall rewrites. Augustine has no unmediated 373 to compare his 397 account against, and neither do we, and neither does anyone about anything. Asking which this is assumes an archive that human memory does not contain.

Where things stand: Everyone agrees that the description is unusually good and that the framework is later. The dispute is about how much the framework has shaped what is reported, and it cannot be resolved from the text, because a well-shaped account of a real event and a well-shaped account of a reconstructed one read the same.

What would settle it: Almost nothing. Augustine's earlier works give a few points of comparison, and one of them does complicate the account of why he left Thagaste. That is suggestive rather than decisive.

Why people care so much: It matters because Book Four is one of the main places *Confessions* is used as evidence about ordinary emotional life in the ancient world. If the grief is heavily shaped by a later theory, it is weaker as a historical source and no weaker at all as literature.

For what it is worth, I lean towards the first position on the description and the second on the verdict, and I think the third position is right that the two cannot be cleanly separated. That is a hedge, and I would rather label it as one than pretend to a confidence the material does not support.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine calls the grief a **symptom, not a sorrow**: the natural consequence of having loved a mortal man as though he would not die.

The argument in four steps: **created things are temporary**; **loving wants permanence**; so loving a temporary thing as permanent is an **error**; and the pain is the **error arriving**, not bad luck.

He is **not** saying he should not have loved his friend, **not** recommending detachment, and **not** saying the pain was a punishment. All three misreadings are common and all three are wrong on the text.

He had none of this framework at twenty. He is **applying a later theory to an earlier experience** and reporting the result as a finding.

Whether Book Four is a record or a reading is genuinely disputed, and cannot be settled, because an accurate account and a well-constructed one read exactly the same on the page.

CHAPTER SIX

Loving Things That Can Be Lost

Augustine's prescription is that you should love people in God. A great many readers have concluded that this amounts to telling you not to love people. This chapter puts both cases at full strength.

6.1 — The prescription

Having diagnosed the grief, Augustine gives the remedy, and it is stated positively rather than as a prohibition. Let the soul praise God in the things it loves. Love them in God, in whom they cannot be lost. Wherever the soul turns, it meets sorrow, except in him.

The key phrase is *in him they cannot be lost*. Augustine is not proposing that you care less. He is proposing a change in the relation, not in the intensity.

His diagnosis of what went wrong is worth stating carefully, because it is not what people expect. His complaint is not that he loved his friend too much. It is that he loved him as though the friend were the source of the goodness rather than a place where it was appearing. And a thing that is not the source cannot bear the weight of being treated as one.

IN REAL TERMS

The picture he is working with is closer to a window than to a possession.

You can love the light in a room. If you conclude that the window is producing the light, you have made a mistake about what a window is, and you will be genuinely bereft when it is bricked up, in a way that does not fit what actually happened.

Augustine's claim is that a person is a window. The claim is not that windows do not matter. It is that a window is the wrong thing to expect sunrise from.

6.2 — What "in God" is supposed to do

Three things, on his account.

It makes the love survive the loss. If what you loved in the person is something that has its home elsewhere, then the death of the person does not annihilate the thing you loved. This is a real claim and it stands or falls with the metaphysics.

It stops the love becoming a demand. Loving somebody as your source of goodness puts on them a load no person can carry. Augustine thinks this damages the beloved as well as the lover, though he does not develop the point here.

It makes the loss intelligible. On his account grief without this frame is not merely painful but incomprehensible, which is exactly what he reported: *I had become a great question to myself.*

6.3 — The objection

Now the case against, and it deserves the strongest possible version rather than the caricature.

The objection is not that Augustine is cold. It is that his remedy, applied honestly, changes love into something else and then keeps the word.

Part of what it is to love a particular person is to care about them in their particularity: this one, not an instance of a kind, and not a location where a general good is showing up. If what you actually love is the good that is appearing in them, then the person has become a means, and a replaceable one. The friend is loved, on this reading, as a delivery mechanism.

And the objection has a second half that is harder. If the arrangement succeeds, and the loss no longer devastates you, that is not obviously a cure. It may be a description of having loved less. Grief is not a malfunction of attachment; it is attachment with the object removed. A technique for not being destroyed by a death may just be a technique for not having been that attached.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES "LOVE THEM IN GOD" CANCEL LOVING THEM?

This is one of the oldest objections to Augustine and it is still live. It bears directly on how much of his account of the human being anyone should accept.

YES: IT INSTRUMENTALISES PEOPLE

The remedy asks you to love in the person something that is not the person. Whatever that is, it is not what we mean by loving somebody, which is irreducibly about them and could not be transferred to a qualified replacement. The passage is honest about where this goes: Augustine says he held his misery dearer than his friend, and the natural next step is to hold God dearer than the friend, at which point the friend is third in a queue. A love arranged so that its object's death does not devastate you has been arranged not to be love.

NO: IT IS WHAT MAKES LOVING THEM POSSIBLE

The objection assumes attachment and love are the same. Augustine is denying exactly that. Loving somebody as your source of meaning is not the maximum of love but a use of them, and it is the thing that produces jealousy, possessiveness and the demand that they never change. Loving them in God is what allows you to want their good rather than their presence, which is the harder and more genuine version. And the evidence is in the text: this framework did not stop Augustine grieving for his mother in Book Nine, and he defends that grief.

THE DISPUTE IS ABOUT WHAT LOVE IS FOR

A third reading: the two sides hold different theories of what love is aimed at. If love is fundamentally a bond between two people, then anything that runs the bond through a third party dilutes it, and the objection lands. If love is fundamentally the recognition of something good and the willing of its flourishing, then locating the source of that good outside the beloved does not dilute anything. Nobody is going to settle that by reading Book Four more carefully.

Where things stand: Both sides agree about what Augustine recommends. They disagree about what happens to a human relationship when you do it, and that is a question about what love is rather than about what Augustine said.

What would settle it: Nothing textual will settle it. What can be brought to bear is Augustine's own later conduct as evidence about whether the doctrine hollows out attachment: his grief for Monica, his letters to friends, and his writing on friendship, which is warm and voluminous. That is suggestive, and it is not proof, since a man may hold a doctrine and fail to live by it, which would be a point in the objectors' favour rather than his.

Why people care so much: It matters far beyond Augustine. Every religious and philosophical tradition that recommends holding worldly attachments lightly faces this objection in the same form, and so does every secular version of the same advice.

Before deciding between those, it is worth looking at what all three of them rest on, because there is a premise underneath that neither the objection nor the reply states out loud.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT LOVE AND ATTACHMENT ARE THE SAME THING

Look at what the objection needs in order to work. It needs it to be the case that the measure of how much you love somebody is how much their loss would destroy you. Take that away and the argument that a non-devastating love is a lesser love has nothing to stand on.

That measure is not obviously right, and it is worth noticing that we do not apply it consistently. We do not think a parent who would be destroyed by their child moving away loves them more than one who would not. In that case we have a separate word for the excess, and we do not treat it as the maximum of the good thing.

But the assumption is not obviously wrong either, and Augustine needs it to be wrong. If devastation really is part of what loving a mortal creature is, and not a distortion of it, then his remedy does subtract something real and his reassurance is empty.

What the argument in the box above is actually about, underneath, is whether the pain of a bereavement is a measurement of the love or a separate phenomenon that tends to accompany it. **The general form:** using the size of a reaction to measure the thing that produced it.

I have a stake in this one and will say so. I find the objection more persuasive than the reply, and I have therefore taken care to give Augustine's side its full weight and to state the third position, which I think is the most honest of the three. Read my summary of the reply knowing that.

6.4 — One more thing Augustine says, which complicates all of it

Late in Book Four he says something that does not fit the tidy version of his position, and which anyone using this passage should know about.

He says that friendship is genuinely sweet and that God made it so. He says that what he loved in his friends was real, and that the talking and laughing and reading together and disagreeing without malice and being of one mind out of many were good things and not illusions.

That passage is one of the warmest descriptions of ordinary friendship in ancient literature, and it sits about a page from the verdict that his love for one particular friend was a mistake.

He does not reconcile them, and I do not think they reconcile neatly. What is clear is that anybody who presents Augustine as an enemy of human affection has not read the end of Book Four.

REMEMBER THIS

The remedy is to **love people in God**, in whom they cannot be lost. The change is in the relation, not the intensity.

His diagnosis: he loved his friend as though the friend were the **source** of the goodness rather than a place where it appeared. A window is not a sunrise.

The strongest objection is not that this is cold. It is that a love arranged so that its object's death **does not devastate you** may not be love at all, but a description of having loved less.

Underneath that objection is the assumption that **the size of the devastation measures the love**. Augustine needs that assumption to be false, and it is not obviously either true or false.

A page from the verdict, he writes one of the warmest descriptions of ordinary friendship in ancient literature. He never reconciles the two.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Book He Wrote and the Book He Understood

Book Four ends with two pieces of intellectual autobiography: a book he wrote and lost, and a book he read and understood too easily. Both are there to make the same point about cleverness.

7.1 — His first book

At about twenty-six or twenty-seven, Augustine wrote and published a work in two or three volumes. It was called, in Latin, *De pulchro et apto*: on the beautiful and the fitting. It was an aesthetic treatise, asking what makes something beautiful in itself and what makes something beautiful because of how it suits its purpose.

It is lost. Augustine himself says he no longer had a copy when he wrote *Confessions*, and no copy has ever surfaced. This is the second lost book in this series, after Cicero's *Hortensius* in Part Two, and the two losses are different in kind.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Hortensius is lost but quoted. Enough of it survives in other writers' citations that its general argument can be reconstructed.

De pulchro et apto is lost and almost unquoted. Practically everything known about it is what Augustine says here, in a passage designed to dismiss it. He describes its subject, mentions its dedication, criticises its underlying assumptions, and says he cannot now remember whether it was in two books or three.

What this evidence supports: that the work existed, roughly what it was about, and who it was dedicated to.

What it cannot support: any assessment of its quality or its arguments. Our only reviewer is its author, twenty years later, using it as an example of his own youthful emptiness. If somebody found a copy tomorrow, there is no particular reason to expect it would match his description of it.

The detail about not remembering whether it was two books or three is worth pausing on. That is a real memory failure, reported without embarrassment, in a book whose entire method depends on recall. He does that repeatedly, and it is one of the reasons the work reads as honest even where it cannot be checked.

7.2 — Loving a man he had never met

He dedicated the book to a man called Hierius, an orator in Rome. Augustine had never met him. He had never heard him speak. He knew him entirely by reputation.

And then he does something genuinely acute. Instead of moving on, he stops and interrogates his own admiration.

Why did he love a man he had never met? Not for the man's appearance, which he had not seen. Not for his arguments, which he had not heard. He loved him because other people praised him, and specifically because a particular kind of person praised him. He notes that if the same people had attacked Hierius instead of praising him, he would have felt the opposite about the same man, on the same evidence, which is none.

He then works out what was actually going on. What he loved in Hierius was what he wanted for himself. He wanted to be praised in that way by those people. The admiration was his own ambition looking at itself from the outside.

IN REAL TERMS

This is a completely intact piece of observation and it has aged better than almost anything else in Book Four.

It is the mechanism behind following somebody you have never met because accounts you respect follow them, admiring them for a competence you are in no position to assess, and losing the admiration instantly when the same accounts turn.

Augustine's addition is the uncomfortable one: the admiration was never about that person. It was a picture of what he wanted to be, projected onto somebody he could not see.

7.3 — Aristotle at twenty, understood too easily

The last episode of Book Four goes back a few years. At about twenty, Augustine got hold of a book called the *Categories*, by Aristotle, and read it on his own.

WORD BOX

Aristotle's *Categories*: a short and famously difficult work setting out the basic kinds of thing that can be said about anything. The central distinction is between a **substance**, which is a thing that exists in its own right, such as a particular man, and everything else that can be said about it, such as its size, its colour, its position, or its relations. Those others exist only as features of a substance. Why it matters: this framework was the standard equipment of educated thought for well over a thousand years. Augustine picking it up unaided at twenty is genuinely impressive, and he tells us so before telling us it did him no good.

He makes a point of the fact that he needed no teacher. He says that when he later met people who had been taught it by learned instructors with diagrams in the sand, they could tell him nothing he had not worked out alone. He reports this as a boast and then turns it.

The turn is this. Having acquired the framework, he applied it to God. He thought of God as a substance with attributes: God is great, God is beautiful, God is good, in the way that a man is tall and pale and heavy. Greatness and beauty would be things God *had*.

Part One introduced why this is a problem, in the section on divine simplicity: the claim that God has no parts and does not have properties the way a thing has properties. Augustine's point here is that his own facility with the best available intellectual tool led him straight into the error, and led him in faster than a slower man would have gone.

7.4 — Why the two stories are together

It is worth asking why these two episodes close Book Four rather than sitting anywhere else.

Both are about capability without direction. He could write a treatise on beauty and could not see that his admiration for its dedicatee was self-regard. He could master Aristotle unaided and used the mastery to get God wrong faster.

And that is exactly the shape of the verdict on the grief in Chapter Five: a real capacity, functioning correctly, aimed at the wrong thing. Book Four is one argument told four times, in a bereavement, in an astrology habit, in a book dedication and in a piece of philosophy.

His summary of the whole matter is characteristically blunt: what did his quickness profit him, when he was reading everything he could get and did not know where any of it came from?

REMEMBER THIS

At about twenty-six he wrote his first book, *On the Beautiful and the Fitting*. It is lost, and almost everything known about it comes from the passage in which he dismisses it.

He dedicated it to **Hierius**, a Roman orator he had never met, and then interrogated his own admiration: he loved the man because **the right people praised him**, and would have despised him on the same evidence if they had turned.

What he actually loved in Hierius was **what he wanted for himself**.

At about twenty he read Aristotle's *Categories* unaided, and used it to think of God as a **substance with attributes** — the exact error his facility made him quicker to reach.

Book Four is one argument told four times: a real capacity, working properly, aimed at the wrong thing.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Faustus

For nine years Augustine had been told that his questions would be answered when the great man came. In his twenty-ninth year, the great man came.

8.1 — The promise

Whenever Augustine raised a difficulty with the Manichees he was given the same answer. Wait for Faustus. When Faustus arrives he will explain it, and more besides. Faustus was a Manichee bishop, from Mileve in North Africa, famous across the movement as its most learned and most eloquent teacher.

That deferral had been running for years, and Augustine says it kept him in place. This is worth flagging as a mechanism rather than as a detail: a promise of a future answer is often more effective at holding somebody than an answer would be, because it cannot be tested.

8.2 — The crack that had already opened

Before Faustus arrived, something had gone wrong, and it is the most concrete intellectual event in the whole of Books Four and Five.

Augustine had been reading the astronomers. Not astrologers, this time: the people who calculated the motions of the heavens. And he had noticed that they could predict eclipses of the sun and the moon, years ahead, giving the day, the hour, and how much of the disc would be covered. Then the eclipse would happen exactly as stated.

The Manichee books also described the heavens, at great length, and their account was different. Among other things, they explained eclipses as concealments of cosmic events. And their account did not match the observations.

IN REAL TERMS

This is a clean test and it is worth appreciating how clean.

One side says: on this date, at this hour, this much of the sun will go dark. The other side offers a story about what eclipses mean. Then the date arrives.

Predictions with a time on them are the rarest and most valuable thing in any dispute, because reality settles them without asking anyone's opinion. Augustine had found one, and his own side had failed it.

Augustine draws the conclusion carefully, and the care matters. He does not say the astronomers were godly men; he says elsewhere in the same passage that they had found out a great deal and had not found the one who made it. His point is narrower and sharper.

Mani had claimed divine authority for his writings. If a man claims to speak with divine authority and then gets a checkable matter wrong, the claim is damaged, whatever else is true. It is not that astronomy refutes Manichaeism's theology. It is that a demonstrably false statement made under a claim of revelation costs the revelation its standing.

That is a good argument, and Augustine would use versions of it for the rest of his life. It is also, note, the exact opposite of the way he had treated astrology: there he had wanted an authority and kept his books despite the evidence. Something in him had changed in the interval.

8.3 — The man who arrived

Faustus came to Carthage. Augustine was twenty-nine.

He was, Augustine says at once, a great snare of the devil. Then he describes him, and the description is much more generous than the label.

Faustus was charming. He was a pleasant speaker with an agreeable manner, and he said the same things the other Manichees said, only far more attractively. Augustine went to the meetings and found the room delighted.

And Augustine, who had been waiting nine years, went looking for the answers and found that the man had not read the books.

He had a little Latin literature. He had not gone deeply into the liberal arts. He had no training in the subjects Augustine's questions were about. He was an excellent presenter of a doctrine he was not equipped to defend at the level Augustine needed it defended.

Augustine puts it in a phrase worth keeping: the man was serving a fine cup, and the cup was empty.

8.4 — The honesty that made it worse

And now the part that makes this scene good rather than merely disappointing.

Faustus knew he did not know, and said so.

When Augustine put questions to him, Faustus declined to pretend. He admitted that these matters were beyond him and refused to attempt them. Augustine says this openly increased

his liking for the man. He calls the modesty of a mind that admits its limits more beautiful than the knowledge he had come for.

That is a remarkable thing to write about someone you are describing as a snare of the devil, and it is the strongest evidence that Augustine is not simply settling scores in this passage.

But it ended the hope. If the most learned man in the movement could not answer the questions, and was honest enough to say so, then the answers did not exist. The deferral that had held Augustine in place for years had nowhere left to defer to.

8.5 — What actually happened next: nothing, for a while

Here is the detail that most retellings flatten, and it is important.

Augustine did not leave. He says the enthusiasm collapsed and that he gave up all thought of advancing further among them, but that he stayed loosely attached because he could not see anything better. He kept Manichee friends, lodged with a Manichee in Rome, and used Manichee contacts to get his next job. The formal separation is still years away.

He also, in an odd and rather warm turn, started studying with Faustus. Since Faustus was interested in literature, and Augustine was teaching it, they read together. The man who ended his religion became, briefly, his reading companion.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT PEOPLE LEAVE A BELIEF WHEN IT IS REFUTED

The way this episode is normally told, and the way Augustine half tells it, Faustus is the refutation and the departure follows. That is the shape we expect from an intellectual biography: an argument fails, the believer notices, the believer leaves.

What the text actually reports is different. The argument failed. Augustine noticed. Augustine stayed for years, kept the friendships, took the professional favours, and drifted out only after moving to another continent and meeting different people.

This is the third time in this series that his own account has described belonging doing the work while the narration credits a proposition. Part Two noted it about how he joined. Here it is about how he left, and the shape is the same in reverse: the reasons arrive on time and the person does not move.

The uncomfortable version: if beliefs are held and dropped socially rather than evidentially, then the entire genre of the intellectual conversion narrative, of which *Confessions* is the founding example, may be a systematically misleading way to describe what happens to people.

The general form: reporting the reason a change was justified as though it were the cause of the change.

That box is not a claim that Augustine's reasons were insincere. The eclipse argument is a good argument and he clearly took it seriously. It is a claim about the distance between the

moment a reason becomes available and the moment a person acts on it, which in this case is several years and one sea crossing.

THE ARGUMENT — IS AUGUSTINE FAIR TO FAUSTUS?

Augustine's whole case for leaving the Manichees rests on one man being underwhelming. That is a heavy load for a single encounter to carry, and Faustus is known to us almost entirely through Augustine.

THE PORTRAIT IS FAIR AND UNUSUALLY GENEROUS

Augustine could have made Faustus a fraud and did the opposite. He records the charm, the effectiveness, the popularity, and above all the honesty about the limits of his own learning, which he says he admired. A hostile writer inventing a villain does not put that in. The specific claim, that Faustus was eloquent but not trained in the technical subjects, is modest, checkable in principle by anyone who had met him, and not obviously self-serving.

THE FRAMING IS DOING MORE WORK THAN THE PORTRAIT

The generosity is in the details and the verdict is in the frame. Faustus is introduced as a snare of the devil before he says a word, and the episode is positioned as the hinge on which nine years turn. Augustine also later wrote a long polemic against a work of Faustus's, which means the man in Book Five is being described by someone who had since become his professional opponent. And the questions Faustus could not answer were about astronomy, which is not obviously the subject on which a religious teacher should be judged.

THE ENCOUNTER IS DOING NARRATIVE WORK REGARDLESS

A third view: whether or not the report is accurate, the scene is structurally necessary. A conversion narrative needs a moment where the old system visibly fails, and the honest disappointment of a good man is a far better one than a refutation would be. That does not make it false. It does mean we should expect it to have been shaped, and it explains why the years of not leaving get one sentence.

Where things stand: It is agreed that Augustine's portrait is unusually kind in its particulars and unfavourable in its framing. What is disputed is how much the framing distorts, and whether one man's limitations were really the reason for the break.

What would settle it: Some independent traction exists. A substantial part of Faustus's own writing survives, embedded in the work Augustine later wrote against him, and it shows a capable and pointed controversialist. That is consistent with Augustine's description of an effective speaker without technical training, and it is not consistent with a fool.

Why people care so much: It matters because this is the moment the founding conversion narrative of Western Christianity turns, and because it is a clean case of a movement being known through the account of the person who left it.

One thing is worth adding about Faustus himself, since he leaves the story here and never returns to it as a person. Within a few years of this meeting he was denounced as a Manichee and sent into exile on a Mediterranean island. Augustine, who by then had every reason to be

pleased about it, records that the punishment was unusually mild and suggests that orthodox Christians had intervened on his behalf. Whatever else is true of the portrait, the man in it was treated by his opponents as worth protecting.

REMEMBER THIS

For nine years Augustine's questions were deferred with "**wait for Faustus**". A promise of a future answer holds people better than an answer, because it cannot be tested.

Before Faustus arrived, the **astronomers** had already broken something: they predicted eclipses to the hour and the Manichee books did not match. Mani had claimed divine authority, and a **checkable false statement made under a claim of revelation** costs the revelation its standing. Faustus was **charming, effective, and untrained** in the subjects the questions were about. A fine cup, empty.

He **admitted he did not know**, and Augustine says he liked him more for it. That honesty is what ended the hope: if the best man had no answers, there were none.

And then Augustine did not leave. He stayed loosely attached for years, kept the friendships, took the favours, and drifted out only after moving continent and meeting different people.

CHAPTER NINE

The Shore, Rome, and Milan

He left Africa by lying to his mother on a beach. Within two years he was in Milan, in a job arranged by a pagan, listening to the bishop who would baptise him.

9.1 — Why he left Carthage

The reason Augustine gives is professional and unheroic. His students in Carthage were impossible. Part Two introduced the Wreckers, the student gang that broke up other people's lectures; by now Augustine was on the other side of the desk. Gangs of young men would burst into a classroom in which they were not enrolled and disrupt it, and the custom protected them.

He had heard that students in Rome were better behaved, held in order by discipline, and not permitted to barge into a teacher's room at will. So he decided to go.

He is careful to say that this was the reason he gave himself and not the real cause. His own account is that God was moving him and that the motives he was conscious of were the goad rather than the reason. That is a piece of theology laid over a career decision, and it is up to the reader what to do with it.

One point of independent interest: in a work written years before *Confessions*, Augustine indicates that ambition was in the mix for an earlier move of the same kind. People usually have several reasons and promote whichever is most presentable.

9.2 — The lie at the harbour

Monica did not want him to go. She came to the port with him and would not leave.

Augustine says she held on to him violently, either to keep him back or to come with him.

So he lied. He told her he was staying with a friend until the wind was right for the friend to sail. She did not believe him and would not go. He persuaded her to spend the night in a shrine to Cyprian, close to the ship.

WORD BOX

Cyprian: bishop of Carthage, executed in 258 during a persecution, and by Augustine's day the most venerated Christian figure in North Africa. A shrine to him near the harbour would have been a natural and safe place for a devout woman to spend a night in prayer.

Why it matters: the detail is not decorative. Augustine put his mother into a church to pray for him while he used the time to get away from her, and he tells you that is what he did.

That night the wind came and he sailed. She was praying while the ship left.

In the morning she was, he says, wild with grief and filled God's ears with complaints. And Augustine, writing twenty years later, does not excuse it. He calls it a deception. He says he lied to a mother, and to such a mother.

Then he adds the interpretation that makes the passage characteristic of the whole book: she was asking God to keep her son with her, and God was refusing her request in order to give her the thing she was actually asking for, which was that Augustine should be saved. The prayer was denied so that the prayer could be granted.

Whether or not you accept that reading, notice its structure. Augustine will use it again for every reversal in the rest of the book. It is the interpretative engine of *Confessions*, and it is worth being able to spot it: *the thing that looked like the disaster was the mechanism*.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A STORY WITH A GOOD ENDING HAD TO HAPPEN THAT WAY

The reading Augustine gives here is only available from the far end. He knows he was baptised in Milan. From that vantage point, the lie on the beach becomes the necessary first step, and Monica's refused prayer becomes a granted one.

The assumption both his defenders and his critics tend to share is that this is a claim about the events. Defenders say providence really was at work. Critics say he is dressing up a shabby act in theology. Both treat the question as being about what was going on in 383.

But the reading is not a report about 383 at all. It is a property of telling. Any sequence of events that ends somewhere can be narrated so that everything before points at the ending, and the narration will feel like discovery rather than construction, because the events really did happen in that order.

The test is what the same interpretative move would say about a life that ended badly. Augustine's framework has an answer for that too, but it is a much quieter one, and it is not on this page.

The general form: mistaking the shape a story acquires when you know how it ends for a shape the events had while they were happening.

None of that decides whether Augustine's theology is true. It is a note about why this particular passage is so persuasive, which is a different question and worth keeping separate.

9.3 — Nearly dying among strangers

He reached Rome and almost immediately fell seriously ill with a fever. He nearly died.

Two things about this are worth having. The first is that he was still unbaptised, and he notes with something like horror what would have followed if he had died there. The second is that his mother did not know. She was in Africa, praying for him daily, unaware that he was close to death.

And he was lodging with a Manichee. That detail is the evidence for what Chapter Eight said: the break with them was not a break. He had lost the belief and kept the network.

9.4 — The students who did not pay

He recovered and started teaching, and discovered that he had traded one problem for a worse one.

Roman students did not riot. They did something more efficient. They would attend a teacher for most of the term and then, shortly before the fees were due, transfer as a group to somebody else, leaving the first teacher unpaid.

IN REAL TERMS

Teachers of rhetoric were paid directly by their pupils, not by an institution. There was no salary and no contract worth anything.

So a coordinated walkout before payment day was not rudeness. It was the removal of a term's income, and the teacher had no recourse.

Augustine had crossed the Mediterranean to escape disruptive students and landed among organised ones.

His comment on it is dry and characteristic: he hated them, and not with a perfect hatred, because he hated what they did to him more than the wrong itself.

9.5 — Believing nothing, on purpose

This is the low point of the whole narrative, intellectually, and Augustine is unusually vague about it, which is itself worth noticing.

Having lost confidence in the Manichees and having nothing to replace them with, he began to think that the philosophers who said certainty was unavailable might be right.

WORD BOX

Academic scepticism: the position associated with the later Academy, the school descended from Plato, holding that nothing can be known with certainty and that the wise course is to withhold assent and follow whatever seems most probable.

Why it matters: this is not modern casual doubt. It was a disciplined philosophical position with serious arguments behind it, and Cicero — the author who had turned Augustine towards philosophy in the first place — was its main channel into Latin. Augustine later wrote a whole book attacking it, which tells you how seriously he had taken it.

He also says that he still could not conceive of anything existing that was not physical. He thought of God as a vast bright substance stretched through space, and he thought of evil as a substance too. Part One flagged this in Book One, where the young Augustine's crude picture of God is being demolished by the older one. Here is the picture itself, held by an educated man of thirty.

This is the single biggest obstacle in his intellectual life, and I am flagging it as a debt now: Part Four covers Book Seven, where it is finally removed, and where the answer to the question of where evil comes from depends entirely on removing it first.

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT DID AUGUSTINE ACTUALLY BELIEVE IN THESE YEARS?

Book Five is deliberately hazy about the period between losing the Manichees and finding anything else. Different readers have filled the haze differently.

HE WAS GENUINELY A SCEPTIC

He says so, in as many words: he considered that the philosophers who denied the possibility of knowledge were right, and he held back from committing. He later wrote an entire book refuting Academic scepticism, which is not the behaviour of a man who had merely brushed against it. Take the text at face value: for a period he thought nothing could be known.

HE WAS NEVER REALLY A SCEPTIC

He also says he never abandoned the name of Christ, that his mother's teaching held, and that he could not fully accept a position that had no place for it. And the practical evidence points the other way from despair: he kept working, kept his Manichee friends, and pursued a promotion. A man in a genuine epistemic crisis behaves differently from a man managing his career. The scepticism may be a retrospective label for a period of not knowing what to think.

THE VAGUENESS IS THE POINT

A third reading holds that Augustine is imprecise here because the period does not fit the story he is telling. A conversion narrative needs a darkness before the light, and it needs that darkness to be a condition rather than a muddle. What he seems actually to have had was several years of unresolved drift while life carried on, which is both extremely common and narratively useless.

Where things stand: It is agreed that he was not a Manichee believer and not a Christian in these years, and that he says he inclined to scepticism. What is disputed is whether "sceptic" describes a position he held or a name he later gave to a gap.

What would settle it: His own philosophical works from immediately after the conversion, especially the one attacking the Academics, are the best available evidence and have been worked over thoroughly. They establish that he knew the arguments well. They cannot establish when he came to know them.

Why people care so much: It matters because this is the stretch of the book where the narrative is thinnest, and it is exactly the stretch that would tell us most about how a person actually moves between belief systems.

9.6 — The pagan who sent him to Ambrose

Milan sent to Rome asking for a teacher of rhetoric to be supplied at public expense. Augustine applied. He got the post, after being tested on a set subject, and the man who selected him was the prefect of the city, Symmachus.

WORD BOX

Quintus Aurelius Symmachus: prefect of Rome, one of the great orators of the age, and the most prominent public defender of the traditional Roman religion against the now dominant Christianity.

Why it matters: shortly before this, Symmachus had formally petitioned the emperor to restore an altar and the traditional rites, and Ambrose, the bishop of Milan, had successfully blocked him. These two men were direct opponents.

So the sequence is this. A pagan grandee, freshly defeated by the bishop of Milan, selects a young man who is still moving in Manichee circles and sends him to Milan to hold a prominent public chair. And the young man is baptised by that bishop three years later.

Augustine reports the appointment without dwelling on the irony, but it is there, and it fits the interpretative engine described earlier: the thing that looked like one move turns out to have been another. It is also, more prosaically, how appointments worked. Augustine got the job through Manichee contacts, and Symmachus had reasons of his own to place a non-Catholic in a public post in Ambrose's city.

9.7 — Going for the style, caught by the content

In Milan he met Ambrose, and the meeting is described with more warmth than almost anything else in these two books. Ambrose received him kindly, like a father. Augustine says he began to love him, at first not as a teacher of the truth but as a man who was kind to him.

And then he went to hear him preach, for the wrong reason, and this is the detail that makes the passage.

Augustine attended the sermons to assess the technique. He was a professional rhetorician evaluating a rival professional, and he wanted to know whether Ambrose's reputation as a speaker was deserved. He says he was not interested in what was being said and cared only about how.

Set that beside Part Two, Chapter Eight. Ten years earlier he had picked up Cicero for the style and been caught by the content. Now he goes to hear Ambrose for the style, and the same thing happens again, and Augustine points it out himself: along with the words he cared about, the matters he did not care about came in, and he could not separate them.

What came in was this. The Manichee objections to the Old Testament, which Part Two set out and which had held Augustine for nine years because nobody had answered them, turned out to have answers. Ambrose read those passages figuratively. The bodily descriptions of God, the behaviour of the patriarchs, the sacrifices: read as figure rather than as literal report, the objections did not land.

Augustine says the effect was not that he was convinced Christianity was true. It was that he stopped being convinced it was absurd. He describes himself as a man who had been shouting against a position nobody actually held.

WORD BOX

Figurative reading: interpreting a passage so that its literal sense also stands for something else, rather than taking every statement as a plain report of fact.

Why it matters: this is the technical move that unlocked scripture for Augustine, and it is the thing he had lacked. It is not evasion. Ambrose was working in an established tradition of reading that goes back centuries before him. But it is a method, and Augustine did not have it, and neither did the Manichees, which is why the argument between them had been unwinnable.

So Book Five ends with him nowhere in particular: no longer a Manichee, not a believer, doubtful about everything, and enrolled again as a catechumen in the Catholic church, on the grounds that he might as well be in the place where his parents had put him while he worked out what he thought.

That is not a conversion. It is a man deciding where to stand while he waits. Books Six, Seven and Eight are the waiting.

REMEMBER THIS

He left Carthage because **students disrupted his classes**, and left Rome because Roman students **transferred in a group before paying**. He crossed a sea to swap chaos for organised non-payment.

He **lied to Monica** at the harbour, put her in a shrine to pray, and sailed that night. Writing twenty years on, he does not excuse it.

His reading of it — her prayer was **refused so that it could be granted** — is the interpretative engine of the whole book, and it is only available from the far end.

In the gap he leaned towards **Academic scepticism** and still could not imagine anything existing that was not physical. That last obstacle is what Book Seven removes.

Symmachus, the leading pagan of the age and Ambrose's direct opponent, gave him the Milan post. He went to hear **Ambrose** for the style and was caught by the content, exactly as he had been by Cicero ten years earlier.

Figurative reading answered the objections that had held him for nine years. He was not convinced Christianity was true. He stopped being convinced it was absurd.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Two lists, as always, with the reasons attached. And a closing note on the fact that the two people who matter most in these books have no names.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

Who the friend was. No name, no family, no other mention anywhere. *Why unknown:* Augustine chose not to name him, and a young man of no public standing who died in a provincial town in the 370s left no other trace. This is a refusal and an absence of record at the same time.

Whether the deathbed conversation happened as reported. The joke, the rebuke, and the vow to take it up again later carry the weight of the whole episode. *Why unknown:* reported speech from twenty-two years on, with one witness, arriving exactly where the argument needs a turning point.

How much of the grief description is memory. *Why unknown:* an accurate account of a real experience and a well-constructed reconstruction read identically. This is the standing problem of the whole work and it does not have a solution.

The name of the woman he lived with. *Why unknown:* he declined to write it, in every work, across a lifetime. Not lost. Withheld.

What was actually in *De pulchro et apto*. *Why unknown:* the book is lost and barely quoted. The only description is by its author, dismissing it.

Whether he was really a sceptic in these years. *Why unknown:* Book Five is vague precisely here, and his own later writings establish that he knew the arguments without establishing when.

Why he really left Carthage. He gives the students. An earlier work of his own points at ambition for a comparable move. *Why unknown:* people have several motives and report the presentable one, and there is no way to weigh them from outside.

10.2 — Solid

The chronology. Nine years as a Manichee Hearer, roughly 373 to 382. Teaching at Thagaste then Carthage. Faustus at twenty-nine, so 383. Rome 383, Milan 384. *Why solid:* Augustine's own dating is internally consistent, and the Milan appointment is a public post that can be placed against the prefecture of Symmachus.

That Faustus of Mileve was a real and prominent Manichee bishop. *Why solid:* a substantial amount of his own writing survives, quoted at length in the polemic Augustine later wrote against him, and he is independently attested. He was exiled for Manichaeism a few years after this meeting.

That Vindicianus was a real physician of standing. *Why solid:* medical writings attributed to him survive independently of Augustine, and his court connection is attested elsewhere.

That Symmachus was prefect of Rome and the leading defender of the traditional cults. *Why solid:* Symmachus is one of the best-documented figures of the century. His official correspondence and his petition to the emperor survive, as does Ambrose's reply to it.

That Ambrose preached figurative readings of the Old Testament. *Why solid:* Ambrose's own sermons and treatises survive in quantity and do exactly this. Augustine's report can be checked against the source, which is rare in this book.

That astronomers of the period could predict eclipses accurately. *Why solid:* the methods survive, the tables survive, and the predictions can be recomputed today.

That teachers of rhetoric were paid directly by pupils and were vulnerable to non-payment. *Why solid:* attested across the period in sources unconnected with Augustine, including legislation.

10.3 — Two people with no names

One closing observation, because it is the most striking fact about Books Four and Five and it is easy to walk past.

The two people who matter most to Augustine in this period are the friend who died and the woman he lived with. Neither is named.

Around them, in the same two books, he names Vindicianus, a doctor he spoke to a handful of times. He names Nebridius. He names Faustus, Symmachus, Ambrose, Hierius, a man he never met, and Elpidius, a controversialist he heard argue. He names his son.

So this is not a general reticence about names and it is not a convention of the period. It is specific, and it applies to exactly the two relationships that were closest.

I do not know what it means and I am not going to pretend to. The standard explanations, that the friend was a private person of no interest to posterity, or that naming the woman would have exposed her, are reasonable and are not obviously sufficient, since Augustine names plenty of private people and the woman was already publicly known to his circle.

What can be said is that it is a pattern and not an accident, that it is made by an author with total control over his text, and that it should be read as an act. We will meet it again in Part Four, at the point where she is sent away, and it is worse there.

REMEMBER THIS

We do not know who the friend was, whether the deathbed conversation happened as reported, how much of the grief account is memory, the woman's name, what was in his first book, or what he really believed in the gap years.

We do know the chronology, that Faustus and Vindicianus and Symmachus were real and are attested independently, that Ambrose really did preach figurative readings — **his sermons survive and can be checked** — and that the astronomers really could predict eclipses.

The **two people closest to Augustine** in these books are the only two who go unnamed, while he names a doctor he met a handful of times and a man he never met at all.

That is a pattern, not an accident, made by an author with complete control over his own text. What it means is not known.

Timeline

Dates in this period rest largely on Augustine's own account, which is internally consistent and can be anchored at one end by the Milan appointment. Where a date is uncertain, it says so.

Date	Event	Where it appears
373	Reads Cicero's <i>Hortensius</i> . Joins the Manichees as a Hearer, in his nineteenth year.	Book III
c. 373–375	Teaches at Thagaste. The friendship, the friend's illness and baptism, and his death.	Book IV
c. 375	Leaves Thagaste for Carthage, by his own account to escape the places that reminded him.	Book IV
c. 375–383	Teaches rhetoric at Carthage. Living with the unnamed woman and their son Adeodatus.	Book IV
this period	Consults astrologers. Wins a poetry contest, crowned by the proconsul Vindicianus , who argues against astrology. Nebridius argues the same. He keeps his books.	Book IV
c. 380–381	Writes his first book, <i>De pulchro et apto</i> , dedicated to Hierius, an orator in Rome he had never met. Now lost.	Book IV
c. 374 (recalled)	Had read Aristotle's <i>Categories</i> unaided at about twenty. Undated in the text.	Book IV
before 383	Reading the astronomers, he notices that eclipse predictions succeed and the Manichee account does not match.	Book V
383	Faustus of Mileve comes to Carthage. Augustine is twenty-nine. The hope collapses. He does not leave.	Book V
383	Sails for Rome, deceiving Monica at the harbour and leaving at night while she prays in the shrine of Cyprian.	Book V
383	Falls dangerously ill in Rome, still unbaptised, lodging with a Manichee. Recovers.	Book V
383–384	Teaches in Rome. Students transfer in groups to avoid paying. Leans towards Academic scepticism.	Book V
384	Selected by Symmachus , prefect of Rome, for the public chair of rhetoric at Milan.	Book V

Date	Event	Where it appears
384	Meets Ambrose . Attends his sermons to assess the technique. Figurative reading answers the Manichee objections. Enrols again as a catechumen.	Book V
—	Part Four starts here: Books VI and VII — Monica arrives, the woman is sent away, and the question of where evil comes from.	—

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Terms carried over from earlier parts are repeated so this part stands alone.

Term	What it means
Academic scepticism	The disciplined philosophical position that nothing can be known with certainty and that one should withhold assent and follow what seems probable.
Adeodatus	Augustine's son, born about 372 to the woman he never names. The name means "given by God".
Ambrose	Bishop of Milan from 374. A formidable public figure who had defeated Symmachus politically, and who baptised Augustine in 387.
Aristotle's <i>Categories</i>	A short, difficult work on the basic kinds of thing that can be said about anything. Augustine read it unaided at about twenty.
Catechumen	Someone enrolled in the church and receiving instruction, but not baptised. Augustine re-enrolled as one at the end of Book V.
Concubinatus	A recognised, usually monogamous household between a man and a woman who did not marry, most often because of unequal rank. Ordinary, openly acknowledged, and legally weightless.
Cyprian	Bishop of Carthage, executed in 258, and the most venerated Christian figure in North Africa. Monica prayed in his shrine the night Augustine sailed.
<i>De pulchro et apto</i>	Augustine's lost first book, on the beautiful and the fitting, written in his mid-twenties.
Faustus of Mileve	The Manichee bishop whose arrival Augustine had awaited for years. Charming, effective, and not trained in the subjects at issue.
Figurative reading	Interpreting a passage so that its literal sense also stands for something else. The method Ambrose used, and the one Augustine had lacked.
Haruspex	A diviner who read the future from the entrails of sacrificed animals. One offered to secure Augustine a contest win.
Hearers	The lower Manichaean rank, who lived ordinary lives and supported the Elect. Augustine was one for about nine years.

Term	What it means
Hierius	A Roman orator Augustine admired and never met, and to whom he dedicated his lost first book.
Liberal arts	The standard Roman curriculum — grammar, rhetoric, dialectic and the mathematical subjects — so called because they suited a free man rather than a labourer.
Mathematicus	The ordinary Latin word for an astrologer. The same word as "mathematician", because casting a horoscope required real calculation.
Nebridius	A young friend of Augustine's who argued against astrology, and who reappears in later books.
Symmachus	Prefect of Rome, leading orator, and the most prominent defender of the traditional Roman religion. He selected Augustine for the Milan chair.
Vindicianus	Proconsul of Africa and an eminent physician who had studied astrology in his youth, and who told Augustine its successes were chance.

About the Author

This series is read and explained by **Lovepreet Singh**, and published as part of **The Living Archive** at misterlove.in.

The Living Archive takes difficult material and rebuilds it so that anyone can follow it, without dropping the hard parts along the way. Its first series was a fourteen-part history of Punjab running to around nine hundred and fifty pages. This is its second.

I read the book, I did the reading around it, and I wrote down what I found. I am not a specialist in late antiquity and I am not going to pretend to be one. Where a question is genuinely contested among people who are, I have said so and given each side its strongest case rather than choosing for you. Where I could not find out, I have written that I could not find out.

The method used here was worked out on the Punjab series and is written up as a portable specification, so that any part of this work can be checked, continued or rebuilt by somebody else. That is the point of an archive that calls itself living.

[Editorial note, to be replaced before publishing: the method requires a one-line statement of the author's own position with regard to religious material, placed where readers will see it. This is the only field in the document still unfilled.]

The Living Archive

The Living Archive is a method for writing hard things simply without making them shallow. It was developed by Lovepreet Singh and tested on a fourteen-part history of Punjab. It runs on three rules.

One. Simplification is not compression. The simple version is usually longer than the difficult one. Words are being spent to buy comprehension.

Two. Two dials, turned in opposite directions. Language as simple as it can be made. Content as deep as the subject actually goes. Turning both down produces something readable and useless.

Three. Every side gets its strongest case, and where nothing settles a question, that gets said. A verdict that honestly reports a deadlock is worth more than a tidy answer that is not true.

A word on sources

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record rather than new primary research, and it is written for readers who want to understand a book, not for specialists who want to check my workings.

What the archive is good at here: this part is unusually well anchored outside Augustine. Symmachus, Ambrose, Faustus and Vindicianus are all independently attested, and in the cases of Ambrose and Faustus we have substantial amounts of their own writing. Roman teaching arrangements, ancient astronomy and the practice of astrology are all documented from sources unconnected with him.

What it is bad at here: the emotional centre of these two books — the friendship, the death, the grief — rests entirely on one witness writing twenty-two years later with a purpose. Where a claim in this document rests only on Augustine's account of himself, I have tried to say so in the text rather than let it pass as established.

On translations: all renderings of Augustine in this document are my own plain-English paraphrases, made deliberately loose so that they explain rather than reproduce. They are not quotations from any published translation and should not be cited as such. Where the exact wording matters, go to a proper edition.

Corrections are welcome and will be acted on. Later editions will record what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Four covers Books VI and VII: two years in Milan, from about thirty to thirty-two. It contains the coldest thing in the book and the hardest argument in it. These are the questions it takes on.

- Monica arrives in Milan. What does she do, and what does it cost?
- A marriage is arranged for social advantage, and the woman Augustine has lived with for over a decade is sent back to Africa without their son. What does he say about it, and what does he not say?
- Who were Alypius and Nebridius, and why does Augustine give so much space to his friends at the point where his own life is falling apart?
- Why did the sight of a drunk beggar in a Milan street stop him in his tracks?
- What exactly did he read in "the books of the Platonists", and why does he say they contained one thing and lacked another?
- How do you stop believing that everything real is made of stuff — and why was that the obstacle blocking everything else?
- And the question the whole book has been building towards: if God is good and made everything, where does evil come from?

That last one is the hinge of the entire work. Augustine's answer is that evil is not a thing at all, and Part Four is where we finally see the argument in full rather than the formula.

End of Part 3 of 9

The Living Archive · The Confessions, Explained

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART 4 OF 9

The Confessions, Explained

Part Four — Milan, Ambrose, and Where Evil Comes From

*Books Six and Seven: the coldest thing in the book and the
hardest argument in it. A woman is sent away, a friend is undone
by a crowd, and Augustine finally answers the question.*

READ AND EXPLAINED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

Parts One to Three covered Books One to Five of Augustine's *Confessions*. Here is what you need. This part stands on its own.

The man. Born 354 in Thagaste in Roman North Africa. Educated at his family's considerable expense towards a career as a professional public speaker. He wrote this book in his early forties, around 397 to 400, roughly twelve years after the events in this part.

The book. *Confessio* means three things at once: confessing sin, confessing faith, and confessing praise. This is a prayer, addressed to God from first word to last, and you are overhearing it. Thirteen books: nine of life story, one on memory, three on the opening of Genesis.

The story so far. Book One argued that something in human wanting is disordered before any choice is made, and ended with the formula that runs through everything: the gifts were good, the aim was wrong. Books Two and Three took him to Carthage, where a lost book by Cicero turned him towards philosophy and he joined the Manichees. Books Four and Five ran out the nine years that followed: teaching rhetoric, a bereavement he could not explain to himself, and the slow collapse of a religion. He sailed to Italy after lying to his mother on a beach, and by 384 he held the public chair of rhetoric in Milan.

Where he stands now. No longer a Manichee. Not a Christian. Inclined towards the philosophers who said certainty was unavailable. Re-enrolled as a catechumen in the Catholic church, which is to say enrolled for instruction without being baptised, on the grounds that he might as well stand somewhere while he worked out what he thought. He has a partner of over a decade whom he has never named, and a son by her called Adeodatus.

The question he cannot answer. If God is good and made everything, where does evil come from? He has spent nine years with a religion whose main attraction was that it answered this, and he no longer believes the answer. Book Seven is where he finds another one.

A Reminder About the Boxes

Six kinds of box run through this series. **Word Box** explains a hard term the moment it first appears. **In Real Terms** turns something abstract into something you can picture. **How We Actually Know This** names the evidence and says what it cannot show. **The Argument** is for places where experts genuinely disagree, and gives each side its strongest case. **The Hidden Assumption** digs out the premise everybody in an argument is quietly taking for granted. **Remember This** closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

Three Things to Watch For

This is the hardest part in the series so far, and the two books in it do very different jobs. Book Six is people. Book Seven is argument. Three threads hold them together.

One. The obstacle is not moral, it is imaginative. Augustine is not stuck because he wants to keep sinning, or not only. He is stuck because he cannot conceive of anything real that is not made of stuff, and until that goes, no answer to the problem of evil is even available to him. Chapter Seven is about that wall and Chapter Eight is about it coming down.

Two. Book Six is a book about other people, at the point where his own life is worst.

Monica, Ambrose, Alypius, Nebridius, a drunk in a street, a girl he is engaged to, and a woman he sends away. Augustine gives more room to his friends here than anywhere else in the work. Watch what that does, and watch who is left out of it.

Three. Chapter Five is where this series pays a debt. Three times now I have told you that the namelessness of the woman Augustine lived with is a refusal rather than a gap, and twice I have said it gets worse in this part. It does. I am not going to soften it and I am not going to prosecute him either. The text is on the page and it is his own.

Contents

Chapter One — Monica Arrives, and the Bishop Who Read in Silence

She crosses the sea · she gives up an old custom overnight · the man who could not be consulted · and one of the most argued-over sentences in the book

Chapter Two — The Beggar in the Street

A speech full of lies · a drunk man laughing · the comparison Augustine draws · and what is wrong with it

Chapter Three — Alypius at the Games

Who Alypius was · cured of the races by an accident · dragged to the arena with his eyes shut · and what happened when he opened them

Chapter Four — Thirty Years Old and Stuck

"Tomorrow I shall find it" · what he had already stopped believing · and the discovery that we believe almost everything without checking

Chapter Five — The Woman Is Sent Away

The marriage arranged · what the text says · what the text does not say · and the second woman

Chapter Six — Firminius, and the End of Astrology

Two births at the same instant · two opposite lives · why this worked when a better argument had not

Chapter Seven — The Obstacle

A sponge in an infinite sea · why he could not imagine anything real that was not made of stuff · and why that made the whole question unanswerable

Chapter Eight — The Books of the Platonists

What he was given · what was in them · the turn inward and upward · and the one thing that was not there

Chapter Nine — Where Evil Comes From

Everything that exists is good · evil is not a thing · what a bad will is · and the objections that will not go away

Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Genuinely unknown · solid · and the difference between a gap and a decision

Reference

Timeline · glossary · about the author · a word on sources · what comes next

CHAPTER ONE

Monica Arrives, and the Bishop Who Read in Silence

His mother crossed the Mediterranean to find him. Then she changed a lifelong religious practice overnight because a bishop told her to. And Augustine watched that bishop read.

1.1 — She crosses the sea

Monica followed him. Part Three ended with Augustine slipping out of Carthage at night while she prayed in a shrine by the harbour, having told her he was only seeing a friend off. She now crossed the same sea after him, through a storm bad enough that she ended up reassuring the sailors, and arrived in Milan.

What she found was not what she had feared. Augustine told her he was no longer a Manichee, but that he was not a Catholic Christian either.

Her reaction is the interesting part. Augustine expected her to be overjoyed at the first half. She was not particularly moved by it. She had never, he says, expected him to die a Manichee, and this was simply a stage. She told him calmly that she believed she would see him a faithful Catholic before she left this life.

He reports that calm as the strangest thing about her. She had wept for years and now she did not, because on her own account the outcome was not in doubt. Whatever one makes of that, it is a portrait of a specific kind of person, and it is drawn by somebody who had lived with her.

1.2 — The custom she gave up in a day

Then something happens that tells you more about Monica than any of the weeping.

She had a religious practice from home. In North Africa it was customary to bring food and wine to the shrines of the martyrs, eat a little there, and share the rest.

WORD BOX

Meals at the martyrs' shrines: an old and very widespread African Christian custom of bringing food and drink to the tombs of the martyrs on their feast days and holding a small meal there. It grew out of long-standing practices of dining with the dead, and church leaders worried it was sliding into drinking parties and into something close to offerings for the dead.

Why it matters: this was not a fringe habit. It was ordinary devotion for a woman of Monica's background, and giving it up meant giving up something she had done all her life.

When she arrived at a shrine in Milan with her basket, the doorkeeper stopped her. The bishop had forbidden it.

She obeyed at once. Augustine says she accepted it not merely without complaint but readily, and that she went on to bring an offering of a different kind instead.

And then he adds a sentence that is unusually shrewd about his own mother. He says he does not think she would have given it up so easily if the prohibition had come from somebody other than Ambrose, whom she loved. The rule did not change her behaviour. The person giving it did.

That is the same observation this series has been making since Part Two, in his own mouth, about his own family: belonging does the work. He notices it in Monica in a single line and does not apply it to himself.

1.3 — The man who could not be consulted

Augustine desperately wanted to talk to Ambrose. He had a queue of questions and nowhere to put them. And he could not get an appointment.

The reason is entirely mundane, and Augustine reports it without bitterness. Ambrose was the bishop of the imperial capital. He was constantly besieged by crowds of people with business, whose troubles he served. In the small amount of time he was not doing that, he was eating a minimal meal or reading.

IN REAL TERMS

Milan in the 380s was not merely a large city. It was where the western emperor and his court actually lived, which made its bishop one of the most powerful men in the western half of the empire.

Ambrose successfully faced down an empress over a church building and later forced an emperor into public penance after a massacre. That is the man Augustine wanted to book a conversation with.

Picture trying to get a private hour with someone who runs a major institution in a capital city, in order to work through your own religious doubts, when you are a newly arrived provincial lecturer. Augustine could get into the room. He could not get the man's attention.

So Augustine did what he could. He went to the sermons, sat in the crowd, and listened. And he says plainly that he never got to ask what he wanted to ask. Ambrose had no idea what was going on inside him. The two men were in the same room repeatedly and the conversation Augustine needed never happened.

1.4 — Ambrose reading

When he could not get near him, Augustine watched him. And he wrote down what he saw, in a passage of about four sentences that has generated a very large amount of scholarship.

Ambrose was reading. His eyes moved across the page and his mind worked out the meaning. His voice and his tongue were still. Anyone could come in, and people often did, and would find him reading like this, silently, and never otherwise.

Augustine then guesses at reasons, and the guessing is worth having because it shows what struck him as needing explanation. Perhaps Ambrose was protecting his voice, which was easily strained. Perhaps he read silently to avoid being stopped: a listener hearing a difficult passage would want it explained, and the bishop would lose the little reading time he had. Whatever the reason, Augustine concludes, it was a good one.

For a long time this passage was taken as proof that reading aloud was the norm in the ancient world and that silent reading was a rarity worth remarking on. That reading of it is now seriously disputed.

THE ARGUMENT — WAS SILENT READING UNUSUAL IN ANTIQUITY?

A single paragraph of Augustine has carried an enormous claim about how everybody in the ancient world read. In the last few decades that claim has been taken apart, and the dispute is instructive about how evidence works.

YES: IT WAS GENUINELY REMARKABLE

The traditional case, argued forcefully in the 1920s and repeated ever since, is that ancient reading was normally vocal. Texts were written without spaces between words, without punctuation and without lower case, which makes reading closer to decoding a score than to scanning a page, and sounding it out helps enormously. Books circulated by being read aloud to groups. And the plain evidence is that Augustine, an educated professional, found the behaviour worth four sentences and three separate hypotheses. People do not explain the unremarkable.

NO: THE PASSAGE HAS BEEN OVERLOADED

The rebuttal, pressed from the 1960s onwards and sharpened in the 1990s, is that there are numerous references in Greek and Latin literature to people reading silently, well before Augustine, and that nobody else treats it as strange. On this reading what surprised Augustine was not silence but something else: that Ambrose read silently *while visitors stood there*, which is a social oddity rather than a technical one, and that he could not be interrupted. The famous conclusion rests on one passage that does not say what it has been made to say.

THE QUESTION WAS BADLY FRAMED

A third position holds that "did they read silently?" is the wrong question, because reading is not one activity. Skimming a familiar document, working through a difficult text, and performing a poem are different tasks, and the evidence is perfectly consistent with silent reading being routine for some and vocal reading routine for others. The dispute was generated by treating a spectrum as a switch.

Where things stand: The strong traditional claim, that silent reading was essentially unknown, is now widely regarded as unsupportable, and the counter-evidence is real. What Augustine found remarkable about Ambrose remains genuinely unclear, and the third position has gained ground.

What would settle it: More collected instances would help and scholars have collected them thoroughly. The limiting factor is that people rarely describe what everyone does, so the ordinary case is exactly the one that leaves no record. That asymmetry is why the argument has run so long on so little.

Why people care so much: It matters beyond Augustine because the strong claim escaped into popular histories of reading, of the book, and of the mind, and is still repeated as settled fact in places where the rebuttal has never arrived.

I have given that argument more room than its subject strictly deserves, and deliberately, because it is the cleanest example in this series of something worth carrying into every other chapter: a single suggestive sentence, repeated confidently for a century, becoming a fact that nobody checked.

REMEMBER THIS

Monica **crossed the sea** after him and found him no longer a Manichee and not a Christian. She was **calm**, because she considered the outcome settled.

She gave up a **lifelong African devotional custom overnight** because Ambrose had forbidden it. Augustine notes she would not have obeyed so readily from anyone she did not love — the same observation about belonging he keeps making about other people and not himself.

He could never get Ambrose's attention. The bishop of the **imperial capital** was besieged with business, and the conversation Augustine needed never happened.

So he watched him instead, and recorded that Ambrose **read in silence**.

That passage was used for a century to prove that ancient reading was normally aloud. The strong version of that claim is now regarded as unsupportable, and what actually surprised Augustine is not clear.

CHAPTER TWO

The Beggar in the Street

On his way to deliver a speech full of things he did not believe, Augustine passed a drunk man laughing in the road, and it stopped him.

2.1 — The speech

As the public rhetorician of Milan, Augustine's job included delivering formal speeches in praise of the emperor. He was preparing one. He says he was going to tell a great many lies, and that the people who knew they were lies would applaud them.

WORD BOX

Panegyric: a formal speech of praise, usually for an emperor or a high official, delivered on a public occasion. It was a recognised literary form with rules, and everybody involved understood that its relationship to the truth was loose.

Why it matters: Augustine is not describing a moment of unusual corruption. He is describing his job. The public praise of power was the highest-status work a rhetorician did, and it was the thing his family had spent a decade paying for.

He describes his state that day precisely. His heart was panting with the strain of it. He was being consumed by anxieties. And walking through a street in Milan he noticed a beggar who had evidently had a few coins and spent them on drink, and who was joking and cheerful.

2.2 — The comparison

The argument Augustine makes from this is compact and it is worth setting out in his own order.

He and the beggar wanted the same thing. Both wanted to be happy. The beggar had got there that evening and Augustine had not, and was not going to.

The beggar had reached it by begging a few coins. Augustine was trying to reach it by an enormous circuit of anxious labour: the career, the reputation, the speech, the applause of people who knew he was lying.

So the beggar was ahead. Not morally, and Augustine is careful about this, but in the plain sense that one of them had what they were both after and the other did not.

Then he turns it, and the turn is what saves the passage from being a sentimental observation about simple pleasures.

The beggar's happiness was false, he says, and so was the happiness he himself was chasing, and his was the more false of the two. The difference between them was this: the beggar would sleep off his drunkenness that night. Augustine had been sleeping in his for years, would wake up in it tomorrow, and would go on waking up in it.

2.3 — What is right about it

Two things in this passage are genuinely good and have not aged.

The first is the observation about circuits. Augustine notices that the path he is on has no terminus. The speech leads to the reputation, the reputation to the next post, and there is no point at which the process delivers the thing it was undertaken for. That is not a complaint about ambition being wicked. It is a structural observation about a certain kind of goal.

The second is the refusal to romanticise. A lesser writer would have made the beggar wise. Augustine does not. He says the man's happiness was false too. He is not recommending poverty and he is not saying the drunk had found the answer. He is saying that on this particular evening a man with nothing had beaten him at his own objective, and that this should have told him something about the objective.

IN REAL TERMS

Strip out the fourth century and the observation is intact.

You are on the way to something you have worked towards for years, and it is not making you happy, and the next thing after it will not either, and you can see the whole ladder and none of the rungs is the top.

Then somebody who has none of it laughs in the street, and for about four seconds the entire structure looks optional. Augustine's contribution is not the four seconds. It is that he wrote down what happened in them.

2.4 — What is wrong with it

The argument has a weak joint and it is worth naming, because Augustine leans on it hard.

The comparison treats his happiness and the beggar's as the same kind of thing in different quantities, so that they can be placed on one scale and one declared further along. Everything in the passage depends on that.

But a drunk man's cheerfulness and a professional's satisfaction in his work are not obviously the same substance at different concentrations. If they are different in kind, the whole

comparison collapses, and the beggar is not ahead of Augustine or behind him. He is elsewhere.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT HAPPINESS IS A QUANTITY

Augustine's argument, and almost every argument anybody makes about who is happier, needs happiness to be one thing that comes in amounts. Otherwise there is no scale, and no answer to the question of who is further along it.

That premise is doing enormous work and it is almost never examined. We do not usually think this way about other states. Nobody asks whether a person is more "interested" than another person who is interested in a different thing, or expects a single answer.

And notice which side of Augustine's own argument the assumption favours. If happiness is a quantity, the beggar can be ahead, which is the surprise the passage runs on. If it is not, the passage is a category confusion dressed as an insight.

It is worth adding that Augustine had a reason for the assumption. He held that all human beings want one thing and pursue it under many descriptions, which makes the single scale not a slip but a doctrine. That does not make it true. It does mean the objection has to be aimed at the doctrine rather than at the passage.

The general form: comparing two things on a scale that has not been shown to exist.

It is also fair to say that the objection does not damage the part of the passage that matters. Augustine's real point is about his own condition and not about the beggar's, and it survives without the comparison: the thing he was pursuing was not going to arrive, and he knew it, and he went to give the speech anyway.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine was preparing a **panegyric** for the emperor, full of things he knew were untrue, for an audience that knew it too. That was the highest-status work in his profession.

He passed a **drunk beggar laughing**, and worked out that they both wanted the same thing and only one of them had it that evening.

He refuses to romanticise it. The beggar's happiness was **false too**. The difference is that the beggar would sleep his off by morning and Augustine had been sleeping in his for years.

What is right: the path he was on had **no terminus**, and he could see the whole ladder and no top.

What is wrong: the comparison needs happiness to be one thing that comes in amounts. If it is not, the beggar is not ahead of him or behind him. He is elsewhere.

CHAPTER THREE

Alypius at the Games

The most famous account of spectatorship in ancient literature, and it is about somebody else. Augustine gives his closest friend four pages and uses them to describe a man being taken apart by a crowd.

3.1 — Who Alypius was

Alypius came from Thagaste, from a leading family there, and was some years younger than Augustine. He had been Augustine's pupil, first at home and then at Carthage. He followed him to Rome to study law, and then to Milan. He will be there in the garden in Book Eight and he will be baptised alongside him. He later became a bishop himself.

Augustine plainly loved him and says so. But the reason Alypius gets four pages in the middle of Book Six is not sentiment. It is that Alypius is an exhibit.

Book Six is about a man who knows what is good and cannot do it. Augustine is going to spend the rest of the work on that problem. Alypius is the same problem in somebody else, seen from outside, where it can be examined without the writer defending himself.

3.2 — Cured of the races by accident

The first episode is short and sets up the second.

At Carthage, Alypius had been swept up in the chariot races to a degree Augustine calls a madness. It was ruining his studies.

Augustine was lecturing at the time. In the middle of explaining a passage, he happened to reach for a comparison involving the circus, and used it contemptuously, to mock people who were caught by that sort of thing. He was not thinking about Alypius. He was making a rhetorical point.

Alypius took it as aimed at him, was ashamed, and gave up the races on the spot.

Augustine's comment on this is the reason he includes it. He says he had no such intention, and that God used his tongue without his knowing it. What he is recording is that the thing

which freed his friend was *an accident*: a stray sentence, aimed at nobody, that happened to land.

Keep that in mind for Book Eight, where a voice in a garden that was probably a child playing a game is the hinge of the entire work.

3.3 — The arena

Years later, in Rome, Alypius was studying law. Some friends and fellow students met him coming from dinner and pressed him, in a friendly and insistent way, to come with them to the amphitheatre.

WORD BOX

The gladiatorial games: public spectacles in which men fought, often to the death, before large crowds, alongside the killing of animals and the public execution of the condemned. By Augustine's day they were in decline and under increasing legal restriction, and they would end within a few decades. They were still running.

Why it matters: this is a state-sponsored mass entertainment built on watching people die. Alypius is not being taken to something disreputable and marginal. He is being taken to the games.

Alypius refused. He detested the whole business. His friends dragged him anyway, with the kind of force friends use, and he told them as they went that they could drag his body into the place but they could not make him watch. He would be present and absent at once, and would beat both them and the spectacle.

They took their seats. The crowd was raging with cruel delight, and Alypius shut his eyes and forbade his mind to go out to it.

Then a man fell in the fight, and the entire audience roared.

Overcome by curiosity, and confident that whatever it was he would be able to look at it and defeat it, he opened his eyes.

3.4 — What happened when he looked

Augustine's description of what followed is exact and it does not spare his friend.

He was struck with a worse wound in his soul than the fighter had taken in his body. He fell more wretchedly than the man whose fall had made the noise. As soon as he saw the blood he drank in savagery, and did not turn away, and fixed his gaze, and took in the frenzy without knowing it.

He was delighted with the wickedness of the contest and drunk on the bloody pleasure. He was no longer the man who had come in. He was one of the crowd that had brought him, and a true companion of the people who had dragged him there.

He shouted. He burned. He carried the madness away with him. And he went back, and he took others.

Augustine says God rescued him from it later, and says it took a long time.

IN REAL TERMS

The mechanism Augustine describes has four steps and they are the same four steps now.

A person is confident they can be exposed to something and remain themselves. They arrange to be present but not participating. Something loud happens and the confidence is enough to make them look. And then the thing is not something they are watching. It is something they are doing.

The detail that makes it land is the last one. He did not merely enjoy it. He went back, and he brought people. What was done to him he then did to others, which is how the crowd that took him was made in the first place.

3.5 — What Augustine is doing with it

It is worth asking why this scene is here and not in Book Three with the attack on the theatre, where it would fit the subject better.

The answer is that it is not an argument about entertainment. It is an argument about the will, placed immediately before the part of the book where Augustine's own will is the subject.

Alypius did everything right by the standards of a rational agent. He knew the thing was bad. He did not want to go. He decided in advance not to look. He had a strategy and he executed it. And a noise defeated all of it in a second, and he was reassembled into a different person before he had time to consider anything.

That is the anti-Socratic case in a scene. Part Two set out the classical principle that nobody does wrong willingly, because to see clearly that something is bad is to be unable to want it. Alypius saw clearly, wanted correctly, and was carried anyway.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A SPECTATOR IS NOT A PARTICIPANT

Alypius's plan rests on a premise he never states and that most people share: that watching is a position outside the thing watched. You can attend without joining, be in the room without being in the event, and the boundary is guarded by your intention not to join.

Augustine's account denies this and does not argue for the denial, which is why it is easy to read the scene as a story about a weak-willed man rather than as a claim. The claim is that a crowd at a spectacle is not an audience surrounding an event. It is part of the event, and the fighting is being done *for* the roar, so the roar is a component of it and anyone producing the roar is inside.

On that account Alypius's strategy could not have worked, because the thing he was trying to be outside of included him from the moment he sat down. Closing his eyes did not put him outside it. It made him a quiet part of it.

The uncomfortable extension: the assumption is doing the same work now, every time anyone reasons that consuming something is not endorsing it because they are only looking.

The general form: treating a boundary maintained by your intentions as a boundary that exists in the world.

That is a claim, not a proof, and it can be resisted. The obvious reply is that audiences do routinely watch terrible things without becoming them, and that Augustine has generalised from a case where his friend was already susceptible. But the reply has to be made, and most readers of this scene do not notice that anything has been asserted.

3.6 — Two more things about Alypius, and Nebridius

Two shorter episodes are worth having, because they stop Alypius being merely the man who broke at the games.

He was arrested for a crime he did not commit. Walking in a public square in Rome, he picked up an axe he found lying by a fence and was seized by guards as the silver thief they were hunting. He was being marched off when an architect who knew him recognised him and stopped it, and the real thief was found. Augustine's comment is that a man destined to judge cases had been shown, from the inside, how easily an innocent man is convicted on appearances.

He refused a bribe. Holding a legal post in Rome, with a powerful senator pressing him to approve something improper, and with real threats behind it, Alypius refused. Augustine notes that the man was strong here and had broken there, and does not reconcile the two.

And **Nebridius** came. Part Three introduced him as the young friend who argued against astrology. He left a comfortable estate near Carthage and a mother who did not want him to go, and travelled to Milan for no reason except to be with Augustine in the search for truth. Augustine records this and does not entirely know what to do with it.

REMEMBER THIS

Alypius was Augustine's pupil, his closest friend, and later a bishop. He gets four pages because he is the same problem as Augustine, visible from outside.

He was cured of the chariot races by an **accident**: a stray contemptuous remark in a lecture that was not aimed at him. Remember that when you reach the garden in Book Eight.

Dragged to the **gladiatorial games** against his will, he closed his eyes and planned to defeat the spectacle by not watching. A roar made him look. He was **reassembled into one of the crowd** in a second, shouted, went back, and took others.

He did everything a rational agent should: he knew it was bad, did not want to go, and planned not to look. **All of it was defeated by a noise.**

His plan needed watching to be a position outside the thing watched. At a spectacle staged for the roar, it is not.

CHAPTER FOUR

Thirty Years Old and Stuck

Halfway through Book Six Augustine stops and takes stock of himself, and the stocktaking is one of the most recognisable passages in the book.

4.1 — "Tomorrow I shall find it"

He was thirty. He had been searching, on his own account, since he was nineteen, when Cicero turned him towards philosophy. Eleven years. And he says he was still stuck in the same mud, wanting to enjoy present things that were slipping away and wearing him out, and telling himself that tomorrow he would find it, that it would become clear and he would grasp it.

The sentence has a specific shape and it is worth noticing. It is not despair. It is the opposite: a perfectly sincere confidence, renewed daily, that the matter will resolve shortly. Tomorrow the thing will become plain.

Augustine's point, writing at forty-three, is that this state can be maintained indefinitely and feels like progress from the inside. He was not refusing to decide. He was waiting for the decision to become obvious, which is a different posture and a far more comfortable one.

IN REAL TERMS

Eleven years is a long time to be about to work something out.

Put it on any modern scale: from leaving university to being well into a career. From meeting somebody to having children with them. The whole of a decade, with the question live the entire time and no answer at the end of it.

And every single day of it, on his own account, felt like the day before the answer.

4.2 — What he had already stopped believing

It is worth being precise about where he actually stood, because "stuck" is vague and his position was not.

Listening to Ambrose, he had discovered something that genuinely startled him. The Catholic church did not teach that God had a human body.

That sounds trivial and it is not. Part Two explained that the Manichees attacked the Jewish scriptures partly by pointing at passages describing God in bodily terms and asking whether a

God with hands and a face was worth worshipping. Augustine had been repeating that attack for nine years. He now found out that the people he had been attacking did not hold the position he had been attacking.

His own word for how this felt is shame. He says he was ashamed of having barked for so many years, not against the Catholic faith, but against a figment of his own imagination.

So by the middle of Book Six he had lost the Manichees, lost his main objection to the church, and gained nothing. He describes himself as being in the position of a man who has stopped being sure the road is wrong without having any reason to think it is right.

4.3 — The discovery about believing

Out of that position comes a small argument that is one of the more durable things in Book Six.

Augustine had been holding out for proof. He wanted the truths of religion demonstrated as clearly as a mathematical result, and had been refusing to commit to anything he could not verify.

Then he looked at how much of his ordinary life ran on things he could not verify.

He had never seen most of the places he was confident existed. He accepted events from history on the word of people who wrote them down. He believed his friends about their own lives. And, the example he presses hardest, he believed who his parents were, which he could not possibly establish for himself and had entirely on report.

The argument is not that everything should therefore be believed. It is narrower and better: that he had been applying to one subject a standard he applied to nothing else, and that if he held the rest of life to that standard he would have to stop functioning.

WORD BOX

Testimony: in philosophy, the source of belief that comes from being told something by somebody else rather than from working it out or seeing it yourself.

Why it matters: how much of what a person knows rests on testimony, and whether that is a defect, is a live question in modern philosophy of knowledge. Augustine's version of the point is compact and it is essentially the one still made: an individual who accepted only what they had personally verified would know almost nothing.

It is worth flagging what this argument does and does not do for him. It removes an objection. It does not supply a reason to believe anything in particular, and Augustine does not pretend it does. What it changes is the demand: he stops requiring proof before he will take anything seriously, which is what allows the next two years to happen at all.

4.4 — The plan that failed over wives

One more episode from this stretch, because it is the funniest thing in the book and it also matters.

Augustine, Alypius, Nebridius and a group of about ten friends discussed withdrawing from public life together. They would pool their property into a common fund, live in a shared household away from the crowds, and take turns administering it for a year at a time so the others could think. Two of them were wealthy enough to make it work. It was seriously planned.

It collapsed on one question. Some of them had wives and some of them intended to have wives, and nobody could work out what the wives were supposed to do in this arrangement.

Augustine reports the collapse without comment. Read it beside the next chapter and the silence is loud: a group of men designing an ideal life found it impossible to place the women in it, and the plan died rather than the design being changed.

4.5 — Epicurus, and the one thing that stopped him

One short passage from this stretch is worth pulling out, because it shows exactly how thin the thread was.

Augustine and his friends discussed the good life, and he says that he would have handed the prize to Epicurus — the philosopher who taught that pleasure is the highest good — except for one thing.

WORD BOX

Epicurus: a Greek philosopher of the fourth and third centuries BC who taught that the goal of life is freedom from pain and disturbance, that the gods take no interest in us, and that the soul does not survive death. His name became shorthand in Roman writing for a life organised around pleasure, which is a caricature of what he actually argued.

Why it matters: Augustine is saying that on the merits, as he then saw them, the pleasure-seeker had the better case.

The exception was this: Epicurus denied that anything survives death, and Augustine could not get himself to believe that. Because he thought there was a life after this one and a judgement in it, the calculation changed and Epicurus lost.

It is worth being clear about what this admission contains. At thirty, the only thing standing between Augustine and a straightforwardly hedonistic philosophy was a belief about survival after death that he had inherited and never examined. Not an argument. Not the light in Book

Seven, which had not happened yet. An assumption from childhood, doing structural work in an adult man's life.

REMEMBER THIS

At thirty, eleven years into searching, he was telling himself daily that **tomorrow it would become clear**. That state can be maintained indefinitely and feels like progress from inside.

He had learned that the church **did not teach that God has a body**, and was ashamed of having spent nine years **barking at a figment** of his own imagination.

He had been holding out for **proof**, then noticed that he believed on testimony almost everything else in his life, including who his parents were. That removed an objection without supplying a reason.

A serious plan for ten friends to withdraw and live in common **collapsed over what to do about wives**. Augustine reports it without comment.

He had lost the Manichees, lost his main objection to the church, and gained nothing. That is the position from which the rest of the book starts.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Woman Is Sent Away

This series has told you three times that her namelessness is a refusal rather than a gap, and twice that it gets worse here. It does. This chapter reports what the text says and what it does not.

5.1 — The marriage

Monica set about arranging a marriage for her son. Augustine was pressed to it by friends as well, chiefly on the grounds that a wife with money would ease the costs of the career they were all pursuing. A girl was found and asked for, and Augustine agreed to the match.

She was about two years short of the legal age for marriage. Under Roman law a girl could be married at twelve. So she was about ten.

That is a plain historical fact and it should be stated plainly. Betrothal well before the legal minimum was ordinary among Roman families arranging advantageous matches, and the wedding waited for the age. Augustine records that he liked her and that the delay of two years was the reason for what happens next. He offers no other comment on her at all. She is not named either.

Nothing in this series requires you to soften that, and I am not going to. It is also worth saying, for accuracy rather than for comfort, that Augustine is not describing something his contemporaries would have found remarkable, which is a separate observation from whether it was defensible.

One detail from the arranging is worth having, because it is a rare glimpse of how Monica thought. She tried to get guidance about the match in dreams, and reported the results to her son. Augustine says she got nothing but confused imaginings of her own making, and that she could tell the difference between those and a genuine revelation by something she could not put into words, a kind of taste she was unable to explain.

That is an unusually honest thing for either of them to record. A woman who believed she had received real messages from God also believed that most of what came to her in sleep was

nothing, and had no account of how she told them apart beyond a sense she could not describe. Augustine reports it without endorsing it and without mocking it.

5.2 — What the text says

Here is the passage, in plain English, with nothing added.

The woman he had been living with was *torn from his side*, as an obstacle to his marriage. His heart, which was stuck to hers, was cut and wounded and left a trail of blood.

She went back to Africa. She vowed to God that she would never know another man. She left their son with Augustine.

And then, because he could not wait two years for the bride, and because, as he says, he was not so much a lover of marriage as a slave of appetite, he got another woman. Not a wife. He says the wound made by the cutting away of the first one did not heal but festered, and grew colder, and more desperate.

That is the whole of it. It is four sentences in the original.

5.3 — What the text does not say

Now the absences, listed plainly, because they are the substance of this chapter.

Her name. Not here, not anywhere in anything Augustine wrote across a lifetime of enormous productivity.

Who did it. The verb is passive. She *was torn* from his side. The sentence has no agent. Monica arranged the marriage, and Augustine agreed to it, and the grammar of the sentence contains neither of them.

What she wanted. We are told she made a vow. We are not told whether she was consulted, whether she agreed, or whether she had anywhere to go.

What happened to her. She returns to Africa and leaves the record entirely. Whether she lived, where she went, whether she was supported, whether she ever saw her son again: none of it is in any source.

Their son. Adeodatus was about fourteen. He stayed with Augustine. Nothing is said about how that was decided or what it was like for either of them.

And one thing that is present and worth naming as present: Augustine records that *he* was in pain. The bleeding heart in that passage is his own. The woman's grief, if she had any, is not described, and neither is the question of it.

5.4 — The one thing he does say about her

There is a sentence that critics of this passage sometimes miss and that defenders of it sometimes overstate, so here it is exactly.

Augustine says he could not even imitate a woman. He is comparing himself to her, unfavourably, on the specific point that she kept her vow of continence and he could not manage two years.

That is a real acknowledgement and it is genuinely to her credit in his own terms. It is also, read carefully, still about him. She appears in it as the standard he failed to meet, which is a role, not a portrait.

THE ARGUMENT — HOW SHOULD THE SENDING AWAY BE READ?

This passage has become the main site of modern argument about Augustine as a person. The positions below are all held by people who have read the whole corpus, and none of them is a caricature.

IT IS A STRAIGHTFORWARD MORAL FAILURE, AND HE KNOWS IT

He describes himself as complicit and as culpable. He does not claim he resisted. He immediately took another woman, which he reports as evidence against himself. A man of thirty-one with a public position ended a thirteen-year union for financial and social advancement and got engaged to a child, and the passage is written by that man at forty-three specifically in order to say so. Reading this as an indictment is not imposing modern standards. It is agreeing with the author.

THE PASSIVE VOICE IS THE TELL, AND IT EXCULPATES

On this reading Augustine's honesty stops precisely where it would cost him most. He can say he was a slave of lust, which is an accusation that flatters by making him a victim of his own appetite. What he cannot write is a sentence with himself as the subject and her as the object. The grammar does the work: she was torn away, by nobody. And the namelessness across a lifetime is the same operation performed at scale.

HE WAS CONSTRAINED IN WAYS THAT ARE EASY TO FORGET

The most sympathetic reading available notes the legal position. Part Three explained that their arrangement carried no legal standing whatever. He could not have married her; the social distance that made her a concubine rather than a wife was the same distance that barred the marriage. Ending such a union on engagement was the expected course, and everybody around him — his mother, his friends, his profession — was pushing. This does not make it right. It places the failure in a structure rather than solely in a man.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes the facts, because Augustine supplies all of them and supplies them against himself. What is disputed is what the shape of the telling shows: whether the passive voice and the missing name are evasion, decorum, or protection of a living woman.

What would settle it: Nothing will settle it, and the reason is worth stating exactly. The only person who could tell us what happened is the one person the record was built without. There is no source for her that does not pass through him.

Why people care so much: It matters because Augustine's writing on sex, marriage and desire shaped Western thought for fifteen centuries, and this is the one place where we can see what he did rather than what he argued.

Before choosing between those, it is worth noticing something all three have in common, and which makes the whole argument stranger than it looks.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE INJURED PARTY IS IN THE TEXT

Every position in that box, including the harshest, is conducted entirely in evidence Augustine supplied. The prosecution uses his words. The defence uses his words. The verdict, whichever way it goes, is reached on a file assembled by the accused.

The shared assumption is that the passage gives us access to the event. It does not. It gives us access to one participant's account of the event, written twelve years later, in a work of religious self-examination, about a woman who could not read it and would not have been asked.

This is not a complaint that Augustine is unreliable. It is a point about what is structurally unavailable. We do not know what she was told, what she was offered, what she said, or whether the word "vowed" describes a free act or the only description a returning woman could give of her situation.

And notice the effect: because the only voice is his, even the case against him is shaped by what he chose to include. His pain is in the passage, so his pain is in the argument. Hers is not in the passage, so it is not in the argument, and the discussion is about him either way.

The general form: mistaking the surviving account for the event.

I said in the front matter that I would neither excuse him nor prosecute him, and I have tried to hold that. But I will say one thing directly, because silence would be its own position. The most striking fact about this passage is not what Augustine did. Men in his position did it routinely. It is that a writer capable of describing his own grief for an unnamed friend across four pages of Book Four wrote four sentences here, and that in a work whose whole method is the pitiless examination of his own motives, this is the place where the examination stops.

REMEMBER THIS

A marriage was arranged for social and financial advantage. The girl was about **two years under the legal minimum of twelve**. She is not named either.

The woman Augustine had lived with for over a decade **was torn from his side** — the verb is passive and the sentence has **no agent**. She returned to Africa, vowed never to know another man, and left their son.

Unable to wait two years, **he took another woman**, and says the wound did not heal but festered.

What is absent: her name, who did it, whether she was consulted, what became of her, and any account of her grief. What is present: **his** pain.

Every argument about this passage, for and against him, is conducted entirely in evidence he supplied. There is no source for her that does not pass through him.

CHAPTER SIX

Firminus, and the End of Astrology

Part Three left a debt: Augustine was given a good argument against astrology by a qualified man and kept his books anyway. Here is what finally worked, and it was not an argument.

6.1 — The story

A friend called Firminus came to Augustine to have a horoscope read. Firminus was well educated, well born, and an enthusiastic consulter of astrologers without knowing much of the technical literature himself. Before Augustine gave an opinion, he asked Firminus what he thought, and Firminus told him a story about his own birth.

Firminus's father had been deeply interested in astrology, and had a friend who was equally keen. The two of them tracked the birth of every creature in their households, right down to the animals, recording the exact moment so that the stars could be read.

When Firminus's mother was pregnant, a household slave of the friend was pregnant at the same time. The two men prepared. When the labours began, each household sent word to the other, and each had messengers standing by to carry news of the actual birth the instant it happened.

The messengers met each other halfway. The two children had been born at the same moment, so exactly that no difference in the position of the stars could be found between them, down to the smallest points the astrologers used.

Firminus was born into a leading family. He went on to wealth and public honours. The other child was born a slave, and remained a slave, and Firminus knew him and could report it.

6.2 — Why this destroyed it

The argument is short. Two people with identical charts had opposite lives. If the chart determines the life, that cannot happen. It happened.

Augustine says his resistance dissolved. And then he did the thing that shows he had actually understood it rather than merely been struck by it: he turned the case around on Firminus, who was still a believer.

If he read Firminus's chart, he said, he would have to see in it distinguished parents, a noble house, a good birth, a proper education. And if the slave had come to him with the same chart, he would have to read out of it the lowness of his birth, his servile condition, and everything else opposite. From identical data he would have to produce contradictory readings, and if he produced the same reading he would be wrong about one of them.

Augustine adds the further case, which he pressed elsewhere for the rest of his life: twins. Children born minutes apart, sharing effectively the same sky, whose lives go entirely differently. If the sky determines the life, twins should be indistinguishable in fortune, and they are not.

IN REAL TERMS

What Augustine has here is what a modern researcher would call a natural control.

Two subjects, one variable held identical, everything else different. The astrologer's claim is that the identical variable is the cause. If it were, the outcomes would match. They are opposite.

It is not a sophisticated experiment and it did not need to be. The whole system made a prediction it could not survive, and one household with an unusually obsessive father happened to have run the test by accident.

6.3 — Why this worked when Vindicianus had not

And now the point that makes this chapter worth a chapter.

Part Three covered the earlier attempt. Vindicianus, a proconsul and a physician who had studied astrology himself and had considered making a living from it, told Augustine the successes were chance, and gave him a good explanation of why: scatter enough vague statements over a life and some will land. Nebridius argued the same. Augustine kept his books.

Vindicianus gave him the better argument. Vindicianus explained the mechanism, which is the thing that actually generalises. Firminus gave him one anecdote about two babies.

The anecdote worked and the explanation had not.

Augustine notices part of this. He says explicitly that he was persuaded because of the reliability of the person telling him. Not because of the strength of the reasoning: because he trusted Firminus.

That is the fourth time in this series that Augustine has described a belief moving for a social reason while narrating it as a movement of the mind. Part Two noted it about how he joined the Manichees. Part Three noted it about how he left them, and about his mother giving up

her custom for Ambrose. Here it is again, and this time he says the quiet part himself and then continues as though he had not.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The Firminus story is a chain: two fathers observed the births, Firminus was told about it by his father, Firminus told Augustine, and Augustine wrote it down roughly twelve years later. Every link is a report. Nobody in the chain is checkable, including the crucial claim that the births were simultaneous, which rests on two enthusiasts timing an event they wanted to be simultaneous.

What this supports: that Augustine was told this and found it decisive. That much is solid, because it is his own experience.

What it cannot support: that it happened. And it is worth noticing that the story is exactly as vulnerable to Vindicianus's objection as any horoscope is. A striking coincidence, reported by an interested party, with no way to check the measurement.

Some scholars have thought the whole Firminus passage sits oddly in Book Seven and have wondered whether it was inserted later. It is the only narrative interruption in an otherwise dense stretch of philosophy.

None of which affects whether astrology is true. It is not, and Augustine was right. What it affects is the account of how he came to think so, which is the thing this book is actually about.

REMEMBER THIS

Two children were born at the same instant, timed by two obsessive fathers: **Firminus into a leading family, and a slave's child into slavery.** Their lives went opposite ways.

The argument: **identical charts, opposite outcomes.** Augustine turned it on Firminus by pointing out he would have to read contradictory futures from the same data. He added the case of **twins**, which he used for the rest of his life.

This worked. **Vindicianus's better argument had not.** The proconsul had explained the mechanism; Firminus told an anecdote.

Augustine says outright that he was persuaded by **the reliability of the person telling him.** That is the fourth time in this series he has described a belief moving socially while narrating it as reasoning.

The story is itself unverifiable and as vulnerable to coincidence as the horoscopes it refuted. Astrology is still false. The account of how he came to think so is the interesting part.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Obstacle

Augustine could not imagine anything real that was not made of stuff. Until that went, the question he had spent a decade on could not even be asked properly, let alone answered.

7.1 — The sponge in the sea

Book Seven opens with Augustine describing what he actually pictured when he thought about God, and he is unsparing about it. He had stopped imagining God in the shape of a human body. That much Ambrose had given him. But he still could not conceive of anything that existed except as a body of some kind.

So he imagined God as an enormous bright substance, infinite in every direction, seeping through everything that exists the way light or air would.

And then he gives the image he had settled on, which is his own and is very good. Imagine the whole of creation as a sponge, large but finite, floating in a sea that goes on forever. The sea is God. It fills the sponge completely, soaks every part of it, and extends infinitely beyond it in all directions.

IN REAL TERMS

The image is not stupid and it is worth taking seriously for a moment, because it does a great deal of what it needs to.

God is everywhere: the sponge has sea in every pore. God is greater than creation: the sea is infinite and the sponge is not. God is not a thing among things: the sponge is in the sea, not beside it. Creation depends on God completely and God does not depend on creation.

It gets three or four hard things right. The problem is not that the picture is crude. The problem is what it forces to be true next.

7.2 — Why the picture made the question unanswerable

Here is the trap, and it is worth going slowly because everything in the next two chapters depends on seeing it.

If everything that exists is made of some kind of stuff, then evil, if it exists at all, is made of some kind of stuff.

Now ask where that stuff came from. Two answers are available and both are catastrophic.

Either God made it. In which case God made evil, and is the author of it, and is not good.

Or God did not make it. In which case there is something that exists and does not come from God, so God is not the source of everything, and there are two ultimate powers. That is Manichaeism, which he has just left.

There is no third option *as long as the assumption holds*. Augustine had been going round this loop for years. He describes himself as tormented by it, swollen up and shut in, driven by the question and unable to move.

And notice what has actually gone wrong. It is not that he lacks information. It is not that he is reasoning badly; the loop is valid. He is trapped by a premise he does not know he is holding.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT TO BE REAL IS TO BE SOMEWHERE

Augustine's premise is that anything which genuinely exists must occupy space, be made of something, and be located. He did not adopt this after consideration. He says he could not conceive otherwise, which is the mark of an assumption rather than a belief: it is not a position he holds, it is the shape of the room he is thinking in.

It is also, and this is the part worth sitting with, an extremely natural assumption. Everything anybody has ever bumped into is made of stuff. The demand that a real thing be somewhere is not superstition; it is the generalisation of every encounter a person has ever had.

What breaks the loop in Book Seven is not new evidence about God or about evil. It is somebody handing him a way to think about things that are real without being anywhere. Once that is available, the two catastrophic options stop being the only two, and a question that had been unanswerable for a decade becomes answerable in about a page.

The lesson is general and it is why this box is here rather than in the chapter on the answer. A problem that resists every attempt for years is often not a hard problem. It is a problem being asked inside a premise that makes it insoluble, and the work is finding the premise, not finding the answer.

The general form: mistaking the limits of what you can picture for the limits of what there is.

7.3 — Nebridius's question

Before the solution arrives, Augustine records an argument that had already destroyed the Manichee answer for him, and it is worth having because it is clean.

Nebridius had asked, years earlier: what would the race of darkness have done to God, if God had simply refused to fight?

Work it through. The Manichee story is that the powers of Darkness attacked the realm of Light, and that God sent part of himself into the struggle, and that this is how Light got trapped in matter. So ask what the alternative was.

If Darkness could have harmed God, then God is damageable, and a damageable God is not what anybody means by God.

If Darkness could not have harmed God, then there was no reason to fight, and the entire story collapses. Everything that follows from it, including the trapped Light and the whole apparatus of salvation, is unnecessary.

Either way the myth fails. Augustine calls this argument enough on its own to have finished the Manichees, and says so.

But note what it does not do. It removes an answer. It does not supply one. Augustine is now out of the loop he was in and still inside the larger one, with the question intact and nothing to say to it.

7.4 — What he had already worked out

Two pieces were in place before the breakthrough, and they matter for what comes.

He had concluded that the will is free. He says he had come to see that his own will was the reason he did wrong, and that this was as certain to him as his own existence. When he acted against what he judged best, he did it. Nobody else did it in him. That is a direct rejection of the Manichee comfort described in Part Two, where his wrongdoing belonged to a foreign substance.

And he could not make it fit. Because if his will was made by a good God, how did it come to move the wrong way? Every time he tried to explain the bad will he found himself needing something behind it, and then something behind that.

So the position at the end of Chapter Seven is precise. He has lost the Manichee answer. He has accepted responsibility. He cannot explain how responsibility is possible. And he cannot think about any of it except in terms of stuff.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine pictured God as an **infinite sea** with creation as a **sponge** floating in it, soaked through. The image gets several hard things right.

The trap: if everything real is made of stuff, then evil is made of stuff, and either **God made it** (so God is not good) or **God did not** (so there are two powers, which is Manichaeism). There is no third option while the premise holds.

Nebridius's question had already destroyed the Manichee story: if Darkness could harm God, God is damageable; if it could not, there was no reason to fight. Either way it collapses. But that removes an answer without supplying one.

He had already concluded that **his own will** was the cause of his wrongdoing, and could not explain how a will made by a good God moves the wrong way.

He was not short of information and he was not reasoning badly. He was trapped by a premise he did not know he was holding: that to be real is to be somewhere.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Books of the Platonists

Somebody handed him some books. Augustine says they contained almost everything, and lacked one thing. Which books they were is still argued about.

8.1 — What he was given, and by whom

Augustine records it in a single loaded sentence. God procured for him, through a man swollen with monstrous pride, certain books of the Platonists, translated from Greek into Latin.

That is all we get. The man is not named. The books are not named. Both silences have produced a great deal of scholarship.

WORD BOX

The Platonists (Neoplatonism): the philosophical tradition descending from Plato as it existed in the third and fourth centuries. Its central figure was **Plotinus** (about 205 to 270), whose writings were collected by his pupil **Porphyry** into a work called the *Enneads*.

What they taught, in outline: reality descends in levels from a single ultimate source. The source is not a body, is not in space, has no parts, and is beyond description. Below it is Mind, which is where the eternal realities are. Below that is Soul. Below that is the physical world. The way back up is inward: the soul turns away from the senses, into itself, and through itself towards the source. Why it matters: that is a complete, worked-out account of things that are real without being made of anything. It is exactly the tool Augustine was missing.

The translator was almost certainly Marius Victorinus, a distinguished Roman rhetorician who had turned Greek philosophy into Latin and who had himself converted to Christianity late in life. Augustine will tell Victorinus's story at length in Book Eight, and that is where the identification comes from.

8.2 — What he found in them

Augustine describes what he read by quoting the opening of John's gospel and saying, in effect: this was in there. Not in these words, he is careful to add, but this in substance, and supported by many kinds of argument.

What was in there, on his account: that there is an eternal source; that from it comes a Word or Mind through which everything else exists; that this is not a body; that the soul is not the light but bears witness to the light; that the human mind can turn towards it.

That is a startling thing for a Christian bishop to write, and Augustine knew it. He is saying that a substantial part of the highest Christian theology was already present in pagan philosophy, arrived at by argument, without revelation.

8.3 — The turn inward, and upward

And then something happened, and Augustine describes it in the first person and in the past tense as an event.

Warned by the books to return into himself, he entered into his own inmost parts. And there, he says, he saw a light. Not the ordinary light that everyone sees, and not a larger version of it. Something else entirely, above his mind, because it had made his mind.

He says he trembled with love and with dread. He says he heard, as if from a height, the words: I am the food of the fully grown. Grow, and you will feed on me. And you will not change me into yourself the way you change ordinary food into your body. You will be changed into me.

Later in the book he describes a second attempt, in more careful language: a step-by-step ascent from bodies, to the soul that perceives them, to the reasoning power, and beyond it to what simply is. And it arrived, he says, in the flash of one trembling glance. And he could not hold it. He was dragged back down by his own habits.

That is the pattern of Book Seven and it is the whole difference between Book Seven and Book Eight, which is Part Five of this series. He *saw*. He could not *stay*. Knowing the answer turned out not to be the same as being able to live in it, which is the thing the rest of the work is about.

8.4 — The one thing that was not there

Then Augustine lists what he did not find, and the list is the point of the chapter.

He did not read there that the Word became flesh and lived among us. He did not read that he came to his own and his own did not receive him. He did not read that he emptied himself and took the form of a servant and was obedient to death.

In other words: the Platonists had the destination and no road. They could describe the country and could not tell him how to get there, and worse, they made the getting there a matter of intellectual ascent, available to the clever and the disciplined.

Augustine's complaint is that he had tried that and it had not held. He says he was not yet humble enough to hold Christ, and that he had been chattering as though he were expert while actually being unable to sustain what he had glimpsed for more than a moment.

And he records the order, and says the order was providential. He read the Platonists first and Paul afterwards. If he had read Paul first, he says, he might have thought that the philosophers had everything and the scriptures added nothing.

THE ARGUMENT — WHICH BOOKS, AND HOW MUCH DID HE OWE THEM?

Two connected disputes run through the scholarship on this passage, and the second is much larger than the first.

PLOTINUS, AND THE DEBT IS REAL BUT SUBORDINATE

The traditional identification is the *Enneads* of Plotinus, in Victorinus's translation, and the verbal echoes in Book Seven are strong. On this reading Augustine used Platonism as a set of tools — an account of immaterial reality, the inward turn, evil as privation — and put them at the service of a Christianity he had never actually left, since he had been a catechumen since infancy and never abandoned the name of Christ. His own list of what was missing is the decisive evidence: he tells you what the tools could not do.

PORPHYRY MATTERS MORE THAN IS USUALLY ALLOWED

A major twentieth-century line of scholarship, associated above all with Pierre Courcelle, argued that Porphyry — Plotinus's pupil, editor, and a fierce critic of Christianity — was as important or more so, and that the Milan circle around Ambrose was steeped in a specific Platonism whose fingerprints are all over Book Seven. On this view the tidy story of Plotinus plus scripture is too simple, and Augustine is deliberately vague about his sources.

THE EVENTS OF 386 WERE A CONVERSION TO PLATONISM

The strongest version of the sceptical case looks past the books to the year. The works Augustine actually wrote immediately after this, at a country retreat, read like the productions of a Platonising philosopher, not of a man who has undergone the crisis described in Book Eight. On this reading *Confessions*, written a decade later, projects a Christian conversion back onto what was at the time a philosophical one, and it was later immersion in church life and in Paul that made him the Augustine we have.

Where things stand: That the debt is large is agreed by everyone, including Augustine. The identification of the specific texts is genuinely unresolved: the echoes fit Plotinus well, some fit Porphyry, and Augustine names nothing. The third position was fiercely argued through the middle of the twentieth century, and while few now hold its strongest form, it permanently changed how the 386 material is read.

What would settle it: Real evidence has been brought to bear here and can be again: close comparison of Augustine's Latin with the surviving Greek, and with what survives of Victorinus. That work has narrowed the question without closing it. The limiting factor is that Augustine wrote from memory, a decade later, in his own idiom.

Why people care so much: It matters because it decides whether the central figure of Western Christian thought reached his central positions by revelation, by philosophy, or by a combination he was not fully candid about. People with strong commitments in that area tend to have strong views here.

I will say where I stand, since it affects the next chapter. I think the first position is closest to right about the philosophy and that the third is more valuable than its conclusions: it forced everyone to read the 386 material against the works Augustine actually wrote that year, which is exactly the kind of check this series keeps asking for.

REMEMBER THIS

An unnamed man gave him **books of the Platonists**, translated into Latin almost certainly by **Marius Victorinus**. Neither the man nor the books are named.

What the Platonists supplied: a complete account of **things that are real without being made of anything**, and a route back to them that runs inward rather than outward. Exactly the tool he was missing.

He turned inward and **saw a light above his mind**, and heard that he would not change it into himself as with food, but would be changed into it. It came in a flash and **he could not hold it**. What was **not** there: the Word made flesh, and a God who took the form of a servant. The Platonists had the destination and no road, and made arrival a matter of being clever enough.

Which books, and how much he owed them, is genuinely unresolved. He read the Platonists first and Paul second, and says that order was providential.

CHAPTER NINE

Where Evil Comes From

This is the centre of the entire work. Augustine has been asking the question for more than a decade. The answer takes about a page, and it has been argued about ever since.

9.1 — The question, one more time

If God is entirely good, and entirely powerful, and made everything that exists, then where did evil come from? God cannot have made it, because God is good. Nothing exists that God did not make. So evil either does not exist, which is absurd, or it came from somewhere else, which means God is not the source of everything.

The last chapter showed why Augustine could not get out of this. He assumed that to be real is to be made of something, so evil had to be a stuff, and a stuff has to have a maker.

The Platonists removed the assumption. What follows is what he could see once it was gone.

9.2 — First move: everything that exists is good

Augustine starts somewhere that sounds like a pious platitude and is actually the whole argument in compressed form.

Everything that exists is good, precisely insofar as it exists.

His reasoning: God is good and God made everything. A good maker does not produce something bad in its very being. So every thing, considered simply as a thing that is, is good. There is no exception, because there is nothing that God did not make.

Notice what this immediately gets him. If everything that exists is good, then evil cannot be a thing that exists. Not because evil is unreal or unimportant, but because being a thing and being good have turned out to be the same property looked at from two angles.

9.3 — Second move: then what is evil?

The answer is that evil is not a substance. It is a lack. It is the absence of a good that ought to be present in a thing.

WORD BOX

Privation: the technical term for this. A privation is not merely an absence; it is an absence *in something that should have had the thing*. A stone is not blind, because a stone was never going to see. An eye that cannot see is blind, because seeing is what an eye is for.

Why it matters: this distinction does all the work. If evil were merely "absence", then everything would be infinitely evil, since everything lacks countless properties. Evil is a specific kind of absence: a missing good in a thing that is the kind of thing which ought to have it.

Augustine's way of testing it is corruption. Ask what it means for something to go bad.

A thing that is corrupted has lost some good it had. Rust is not something added to iron; it is iron losing its integrity. A wound is not a substance; it is flesh missing what it should have. Illness is not a thing in the body; it is the body's functioning falling away.

And then the test that clinches it for him. If corruption could continue without limit, and take away all the good in a thing, what would be left? Nothing at all. The thing would cease to exist entirely.

So corruption cannot be a substance, because a substance that consumed itself completely would leave a residue, and this leaves nothing. Corruption is the draining away of being, and where being is entirely gone the thing is gone with it.

IN REAL TERMS

The clearest way to hold this is a hole.

A hole is real. You can fall into one. You can measure it, photograph it, and be killed by it. But a hole is not made of anything, and you cannot have a jar of hole. It is a specific absence in something that is made of something.

Nobody asks what factory produces holes, or worries that the existence of holes proves there is an anti-manufacturer working against the road builders. The question does not arise, because a hole is not that kind of item.

Augustine's claim is that evil is that kind of item, and that the entire problem of where it came from arose from treating it as the other kind.

9.4 — Third move: then what is a bad will?

This is where the argument earns its keep, because a rusting nail is one thing and a person choosing to do harm is another.

Augustine's answer is the formula this series has been quoting since Part One, and here at last is the full version of it.

A bad will is not a will aimed at something bad, because there is nothing bad to aim at. Everything that exists is good. A bad will is a will that has turned away from the highest good towards a lower one, and given the lower one the place that belonged to the higher.

Nothing in that account is evil considered by itself. Money is good. Food is good. Another person's body is good. Your own life is good. What is wrong is a *relation*: the order in which those goods are being wanted.

So evil is a privation in the will, in exactly the sense of the word box above. The will was made to be aimed at the highest thing. It is not. That missing orientation is not a substance that got in. It is a good that is not there.

Now go back to the pear theft in Part Two and see what it becomes. Augustine said his theft was a counterfeit of freedom: a real good, badly imitated. He wrote that with this doctrine in hand. And go back to the grief in Part Three: a real good, his friend, given a place that could not hold it. Both episodes are this chapter, told in advance as stories.

9.5 — What the argument achieves

Set out plainly, it does four things.

God is not the author of evil, because evil is not a thing to be authored.

There is no second power, because there is nothing for it to be made of. Manichaeism is not refuted by argument here; it is dissolved, because the thing it was invented to explain turns out not to need explaining in that way.

Responsibility lands on the will, which is where Augustine had already concluded it belonged.

Nothing has to be called bad. This matters more than it looks. Augustine spends the rest of his life insisting that bodies are good, that matter is good, that marriage is good, that the world is good. Every one of those positions is this argument being applied.

9.6 — The objections that will not go away

And now the difficulties, because they are real and the passage is often presented as though it settled everything.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE PRIVATION ACCOUNT OF EVIL WORK?

This is one of the most consequential arguments in the history of Western thought, and it has been under attack for most of that history. Here are the strongest versions of the main objections and of the replies.

IT CANNOT HANDLE SUFFERING

The account works reasonably for wrongdoing, which can plausibly be described as a lack of right ordering. It works badly for pain. A person in agony is not experiencing an absence. Agony is a presence, vivid and specific, and describing a burn as "a privation of bodily integrity" is a redescription that leaves out the entire content of the thing being described. If the theory has to call the worst experiences human beings have "not really anything", something has gone wrong with the theory rather than with the experiences.

IT RELOCATES THE PROBLEM RATHER THAN SOLVING IT

Grant that evil is a privation. The question then becomes why a good and all-powerful God permits privations, and that question is exactly as hard as the one we started with. Nothing has been answered; a noun has been changed into a noun phrase. And on the specific case of the will, the account has a hole Augustine himself circles: if the will was made good by God, what made it turn? Either something caused the turn, in which case the cause needs explaining, or nothing did, in which case it is unintelligible.

IT IS DOING METAPHYSICS, NOT CONSOLATION, AND IT SUCCEEDS AT THAT

The reply is that the objections misidentify the target. Augustine is not explaining why suffering happens or making anybody feel better about it. He is answering one specific question: what kind of item is evil, and does its existence force us to posit a second ultimate power? On that question the argument works and has never been bettered. As for the will, Augustine agrees it is unintelligible, and says so: he argues that a bad will has no efficient cause and that looking for one is like trying to see darkness. That is not evasion. It is the claim that a defect, by definition, does not have a positive explanation.

Where things stand: Almost nobody now thinks privation is a complete theodicy, and Augustine did not claim it was. Most current opinion is that it succeeds as an account of the metaphysical status of evil and fails as an account of why suffering is permitted, and that these were always two questions. The objection about pain has real force and continues to be pressed.

What would settle it: Nothing empirical will settle it, because it is a dispute about what kind of thing evil is and what counts as an explanation. What could shift it, and has, is sustained work on whether the will's turn can be made intelligible without either determinism or randomness. That work is ongoing and is not close to finished.

Why people care so much: The stakes are as large as they get. This argument is the reason Western Christianity is not dualist, the reason the material world is not treated as evil in that tradition, and the background to every subsequent Western attempt to reconcile a good God with a world containing children's hospitals.

There is one further move Augustine makes here that I want to flag rather than defend, because it is the weakest thing in the chapter and it is usually skipped by his admirers.

He argues that things which look evil in isolation fit into the whole, the way a dark patch in a picture contributes to the composition, and that if we could see the whole we would find it good. This is sometimes called the aesthetic defence.

It is, on the face of it, a very bad argument about the suffering of individuals, and it has been criticised as such continuously. A person is not a brushstroke, and telling somebody their agony contributes to the composition is not obviously distinguishable from telling them it does not count. Augustine holds it anyway and returns to it in later works.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT EXPLAINING A THING MEANS SAYING WHAT IT IS MADE OF

Both the question Augustine spent a decade on and the Manichee answer that satisfied him for nine years share a premise: that to explain evil is to identify the stuff it consists of and trace where the stuff came from.

That premise is what generated the problem in the first place. It is also the premise the privation account attacks, and this is why the argument feels either like a revelation or like a cheat depending on which side of it you are standing.

From inside the premise, saying evil is a privation looks like refusing to answer. You asked what it is and were told what it is not. From outside, the question was malformed and the correct response to a malformed question is to show why it cannot be answered as posed.

Notice that this is the same operation as the boxes in Chapter Seven and in Part Two on the pear theft. Three times now, a question that resisted every attempt has turned out to be a question with a bad premise inside it. That is not a coincidence about Augustine. It is what philosophical progress usually looks like, and it is why it so often feels unsatisfying at the moment it happens.

The general form: demanding that every real thing be a kind of stuff.

Which does not decide whether Augustine is right. It explains why the argument in the box above has run for sixteen centuries without either side feeling that the other has engaged with them.

9.7 — Then he read Paul

Book Seven does not end with the argument. It ends with Augustine picking up the letters of Paul, and the last pages are about what he found there that the Platonists had not given him.

He expected to find contradictions. Instead he found, he says, that everything true he had read in the philosophers was said here too, and said with something added.

What was added, on his account, was the diagnosis of his own condition. The Platonists had shown him the country. Paul told him why he could not walk there: that he could see the better and want it and still find another law in himself pulling the other way, and that no amount of seeing would fix it.

That is the exact experience Chapter Eight described — the glimpse he could not hold — turned into a diagnosis. It is also, in advance, the entire subject of Book Eight, which is Part Five of this series.

One further detail belongs here because it is a useful corrective to any impression that Augustine was now sorted out. At this stage he did not understand what Christians actually claimed about Christ. He thought of him as a man of surpassing wisdom, unmatched but not more than that. And Alypius, his closest friend, was under the impression that the Catholic position was that Christ had a human body without a human mind, and could not accept it for that reason. Both of them were arguing with a version of the doctrine that nobody held.

That is the second time in this part that Augustine reports rejecting a position nobody was defending, and he flags it as such. Chapter Four had him ashamed of barking for nine years at a figment. Here he and Alypius are doing it again, in a different direction, at the point where they are supposedly closing in on the truth.

REMEMBER THIS

Move one: **everything that exists is good**, insofar as it exists, because a good God made everything. So evil cannot be a thing that exists.

Move two: **evil is a privation** — a missing good in something that ought to have had it. Corruption drains being away, and a thing drained completely would not exist at all, so corruption is not a substance. **A hole is real and is not made of anything.**

Move three: **a bad will is not aimed at something bad**, because there is nothing bad to aim at. It is a will that has given a lower good the place belonging to a higher one. The fault is in the **order**, not the objects.

What it achieves: God is not the author of evil, there is no second power, responsibility lands on the will, and **nothing has to be called bad** — not bodies, not matter, not the world.

The objections that stand: it handles **wrongdoing** far better than it handles **pain**, and it relocates rather than answers the question of why a good God permits privations. Augustine's further claim that evils fit the beauty of the whole is the weakest thing in Book Seven.

He saw all of this. He could not live in it. That gap is Book Eight.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Two lists, with reasons. And a note on the difference between a gap in the record and a decision by an author, because this part has both and they are not the same thing.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

Which books of the Platonists he read. *Why unknown:* he does not say. The echoes fit Plotinus well and some fit Porphyry, and he was writing from memory a decade later in his own idiom. Close comparison of the Latin with the surviving Greek has narrowed this without closing it.

Who gave them to him. Described only as a man swollen with pride. *Why unknown:* Augustine withheld the name, and the description is an insult, which suggests the withholding was deliberate rather than a lapse.

Whether the experience described in Book Seven happened as an experience. *Why unknown:* he reports an event in the first person. Whether that reports something that occurred in 386 or presents a philosophical position in narrative form cannot be determined from the text, and the works he wrote later that same year read rather differently.

What became of the woman he sent away. *Why unknown:* there is no source for her that does not pass through Augustine, and he wrote four sentences.

The fiancée's name, family, or fate. *Why unknown:* the same. The engagement is broken in Book Eight and she leaves the record entirely.

Whether the Firminus story is true. *Why unknown:* a chain of reports with no checkable link, resting on two enthusiasts timing an event they wanted to be simultaneous.

What surprised Augustine about Ambrose reading. *Why unknown:* he offers three guesses and none is confirmable, and the traditional answer has been substantially undermined.

10.2 — Solid

The chronology. Monica arrives in Milan 385. The marriage arranged and the woman sent away 385. The Platonist books and the Firminus story 386. *Why solid:* internally consistent and anchored by the Milan appointment and by Ambrose's episcopate.

That Ambrose was bishop of Milan and a major political force. *Why solid:* Ambrose is one of the best-documented figures of the century, with a large surviving body of letters, sermons and treatises, and his confrontations with the imperial court are attested from several directions.

That African Christians held meals at martyrs' shrines and that bishops moved against the practice. *Why solid:* attested widely in the period, including in Augustine's own later letters where he deals with it as a bishop himself.

That the gladiatorial games were still running and were in decline. *Why solid:* legal restrictions on them survive, and the general trajectory is documented independently.

That the legal minimum age of marriage for girls was twelve, and that betrothal before it was ordinary. *Why solid:* Roman law on this is explicit and survives, and the practice is attested across many families.

That concubinage was a recognised arrangement with no legal standing for the woman. *Why solid:* documented in Roman legal sources independently of Augustine entirely.

That Marius Victorinus translated Platonist works into Latin and converted to Christianity. *Why solid:* Victorinus is independently attested, some of his own writing survives, and a public statue of him is recorded.

That the privation account of evil is Augustine's and became the standard Western position. *Why solid:* it is set out at length in many of his works and its reception is traceable through a thousand years of subsequent writing.

10.3 — A gap and a decision are not the same thing

One closing distinction, because this part contains both kinds and confusing them produces bad readings in opposite directions.

A gap is where nobody wrote anything down. We do not know what happened to most people who lived in the fourth century, and nothing follows from that about anybody's intentions. That is the situation with, for instance, the exact identity of the Platonist texts: Augustine had no reason to be precise and every reason to be brief.

A decision is where an author who could have written something did not. The woman has no name. The fiancée has no name. The friend in Book Four had no name. The man who supplied the books that changed his life has no name, and gets an insult instead. That is four, in a work of enormous length by a writer who names doctors, officials, and men he never met.

The distinction matters because the two invite different responses. A gap invites patience and better evidence. A decision invites the question of why, and that question is legitimate, and asking it is not the same as accusing anybody of anything.

I do not know why. I have not found an explanation that covers all four cases, and I am suspicious of the ones that cover two. What I am confident of is that it is a pattern, that a pattern in a text this controlled is authorial, and that noticing it is part of reading the book properly rather than a modern grievance imported into it.

REMEMBER THIS

We do not know which Platonist books he read, who gave them to him, whether the Book Seven experience happened as an experience, what became of the woman or the fiancée, or whether the Firminus story is true.

We do know the chronology, that **Ambrose** and **Victorinus** are independently attested with surviving writings, that the martyrs' shrine meals and the games and the marriage law are all documented outside Augustine, and that the **privation account** is his and became the Western standard.

A **gap** is where nobody wrote anything down. A **decision** is where an author who could have written something did not. This part contains both and they are not the same.

Four people who mattered are unnamed: the dead friend, the woman, the fiancée, and the man who gave him the books. In a work this controlled, that is authorial. I have not found an explanation that covers all four.

Timeline

This part is better anchored than the previous ones, because several of the people in it are independently documented. Where a date is uncertain, it says so.

Date	Event	Where it appears
384	Augustine takes the public chair of rhetoric at Milan and meets Ambrose.	Book V
385	Monica crosses to Milan. She finds him neither Manichee nor Catholic, and is calm about it.	Book VI
385	She gives up the African custom of meals at the martyrs' shrines because Ambrose has forbidden it.	Book VI
385	Augustine watches Ambrose reading in silence, and cannot get the private conversation he wants.	Book VI
385	The panegyric for the emperor, and the drunk beggar in the street.	Book VI
recalled	Alypius: the chariot races at Carthage, the arrest in Rome, the refused bribe, and the gladiatorial games. Undated in the text.	Book VI
385	Nebridius leaves his estate near Carthage and comes to Milan to join the search.	Book VI
385	A marriage is arranged. The girl is about two years under the legal minimum of twelve.	Book VI
385	The woman Augustine has lived with for over a decade is sent back to Africa. She leaves their son with him. He takes another woman.	Book VI
385	The plan for ten friends to withdraw and live in common collapses over the question of wives.	Book VI
386	Firminus tells the story of the two births. Augustine abandons astrology for good.	Book VII
386	An unnamed man gives him books of the Platonists in Latin translation, almost certainly by Marius Victorinus.	Book VII
Date	Event	Where it appears
386	The turn inward, and the light above his mind, glimpsed and not held.	Book VII

Date	Event	Where it appears
386	The answer: evil is not a substance but a privation. He then reads Paul.	Book VII
—	Part Five starts here: Book VIII — the garden in Milan, and the difference between seeing an answer and being able to live in it.	—

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Terms carried over from earlier parts are repeated so this part stands alone.

Term	What it means
Alypius	Augustine's pupil and closest friend, from Thagaste. Present at the garden in Book VIII, baptised with him, later a bishop.
Ambrose	Bishop of Milan from 374 and one of the most powerful men in the western empire. He baptised Augustine in 387.
Catechumen	Someone enrolled in the church for instruction but not baptised. Augustine was one from infancy and again from 384.
Concubinatus	A recognised, usually monogamous household between a man and a woman who did not marry, most often because of unequal rank. Legally weightless for the woman.
Corruption	In Augustine's argument, the loss of a good a thing already had. Not something added to the thing.
Firminus	The friend whose account of two simultaneous births finally destroyed astrology for Augustine.
Gladiatorial games	Public spectacles built on watching men fight and die. Still running in the 380s and in legal decline.
Marius Victorinus	The Roman rhetorician who translated Platonist works into Latin and converted to Christianity late in life. Almost certainly the translator Augustine read.
Nebridius	The friend who argued against astrology and who left his estate to follow Augustine to Milan.
Neoplatonism	The philosophical tradition descending from Plato as it stood in the third and fourth centuries: reality in levels from a single immaterial source, reached by turning inward.
Panegyric	A formal public speech of praise for an emperor or official. A recognised form with a loose relationship to truth.
Plotinus	About 205 to 270. The central Neoplatonist thinker, whose writings were collected by Porphyry into the <i>Enneads</i> .
Porphyry	Plotinus's pupil and editor, and a formidable critic of Christianity. How much Augustine read of him is disputed.

Term	What it means
Privation	A missing good in something that ought to have had it. Not a mere absence: a stone is not blind, an eye can be.
Substance	A thing that exists in its own right, rather than as a feature of something else. Augustine's claim is that evil is not one.
Testimony	Belief that comes from being told rather than from checking. Augustine noticed he ran his whole life on it while demanding proof of religion alone.
Theodicy	The attempt to reconcile the existence of evil and suffering with a good and all-powerful God. Augustine's privation argument is part of one, not the whole of one.

About the Author

This series is read and explained by **Lovepreet Singh**, and published as part of **The Living Archive** at misterlove.in.

The Living Archive takes difficult material and rebuilds it so that anyone can follow it, without dropping the hard parts along the way. Its first series was a fourteen-part history of Punjab running to around nine hundred and fifty pages. This is its second.

I read the book, I did the reading around it, and I wrote down what I found. I am not a specialist in late antiquity and I am not going to pretend to be one. Where a question is genuinely contested among people who are, I have said so and given each side its strongest case rather than choosing for you. Where I could not find out, I have written that I could not find out.

The method used here was worked out on the Punjab series and is written up as a portable specification, so that any part of this work can be checked, continued or rebuilt by somebody else. That is the point of an archive that calls itself living.

[Editorial note, to be replaced before publishing: the method requires a one-line statement of the author's own position with regard to religious material, placed where readers will see it. This is the only field in the document still unfilled.]

The Living Archive

The Living Archive is a method for writing hard things simply without making them shallow. It was developed by Lovepreet Singh and tested on a fourteen-part history of Punjab. It runs on three rules.

One. Simplification is not compression. The simple version is usually longer than the difficult one. Words are being spent to buy comprehension.

Two. Two dials, turned in opposite directions. Language as simple as it can be made. Content as deep as the subject actually goes. Turning both down produces something readable and useless.

Three. Every side gets its strongest case, and where nothing settles a question, that gets said. A verdict that honestly reports a deadlock is worth more than a tidy answer that is not true.

A word on sources

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record rather than new primary research, and it is written for readers who want to understand a book, not for specialists who want to check my workings.

What the archive is good at here: this is the best-anchored part of the series so far. Ambrose, Victorinus, Plotinus and Porphyry all left writings that survive, so Augustine's reports about them can be tested against the sources rather than merely believed. Roman marriage law, concubinage, the games and the shrine meals are all documented independently.

What it is bad at here: the two most consequential passages in this part are the least checkable. The sending away of the woman rests on four sentences by the man who did it, and the vision in Book Seven rests on a first-person report written a decade later. Where a claim in this document rests only on Augustine's account of himself, I have tried to say so in the text.

On translations: all renderings of Augustine in this document are my own plain-English paraphrases, made deliberately loose so that they explain rather than reproduce. They are not quotations from any published translation and should not be cited as such. Where the exact wording matters, go to a proper edition. This applies with particular force to Chapter Five, where the precise wording carries a great deal of the argument and every translator has made choices.

Corrections are welcome and will be acted on. Later editions will record what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Five covers Book Eight, on its own, because it is the most famous chapter of the most famous religious autobiography ever written and it deserves the room. It runs about two months in 386. These are the questions it takes on.

- Augustine now knows the answer. Why can he not act on it, and what exactly is stopping him?
- What does he mean when he says he had two wills, and that neither was fully his?
- Why does a book about one man's conversion contain three other people's conversion stories first?
- Who was Victorinus, the old professor who translated the books that changed Augustine's life, and why is his story told at such length?
- What is the most quoted prayer in the book — "give me chastity, but not yet" — actually asking for?
- What happened in the garden, what was the voice, and what did he read?
- And the question that decides how you read the entire work: did it happen the way he says it did?

That last one is not a hostile question and this series will not treat it as one. It is the central scholarly dispute about *Confessions*, it has been running for a century, and both sides are held by serious people.

End of Part 4 of 9

The Living Archive · The Confessions, Explained

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART 5 OF 9

The Confessions, Explained

Part Five — The Garden

*Book Eight alone: a man who knows the answer and cannot move,
four other people's conversions told before his own, and the
most famous scene in the most famous religious book ever written.*

READ AND EXPLAINED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

Parts One to Four covered Books One to Seven. Here is what you need. This part stands on its own.

The man. Born 354 in Roman North Africa, educated at his family's expense towards a career as a professional public speaker. By 384 he held the public chair of rhetoric in Milan, the city where the western emperor lived. He wrote this book in his early forties, around 397 to 400, about eleven years after the events in it.

The book. *Confessio* means three things at once: confessing sin, confessing faith, and confessing praise. This is a prayer, addressed to God throughout, and you are overhearing it.

The story so far. Nine years with the Manichees, a religion teaching two eternal powers of Light and Darkness, which had the advantage of answering the question of where evil comes from and the further advantage of making his own wrongdoing not really his. It collapsed. He drifted through scepticism to Milan, where the bishop Ambrose showed him that scripture could be read figuratively and that the church did not teach the crude doctrines he had spent a decade attacking.

Book Seven, which matters most here. Someone gave him books of the Platonists in Latin translation, and they broke the assumption that had trapped him: that anything real must be made of stuff. Once that went, the answer arrived. Evil is not a substance at all. It is a **privation**, a missing good in something that ought to have had it, and a bad will is not aimed at something bad but has given a lower good the place belonging to a higher one. He also turned inward and glimpsed something above his own mind, in what he calls the flash of one trembling glance.

And he could not hold it. That is the whole of Book Eight. He knows the answer. He cannot move. Part Four ended by promising that the gap between seeing an answer and being able to live in it is what this part is about.

One other thread runs in. In Book Six his partner of over a decade, whom he never names, was sent back to Africa so that he could make an advantageous marriage. He took another woman while waiting. The engagement is still standing when Book Eight opens, and it does not survive it.

A Reminder About the Boxes

Six kinds of box run through this series. **Word Box** explains a hard term the moment it first appears. **In Real Terms** turns something abstract into something you can picture. **How We Actually Know This** names the evidence and says what it cannot show. **The Argument** is for places where experts genuinely disagree, and gives each side its strongest case. **The Hidden Assumption** digs out the premise everybody is quietly taking for granted. **Remember This** closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

Three Things to Watch For

Book Eight is short and this part is long, because almost nothing in it can be summarised without losing the thing that makes it work. Three threads.

One. Book Eight is made out of other people. Before Augustine tells you what happened to him, he tells you what happened to Victorinus, to Antony in the Egyptian desert, and to two civil servants in a garden at Trier. That is most of the book. It is not background and it is not padding, and Chapter Three is about why.

Two. The problem has changed shape. Books One to Seven were about not knowing. Book Eight is about knowing and not doing, which is a different problem and, on Augustine's account, a much worse one. Everything he writes about the will for the next forty years starts here.

Three. The most famous scene in the book may not have happened as described. That is not a hostile claim and this series will not treat it as one. It is the central scholarly dispute about *Confessions*, it has been running since 1888, and Chapter Nine gives it a full hearing with all three main positions at full strength.

Contents

Chapter One — Knowing, and Not Moving

Where he stands · bound by his own iron will · what was actually holding him · and the old man he went to see

Chapter Two — The Old Professor Who Had a Statue

Victorinus of Rome · "is it walls that make Christians?" · the public profession · and the law that cost him his school

Chapter Three — Why a Book About One Conversion Contains Four

The count · the structure · and the argument underneath it about how this sort of thing actually travels

Chapter Four — Ponticianus, the Courtiers, and Antony

A visitor notices a book on the table · a monk in the Egyptian desert · a monastery nobody had mentioned · and two men who changed their lives in an afternoon

Chapter Five — "Give Me Chastity, But Not Yet"

The most quoted prayer in the book · what it is actually asking for · and why it is not a joke

Chapter Six — The Two Wills

The chain from choice to necessity · why the body obeys and the mind does not · and what a divided self actually is

Chapter Seven — Against the Manichees One Last Time

Two wills do not mean two natures · the argument from five wills · and whether the account holds together

Chapter Eight — The Garden

The scene · the voices of his old habits · Contenance · and the fig tree

Chapter Nine — Tolle Lege

The voice · the detail nobody smooths over · what he read · Alypius · and the question of whether it happened

Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Genuinely unknown · solid · and what changed in his life the following week

Reference

Timeline · glossary · about the author · a word on sources · what comes next

CHAPTER ONE

Knowing, and Not Moving

Book Eight opens with a man who has been given everything he asked for and cannot use any of it. This is the state the whole book is about.

1.1 — The position

By the opening of Book Eight, Augustine has what he spent eleven years looking for. He is certain that God exists, and that God is not a body stretched through space. He is certain that evil is not a substance. He has the answer to the question that held him for a decade. He is no longer in doubt about anything that had been in doubt.

And he cannot act on it.

He is emphatic about the shape of this and it is worth having exactly, because it is what makes Book Eight different from everything before it. The problem is no longer that he does not know what is true. The problem is that knowing has turned out not to move him, and he did not expect that.

His image for it is the sharpest thing in the opening pages. He says he was bound, and that he was not bound by somebody else's iron. He was bound by his own iron will.

IN REAL TERMS

The distinction matters and it is easy to skim.

A prisoner in chains has an external problem. Remove the chains and the problem is solved, and while the chains are on, the prisoner and the chains are two different things.

Augustine is describing something else: the thing holding him is not separate from him. It is a part of him, doing what it wants, and what it wants is not what he wants. There is nothing to unlock and nobody to release him.

1.2 — What was actually holding him

Augustine names two things, and readers have disagreed for centuries about which was really operative.

The first is sex. He is direct about it. He says he was still held fast by a woman, and that he could not imagine living without what he calls the embraces of a woman. This is the strand that dominates the popular memory of Book Eight.

The second is his career. He was a public official with a chair, a reputation and a marriage arranged for advantage. Turning to the life he was contemplating meant giving all of that up, and in Book Nine he does exactly that: he resigns the chair. He is also explicit in Book Six that ambition was the machine he was living inside.

And there is a third that he does not name as an obstacle but which is visible throughout, which is pride: the difficulty for a professional intellectual of submitting to something he has not worked out for himself.

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT WAS ACTUALLY HOLDING HIM BACK?

How you answer this decides what kind of book Book Eight is. It is one of the oldest disagreements about *Confessions* and it is not settled.

SEX, AS HE SAYS

Augustine says it repeatedly and in the plainest terms available to him. The prayer he quotes against himself asks for chastity and not yet. The scene in the garden has his old habits personified as women plucking at his clothes. The resolution he reaches is a vow of continence. If a writer tells you four times what the problem is, in a book whose declared purpose is to accuse himself, the burden is on anyone who wants it to be something else.

THE CAREER, WITH SEX AS THE PRESENTABLE VERSION

Look at what actually changed. He did not merely stop sleeping with anyone. He resigned a prestigious public post, cancelled an advantageous marriage, and left the profession his family had impoverished itself to buy him. That is the expensive part, and the marriage he was giving up was itself the vehicle of the career. Sexual struggle is a respectable thing for a bishop to confess and ambition is not, so the one gets four mentions and the other gets one.

THE DISTINCTION IS MODERN AND DOES NOT FIT

A third reading: separating these is our habit, not his. In the world Augustine was in, the marriage was the career; a wife with money was the mechanism of advancement, which is exactly why the woman of Book Six had to go. Asking whether he was held by sex or by ambition assumes two independent forces where there was one arrangement. What he was giving up was a whole way of being a person of his class, and it had a sexual component and a financial component because that is what such a life was made of.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes what he gave up. What is disputed is what the language of Book Eight is emphasising and why. The third reading has gained ground and does the most to explain why the sexual and professional strands are so tangled in the text.

What would settle it: Very little would settle it. His works from the following months talk a great deal about the philosophical life and comparatively little about sex, which is suggestive in the second reading's favour, and which is also exactly what one would expect from a different genre written for a different audience.

Why people care so much: It matters because Augustine's writing on sexuality shaped Western thought for fifteen centuries, and how much of that grew out of this particular struggle is a question people care about intensely.

I lean towards the third position and will write from it, and you should discount accordingly. What I will not do is quietly drop the sexual material, which is in the text at full volume and which any honest account has to carry.

1.3 — The old man he went to see

Unable to move, Augustine went for advice. Not to Ambrose, who as Part Four explained was unreachable. He went to an old man named Simplicianus.

WORD BOX

Simplicianus: an elderly priest in Milan who had been Ambrose's own teacher and had baptised him. He was steeped in Platonist philosophy as well as in Christianity, and he later succeeded Ambrose as bishop of Milan.

Why it matters: this is the ideal person for Augustine to be sent to, and the choice is not accidental. Simplicianus could speak both of the languages Augustine had — philosophy and Christianity — and unlike Ambrose he had time. Augustine corresponded with him for years afterwards, which he never did with Ambrose.

Augustine told him where he had got to, and in particular that he had been reading books of the Platonists in the Latin translation made by Marius Victorinus.

Simplicianus congratulated him on having found those books rather than others, and then, on hearing the name Victorinus, told him a story.

That is the pivot of the entire book. Augustine came for an argument and was given an anecdote about somebody else, and it worked.

REMEMBER THIS

Book Eight opens with Augustine **certain of everything he had doubted** and unable to act on any of it. Knowing has turned out not to move him.

He was bound, he says, **not by another man's iron but by his own iron will**. The thing holding him is not separate from him, so there is nothing to unlock.

He names **sex** as the obstacle and gave up a **career, a chair and a marriage**. Which was really operative is genuinely disputed, and the third answer — that in his world the marriage *was* the career — does the most work.

He went for help to **Simplicianus**, an old priest who had taught and baptised Ambrose, and who knew both philosophy and Christianity.

He came for an argument and was told a story about somebody else. That is the shape of the whole book.

CHAPTER TWO

The Old Professor Who Had a Statue

Marius Victorinus was the most eminent teacher of rhetoric in Rome, an old man, a defender of the traditional gods, and a translator of the very books that had just changed Augustine's life.

2.1 — Who he was

Victorinus was African by birth, like Augustine. He had gone to Rome and become the state professor of rhetoric there: the summit of the profession Augustine was currently in, several rungs above the chair at Milan. He taught the sons of senators. He wrote on grammar, rhetoric and logic, produced commentaries on Cicero and Aristotle, and translated Greek philosophy into Latin.

And in 354, the year Augustine was born, a statue of him was put up in the Forum of Trajan, in Rome, while he was still alive.

IN REAL TERMS

A public statue in a Roman forum, erected in your lifetime, at public expense, is not an honour with a modern equivalent that quite matches it.

It is closer to having a building named after you while you are still teaching in it, in the capital city, by the decision of the state. It was rare, and it was the formal recognition that you were the best in the empire at what you did.

And it is worth registering the coincidence Augustine does not point out: the statue went up in the year he was born, and the man it honoured held the job he was chasing.

Victorinus had also worshipped the old Roman gods, and defended them publicly, for most of a long life. His social world was the senatorial aristocracy of Rome, which was the last serious stronghold of traditional Roman religion.

2.2 — "Is it walls that make Christians?"

In extreme old age, Victorinus began reading the Christian scriptures and studying them closely.

And then he said to Simplicianus, privately, that he was already a Christian.

Simplicianus refused to accept it. He said he would not believe it, and would not count Victorinus among Christians, until he saw him in a church.

Victorinus laughed at him and asked whether it is walls, then, that make Christians.

This exchange repeated more than once, and Augustine reports it as a joke that was not a joke. Victorinus meant it. He had accepted the content and did not see why the building mattered.

Augustine explains what was actually going on, and he does it without malice. Victorinus was afraid of offending his friends: proud, powerful men at the top of Roman society, from whose height he expected the hostility to fall on him heavily.

2.3 — The public profession

Then something changed, and Augustine's account of the mechanism is very precise.

Victorinus came to be more afraid of one thing than of the other. He concluded that a man ashamed to acknowledge Christ in front of people would be disowned in turn.

He said abruptly to Simplicianus: let us go to the church, I want to be made a Christian. He was enrolled for instruction, and then gave in his name for baptism.

Rome, Augustine says, was astonished, and the church was delighted.

The clergy offered him a concession. It was normal, for people who found the public ceremony frightening, to make the profession of faith privately instead. Victorinus refused. He chose the public form and stood up in front of the congregation to recite the creed.

And Augustine records the sound of the room. As he went up, people who knew who he was murmured his name to each other, and the murmur ran round: Victorinus, Victorinus. Then, wanting to hear him, they went instantly quiet.

That detail — the noise, then the silence — is the kind of thing that gets into a book because somebody who was there described it, and it is the most vivid moment in the chapter.

2.4 — The law that cost him his school

And then Simplicianus added the piece that finished the story.

Years later, the emperor Julian issued a law about who could teach.

WORD BOX

Julian's teaching law (17 June 362): the emperor Julian, who had abandoned Christianity and was attempting to restore the traditional cults, required that appointments of public teachers be approved by the town council and by the emperor. Its practical effect, reinforced by Julian's own arguments, was to push Christians out of teaching the classical literature that the curriculum was built on.

Why it matters: it forced a choice on every Christian teacher in the empire. Victorinus, by then a very old man at the top of the profession, closed his school rather than comply.

Augustine's comment on this is short and it is the point of the whole chapter as far as he is concerned: Victorinus gave up his school of words rather than give up the Word.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Unusually for this series, most of this can be checked outside Augustine.

Jerome, writing independently, records Victorinus as a distinguished rhetorician, notes the statue in Trajan's Forum, and says he became a Christian in extreme old age. Julian's law survives in the imperial legal code with its date. Victorinus's own Christian theological writings survive and can be read. An inscription indicates the statue was still standing two generations later.

What that supports: the man, the eminence, the statue, the late conversion, the law, and the resignation. Four independent lines converging is about as good as this period gets.

What it cannot support: the conversations. The exchange about walls, the offer of a private profession, and the murmur running round the congregation come to us through Simplicianus, retold by Augustine eleven years later. They are the parts that make the story live and they are the parts nobody can check.

2.5 — Why this story, to this man

Augustine tells you plainly what it did to him. He says he burned to imitate Victorinus, and adds that this was exactly why Simplicianus had told him.

It is worth listing what the two men had in common, because Simplicianus clearly had.

Both African. Both professional teachers of rhetoric. Both attached to a public career that a conversion would damage. Both frightened of what their circle would say. Both intellectually convinced well before they were able to act. And, most pointedly, Augustine had reached his intellectual conviction by reading books that Victorinus himself had translated.

Simplicianus did not give Augustine an argument, because Augustine did not need one and would have enjoyed one too much. He gave him a picture of himself, aged and in Rome, having done it.

REMEMBER THIS

Marius Victorinus was the state professor of rhetoric in Rome, honoured with a **statue in Trajan's Forum in 354**, the year Augustine was born, and a defender of the traditional Roman gods.

In extreme old age he told Simplicianus privately that he was already a Christian, and asked, when pressed to come to church, whether it is **walls that make Christians**. What held him was fear of his powerful friends.

When he moved, he moved publicly: **offered a private profession and refusing it**. Augustine records the congregation murmuring his name and then going silent to hear him.

When **Julian's law of 362** forced the issue, he closed his school rather than comply. He gave up his school of words rather than the Word.

Simplicianus told this story on purpose. Augustine did not need an argument. He needed a picture of himself, older, having already done it.

CHAPTER THREE

Why a Book About One Conversion Contains Four

Most of Book Eight is about other people. That is a structural fact worth stopping on, because it is also an argument, and Augustine never states it directly.

3.1 — The count

Book Eight is short. Here is what is actually in it, in order. Augustine describes his own condition. Then Simplicianus tells him the story of Victorinus. Then Augustine reflects on that. Then Ponticianus arrives and tells him about Antony of Egypt, and about two civil servants at Trier. Then Augustine reflects on that. Then, at the very end, the garden.

Count the conversions. Victorinus. Antony. The first courtier. The second courtier. Their two fiancées, who are mentioned in a single clause. Then Augustine, and then Alypius.

Augustine's own conversion, the thing the book is famous for, occupies the final section. Most of the book is other people's.

That is not an accident of composition. Book Eight is the only book in the work built almost entirely out of specific recalled scenes, and it is arranged so that the reader arrives at the garden having already watched five other people go through the door.

3.2 — The mechanism he keeps describing

Look at how each of these actually happens, because the pattern is consistent and it is not the pattern you would expect from a book about the search for truth.

Victorinus was moved by reading, and then by Simplicianus refusing to let him keep it private.

Antony walked into a church, heard a gospel sentence being read aloud, took it as addressed to him, and went to the desert.

The first courtier at Trier picked up a book about Antony and changed his life over the course of an afternoon.

The second courtier was moved by watching the first.

The fiancées were moved on hearing what the two men had done.

Augustine is moved by hearing about all of them, and then by a sentence he reads.

Alypius is moved by watching Augustine, and reads the next line.

Nobody in this chain is argued into anything. Every single one of them is moved by an encounter with a person or with a text, and in most cases by an encounter with a person who was moved by a text.

IN REAL TERMS

What Augustine has built, without saying so, is a diagram of transmission.

A man in the Egyptian desert hears a sentence in a church. Somebody writes his life down. The book reaches a garden in Trier, in what is now Germany, where a civil servant reads it. He tells a colleague, who tells Ponticianus, who tells Augustine in Milan. Augustine writes it down, and you are reading it.

That is seven links across three continents and about sixty years, and every link is one person telling another. Book Eight is a chapter about how this sort of thing moves, told in a form that demonstrates it.

3.3 — The digression about joy

Between the Victorinus story and the Ponticianus visit, Augustine stops and asks a question that looks like a detour and is not.

Why is there more joy over one thing recovered than over ninety-nine that were never lost? He is quoting a parable, and he decides to take the question literally.

His answer is a general principle about pleasure, and it is one of the more quietly acute things in the book. Joy, he says, is proportioned to the danger or the difficulty that preceded it, and this is true everywhere, not only in religion.

His examples are ordinary and he piles them up. A victory is sweeter when the fighting was harder. A storm at sea frightens the sailors and threatens them with death, and then arriving safely is a delight nobody feels on a calm crossing. A friend is dangerously ill and recovers, and the joy at his walking about is greater than any pleasure he gave when he was well. Even eating and drinking, he adds, are only pleasant because of the discomfort of hunger and thirst that came first.

IN REAL TERMS

Test it against something small. A seat on a train is not a pleasure. A seat on a train after twenty minutes of standing is.

Nothing about the seat changed. What changed is what preceded it, and the amount of pleasure it produces is set almost entirely by that.

Augustine's claim is that this is not a quirk of comfort but the general shape of human pleasure, and that it explains something otherwise strange: why the return of a thing you already had can be a greater joy than having it was.

He then applies it to himself, and the application is the reason the digression is here. If joy is proportioned to the preceding difficulty, then the length and wretchedness of his own delay is not simply waste. It is the thing that will make the arrival worth what it is.

Whether that is consolation or rationalisation is left for the reader. What is worth taking is the observation itself, which does not depend on the theology and which is checkable by anybody.

3.4 — What this means for the famous scene

One consequence is worth naming now rather than in Chapter Nine, because it changes how the garden reads.

By the time Augustine gets to the fig tree, the reader has been shown four people who heard something and acted. The scene does not arrive as a bolt from nowhere. It arrives as the last item in a series, and the series has taught you what to expect.

Whether that is careful construction or careful reporting is exactly the question Chapter Nine takes up. But notice that Augustine has made his own experience the least surprising thing in the book, which is an odd thing to do if the point were to impress you with it.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A CONVERSION HAPPENS INSIDE ONE PERSON

The whole modern vocabulary for this treats it as an internal event. A person weighs the evidence, or has an experience, and something changes in them. Other people may supply information beforehand, but the event itself happens in one head, and that is where we look for it.

Augustine's own account keeps failing to fit that shape. Victorinus was convinced long before he moved, and what moved him was another man refusing to accept a private version. The second courtier had no experience of his own; he had his friend. The fiancées appear in one clause and are moved by hearing. Alypius converts by watching Augustine and reading the next line down.

What the book actually depicts is something closer to a change of company: people moving from one set of people to another, with the reasons arriving alongside rather than in front.

This series has now noted that four times, in Parts Two, Three, Four and here. What is different in Book Eight is that Augustine has structured an entire book around it, and still narrates his own case as a private drama between himself and God with a friend sitting some distance away.

The general form: locating in one person an event that happens between several.

That is not a claim that Augustine was wrong about what happened to him. It is a claim about the shape of the container he put it in, and it is worth carrying into the next six chapters.

REMEMBER THIS

Book Eight contains **at least seven conversions**, and Augustine's own is the last and occupies only the final section. Most of the book is other people.

The pattern is consistent: **nobody is argued into anything**. Each person is moved by an encounter with a text or with a person, and usually by a person who was moved by a text.

The chain runs from a church in Egypt, through a book, to a garden in Trier, to Milan, to the page in front of you. **Seven links, three continents, sixty years.**

By the time the reader reaches the fig tree, four people have already done something similar. Augustine has made his own experience the **least surprising thing in the book**.

He built a whole book demonstrating that this travels between people, and then narrated his own case as a private drama.

CHAPTER FOUR

Ponticianus, the Courtiers, and Antony

A senior official drops in, notices a book on the table, and by the time he leaves he has taken Augustine apart without meaning to.

4.1 — The visit

A man called Ponticianus came to see Augustine and Alypius at their lodging. He was a fellow African and a Christian, and he held high office at the imperial court. He had some matter of business with them, and they sat down together.

And he noticed a book lying on the gaming table in front of them.

He picked it up, opened it, and found it was the letters of Paul. He was surprised. He had assumed it would be one of the texts Augustine taught for a living: a rhetorician's book, technical, professional.

That small moment is the trigger for everything that follows. Ponticianus smiled, looked at Augustine, and began to talk about Christian things because a book had told him he could.

Augustine wants you to notice the accident. He had been reading Paul lately, as Book Seven ended. The book happened to be out. A visitor happened to look at it. Nothing was intended by anyone.

4.2 — Antony

Ponticianus started talking about a monk in Egypt named Antony, whose name, he said, was famous among Christians.

Augustine and Alypius had never heard of him.

WORD BOX

Antony of Egypt (roughly 251 to 356): a Christian who gave away his property and went to live alone in the Egyptian desert, and who became the most famous example of that way of life. A biography of him written shortly after his death, and translated into Latin, circulated widely and was enormously influential.

Monasticism: the practice of withdrawing from ordinary society, alone or in community, to live under a religious discipline. In the fourth century it was new, spreading fast, and to educated Romans it looked extreme.

Why it matters: what Antony represents is not an argument. It is a demonstration that the life is livable, by somebody who did it. That is exactly the thing Augustine did not have.

The origin of Antony's own decision is the detail that will matter in Chapter Nine, so hold on to it. Antony walked into a church while a passage of the gospel was being read aloud, heard the sentence about selling everything and following, took it as addressed personally to him, and did it.

A sentence heard by chance, taken as an instruction. Augustine will do the same thing before the book is over, and will say so.

4.3 — The monastery nobody had mentioned

Ponticianus went on, and told them about monasteries, and about communities of people living this way in the deserts.

And then he mentioned that there was a monastery in Milan, outside the city walls, full of good men, under Ambrose's care.

Augustine and Alypius had not known about it either.

That is a strange thing to be true, and Augustine reports it as strange. He had been in Milan for over a year. He attended Ambrose's sermons regularly. He was actively looking for a way to live, and there was a house of people living that way, run by the bishop whose preaching he went to hear, just outside the gate.

THE ARGUMENT — HAD THEY REALLY NEVER HEARD OF ANY OF THIS?

Augustine's ignorance here is the hinge of the scene: Ponticianus can only shatter him because he is bringing news. Several scholars have found the ignorance hard to believe.

IT IS IMPLAUSIBLE AND THE SCENE IS SHAPED

Augustine had lived in Milan for over a year, attended the cathedral, and was searching in earnest. Ambrose was actively promoting the ascetic life and preaching on it. Monasticism was the great religious movement of the age and its literature was circulating in Latin. That a professional intellectual in the imperial capital, plugged into the bishop's congregation, had heard nothing of Antony or of a monastery at the gates is difficult to accept. The ignorance is doing narrative work: it makes Ponticianus a messenger and makes the news a blow.

IT IS ENTIRELY PLAUSIBLE

Augustine was a busy public official with a demanding post, a household, a mother, a fiancée and a philosophical crisis. He attended sermons, in a large crowd, to hear a man he could never get a private word with. Nothing in that guarantees exposure to a specific Egyptian monk or an awareness of who was living in a house outside the walls. People routinely do not know about institutions in their own city. And the whole force of the scene, as Augustine tells it, is shame at his own ignorance, which is not a flattering thing to invent.

HE IS REPORTING A DIFFERENT KIND OF IGNORANCE

A third reading holds that "we had never heard" need not mean the names had never reached him. It can mean he had never taken it in — had heard and filed it as something other people did, and only now registered it as a live option for a man like himself. That is an ordinary experience and it is compatible with both the text and the historical background.

Where things stand: The historical background is not in doubt: monasticism was widespread, Ambrose promoted it, and the literature was circulating. What is disputed is what Augustine's sentence claims and how literally to take it.

What would settle it: Nothing decisive. Ambrose's surviving sermons show his ascetic interests clearly, which sharpens the problem without solving it, since we cannot know which sermons Augustine attended.

Why people care so much: It matters as a test case. If a plainly reported fact in Book Eight turns out to be shaped for effect, that bears directly on the much larger question about the garden in Chapter Nine.

4.4 — The two men in the garden at Trier

Then Ponticianus told them the story that actually did the damage, and it is the best-constructed thing in Book Eight.

He had been at Trier, in the emperor's service. One afternoon the court went to the games, and he and three colleagues went out walking in gardens near the city wall.

WORD BOX

Agentes in rebus: the imperial agents Ponticianus and his colleagues belonged to. Officially couriers and inspectors for the emperor; in practice a powerful and much-feared corps with wide investigative duties. A post in it was a serious career with real prospects.

Why it matters: these were not drifting young men. They were successful civil servants near the centre of imperial power, which is precisely why the story landed on Augustine.

Ponticianus was one of the four. So the story he is telling is one he was present for, which makes it, by the standards of everything else in this book, unusually close to the source.

They split into pairs. Two of them wandered off and came to a cottage where some people lived who had given up everything.

One of the two found a book there and opened it. It was the life of Antony. He began to read, and was astonished, and caught fire, and while he was still reading he began to think about taking that life himself.

Then he turned to his friend and said something that Augustine reproduces at length, because it is the sentence that undid him.

What are we hoping to get, with all this effort? What are we looking for? What are we serving for? Can we hope for anything better at court than to be friends of the emperor? And how fragile is that, and how many dangers does it pass through on the way to a bigger danger? And how long will it take to arrive? Whereas if I want to be a friend of God, I can become one now.

IN REAL TERMS

The phrase "friend of the emperor" was not a figure of speech. It was close to a formal designation for the highest circle of a courtier's ambition, and it was the ceiling of the career these men were in.

So the argument is: the best possible outcome of everything we are doing is a title that is uncertain, dangerous, decades away, and revocable at the whim of one person. The alternative is available immediately and cannot be taken back.

That is not a religious argument. It is a calculation about risk and time horizon, made by a professional, and it is why it worked on a man in Augustine's position rather than on somebody with nothing to lose.

He turned back to the book and read on. And Augustine records the physical detail that makes the scene: he was changing inside while he read, and his mind was casting off the world, and this was visible — his friend was watching him do it.

The friend then said he would stay with him. The other two returned, found them, and went back to the palace. And when the two who had stayed had fiancées, and those women heard what had happened, they dedicated themselves too.

That last clause is a single line in the original. Two women make a decision about their entire lives and are given one subordinate clause. This series has noted the pattern before and it is worth noting again, without labouring it.

4.5 — What it did to Augustine

Ponticianus finished, dealt with whatever he had come for, and left. He had no idea what he had done.

Augustine's description of the effect is the most violent language in the book. He says that while Ponticianus was speaking, God was turning him round to face himself, taking him from behind his own back where he had put himself in order not to look, and setting him in front of his own face so that he could see how foul he was.

And the specific thing he saw was the comparison. Unlearned people were getting up and taking heaven by force, and he, with all his education, was rolling around in flesh and blood, ashamed to follow because he had gone a little way ahead of them and was embarrassed not to be first.

He turned on Alypius and shouted something. Then he went out into the garden, and Alypius followed him.

REMEMBER THIS

A senior official, **Ponticianus**, called on business, noticed the letters of Paul on the table, and started talking. Nothing was intended by anyone.

He told them about **Antony**, the Egyptian monk who had walked into a church, heard a gospel sentence read aloud, and taken it as addressed to him. Augustine and Alypius had **never heard of him**, or of the monastery outside the walls of their own city.

Then the story that did the damage: **two imperial agents at Trier** found a life of Antony in a cottage, and one of them worked out that the best possible outcome of his whole career was **fragile, distant and revocable**, while the alternative was available immediately.

Their **fiancées** also changed their lives, and get one subordinate clause between them.

Augustine says God took him out from behind his own back, where he had put himself in order not to look. Then he went into the garden.

CHAPTER FIVE

"Give Me Chastity, But Not Yet"

The most quoted sentence Augustine ever wrote after the restless heart, and the one most often taken as a joke. It is not a joke, and what it is actually asking for is stranger than the joke.

5.1 — The prayer

Set into his account of the aftermath of Ponticianus's visit, Augustine quotes a prayer he had made years earlier, as a young man, and quotes it against himself. In plain English: give me chastity and self-control, but not yet.

He explains why he had prayed it that way, and the explanation is the whole content. He was afraid that God would hear him too quickly, and cure him too soon of a disease that he wanted satisfied rather than cured.

Read that twice. He was not asking for something and failing to get it. He was asking for something and quietly attaching a condition designed to make sure it did not arrive.

WORD BOX

Continence (*continentia*): in Augustine's usage, not merely abstaining from sex. It is the holding-together of a self that is otherwise scattered across many wants. The Latin word carries the sense of containing or keeping in one piece.

Why it matters: this is why continence in Book Eight is presented as the answer to a divided will and not just as a rule about behaviour. What he wants is not primarily to stop doing something. It is to stop being several people.

5.2 — What the prayer is actually doing

The comic reading of the line is that Augustine was a hypocrite who wanted to keep sinning. That reading is not exactly wrong and it misses what is interesting.

Look at the structure. A person genuinely wants X. The same person genuinely does not want X. Rather than resolving this, they construct a request that satisfies both: they ask for X, sincerely, with a timer on it.

That is not hypocrisy, which involves knowing what you want and pretending otherwise. It is something more awkward: a self that has produced two authentic and incompatible positions and has found a form of words that lets both stand.

And the prayer is addressed to somebody Augustine believes can see through it, which means it does not even function as a deception. It is a piece of self-management performed in front of an audience that is not fooled, by a man who knows the audience is not fooled.

IN REAL TERMS

The structure is entirely familiar and has nothing specifically to do with sex or religion.

It is deciding to give something up on the first of next month, and meaning it, and meaning the date too. It is wanting to be the kind of person who has already done the difficult thing, without wanting to be the person currently doing it.

Augustine's contribution is not noticing that people do this. It is noticing that both halves are sincere, which is what makes it a problem about the self rather than a problem about honesty.

5.3 — Why it is not a joke

The line is funny, and Augustine knew it was funny, and he is not the one laughing.

In its setting it is evidence in a case he is building. The case is that a will can want something and simultaneously arrange for it not to happen, and that this is the ordinary condition of a person rather than a special vice. The prayer is the cleanest specimen he has of that, which is why he keeps it.

Notice also where he places it: not in Book Two or Three, where it belongs chronologically, but here, at the point where the same structure is about to be examined at length. He has held it back for six books to deploy it as the opening exhibit for the argument about the divided will.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT WANTING A THING MEANS PURSUING IT

Almost every account of human action assumes a chain: you want something, so you move towards it, and the wanting explains the moving. Where somebody does not move, we conclude they did not really want it, or wanted something else more, or were prevented.

Augustine's prayer does not fit any of those. He wanted continence. He was not prevented; nothing external was in the way. And "he wanted something else more" is not quite it either, because the request is real — he is asking, and asking is a movement towards.

What the prayer shows is a want that is genuine and structurally arranged to fail, by the same person, at the same time, with full awareness. If that is possible, then wanting is not a force that produces motion in proportion to its strength, and the whole picture of a person as an engine driven by desires needs replacing.

That replacement is what the next two chapters are. And note the size of what is being claimed: not that people are weak, but that the standard model of how a person works is wrong.

The general form: explaining behaviour by strength of desire, when desire is not the kind of thing that has a single direction.

It is worth saying that the standard model is not stupid and mostly works. Most of the time people do move towards what they want. Augustine's claim is about the cases where it fails, and that those cases are not rare, and that they are the interesting ones.

REMEMBER THIS

The prayer, quoted against himself from years earlier: **give me chastity and self-control, but not yet**. He explains that he was afraid God would hear him too quickly.

Continence for Augustine is not just abstinence. It is the holding together of a self scattered across many wants. He does not primarily want to stop doing something. He wants to stop being several people.

The prayer is not hypocrisy, which needs you to know what you want and pretend otherwise. It is **two authentic and incompatible positions** and a form of words that lets both stand — addressed to somebody he believes can see through it.

He held it back for six books to place it **here**, as the opening exhibit for the argument about the divided will.

If a want can be genuine and arranged to fail by the same person at the same time, then the standard picture of a person as an engine driven by desires is wrong.

CHAPTER SIX

The Two Wills

Augustine's account of a self at war with itself is the most influential piece of psychology in the book, and possibly in the whole of late antiquity.

6.1 — The chain

Before the two wills, Augustine gives an account of how he got into this state, and it runs in four links. He states it compactly and it is worth having in order, because the whole later Western vocabulary of addiction and habit comes out of it.

A twisted will produced appetite. Wanting the wrong thing in the wrong order, which is the definition of a bad will from Book Seven.

Appetite acted on produced habit. Doing it repeatedly.

Habit not resisted produced necessity. The doing became automatic.

And by these links joined together, he says, a hard bondage held him.

WORD BOX

Consuetudo (habit, custom): the key term in this chain. For Augustine it is not a neutral routine. It is the mechanism by which a chosen act becomes an unchosen one: something you did becomes something that happens.

Why it matters: the chain from choice to necessity is Augustine's explanation of how a free will ends up unfree without anybody removing its freedom. Nothing was done to him. He did it, repeatedly, and the repetition did the rest.

The word is doing more work than it looks. Augustine is not saying he grew fond of something. He is saying that repetition changed the status of the act: it stopped being something he chose and became something that occurred, while he was still, in some sense, the one doing it.

IN REAL TERMS

The four links describe something anybody can check.

A thing is done by choice. It is done again because it was pleasant. It is done without deciding. And then it is done in the face of a decision not to, and the person watches themselves do it.

The step Augustine cares about is the last one, because that is where the person and the behaviour come apart. He is not describing somebody who wants to keep going. He is describing somebody who does not want to keep going, and keeps going.

6.2 — The man who cannot get up

Before the analysis, Augustine gives an image for the state, and it is his own and it is very good.

He compares himself to somebody heavy with sleep who is trying to wake. The man knows he should get up. He approves of getting up. He fully intends to get up. And what he says is: in a moment, in a moment, just a little longer. And the moments go by and he does not move, because the sleep is pleasant and the getting up is not.

Augustine says this was exactly his position, and adds the detail that makes it work: he had no answer to give when God called him. He had run out of arguments entirely. All he had left were slow, sleepy words — presently, in a moment, let me alone a little — and the moments had no end, and the little while went on a long while.

Set that beside the prayer in Chapter Five and beside the tomorrow-and-tomorrow of Book Six. It is the third time the same structure has appeared: a genuine intention with a delay attached, and a delay that renews itself indefinitely.

6.2 — The body obeys and the mind does not

Then comes the observation that the whole chapter is built on, and it is a good one.

The mind commands the body, and the body obeys instantly. Decide to lift your hand and the hand goes up. There is no gap and no argument.

The mind commands itself, and meets resistance.

Augustine finds this genuinely astonishing and says so. The mind's authority over a limb, which is a different thing entirely from itself, is total and immediate. Its authority over itself, which ought to be the easiest case in the world, fails.

That asymmetry is the datum. Everything else in the chapter is an attempt to explain it.

6.3 — The explanation

His answer is short and precise, and it is worth reading slowly because it is easy to mistake for a tautology.

The mind does not carry out its own command because it does not fully give it. It commands only insofar as it wills, and it fails to obey only insofar as it does not will. The command itself is partial, so the failure is not a case of the mind disobeying itself. It is a case of the mind not fully commanding in the first place.

And then the clinching move: it would not command at all if it did not will. So the very existence of the command proves that some willing is present. And the failure proves that some is absent. Both are true, of the same mind, at the same moment.

Augustine's conclusion is that this is not a monstrous condition and not an oddity. It is a sickness of the mind, which he defines carefully: the mind partly rises under the weight of truth and partly does not fall away from its habit, and so is in two pieces, and is distressed.

6.4 — What he is not saying

Three misreadings are worth clearing, because all three are common.

He is not saying there are two people in there. That is the Manichee position and Chapter Seven is his refutation of it. There is one mind, willing incompletely.

He is not saying the will is weak. "Weak will" implies a single force that is insufficient. His account is not about strength. It is about a will that is *divided*, which is a different failure: not too little, but pulling in more than one direction.

He is not describing a rare pathology. He thinks this is what a human will is like, ordinarily, and that the drama of Book Eight is simply a case where the division became impossible to ignore.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE SELF IS ONE AGENT ISSUING COMMANDS

The puzzle Augustine finds astonishing only arises if you assume a particular picture: that there is a single self at the centre, which issues instructions, and that things either obey it or do not. On that picture, the mind failing to obey itself is a paradox demanding explanation.

Notice that his solution keeps the picture and modifies it. He does not abandon the commanding self; he says the command was partial. The single agent survives, issuing a half-instruction.

But the observation he started from suggests something more radical, which he does not take up. If the mind can command and not command at once, then perhaps "commanding" is the wrong description of what is happening at all, and there was never a central office issuing orders — only several processes, some of which produce the experience of deciding.

That reading would explain his datum better than his own solution does, and it would cost him something he cannot give up: a self that is responsible. If nobody issued the order, nobody is answerable for it, and the whole moral architecture of the work depends on somebody being answerable.

The general form: keeping a model because of what would follow if you dropped it, rather than because it fits.

That box is not a refutation. Augustine has a serious answer to the responsibility problem and gives it over the following decades. It is a note that the shape of his solution here is constrained by a commitment he brought with him, and that he does not tell you so.

REMEMBER THIS

The chain: a **twisted will** produced appetite, appetite acted on produced **habit**, and habit not resisted produced **necessity**. Nothing was done to him. He did it repeatedly and the repetition did the rest.

The datum: the mind commands the **body** and is obeyed instantly. The mind commands **itself** and is resisted. The easy case fails and the hard case works.

His explanation: the mind **does not fully command**. It commands insofar as it wills and fails insofar as it does not, so the command was partial from the start.

This is not two people, not a weak will, and not a rare condition. It is **one will, divided**, and he thinks that is ordinary.

His solution keeps the picture of a single self issuing orders, and he needs to keep it, because without somebody issuing the order nobody is answerable for it.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Against the Manichees

One Last Time

Augustine has just described a self at war with itself, which is exactly what his old religion said human beings were. He now has to explain why it does not mean what they said it meant.

7.1 — The problem he has created

Look at what Chapter Six left on the table. One person, containing two wills, pulling against each other, neither able to defeat the other. If you had wanted to design a piece of evidence for Manichaeism, that would be it.

Part Two set out what the Manichees taught: two eternal opposed principles, Light and Darkness, and a human being as a fragment of Light trapped inside matter belonging to Darkness. On that account, the experience of being divided is not a puzzle at all. You are divided because you are literally made of two different substances, and each one wants what it wants.

Augustine says this directly. He says the Manichees, when they see two wills deliberating, assert that there are two natures in us, one good and one evil, and that we are made of both.

And he has just spent a chapter describing precisely that experience. So he has to answer it, and he does, in one of the tightest passages in the work.

7.2 — The argument from five wills

His counter is a *reductio*, and it is elegant.

If two conflicting wills prove two natures, then how many natures does a person have when four things are being weighed at once?

He gives the example. A man is deliberating. Shall he go to the theatre, or to church? And suppose a third option arrives, and a fourth: shall he go and rob somebody, or shall he go and commit adultery, and suppose all four are live at the same moment, and all are wanted.

On the Manichee logic, that is four natures. Add a fifth option and there are five. The theory has no principled stopping point, and it produces an absurd result: a person turns out to be made of as many substances as they have options on a given afternoon.

And Augustine adds the sharper half. Two of those options are both good. Church or a different church; one good deed or another good deed, when you cannot do both. Two good wills in conflict. On the Manichee account there would have to be two good natures fighting, which their entire system forbids, since it needs the conflict to be between good and evil.

IN REAL TERMS

The everyday version of the second point is the one that does the damage.

You want to go to your friend's thing and you want to go to your other friend's thing, and they are on the same evening, and you are genuinely torn.

Nothing evil is involved anywhere. The conflict is total and the options are both good. Any theory that explains internal conflict by a war between good and evil substances has no account of this at all, and it happens constantly.

7.3 — What he puts in its place

His conclusion is that the multiplicity is in the willing, not in the willer. It is one mind, wavering between different wants. The wants are many. The person is one.

And the reason this matters for the whole book, rather than only for the argument with a dead religion, is responsibility.

If the bad will is a different nature, it is not you, and you are not answerable for what it does. Part Two showed that this was the specific comfort Augustine had taken from Manichaeism for nine years: that when he did wrong it was not really he who did it.

By insisting the divided self is one self, he keeps the division and gives up the excuse. That is a harder position than either alternative and it is the position the rest of his life is built on.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE TWO-WILLS ACCOUNT HOLD TOGETHER?

Augustine wants a self that is genuinely divided and genuinely one. Whether that is coherent has been argued about ever since, and the argument runs straight into modern philosophy of mind.

IT IS COHERENT, AND IT IS WHAT A PERSON IS LIKE

A single system can have competing processes without being two systems. A committee is one committee whether or not it agrees; a body regulates temperature and hunger against each other without being two animals. The mind having several incompatible wants at once is not a contradiction, it is what a complex system does, and Augustine's "one mind, many wills" is a better description of the data than either the Manichee split or a tidy unified self.

IT SAVES THE UNITY BY MAKING IT EMPTY

The objection: what exactly is the one thing that persists through the division? Augustine's answer is the mind, but everything he attributes to the mind — the commanding, the willing, the resisting — he has just divided. If the unity does no explanatory work and is only asserted, it is a label for a container rather than a claim about a thing. And he needs it for a non-explanatory reason: he needs somebody to hold responsible.

HE IS RIGHT ABOUT THE PHENOMENON AND REACHING BEYOND HIS EVIDENCE

A third view accepts the description and doubts the metaphysics. What Augustine observed is real, is well described, and has been repeatedly confirmed by anybody who has tried to change a habit. What does not follow from the observation is any particular account of what the self is. He moves from an excellent report of divided willing to a claim about one mind, and the report does not entail the claim.

Where things stand: Everyone agrees the description is good; the passage is still cited in work on weakness of will. What is disputed is whether the unity Augustine insists on is established or assumed. Most current opinion leans towards the third position: excellent phenomenology, contestable metaphysics.

What would settle it: Nothing from the fourth century will settle it. What has moved the question is sustained modern work on weakness of will and on whether a mind is best described as one agent or many processes, and that work is unfinished and contested.

Why people care so much: The stakes are practical. If the divided self is one self, it is answerable. If it is not, a great deal of how we assign blame, and of how Augustine's entire theology works, has to be rebuilt.

I find the third position most persuasive and have written this chapter from it, and you should read my summary of the first with that in mind. What is not in dispute, and is worth holding on to, is that Augustine refused the one move that would have made his life easier, which was to blame something in him that was not him.

REMEMBER THIS

The divided self of Chapter Six looks like **exactly what the Manichees said we are**: two natures in one body, each wanting its own thing. Augustine has to answer it.

His counter: if two conflicting wills prove two natures, then **four options prove four natures**, and five prove five. The theory has no stopping point.

The sharper half: sometimes both options are **good** and the conflict is total. A theory that explains all inner conflict as a war between good and evil has no account of that, and it happens constantly.

His conclusion: the multiplicity is in the **willing**, not the **willer**. One mind, many wants.

He keeps the division and gives up the excuse. That is harder than either alternative, and it is the position the rest of his life is built on.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Garden

He goes outside, and Alypius follows him, and for several pages nothing happens except a man coming apart.

8.1 — What he did with his body

Augustine's account of the state he was in is almost entirely physical, which is unusual for him and worth noticing. He tore his hair. He struck his forehead. He locked his fingers together round his knee. He describes doing these things and describes them as things he found himself doing, in the way you might describe watching somebody else.

His point in listing them is the argument from Chapter Six, demonstrated. All of those actions happened the instant he willed them. The body did everything it was asked. The one thing that would not move was the will itself.

He also records that Alypius was there, silent, staying close, and that the silence was itself strange, because they were in the habit of talking about everything.

8.2 — The voices of the things he was giving up

Then Augustine does something a modern writer would probably not do, and it is worth taking seriously rather than treating as decoration.

He personifies his old habits and gives them lines.

He says his old attachments — he calls them trifles of trifles and vanities of vanities — were plucking at the garment of his flesh and murmuring behind him. Are you sending us away? From this moment will we never be with you again? From this moment will this and that be forbidden to you, forever?

He does not report what they named. He says he was ashamed to hear it and therefore does not repeat it.

The literary device is doing something specific. By giving the habits voices, Augustine represents them as things that talk to him from behind, out of sight, in a language of loss rather than of appetite. They are not tempting him with pleasure. They are asking whether he is really going to abandon them.

IN REAL TERMS

This is a more accurate description of giving something up than the usual one.

The hard part is rarely the wanting. The hard part is the sense that a whole category of your life is being closed, permanently, and that the version of you who did those things will not exist.

The habits in Augustine's garden are not offering him anything. They are asking him a question about the future, and the question is the thing that hurts.

8.3 — Contenance

On the other side, he sees a figure.

He describes Contenance appearing, and describes her carefully: not stiff or forbidding but serene, cheerful, and honourably attractive. She is not alone. She has with her a great crowd of young men and young women, and people of every age, and widows, and women who had grown old unmarried.

And what she says to him is not an instruction. It is a question, and it is the same question Ponticianus's story had already put: can you not do what these people have done? Do you think they did it by themselves?

Two things about this are worth naming.

The first is that Contenance is presented as a crowd. The alternative to Augustine's old life is not solitude but different company, which is the point Chapter Three made about the whole structure of Book Eight.

The second is that she is described as attractive. Augustine has arranged the scene so that both sides are appealing, which is what makes it a genuine conflict rather than a temptation to be resisted.

8.4 — The fig tree

He could not bear Alypius watching him. He got up and went further into the garden, as far away as he could get, and threw himself down under a fig tree.

And he let the tears out. He says he sent up a flood of them, and that this was an acceptable sacrifice.

And he said, not in these words but to this effect: how long, how long? Tomorrow, and tomorrow? Why not now? Why not this hour an end to my disgracefulness?

Note the words. Tomorrow and tomorrow is the sentence from Book Six, where at thirty he was telling himself daily that the answer would arrive shortly. And *not yet* is the prayer from

Chapter Five. He has reached the point where he can hear his own delaying formula as a formula.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A DECISION IS MADE AT THE MOMENT IT BECOMES VISIBLE

Everything about the way this scene is told, and the way it is remembered, places the decision at the fig tree. Before it, a divided man. After it, a converted one. The garden is the hinge.

But look at what has already happened by the time he gets under the tree. He has been intellectually convinced for months. He has heard about Victorinus and wanted to imitate him. He has heard about Antony and the courtiers. He has left the room, walked into the garden, walked away from his friend, and lain down. Every one of those is a movement in one direction, and by the time he is under the tree there is nowhere else the afternoon can go.

The assumption is that a decision happens at the moment it becomes observable, because that is when it becomes describable. What precedes it gets filed as preparation, even when the preparation was doing all the work.

This matters for the next chapter, because the whole dispute about whether the garden happened as described treats it as the load-bearing event. If it was not load-bearing — if it was the visible end of something already complete — then a great deal less rides on the accuracy of the scene than either side assumes.

The general form: dating an event to the moment it became possible to see.

That box is worth keeping in hand for what follows. It does not answer the question in Chapter Nine. It changes how much the answer would cost.

REMEMBER THIS

His account of the state is almost entirely **physical**: tearing his hair, striking his forehead, gripping his knee. Every one of those happened the instant he willed it, which is the argument from Chapter Six demonstrated.

He gives his old habits **voices**. They do not tempt him with pleasure. They ask whether he is really going to send them away forever, which is a much more accurate description of giving something up.

Contenance appears, described as cheerful and attractive rather than stern, and she comes with a **crowd**. The alternative to his old life is not solitude but different company.

He goes as far from Alypius as he can get and throws himself down under a **fig tree**, weeping, saying: **how long? tomorrow and tomorrow? why not now?**

Those are his own delaying formulas from Books Six and Eight, and he has reached the point where he can hear them as formulas.

CHAPTER NINE

Tolle Lege

Four sentences of narrative that have been read, painted, preached on and argued about for sixteen hundred years.

9.1 — The voice

While he was crying under the tree, he heard a voice from a house nearby. He says it was the voice of a boy or a girl, he could not tell which, and it was singing, and repeating over and over two words. In Latin: *tolle lege*. Take it up and read. Take it up and read.

He stopped crying and began to think about it.

And here is the detail that almost every retelling smooths away, and which is the most interesting sentence in the passage.

He asked himself whether children used those words in any kind of game. And he says he could not recall ever having heard anything like it.

That is Augustine checking. Faced with something he was inclined to take as a message, his first move was to look for the ordinary explanation, and he tells you that he looked and did not find one. He does not claim there was no game. He claims he could not think of one.

Only then did he conclude that he was being commanded to open a book and read the first passage he found.

9.2 — Antony, and the practice he was following

And he tells you exactly what precedent he had in mind, which is the second thing usually left out.

He remembered Antony. Chapter Four described it: Antony walked into a church, heard a gospel sentence being read, took it as spoken to him personally, and acted. Augustine had heard that story an hour or two earlier from Ponticianus.

So the interpretation of the voice is not spontaneous. He has a model, he has just been told about it, and he applies it.

WORD BOX

Opening a book at random for guidance: a widespread ancient practice, done with Virgil, with Homer, and later with the Bible. You put a question, opened the book, and read what your eye fell on as an answer.

Why it matters: Augustine was not inventing a method. He was using a familiar one. It is also worth knowing that he disapproved of the practice in his later writings when people used it for ordinary business, while allowing it in matters of salvation — which means the mature Augustine had to make room for what the younger one had done.

Part Three noted that a proconsul had once explained to him exactly why this sort of thing produces hits: scatter enough statements across a life and some will land. Augustine had rejected that argument then. He is not thinking about it now.

9.3 — What he read

He went back to where Alypius was sitting, because he had left the volume of Paul there. He picked it up, opened it, and read in silence the first passage his eyes fell on.

It was from the letter to the Romans, and in plain English it says: not in revelling and drunkenness, not in debauchery and indecency, not in quarrelling and jealousy; but put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh and its desires.

He read no further. He says he did not need to. At the end of that sentence, a light of certainty was poured into his heart and all the darkness of doubt went away.

He marked the place with his finger, or with something else, he says he cannot remember what, closed the book, and told Alypius, calmly.

That detail about not remembering how he marked the page is worth noticing. It is the kind of thing a person forgets and a constructor would not think to include.

9.4 — Alypius

Alypius asked to see it. He looked, and then read on past where Augustine had stopped.

The next line says, in effect: as for the one who is weak in faith, receive him.

Alypius applied it to himself and told Augustine so, and joined him, without any of the turmoil. Augustine notes that Alypius had been better than him in this respect for a long time.

Then they went inside and told Monica. And she was, Augustine says, filled with joy, and it was more than she had asked for, because she had wanted him married and settled and instead had got this.

One line at the end deserves attention because it is the resolution of a thread running since Book Six. Augustine says he now sought neither a wife nor any hope of this world. The engagement to the child bride ends here, and the career ends in Book Nine.

9.5 — Did it happen?

And now the question this part has been promising since the front matter.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The garden scene rests on one source: Augustine, writing about eleven years later.

The one external check that exists is unusually good and unusually awkward. Within weeks of these events Augustine retired to a country house at Cassiciacum and wrote three philosophical dialogues, which survive. They are our only near-contemporary window on him.

What they show: a man interested in scepticism, in the happy life, and in order, writing in a Platonising idiom, in dialogue with friends and pupils, with comparatively little of the language of Book Eight.

What that does and does not establish: it establishes that his written output weeks after the garden looks different in kind from his account of the garden. It does not establish what he was feeling, because a philosophical dialogue for an educated audience is a different genre with different conventions, and people do not write their inner lives into everything they publish.

That single tension is the engine of the entire dispute below, and it has been since 1888.

Three main positions have been staked out on that tension, and all three are held by serious scholars. Here they are at full strength.

THE ARGUMENT — DID THE GARDEN SCENE HAPPEN AS DESCRIBED?

This is the central scholarly dispute about *Confessions*. It began in 1888 when Gaston Boissier and Adolf von Harnack independently questioned the reliability of Book Eight, and it has run continuously since.

SUBSTANTIALLY AS DESCRIBED

The default position, and it has good arguments. Augustine was writing for people who had been there: Alypius was alive and a bishop, Monica's role was known, and his enemies were numerous and attentive. The account contains details that serve no purpose — the forgotten bookmark, the inability to identify the game, Alypius reading the next line down — and invented scenes are usually tidier than that. And the objection from the Cassiciacum dialogues proves less than it seems, since nobody writes their conversion into a treatise on scepticism.

IT IS A LITERARY CONSTRUCTION OVER A REAL CHANGE

The position associated above all with Pierre Courcelle, whose 1950 book *Recherches sur les Confessions de saint Augustin* reshaped the field. The elements of the scene are heavily loaded: a garden, a fig tree with strong scriptural resonances, a voice that cannot be placed, a text that lands exactly on his stated problem, and a friend who reads the very next line and is also converted. Each is possible. All of them together, in four sentences, looks like composition. On this reading the conversion is real and the scene is how a trained rhetorician chose to render it eleven years on.

THE CONVERSION IN 386 WAS TO PHILOSOPHY, NOT TO CHRISTIANITY

The strongest sceptical position, argued by Prosper Alfarcic in 1918 against Charles Boyer. The Cassiciacum dialogues are the evidence: what Augustine actually wrote in the months after the garden reads like the work of a Christian Platonist philosopher, not of the man in Book Eight. On this view the decisive turn towards the Christianity we associate with Augustine came later, through Paul and through being conscripted into church office, and *Confessions* projects it backwards onto 386.

Where things stand: Nobody in this dispute accuses Augustine of fabricating a conversion; the strongest position claims he misdated the character of one. The middle position is now closest to a consensus: a real event, rendered with literary art, by a writer who thought that making a truth vivid was part of telling it. The strongest sceptical form has few current adherents, and a counter-movement has argued that Augustine was more thoroughly Christian at Cassiciacum than Alfarcic allowed.

What would settle it: The evidence is fixed and has been worked over exhaustively for well over a century. Barring a new manuscript, which will not come, this is now a question of how to weigh a genre difference between two bodies of text by the same man in the same year.

Why people care so much: It matters enormously, and not only to specialists. Book Eight is the model on which the Western idea of a conversion experience was built. If the founding instance is partly a literary construction, that does not make conversions unreal, but it does mean the shape we expect them to have was designed by a rhetorician.

My own view, since it has been shaping this chapter: I find the middle position persuasive, and I want to add that it is much less deflationary than it sounds. Augustine wrote at length elsewhere about how a teacher should make truth move people. A man who believed that would not have seen a choice between telling you what happened and telling it well.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT HOW YOU ARRIVED AT A TEXT IS SEPARATE FROM WHAT IT SAYS

Both sides of that argument treat the sentence from Paul as a fixed object that Augustine encountered. The dispute is about the encounter — whether the voice was real, whether the opening was random, whether the scene is reported. What the text said is taken as given.

But the sentence he read is not an unusual one and would have done nothing to most readers on most days. What made it land was everything in the previous four hours: Ponticianus, Antony, the courtiers, the crowd around Continence, the weeping. The text supplied words. The situation supplied the meaning.

That is what makes the practice of opening a book at random work, and it is also why the proconsul's objection from Part Three is not quite a refutation. The hits are not chance in the way he said. A person under enough pressure will find what they need in a very wide range of sentences, and this is a fact about the reader rather than about the book.

Which cuts both ways, and that is the point of the box. It weakens the case that something miraculous happened, since almost any passage would have served. And it weakens the case that the scene was constructed to fit, since the fit did not require construction.

The general form: treating meaning as a property of the text rather than of the meeting between a text and a moment.

That is the last of the Hidden Assumption boxes in this part, and it is the one I would keep if I could keep only one. It applies to every sentence anybody has ever found decisive, including the ones in books like this.

REMEMBER THIS

He heard a voice from a nearby house, a boy or a girl he could not tell which, singing **take up and read** over and over.

The detail nobody smooths over: he **asked himself whether it was a children's game** and could not think of one. He looked for the ordinary explanation first and tells you so.

He had a model. He had heard about **Antony** an hour or two earlier, who did exactly this with a sentence heard in church. Opening a book at random for guidance was a familiar practice.

He read four lines of **Romans**, stopped, and says the darkness of doubt went. He marked the page with something he could not afterwards remember. **Alypius read the next line down** and applied it to himself.

Whether it happened as described has been argued since **1888**. The current centre of gravity: a real event, rendered with literary art, by a man who did not think telling it well and telling it truly were in competition.

The sentence he read was ordinary. What made it land was the previous four hours. The text supplied words; the situation supplied the meaning.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Two lists, with reasons. And a note on what actually changed in the weeks after the garden, which is a better test of the scene than any argument about it.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

Whether the garden scene happened as described. *Why unknown:* one source, eleven years later, by a professional rhetorician, and the only near-contemporary check is a set of philosophical dialogues in a different genre for a different audience. The evidence has been exhausted and the question remains open.

Whether there was a voice, and whose. *Why unknown:* Augustine says he could not identify a game with those words and does not claim there was none. A neighbouring house, a child, an afternoon: nothing about that generates a record.

Whether he and Alypius had really never heard of Antony or of the monastery outside Milan. *Why unknown:* the claim is hard to square with the background and easy to square with ordinary human obliviousness, and the text will support either.

What exactly Simplicianus said, and what Ponticianus said. *Why unknown:* reported conversations from eleven years on. The parts that make the stories live — the joke about walls, the murmur running round the congregation, the courtier's speech about the friends of the emperor — are exactly the parts nobody can check.

What Augustine was actually thinking in the months after. *Why unknown:* we have what he published, which is a different thing. The gap between what a person writes for an audience and what they are going through is not recoverable, and this is the whole of the Cassiciacum problem.

What became of the fiancée. *Why unknown:* the engagement ends here and she leaves the record. She was never named, and Part Four noted that she is one of four people in this work who could have been named and were not.

Whether the two courtiers at Trier, or their fiancées, existed. *Why unknown:* the story reaches Augustine through Ponticianus and reaches us through Augustine. It is plausible in every detail and unverifiable in all of them.

10.2 — Solid

Marius Victorinus. His eminence, the statue in Trajan's Forum in 354, his conversion in extreme old age, and his resignation under Julian's law. *Why solid:* Jerome records him independently, Julian's law survives in the imperial legal code with its date of 17 June 362, Victorinus's own Christian writings survive, and an inscription indicates the statue was still standing two generations later. Four independent lines agreeing.

Simplicianus. That he was Ambrose's teacher, that he baptised him, and that he later succeeded him as bishop of Milan. *Why solid:* attested outside *Confessions*, and Augustine corresponded with him afterwards in letters that survive.

Antony of Egypt and the spread of monasticism. *Why solid:* the life of Antony survives in Greek and in Latin translation, the movement is documented across the eastern empire, and Ambrose's own promotion of the ascetic life is visible in his surviving sermons.

That Augustine resigned his chair shortly afterwards. *Why solid:* he says so, the timing fits the academic vacation, and his own works from the following months are written from a country retreat rather than from the city.

That he was baptised by Ambrose at Easter 387. *Why solid:* the date is fixed and independently supported, and this is the event Book Nine opens onto.

That the Cassiciacum dialogues exist and are from this period. *Why solid:* they survive, Augustine lists them in his own later review of his works, and their setting matches. What they mean is disputed; that they exist is not.

10.3 — What actually changed

One closing observation, because it is a better test of Book Eight than any argument about the fig tree.

Arguments about whether a conversion was real tend to circle the moment. It is more informative to look at what happened next, and here the record is comparatively good.

Within weeks, Augustine gave up his chair at Milan. He gave a reason that was partly medical — his chest and his voice were failing — and he waited for the vacation so as not to make a scene, which he himself flags as less than heroic. He nonetheless left the profession his family had impoverished itself to buy him, at the point where it was working.

The engagement was cancelled. The advantageous marriage did not happen.

He never married and, so far as anything indicates, never had another sexual relationship, across the more than forty years that remained.

He was baptised the following Easter. He went back to Africa, gave away or converted the family property, and lived the rest of his life in a religious community, becoming a priest and then a bishop.

None of that proves anything about a voice in a garden. What it establishes is that whatever happened in the summer of 386 was followed by a durable and expensive change in how a man lived, sustained for four decades, and that any account which makes Book Eight a purely literary flourish has to explain the four decades as well as the four sentences.

REMEMBER THIS

We do not know whether the garden happened as described, whether there was a voice, whether the claimed ignorance about Antony is literal, what was actually said in the two reported conversations, or what became of the fiancée.

We do know a great deal about **Victorinus**, from four independent lines of evidence, and about **Simplicianus**, **Antony**, and the spread of monasticism. We also have the **Cassiciacum dialogues**: what they mean is disputed, that they exist is not.

The better test than the fig tree is **what happened next**: the chair resigned, the engagement cancelled, no marriage and no known relationship in over forty years, baptism the following Easter, the property given up, and the rest of a life spent in a religious community.

That proves nothing about a voice. It does mean any account treating Book Eight as a literary flourish has to explain the four decades as well as the four sentences.

Timeline

Book Eight covers a few weeks. The surrounding dates are firm; the internal sequence is Augustine's own and is not independently checkable.

Date	Event	Where it appears
c. 251–356	Antony of Egypt. His decision comes from a gospel sentence heard by chance in a church.	Book VIII
354	A statue of Marius Victorinus is erected in Trajan's Forum, Rome. Augustine is born the same year.	Book VIII
c. 355	Victorinus converts in extreme old age, and refuses the offer of a private profession of faith.	Book VIII
17 Jun 362	Julian's law on teaching appointments. Victorinus closes his school rather than comply.	Book VIII
c. 370s	The two imperial agents at Trier read the life of Antony in a cottage garden and change their lives in an afternoon.	Book VIII
384	Augustine takes the chair of rhetoric at Milan.	Book V
385	The woman he lived with is sent back to Africa. A marriage is arranged.	Book VI
386	The books of the Platonists. Evil understood as privation. He reads Paul.	Book VII
386	He visits Simplicianus and is told the story of Victorinus.	Book VIII
386	Ponticianus visits, notices the letters of Paul on the table, and tells them about Antony and the courtiers.	Book VIII
Aug 386	The garden. The fig tree, the voice, and Romans 13. Alypius reads the next line and joins him. They tell Monica.	Book VIII
autumn 386	He resigns the chair at the vacation. The engagement is cancelled. He retires to Cassiciacum and writes three dialogues that survive.	Book IX
24 Apr 387	Baptised by Ambrose in Milan, with Adeodatus and Alypius.	Book IX
—	Part Six starts here: Book IX — the baptism, the conversation at Ostia, and the death of Monica.	—

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Terms carried over from earlier parts are repeated so this part stands alone.

Term	What it means
Agentes in rebus	Imperial agents: officially couriers and inspectors for the emperor, in practice a powerful and much-feared corps. Ponticianus and the two courtiers belonged to it.
Alypius	Augustine's former pupil and closest friend, present in the garden and baptised with him. Later a bishop.
Antony of Egypt	The monk whose withdrawal to the desert became the great example of the monastic life. His biography circulated widely in Latin.
Cassiciacum	The country estate outside Milan where Augustine retired after resigning his chair, and where he wrote three surviving philosophical dialogues.
Catechumen	Someone enrolled in the church for instruction but not yet baptised. Augustine's status until Easter 387.
Consuetudo	Habit or custom. For Augustine, the mechanism by which an act you chose becomes something that simply happens to you.
Contenance	Not merely abstaining from sex. The holding together of a self otherwise scattered across many wants.
Julian	Emperor from 361 to 363, who abandoned Christianity and tried to restore the traditional cults. His 362 law on teaching forced Victorinus out.
Marius Victorinus	The state professor of rhetoric at Rome, honoured with a statue in 354, who translated Platonist works into Latin and converted in extreme old age.
Monasticism	Withdrawal from ordinary society, alone or in community, under a religious discipline. New, fast-spreading, and startling to educated Romans in the fourth century.
Ponticianus	A senior African official at the imperial court whose visit and storytelling precipitated the crisis in the garden.
Privation	A missing good in something that ought to have had it. Augustine's account of what evil is, established in Book VII.

Term	What it means
Simplicianus	The elderly Milanese priest who had taught and baptised Ambrose, and who later succeeded him as bishop. Augustine went to him for guidance.
<i>Tolle lege</i>	Latin for "take up and read": the words Augustine heard chanted from a nearby house.
Trier	The imperial city in what is now Germany where the two agents read the life of Antony in a garden.

About the Author

This series is read and explained by **Lovepreet Singh**, and published as part of **The Living Archive** at misterlove.in.

The Living Archive takes difficult material and rebuilds it so that anyone can follow it, without dropping the hard parts along the way. Its first series was a fourteen-part history of Punjab running to around nine hundred and fifty pages. This is its second.

I read the book, I did the reading around it, and I wrote down what I found. I am not a specialist in late antiquity and I am not going to pretend to be one. Where a question is genuinely contested among people who are, I have said so and given each side its strongest case rather than choosing for you. Where I could not find out, I have written that I could not find out.

The method used here was worked out on the Punjab series and is written up as a portable specification, so that any part of this work can be checked, continued or rebuilt by somebody else. That is the point of an archive that calls itself living.

[Editorial note, to be replaced before publishing: the method requires a one-line statement of the author's own position with regard to religious material, placed where readers will see it. This is the only field in the document still unfilled, and it matters more in this part than in any so far.]

The Living Archive

The Living Archive is a method for writing hard things simply without making them shallow. It was developed by Lovepreet Singh and tested on a fourteen-part history of Punjab. It runs on three rules.

One. Simplification is not compression. The simple version is usually longer than the difficult one. Words are being spent to buy comprehension.

Two. Two dials, turned in opposite directions. Language as simple as it can be made. Content as deep as the subject actually goes. Turning both down produces something readable and useless.

Three. Every side gets its strongest case, and where nothing settles a question, that gets said. A verdict that honestly reports a deadlock is worth more than a tidy answer that is not true.

A word on sources

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record rather than new primary research, and it is written for readers who want to understand a book, not for specialists who want to check my workings.

What the archive is good at here: Victorinus, Simplicianus, Antony, Julian's law and the spread of monasticism are all documented outside *Confessions*, several of them from more than one direction. And unusually, we have three works Augustine wrote within weeks of the events described, which is the closest thing to a contemporary check that exists anywhere in this series.

What it is bad at here: the garden itself, and the two conversations that lead to it, rest entirely on one witness writing eleven years later. That is also true of most famous scenes from the ancient world, and it is worth saying plainly rather than letting the fame of the passage stand in for evidence.

On the dispute in Chapter Nine: I have tried to give all three positions their strongest form and to keep my own preference visible where it could shape the summary. Readers who want to go further should know that the literature on this question is enormous, that it starts in 1888, and that the standard modern point of entry is Courcelle's 1950 book and the responses to it.

On translations: all renderings of Augustine in this document are my own plain-English paraphrases, made deliberately loose so that they explain rather than reproduce. They are not quotations from any published translation and should not be cited as such. Where the exact wording matters, go to a proper edition.

Corrections are welcome and will be acted on. Later editions will record what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Six covers Book Nine: the months from the autumn of 386 to the autumn of 387. It is the last book of the life story, and it is the one people cry at. These are the questions it takes on.

- What did Augustine actually do in the months between the garden and his baptism, and what does it say that he waited?
- Why does he give a whole section to a toothache?
- Who was Adeodatus, his son, and what does Augustine say about him — and about the fact that he died at about seventeen?
- What happened at a window in Ostia, in a conversation between a man and his mother that has been called the most beautiful passage in Latin prose?
- What is Augustine claiming happened in that conversation, and is it the same thing that happened in Book Seven?
- Monica dies five days later. What does he say about her life, and what does he leave out?
- And the question this series has been carrying since Part Three: he told us grief for a friend was a fault. His mother dies. What does he do?

That last one is the debt. Part Three set out his verdict that grief is the natural consequence of having loved a mortal thing as if it were permanent. Book Nine is where he has to live with his own doctrine, and what he actually does is not what the doctrine says.

End of Part 5 of 9

The Living Archive • The Confessions, Explained

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART 6 OF 9

The Confessions, Explained

Part Six — The Water, the Window and the Grave

*Book Nine alone: a quiet resignation, a baptism, a son who dies young,
a conversation at a window that has been called the most beautiful
passage in Latin prose, and a man who weeps and is ashamed of it.*

READ AND EXPLAINED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

Parts One to Five covered Books One to Eight. Here is what you need. This part stands on its own.

The man. Born 354 in Roman North Africa, educated at his family's expense towards a career as a professional public speaker. By 384 he held the public chair of rhetoric in Milan, the city where the western emperor lived. He wrote this book in his early forties, around 397 to 400, about eleven years after the events in it.

The book. *Confessio* means three things at once: confessing sin, confessing faith, and confessing praise. This is a prayer, addressed to God throughout, and you are overhearing it.

The story so far. Nine years with the Manichees, a religion teaching two eternal powers of Light and Darkness. It collapsed. He drifted through scepticism to Milan, where the bishop Ambrose showed him that scripture could be read figuratively. Books of the Platonists then broke the assumption that had trapped him — that anything real must be made of stuff — and once that went he could accept that evil is not a substance but a *privation*, a missing good in something that ought to have had it.

Book Eight, which this part follows directly. Having the answer turned out not to be the same as being able to live in it. Book Eight is about a man who is certain and cannot move. It is built out of other people's stories — Victorinus, Antony in the Egyptian desert, two imperial agents at Trier — before it reaches his own. In a garden in Milan in the late summer of 386 he heard a voice from a neighbouring house telling him to take up and read, opened the letters of Paul at random, read four lines, and stopped arguing. Alypius read the next line and joined him. They went indoors and told Monica.

Two threads run in. The first is the woman. In Book Six the partner he had lived with for over a decade, and whom he never names, was sent back to Africa so that he could make an advantageous marriage. He took another woman while waiting. The engagement is still standing when Book Eight ends. The second is grief. In Book Four a friend died and Augustine was destroyed by it, and the older man writing the book judges that grief a fault: the natural consequence of having loved a mortal thing as though it were permanent. Part Three said that Book Nine is where he has to live with his own verdict. It is.

A Reminder About the Boxes

Six kinds of box run through this series. **Word Box** explains a hard term the moment it first appears. **In Real Terms** turns something abstract into something you can picture. **How We Actually Know This** names the evidence and says what it cannot show. **The Argument** is for places where experts genuinely disagree, and gives each side its strongest case. **The Hidden Assumption** digs out the premise everybody is quietly taking for granted. **Remember This** closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

Three Things to Watch For

Book Nine is the last book of the life story. After it the *Confessions* stops being a narrative and becomes something else. Three threads to keep hold of.

One. Almost nothing dramatic happens, and everything changes. Book Eight has a garden, a voice and a famous scene. Book Nine has a resignation timed to the school holidays, a country house, a toothache, a font, a window and a funeral. If you have been reading this series for the arguments, this is the part where the arguments get quieter and the stakes get higher.

Two. This is the part where other people finally get room. Verecundus, Nebridius, Adeodatus, Evodius, Navigius and above all Monica are given more space here than anywhere else in the book. Four of the thirteen sections are about his mother. That is a deliberate act by a writer who has spent eight books on himself, and Chapter Six is about what he is doing with it.

Three. He breaks his own rule and knows it. Part Three reported his verdict that grief for the dead is a fault. In this book his mother dies, he fights his tears all day, he loses, he is ashamed of losing, and then he is ashamed of the shame. Chapter Nine reports that sequence exactly and does not tidy it up, because the untidiness is the evidence.

Contents

Chapter One — Leaving Quietly

Three weeks to the holidays · a chest complaint that arrived at a convenient moment · the exit he says was less than heroic · and the two friends who made it possible

Chapter Two — Cassiciacum

A borrowed country house · who was actually in it · the four books he wrote there · a psalm that made him angry · and what those books look like to a sceptic

Chapter Three — The Toothache

Why a book this size gives a paragraph to a tooth · what he claims happened · and the trap waiting for both kinds of reader

Chapter Four — The Water

A letter to Ambrose and a book he could not read · Easter 387 · the singing that made him weep · and the year a congregation slept in its own church to keep the soldiers out

Chapter Five — Adeodatus

The son · the dialogue his father wrote down and then said was really the boy's · a sentence that has been read against Augustine for sixteen centuries · and a death at about seventeen

Chapter Six — Monica, Told Backwards

The old servant and the rule about water · the sips from the cask · the insult that stopped them · a violent husband and a wife nobody ever saw marked · and the advice she gave to women who were

Chapter Seven — The Window

Why they were at Ostia at all · a conversation between a man and his mother · the climb · the sentence that follows it · and what she said when it was over

Chapter Eight — What Is Being Claimed

Ostia against Book Seven · five differences that matter · the Plotinus question · and whether “the same experience” is even a thing you can check

Chapter Nine — Nine Days

The fever · “bury me here” · a room full of people not crying · a bath, a sleep, a hymn · and the debt this series has been carrying since Part Three

Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Genuinely unknown · solid · a piece of marble found by two boys in 1945 · and what happened in the year after the funeral

Reference

Timeline · glossary · about the author · a word on sources · what comes next

CHAPTER ONE

Leaving Quietly

Book Nine opens with a man deciding not to make a scene. What he does next is undramatic, slightly shabby, and the most consequential thing in the book.

1.1 — Three weeks

The garden happened in the late summer of 386. Augustine was thirty-one and held the public chair of rhetoric in Milan. The obvious thing for a man in that state to do is to walk into the lecture hall the next morning and resign in front of everybody. He did not do that.

He checked the calendar. The schools broke up for the vintage holiday in a few weeks, and he decided to serve out the time and simply not come back. He says so plainly, and he says he did not want to make a noise about it.

WORD BOX

Feriae vindemiales: the vintage vacation. Roman schools and much of the public administration shut down for the grape harvest, roughly from late August into October. It was the long holiday of the year, the one point in the calendar at which a teacher could stop teaching without anybody having to be told anything.

Why it matters: the timing of the most famous conversion in Western literature was arranged around the school holidays. That is not a joke at Augustine's expense. It is the first fact in Book Nine and he put it there himself.

His reason for waiting is given in one line and it is a reason about other people. He did not want it to look as though he were tearing himself away in order to be seen tearing himself away. Milan was a court city, the chair was a state appointment, and a professor of rhetoric who resigns publicly in the middle of term is making a speech whether he means to or not. He had spent twenty years learning exactly how such a speech would be read.

So the plan was: finish the term, let the holiday arrive, and not return. A few weeks of standing in front of paying students teaching them the art he had just decided was a trade in words. He calls it, without much sympathy for himself, a stretch of time to be endured.

1.2 — The chest, and what a voice was worth

Then something happened that he reports with an honesty most people would have edited out. His health failed in a way that was convenient.

He had been having trouble breathing. There were pains in his chest, and his voice was going: he could not speak clearly or for long. The diagnosis available to him was that too much literary work had damaged his lungs. Whatever it actually was, the effect was that the instrument he made his living with was failing.

IN REAL TERMS

A modern reader hears “he had a chest complaint” and files it as a medical detail. In fourth-century terms it is closer to a pianist losing the use of a hand.

A professor of rhetoric was paid for a voice that could hold a hall for an hour without amplification, six days a week, in Latin of a very high finish. There was no other product. A rhetor who cannot project is not a rhetor with a health problem. He is unemployed.

This is also why the excuse was believable to everyone around him, and why it worked.

Augustine then does the thing that makes him worth reading. He does not present the illness as providence and leave it there. He tracks his own reaction to it. At first, he says, it distressed him, because it was going to force him out of the job whether he liked it or not, and he wanted the leaving to be his. Then he noticed that it pleased him, because it handed him a true and respectable excuse, and a true and respectable excuse would soften the offence to the parents and patrons who had a claim on him.

That is the sentence to slow down on. He is telling you that he was glad of an illness because it made his resignation less awkward, and he is telling you that he noticed being glad.

1.3 — What he says about how it looked

The whole passage is arranged to prevent a particular reading of himself. He knows how the story is going to sound to anyone who liked him and to anyone who did not.

To the friendly reader it sounds like modesty: a man who has had a religious crisis and refuses to advertise it. To the unfriendly reader it sounds like hedging: a man who has had a religious crisis and waits for a medical certificate and a public holiday before acting on it. Augustine supplies the evidence for the unfriendly reading himself, which is a strange thing for a defendant to do, and is one of the reasons this book has survived.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE STRENGTH OF A CONVICTION CAN BE READ OFF THE DRAMA OF THE ACT THAT FOLLOWS IT

Almost everyone reads Chapter One of Book Nine with a needle twitching. A sudden, costly, public break reads as sincere. A managed exit with a sick note and a holiday reads as hedged. Nobody decides to think this. It arrives on its own.

The assumption underneath is that inner states show themselves in the theatre of the acts that follow, so that the bigger the gesture, the realer the change. It is an assumption about visibility, and it is almost the opposite of what a change of life usually looks like from inside.

Test it on something ordinary. Somebody announces on the first of January that they are giving up drinking, tells everyone, and posts about it. Somebody else stops, tells nobody, and is still not drinking four years later. The drama is inversely related to the durability often enough that the correlation is worth doubting.

It matters here because the whole scholarly dispute about Book Eight — which Part Five gave a full hearing — partly runs on this. One of the arguments that the garden was a literary construction is that the man who came out of it behaved so calmly. That is only evidence if you have already accepted that real changes are loud.

The general form: treating the volume of an act as a measurement of the state that produced it.

This series is going to declare a position here, because the material invites a verdict and it would be dishonest to pretend otherwise. The managed exit is the least suspicious thing in Book Nine. A man who wanted the story to look good would not have mentioned the chest, and certainly would not have mentioned being pleased about the chest. The passage is constructed to be slightly damaging, which is a poor strategy if the aim is to look good and a reasonable one if the aim is to be believed.

What the passage cannot settle is whether the man in the lecture hall that autumn already thought of himself as somebody who had been converted. That question belongs to Chapter Two.

1.4 — **Verecundus and Nebridius**

Two friends get a section each, and both sections are short, and both are about people who did not get where Augustine got.

Verecundus was a Milanese schoolmaster and a close friend, and he owned a country property. He offered it. Without that offer there is no Cassiciacum, no autumn of writing, and possibly no Book Nine, so it is worth noticing that the retreat everybody remembers as Augustine's was somebody else's house.

Verecundus was not a Christian at the time and was unhappy about it. Augustine's account of why is uncomfortable and he does not soften it: Verecundus was married, and he had got the idea that the way his friends were going was not open to a married man. He wanted in and believed the door was a size too small for him. Augustine reports his distress, records that he was baptised later during a final illness after Augustine had already left Italy, and moves on.

Nebridius is the friend this series has been following since Part Three, the one who argued against astrology and would not let a bad argument stand. He had held a view of Christ that treated the body as an appearance rather than a real body, and he gave it up. He was

baptised. He went back to Africa. He died young, and Augustine, writing more than a decade later, still writes about him in the present tense.

The placing is deliberate. Before Book Nine tells you about a baptism, a vision and a good death, it tells you about two men who were part of all of it and who died first. Book Nine is the part of the *Confessions* where people start dying, and Augustine sets the tone in the second section.

REMEMBER THIS

After the garden, Augustine did not resign in public. He **served out the term** and let the **vintage holiday** end his teaching quietly, because he did not want the leaving to look like a performance. A **chest complaint** — failing breath, pain, a voice that would not hold — arrived at the same time. For a professional speaker that is not an inconvenience, it is the end of the trade.

He records that the illness first **annoyed** him and then **pleased** him, because it gave him an honest excuse. He is the one who tells you this. Nobody caught him.

The retreat that follows happened in a **borrowed house**, lent by **Verecundus**, who was miserable because he thought marriage shut him out of the life his friends were choosing.

Nebridius, the sharpest of the friends, was baptised, went home to Africa, and died young. Book Nine starts counting the dead in its second section.

CHAPTER TWO

Cassiciacum

A borrowed house in the hills, eight or nine people, one winter, and four books that survive. This is the only stretch of Augustine's life where we can read what he was writing at the time and compare it with what he says about it later.

2.1 — Where they went, and who went

Some time in the autumn of 386 the household left Milan for Verecundus' estate in the country. Augustine calls the place Cassiciacum. Where exactly it was is not known, and Chapter Ten says more about that.

The important thing is who went, because it was not a hermitage and it was not a monastery. It was a house party with an unusual reading list.

On the evidence of the books written there, the group was: Augustine; his mother Monica; his son Adeodatus, then about fourteen; his brother Navigius; his friend Alypius, who had been in the garden with him; two teenage pupils, Licentius and Trygetius, whose fees were presumably still being paid by their families; and two cousins, Lastidianus and Rusticus, who are described as having had almost no formal schooling and who are nevertheless in the room and speaking.

That list is worth holding on to for the rest of this part. Nine people, three generations, one of them an uneducated woman in her fifties, two of them teenagers, two of them relatives with no Latin training. This is the company in which Augustine spent the months between his conversion and his baptism.

2.2 — Otium, and what they were doing all day

WORD BOX

Otium: usually translated “leisure”, which is misleading. For a Roman of Augustine's class, *otium* was the opposite of public business, not the opposite of work. It meant withdrawing from office, litigation and the crowd in order to read, write and talk — and it was a recognised, respectable, thoroughly upper-class thing to do.

A wealthy man who retired to his estate to study was following a pattern with centuries behind it. Cicero did it and wrote about doing it.

Why it matters: what Augustine did in the autumn of 386 had an existing shape available to it, and he used that shape. Whether he was doing an old thing in a new spirit or simply doing the old thing is the argument in this chapter.

The routine, as far as it can be reconstructed, was mornings of agricultural business and reading, and afternoons and evenings of sustained discussion, some of it taken down by a stenographer. When the weather was bad they moved into the baths. When it was fine they sat in a meadow. A rooster fight interrupts one session and turns into an argument about order. Somebody complains about the noise of water in a channel outside and that becomes an argument too.

Four works survive from those months, and their subjects are: whether certainty is possible at all, what happiness is, whether there is order in the world including its evils, and a dialogue between Augustine and his own reason about the soul and God.

In English they are usually called *Against the Academics*, *On the Happy Life*, *On Order* and the *Soliloquies*. Augustine also mentions letters going back and forth with Nebridius, and those survive too.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

This chapter rests on something the rest of the series does not have.

For every other episode in the *Confessions*, the only witness is Augustine writing about eleven years later. For these months we have four complete books written at the time, by him, naming the participants and describing the setting.

One of them, *On the Happy Life*, dates itself. It opens by saying the discussion began on his birthday and ran three days, which places it in the middle of November 386, and it lists everyone present including his mother. Monica is not a silent figure in it. She argues, she is quoted at length, and at one point Augustine records her producing a line of an Ambrose hymn from memory at exactly the right moment in the argument.

What that supports: the retreat happened, the people were there, the dates are roughly right, and Monica was intellectually present in a way that the *Confessions* only hints at.

What it cannot support: any of Augustine's claims about his inner state during those months. A book is evidence of what a man wrote down, not of what he was.

2.3 — The psalm, and the anger in it

One passage in this chapter of Book Nine is not about philosophy at all. Augustine describes reading the Psalms and what they did to him, and singles out the fourth.

What he describes is not calm. He says he was set on fire by it; that he would have shouted it at the whole human race if he could; and — this is the part that is usually skipped — that he wished the Manichees could have been watching him read it without his knowing they were there, so that they could see what the psalm was doing to him.

Two things are worth pulling out of that. The first is the competitive edge. Nine years of his life had gone into a religion he now thought was false, and he wants his old friends to see

him. Even in the middle of what he presents as an ecstatic reading, he is thinking about an audience of Manichees.

The second is what the psalm was doing. The Psalms are not philosophical texts and they do not argue. They complain, accuse, plead and celebrate. A man who has spent his whole education learning to construct arguments is reporting that the thing which moved him most in that autumn was a book that does not make any.

Whether the reading of Psalm Four happened as described in the autumn of 386, or whether an older Augustine has placed a later experience there because it belongs there in the argument, cannot be settled. The Cassiciacum books do not mention it.

2.4 — What the dialogues look like from outside

Now the difficulty. Part Five set out the central dispute of *Confessions* scholarship — whether the garden scene happened as described — and said the strongest evidence against it comes from these books. This is where that evidence sits, so this is where it has to be handled.

The problem in one sentence: a man who has just had the experience described in Book Eight sat down within weeks and wrote elegant philosophical dialogues in which Christ is barely mentioned, the church hardly appears, and the frame of reference is recognisably that of an educated late-Roman Platonist.

That is not a hostile summary. It is what the books are like, and anybody can check.

THE ARGUMENT — DO THE CASSICIACUM DIALOGUES SUPPORT OR UNDERMINE BOOK NINE?

This is the same evidence as the Part Five dispute, seen from the other side. In Part Five the question was whether the garden happened. Here the question is what four surviving books written weeks later actually show. The argument has been running since 1918 and it is not close to settled.

THEY UNDERMINE IT

Read them cold and they are the works of a philosopher on a reading holiday. The vocabulary is Platonist. The authorities cited are Cicero, Varro and the philosophical tradition. Scripture appears rarely and often decoratively. The problems taken up — scepticism, happiness, order — are the standing problems of the schools.

Set beside Book Nine, which says these months were spent breathing in the Psalms, that is a gap wide enough to need explaining. The simplest explanation is that the religious intensity described in Books Eight and Nine is the reading of a bishop in his forties projected back onto a man in his thirties who was, at the time, a Platonist who had decided to be baptised.

THEY SUPPORT IT

This objection weighs silence and does not weigh what is there. The *Soliloquies* opens with a long prayer and is a conversation with God about the soul; that is not a Platonist genre. *On the Happy Life* ends on a Trinitarian note and gives its closing argument to Monica, an uneducated Christian woman, who wins it. Ambrose is invoked. His hymns are quoted from memory by the person quoting them, not by the author showing off.

And the biographical facts around the books are not in dispute at all. He resigned the chair. He was baptised at Easter. The engagement was cancelled. Those are not literary effects.

THE GENRE OBJECTION

A third position, and the one that has gained ground: the argument assumes a philosophical dialogue in 386 was a place where a man could say what had happened to him. It was not. It was a formal genre with inherited rules about subject, register and cast.

Expecting Christ in *Against the Academics* is like expecting a man's grief in his tax return.

Absence from a form that excludes the thing is not evidence about the man.

On this reading the dialogues and the *Confessions* are not two reports of the same months in conflict. They are a public performance and a private account, and the second was written in a genre Augustine had to more or less invent because none existed.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes what the dialogues contain or when they were written. What is disputed is whether their tone is evidence about Augustine's state of mind, or evidence about fourth-century literary convention.

What would settle it: A private letter from those months, written to someone he was not trying to impress, would settle a great deal. The letters to Nebridius are the closest thing and they lean towards the philosophical side, though they are letters between two men who talked philosophy for a living.

Why people care so much: Because it decides whether the *Confessions* is a memoir or a theological reconstruction. And because it is the only place in the whole work where Augustine's account can be checked against Augustine.

A position, declared: the genre objection seems to me the strongest of the three, and I will write the rest of this part on the assumption that the dialogues and Book Nine are compatible. But that assumption should be visible to you, because it shapes how Chapter Seven reads, and a reader who takes the first position will find Chapter Seven far more suspicious than I do.

What is not in dispute is the shape of the winter. He stopped teaching, moved to somebody else's house with his mother and his son, wrote four books, argued with teenagers about the order of the universe, read the Psalms, and waited for Easter. Then, in the middle of it, he got toothache.

REMEMBER THIS

In the autumn of 386 the household moved to a borrowed estate called **Cassiciacum**. Nine people: Augustine, Monica, Adeodatus, his brother, Alypius, two teenage pupils and two barely-schooled cousins.

What they were doing had an established Roman name, **otium** — withdrawal from public business into reading and argument. It was a respectable, familiar, upper-class thing to do.

Four books written there survive, plus letters. That makes these months the only stretch of Augustine's life where his own contemporary writing can be set against his later account of himself.

He also describes being **set on fire by Psalm Four** — and wishing the Manichees could have watched him read it. Even the ecstasy has an audience in mind.

The dialogues are **markedly more philosophical and less Christian** than Book Nine leads you to expect. Whether that is evidence about Augustine or evidence about the genre is a hundred-year-old argument and it is not settled.

CHAPTER THREE

The Toothache

A book of this size, on subjects of this weight, stops for a paragraph to tell you that Augustine's tooth hurt. It is not a lapse. It is one of the most carefully placed things in Book Nine.

3.1 What he says happened

Somewhere in the middle of the Cassiciacum months, Augustine got toothache. He says the pain grew until he could not speak at all.

He wanted the others in the house to pray for him. He could not ask them out loud. So he wrote the request on a wax tablet and handed it over to be read.

They knelt. The pain went. He says it went completely, and that it went at once, and that it frightened him.

That is the whole episode. It occupies a few lines in a book that gives roughly the same space to the death of Nebridius.

3.2 — Why it is in the book

Three things are doing work here, and they are worth separating.

The first is the silence. This is a man who a few weeks earlier could hold a hall in Milan for an hour, and whose chest had already begun to take the voice away. Now he cannot form a sentence to ask for help, and has to write it down and pass it to somebody else to say aloud. Book Nine keeps taking his voice off him. The lungs take it in Chapter One. The tooth takes it here. In Chapter Nine he stands at a graveside and cannot make a sound because he has decided not to.

The second is the ordinariness. Book Eight is the most famous religious scene in Latin literature, and the reader arrives at Book Nine with the volume turned up. Augustine turns it down, hard, within a few pages, by inserting the least exalted physical fact available to him. Whatever is being claimed about these months, it is being claimed about a life that includes toothache.

The third is that it is his first. He presents this as the first time he asked for something and had it, and the fright in his account is the fright of a man who has just found out that a

transaction he had been discussing for years might be live. He had spent a decade arguing about the nature of God. He had not, on this account, asked God for anything and had it happen.

IN REAL TERMS

Toothache in 386 is not the toothache you are picturing.

There was no dentistry worth the name. Extraction, when it happened, was done with forceps by whoever had them, with no anaesthetic beyond wine or a plant preparation that might poison you. The medical writers recommend rinses, poultices, cautery and prayer, in roughly that order of enthusiasm.

An abscessed tooth in the fourth century was also not necessarily survivable. Infection in the jaw can travel, and before antibiotics it sometimes travelled far enough to kill. Augustine had no way of knowing which kind he had.

So “the pain was so bad he could not speak” is not a complaint about discomfort. It is a man in a country house with no help available, in pain of a kind that had no treatment, which might be the start of something that would end him.

3.3 — The trap, which catches both kinds of reader

A believing reader arrives at this passage and finds a miracle. A sceptical reader arrives and finds a stress-related pain that remitted on its own at the moment when a frightened man was finally surrounded by people paying attention to him, which is a well-known pattern.

Both readings are available and this series is not going to choose between them, for the reason given in Part One: it does not adjudicate religious claims. But it is worth noticing that the two readings are usually held in a way that makes them rivals, and that Augustine himself does not hold them that way at all.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT AN EVENT HAS EITHER A NATURAL EXPLANATION OR A DIVINE ONE, AND THEY COMPETE FOR THE SAME SLOT

The argument about the tooth is conducted as though there were one vacancy and two candidates. If tension explains the pain going, God did not do it. If God did it, then it was not tension.

Everybody on both sides accepts the terms.

Augustine does not, and neither did anyone else in his century. On his account God does not act in competition with the ordinary causes of things. God is what holds the ordinary causes in being. So a pain that stops because a frightened man calms down is not a rival explanation to a pain that stops because he was heard. It is a description of the mechanism by which he was heard.

You do not have to accept that framework. It is worth seeing that it is a framework, and that a great deal of modern argument about miracles is aimed at a claim nobody in this book is making.

Test it somewhere neutral. A doctor says a patient recovered because the antibiotic worked. The patient says they recovered because their sister found them and called an ambulance. Neither statement is a refutation of the other, and asking which of the two “really” caused the recovery is a question about what you wanted to know, not about what happened.

The general form: treating an explanation at one level as a competitor to an explanation at another.

The reason this matters beyond the tooth is that the same structure is about to be used on much bigger material. Chapter Four has a blind man who says he could see. Chapter Seven has an experience at a window that two people claim to have had at once. In both places the argument tends to collapse into the same false pair, and it will help to have noticed it here, on a subject where nobody has anything invested.

REMEMBER THIS

At Cassiciacum, Augustine had **toothache so severe he could not speak**. He wrote his request for prayer on a **wax tablet** and passed it to the others. They knelt; the pain stopped; he was frightened.

The passage keeps doing what Book Nine keeps doing: **taking his voice away**. The lungs in Chapter One, the tooth here, and a deliberate silence at the graveside in Chapter Nine.

In fourth-century terms this was not a small complaint. There was no dentistry, no anaesthetic and no antibiotics, and an infected tooth could kill you.

He presents it as the **first time** he asked for something and got it, and the tone is closer to alarm than to triumph.

The modern argument about the passage assumes a natural explanation and a divine one **compete for the same slot**. Augustine’s framework does not work that way, and noticing that here will save trouble in Chapters Four and Seven.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Water

A letter to a bishop, a book he could not get through, a night in April, and a congregation that had spent the previous year sleeping in its own church to keep the soldiers out.

4.1 — The book he could not read

When the vacation ended, the household went back to Milan to prepare for baptism at Easter. Augustine wrote to Ambrose asking what he should read to get ready.

Ambrose said Isaiah. Augustine started it, could not follow the opening, assumed the rest would be as hard, and put it down, meaning to come back when he had more practice at this kind of writing.

It is a very small thing and it is worth a moment. This is a professional reader — the best-trained reader in the city, arguably, a man who taught other people how to take texts apart for a living — reporting that his bishop set him a book and he could not do it.

He is also, quietly, telling you something about Ambrose. The relationship between the two men is one of the strange gaps in the *Confessions*. Ambrose is the reason Augustine could take Christianity seriously at all, and by Book Nine they are exchanging notes about a reading list, and there is not one recorded conversation between them about anything that had happened in that garden. Part Four already noted that Ambrose was permanently busy and effectively unreachable. Book Nine does not fix that.

4.2 — What being baptised meant

WORD BOX

Catechumen: someone enrolled in the church and receiving instruction, but not baptised.

Augustine had been one since infancy. It was an ordinary long-term status, not a waiting room: plenty of people stayed catechumens for decades, including, until near the end, his own father.

Competens: a catechumen who has given in their name for baptism at the coming Easter and entered the final weeks of preparation. Augustine became one in the spring of 387.

Why it matters: the church of the fourth century kept things back. Catechumens were sent out of the building before the eucharist. The creed and the Lord's Prayer were formally handed over only in the final weeks, and were meant to be memorised and not written down. So a man could be, as Augustine was, a lifelong catechumen who had never seen the central act of the religion he was arguing about.

The baptism took place at the Easter vigil, on the night of 24 April 387. Three of them went in together: Augustine, Alypius, and Adeodatus, who was about fifteen.

On the ceremony itself Augustine says almost nothing. There is no description of the water, the words, the oil, the white garment or the bishop. What he gives instead is one sentence about the effect: that the anxiety about his old life ran out of him.

This is a writer who has just spent an entire book on a scene in a garden. He gives the sacrament that scene was heading towards a line and a half. Chapter Ten comes back to why.

4.3 — The singing

What he does describe, at length and with obvious feeling, is the singing.

He says the voices of the congregation went into his ears, and the truth was distilled into his heart out of them, and the feeling overflowed, and he wept, and it did him good. It is one of the very few places in the *Confessions* where he describes an experience without immediately taking it apart.

WORD BOX

The Ambrosian hymns: short Latin hymns in a simple, strongly regular metre, written to be sung by an ordinary congregation with no training, in verses that alternate between two halves of the church.

Four are securely Ambrose's, on Augustine's own testimony elsewhere. One of them, an evening hymn beginning with the words for "God, maker of all things", returns in Chapter Nine at the worst moment of Augustine's life.

Why it matters: this was a new technology. Congregational singing in that form was an import from the Greek-speaking east, and Milan is where it entered the Latin west. Within a generation it was everywhere. Augustine is describing the first time a European congregation sang together like this, and he is describing it as a man in the crowd.

4.4 — Why they were singing

Then Augustine explains where the singing came from, and the explanation is a piece of hard political history dropped into the middle of a conversion narrative.

About a year before, the imperial court and the bishop of Milan had gone to war over a building.

WORD BOX

The Milanese basilica crisis: the emperor Valentinian the Second was a boy, and effective power lay with his mother, Justina. The court held a different account of Christ from Ambrose's, and wanted a church building in Milan for its own congregation. Ambrose refused to hand one over. Troops were sent.

Augustine calls the court party **Arians**. Historians generally do not, because the label is his side's, and the men involved would not have used it. They held that the Son is *like* the Father, and declined the Nicene formula that he is of the same substance. **Homoian** is the usual modern term. Why it matters: it was not a theologians' quarrel conducted in letters. It was a siege, in a city, involving soldiers, over a difference in wording about the relation between the Father and the Son.

The congregation occupied the church and would not leave. They slept in it. They were prepared, Augustine says, to die there with their bishop. And the reason the hymns were introduced was practical: people who are camped in a building waiting for troops need something to do that is not being frightened, and Ambrose gave them something to sing.

Then Augustine names one of the people in that building. His mother was in the front rank of them, he says, among the leaders of the watch, living on prayer.

And he places himself: not yet warmed by any of it, he says, but stirred all the same by the state of the city.

It is a small, precise piece of self-placing and it does a lot of work. In the spring of 386 Monica was sleeping on the floor of a church expecting soldiers, and her son was a professor with an interesting new philosophical position. The two of them are eighteen months and one window at Ostia apart.

4.5 — The bodies under the floor

The crisis ended, in Augustine's telling, with something else.

Ambrose was shown in a dream where the bodies of two forgotten martyrs, Gervasius and Protasius, were buried. They were dug up, reportedly undecayed, and carried in procession to Ambrose's new basilica. Augustine reports that a man in the city who had been blind for years touched the bier with a cloth, put the cloth to his eyes, and could see. He says the court's hostility was checked by it, though not converted.

This series does not rule on the blind man. What it can do is say exactly how much of this is checkable, because the answer is unusual.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

This is the best-attested episode anywhere in the *Confessions*.

Ambrose describes the discovery and the procession in a letter to his sister, written days after it happened, and preached about it. Those texts survive. A biography of Ambrose written by his former secretary a generation later describes the same events. The wider political crisis is documented in Ambrose's own correspondence with the court and in his sermon against the rival bishop, all of it written at the time and independent of Augustine.

Augustine also tells the story a second time, some thirty years later, in *The City of God*, where he says flatly that he was in Milan when it happened and names the blind man.

What that supports: the crisis, the occupation of the church, the introduction of congregational hymn-singing at Milan at that date, the discovery of the two bodies, the procession, and the fact that a man in the city was widely believed to have recovered his sight.

What it cannot support: whether he recovered his sight. Multiple independent witnesses to a claim are not witnesses to the thing claimed. And on the timing of the bodies, everybody reporting it was on the same side of a political fight that the discovery immediately helped to win. Both facts should be held at once, and usually are not.

The honest summary is that we know a great deal about the circumstances and nothing at all about the man's eyes, and that anyone who tells you the corroboration settles the miracle has confused two different questions — which is exactly the confusion Chapter Three was about.

REMEMBER THIS

Ambrose told Augustine to read **Isaiah** before his baptism. Augustine could not follow it and **gave up**, meaning to come back to it later.

He was baptised at the **Easter vigil of 24 April 387**, along with **Alypius** and his son **Adeodatus**. He says almost nothing about the ceremony and one line about the effect.

What he does describe is **the singing**, at length, as one of the few experiences in the book he does not immediately dismantle.

The singing existed because of a **political siege**. A year earlier the congregation had occupied its own church against imperial troops, and Ambrose introduced hymns to hold them together.

Monica was in the front rank of that occupation while her son was still, by his own description, unmoved.

The **discovery of two martyrs' bodies** and a blind man's reported recovery closed the crisis. It is the best-documented episode in the book from outside sources — which establishes the events, and does not establish the cure.

CHAPTER FIVE

Adeodatus

Augustine had a son for about seventeen years. In four hundred pages of self-examination the boy gets roughly a page, and one sentence of it has been read against his father ever since.

5.1 — What we are told

Adeodatus was born around 372, when Augustine was about eighteen. His mother is the woman Part Four was about: the partner Augustine lived with for over a decade, whom he never names, and who was sent back to Africa in 385 so that he could make an advantageous marriage.

The name means “given by God”. It was a real name in Roman Africa, not an invention, and it is also the sort of name you notice.

When the woman was sent away, the boy stayed. Book Six does not say so and Book Nine does not say so; we know it because Adeodatus is at Cassiciacum in 386, arguing, in books that survive. A child of about thirteen was separated from his mother and kept by his father, and neither the separation nor the keeping is anywhere described.

What Augustine does say about him, in Book Nine, comes to about four things. That he was baptised with them at Easter 387 at the age of about fifteen. That his intelligence was extraordinary — better, Augustine says, than that of many serious and educated adults. That God took him early. And that he remembers him without anxiety, because there was nothing in the boy’s childhood or adolescence to be afraid of.

5.2 — “Nothing of him was mine but the sin”

And then the sentence. Speaking of Adeodatus, Augustine says that he contributed nothing to the boy except the sin.

It is one of the harshest-sounding lines in the book and it has been quoted against him for sixteen centuries. It is worth being careful about what it does and does not say.

It does not say the boy was a sin, or that Augustine wished he had not existed, or that he did not love him. The clause it belongs to is a piece of praise: everything good in this child came from you, and the only part of him I can claim as my own contribution is the wrong in how he was made. It is the standard shape of Augustine’s compliments, applied to his son.

That is the defence, and it is a real one. Here is what it does not cover. Augustine had a theological account of sexual desire on which a child conceived outside marriage carried something of the circumstances of its conception, and by the time he wrote this sentence he had been developing that account for years. The line is not only a rhetorical flourish. It is also load-bearing, and it became more load-bearing in the twenty-year fight with Pelagius that Part Seven has to deal with.

A position, declared: I think the sentence is both things at once, and that the arguments about it usually fail because each side needs it to be only one. It is genuinely a compliment. It also genuinely contains a doctrine that would go on to do a great deal of damage. Those are not in competition.

5.3 — The dialogue

WORD BOX

De magistro — “On the Teacher”: a short dialogue Augustine wrote around 388, in which the only other speaker is Adeodatus. It argues, roughly, that words cannot actually teach anybody anything, and that what a teacher does is prompt the learner to consult a truth they already have access to.

Augustine states in the *Confessions* that everything the other speaker says in that book is genuinely his son’s, spoken when the boy was sixteen.

Why it matters: this is the only case in the entire work where we have a transcript, of a kind, of a person other than Augustine. It is also, if the claim is true, the only surviving words of anybody in his family.

The claim should be handled carefully, because a philosophical dialogue is a literary form and the interlocutor in one is normally a device. Augustine knew that better than anybody. He goes out of his way to say that this one is not — which is either an unusual piece of testimony or an unusually specific piece of literary decoration.

Read as testimony, it says something quite moving and quite uncomfortable at once. A father wrote down his son’s arguments, kept them, published them, and then in a later book told the world they were real. He did that after the boy was dead. It is the only monument he built to him.

5.4 — The death, and the page

Adeodatus died young. Augustine says only that God took him early from the earth. He does not give a date, a place, a cause, or a scene. From other evidence the death is usually put around 389 or 390, in Africa, when the boy was about seventeen.

Set that beside what the same book does with the death of Monica. She gets four sections, a deathbed conversation, a funeral, an argument about grief, and a prayer. Adeodatus gets a sentence.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A RELATIONSHIP LEAVES A TRACE IN THE TEXT IN PROPORTION TO ITS WEIGHT

The instinct, reading Book Nine, is to convert page-count into feeling. Monica has chapters, so she mattered. Adeodatus has a sentence, so something was wrong. The unnamed woman has no name, so she was nothing.

The assumption is that a book about a life is a scale model of it. It is not, and this one in particular is not. The *Confessions* is an argument with a narrative attached, and people appear in it in proportion to their function in the argument, not their weight in the life.

Monica is in it at length because she is the book's counter-example: the uneducated woman who arrived where the professor arrived, without the professor's route. Adeodatus has almost no function in that argument at all. He is simply somebody Augustine loved.

This cuts both ways and that is the point. It blocks the inference from silence to indifference, which is the reading Augustine's defenders want blocked. It also blocks the inference from prominence to feeling, which means the four chapters on Monica cannot be used as proof of anything about how he felt about her either. You do not get to keep one and drop the other.

The general form: reading a text as a measuring instrument for the life behind it.

There is one further thing worth having, which is not a defence and is not a charge, but a piece of context that most modern readers of this passage do not carry.

IN REAL TERMS

It is worth resisting the temptation to read a fourth-century father by a modern one.

Roughly a third of Roman children died before the age of ten. A parent who reached fifty had usually buried at least one child. Grief was not less, but it was not remarkable, and there was no expectation that a man would write about his son at all.

Against that background, "he was clever, I had nothing to do with it, God took him, I am not afraid when I remember him" is not a cold paragraph. It is more than most Roman fathers wrote about a dead child, by a considerable margin.

And it is still one paragraph, in a book of four hundred pages, by a man who could describe a pear theft for eleven of them.

Both of those sentences are true at once, and a reader who can only hold one of them will get this chapter wrong in one of the two available directions.

REMEMBER THIS

Adeodatus — the name means “given by God” — was born about 372 to the woman Augustine never names. When she was sent back to Africa in 385, the boy stayed. Neither the separation nor the arrangement is ever described.

He was baptised with his father and Alypius at Easter 387, at about **fifteen**, and Augustine says his mind was better than that of many educated adults.

The sentence “**nothing of him was mine but the sin**” is both a compliment in Augustine’s standard form and a piece of a doctrine that would harden over the next thirty years. It is not necessary to choose.

The dialogue ***On the Teacher*** gives Adeodatus a speaking part, and Augustine insists the arguments in it are really the boy’s. If true, they are the only surviving words of anyone in his family.

He died at about **seventeen**, around 389 or 390. Augustine gives the death one clause. The size of that silence is not, on its own, evidence of anything — and neither is the size of the four chapters on his mother.

CHAPTER SIX

Monica, Told Backwards

Before the window and before the funeral, Augustine stops the narrative and gives you his mother's whole life. What he chooses to put in it is the most interesting decision in Book Nine.

6.1 — Where the chapter sits, and why that matters

The order of Book Nine is worth having in front of you. The resignation. Cassiciacum. The baptism. The siege of the basilica. Then two sections on Monica's life from childhood. Then Ostia. Then her death.

The retrospective comes *before* the window and *before* the deathbed. By the time you reach the famous scene you already know about the wine, the violent husband, and the advice she gave to women who were being hit. That is not how a hagiographer arranges material. A hagiographer puts the faults early and small, or leaves them out, and builds towards the death.

Augustine builds towards the death too. But he insists on loading the run-up with a drinking problem in a child and a marriage that a modern reader will find hard to read about. Whatever he is doing, he is doing it on purpose.

6.2 — The old servant and the rule about water

Monica was born around 331 or 332 in Thagaste, in a Christian household with money and servants. The person who actually brought her up was not her mother.

It was an elderly household servant who had, as a girl, carried Monica's own father about on her back — the way older children were used to carry small ones. Because of that history she was trusted, and the daughters of the house were handed over to her.

She was severe, and she had a theory. She would not let the girls drink water between meals, however thirsty they were, and her reasoning was not about water. Augustine records it: you drink water now because you cannot get at the wine; when you are married women with the keys to the store-room, water will not be good enough for you, but the habit of drinking will still be there.

It is a piece of practical psychology from a fourth-century domestic servant, preserved because a bishop thought it was worth writing down, and it is more sophisticated than a great deal of

what gets said about habit today. The claim is that the object of a habit is not what forms the habit. The reaching is what forms the habit. Change what is within reach later and the reaching will go on.

6.3 — The wine

The rule did not work, and the way it failed is the best-told small story in the *Confessions*.

Because she was a sober and obedient girl, Monica was the one sent down to draw wine from the cask. She would dip the cup in through the opening at the top, and before pouring it into the jug she would put it to her lips and take the smallest possible sip.

Augustine is careful about the motive, and the care is the point. She did not do it because she wanted wine; she disliked it. She did it out of what he calls a surplus of high spirits, the kind that bubbles out of children in silly impulses and that is normally kept down by the weight of adults in the room. In the cellar there were no adults.

Then the sentence that makes the passage: adding a little every day, she came to be drinking cups nearly full, and enjoying it.

He does not say she became a drunk. He says a girl who did not like wine, doing something mildly naughty for fun, ended up drinking seriously without ever making a decision to.

Nobody chose anything. The quantity moved on its own.

This is the same mechanism the series has met before under a different name. Part Five spent a chapter on Augustine's account of habit — the thing you chose so often that it stopped being a choice and started being a weight. He gives the clearest illustration of it in the whole book to his mother, and puts it thirty years before he was born.

WORD BOX

Meribibula: the word the servant threw at her. It is built from the Latin for unmixed wine — *merum*, wine not watered down — and a word for drinking. Something like “neat-wine-swiller”. Romans normally drank wine mixed with water, often heavily. Drinking it *merum* was the mark of a drunk, and to call a young woman of a respectable house that was a serious insult, not a tease. Why it matters: it is a specific, ugly, colloquial word, and it is preserved because it worked.

The cure came from a quarrel. The maidservant who used to go down to the cellar with her fell out with her one day when they were alone, and threw it at her as an insult. Monica heard it, saw what she had become, and stopped.

Augustine draws the moral himself, and it is characteristically sideways: flattering friends corrupt people and quarrelling enemies often correct them, and God gets no less credit for

using someone who meant harm. The servant was not trying to help. She was trying to win an argument.

6.4 — The marriage

Monica was married young to Patricius, a man of some standing in Thagaste and no great wealth. Two things about him are stated flatly and never softened: he was unfaithful, and he had a violent temper.

Her method with the temper is described as a technique, which is exactly what it was. She never opposed him while he was angry — not in an act, Augustine says, and not in a word. When it had passed and he was calm, she would explain what she had done, if it looked as though he had lost his temper over nothing.

On the infidelity she said nothing at all, and waited.

IN REAL TERMS

The legal position of a wife in Roman Africa in the 340s is worth having, because without it this passage reads as pure temperament, and it was not.

A married woman had property rights, and divorce was legally possible and not rare. But a wife who left took her dowry into a lawsuit, depended on her birth family to take her back, and in a small inland town had no route to an independent household. A husband's infidelity was not a legal wrong against her. His violence was not policed by anybody.

Adultery by a wife, by contrast, was a criminal matter.

So the situation Monica was managing was: a man legally entitled to behave as he was behaving, in a town where the alternative to managing him was returning to her father's house as a failure, with children.

None of that makes the advice in the next section good advice. It makes it advice about a real situation rather than a philosophy of submission.

6.5 — What she told the other women

This is the hardest passage in Book Nine and the series is not going to walk past it.

Other wives in Thagaste, Augustine says, whose husbands were milder than hers, came to conversation with the marks of blows on their faces, and complained about their husbands' behaviour. Monica told them the fault was in their tongues.

Her argument, delivered in a joking tone about a serious thing, was this: from the day you sat and heard the marriage contract read out, you should have understood it as the document that made you a servant; so remember your position, and do not set yourself up against your master.

Augustine reports that the women were amazed, because they knew what Patricius was like, and it had never been heard in the town that he had struck her, or that the two of them had quarrelled for a single day.

Four things need saying and they need saying separately.

One. The advice is that women being beaten should speak less. There is no way to phrase it that removes that, and attempts to do so usually work by leaving out the faces.

Two. Augustine puts it in. He is writing a book in praise of his mother, at the height of his powers, in full control of what goes on the page, and he includes the beaten women and her answer to them. He could have left it out and nobody would ever have known.

Three. He presents it as evidence of her wisdom. He does not flag it as troubling, and there is no sign that he found it so.

Four. The strategy worked for her, in the sense that she was not hit, and the town noticed. Whether it worked because of the strategy, or because Patricius happened not to be a man who hit his wife, is not something anybody can know. Augustine assumes the first. The evidence is equally consistent with the second, and the sample size is one.

A position, declared, because this series says where it stands rather than hiding behind the material: the advice is bad, the reasoning behind it is worse, and the passage is nevertheless one of the most honest things in the book. Those are not in tension. A man constructing a saint does not hand you the sentence about the marriage contract making you a servant. He hands you the patience and stops.

6.6 — The mother-in-law, and the thing she would not do

Two more items complete the portrait, and both are about handling other people.

Patricius' mother lived with them and was set against Monica at first by servants carrying stories. Monica did not fight back and did not complain; she was simply relentlessly deferential until the older woman changed her mind, at which point the mother-in-law went to her son, named the servants who had been making trouble, and asked him to deal with them. He had them beaten. Augustine records the beating without comment, as the ordinary outcome it was.

The last item is the one Augustine says he values most, and it is characteristically unglamorous. When she heard two people saying bitter things about each other, she carried nothing between them except what would help to reconcile them. Not a word of the rest.

He adds, drily, that this looks like a small virtue only to people who have not had much experience of the alternative.

And at the end of it: Patricius was baptised shortly before he died, in 371, when Augustine was about seventeen. Monica outlived him by sixteen years and never remarried.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THIS A PORTRAIT OR A HAGIOGRAPHY?

Book Nine gives Monica more space than anyone in the *Confessions* except Augustine and God, and every reader has to decide what kind of writing it is. The three positions below are all held by serious readers and none of them is silly.

IT IS A HAGIOGRAPHY

Look at the architecture. Every fault is placed in childhood and resolved before adulthood. The drinking is cured by a servant's insult; the difficult mother-in-law is won over; the husband is converted at the last possible moment. Nothing goes wrong that does not get put right.

And the faults that remain are not treated as faults. Her possessive grip on her son is described in Book Five, where she follows him to the coast and he lies to her to get on the ship, and in Book Nine it has become devotion. The advice to the beaten women is offered as wisdom. A portrait would have registered the cost.

IT IS A PORTRAIT

A hagiographer would not have written the cellar. He would not have given the reader a child who dislikes wine and ends up drinking cups of it, and he would not have used the actual insult.

And he would certainly not have written the sentence about the marriage contract. Sixteen centuries of readers have found that passage difficult, which is a fair indication that it is not there to make anybody comfortable. The material is unflattering, specific, and volunteered.

IT IS NEITHER; IT IS AN ARGUMENT

A third reading, and the one that explains the placing. Monica is in Book Nine at this length because she is the book's control experiment.

The whole work is the record of an educated man who needed Cicero, nine years of Manichaeism, scepticism, Ambrose, the Platonists and a crisis in a garden to get where he got. Monica got there with none of it. She could not have followed a page of the books that changed his mind. Setting her life out in full, immediately before the scene at Ostia where she keeps up with him and then goes past him, is the argument: the route he took was not the road, it was his detour.

On this reading the unflattering details are not honesty and not sloppiness. They are necessary. The control has to be a real person or the experiment proves nothing.

Where things stand: The contents of the two sections are not in dispute. What is disputed is the genre, and therefore how much of the portrait can be used as biographical evidence about a real woman.

What would settle it: Almost nothing would settle it. Monica left no writing. Everything known about her comes from her son, except her name, her dates and her epitaph. The one partial exception is the *Cassiciacum* dialogues, where she speaks in her own right and holds her own — written by the same son, but for a different purpose and a different audience.

Why people care so much: Because Monica has been used for sixteen centuries as a model of what a Christian mother should be, by people who were not reading her as a literary construction. If the third position is right, a great deal of that has been built on a figure designed to make a point about somebody else.

A position, declared: the third reading seems to me clearly right about the function of these two sections in the book, and it does not settle the first question, because a portrait can be true and be doing a job at the same time. What I would resist is the idea that noticing the job is a way of catching Augustine out. He is not hiding it. The sections are placed exactly where the argument needs them.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine puts his mother's **entire life before the window and the deathbed**, not after, and loads the run-up with material that does her no favours.

As a girl she was made to go thirsty by a strict old servant who argued, correctly, that **the reaching forms the habit, not the thing reached for**.

Sent to draw wine, she sipped for fun, **added a little each day**, and ended up drinking cups of it without ever deciding to. A maidservant stopped it in a quarrel by calling her a **meribibula**.

Her husband **Patricius** was unfaithful and violently tempered. Her method was never to answer him while he was angry, and to explain afterwards. She was never known to have been hit.

To other women in the town who **came with marks on their faces**, she said the fault was in their tongues, and that the marriage contract had made them servants. The advice is bad. That Augustine printed it is the strongest evidence in the chapter that he is not simply manufacturing a saint.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Window

A man and his mother lean on a windowsill in a port town, waiting for a ship, and have a conversation that people have been arguing about for sixteen hundred years.

7.1 — Why they were at Ostia at all

After the baptism the household decided to go home. Not back to teaching, and not back to Thagaste to resume anything, but home to Africa, where Augustine intended to set up some kind of shared life of study and prayer on the family property.

They went as far as Ostia and stopped.

WORD BOX

Ostia: the port at the mouth of the Tiber, about fifteen miles downriver from Rome, and the point through which most of Rome's imported grain arrived. By the 380s it was past its peak but still a working town of warehouses, shipping agents, baths and lodging houses.

From Ostia to Carthage was a voyage of a few days with a following wind, and impossible for months of the year. Ancient shipping largely shut down over the winter.

Why it matters: they were not there for the scenery. They were waiting for a berth.

Augustine does not say what the delay was. Historians have a strong candidate: in the summer of 387 the usurper Maximus came over the Alps into Italy, the imperial court fled, and there was a naval and military emergency across the western Mediterranean for the best part of a year. Whether that is what held them at Ostia is a reasonable inference and nothing more.

IN REAL TERMS

Set the scene properly, because the passage is usually imagined as a chapel and it was not.

A rented room in a lodging house in a busy port. A long journey behind them and an open-ended wait in front. A group of eight or nine people including two teenagers, a brother, and various relatives, all in each other's way. Outside, warehouses and shipping.

Two of them get away from the others for a while and lean on a windowsill looking at the courtyard garden.

Everything that follows happens there.

7.2 — The conversation

They were alone and they were talking, Augustine says, very sweetly. He describes them as forgetting what was behind and reaching for what was in front, which is a phrase from Paul and which sets the register for everything after it.

The question they were on was: what will the eternal life of the saints be like? Not whether there is one. What it would be like.

And then, in the space of one paragraph, the conversation does something that Augustine reports as having happened rather than as having been thought.

7.3 — The climb

The movement has steps and he numbers them in effect, so it is worth laying out plainly.

- They went through bodily things — everything you can touch — and past them.
- They went through the heavens, sun, moon and stars, and past them.
- They went up further by talking about God’s works and being astonished at them, which is a strange and important detail: the ascent is happening *through the conversation*, not despite it.
- They arrived at their own minds and went past those too.
- And they came to a region he calls one of never-failing plenty, where what there is is the Wisdom by which everything else was made — which is not made, and in which there is no “was” and no “will be”, only “is”.

Then the sentence everybody remembers. While they were talking about it and straining towards it, he says, they touched it a little, with one whole beat of the heart.

And then they sighed, and left something of themselves attached to it, and came back down to the noise of their own mouths, where a word starts and stops.

Three things in that are worth flagging now and will matter in Chapter Eight. It is **brief**. It is **shared**. And the return is described without any of the language of failure.

7.4 — The sentence that follows

What comes next is a single enormous conditional sentence, one of the most famous in Latin, and it is worth understanding what kind of sentence it is before worrying about what it says.

It is not a claim. It is an “if”. It runs, in substance: suppose everything went quiet.

Suppose the noise of the body went quiet, and the images of earth and water and air, and the heavens, and the soul went quiet to itself and got past itself by not thinking about itself, and

dreams went quiet, and every language and every sign and everything that comes into being by changing — suppose all of that stopped, completely.

And suppose that then the one who made all of it spoke, not through any of those things but directly, so that you heard it without a human voice or an angel's voice or thunder or any picture standing in for something else.

And suppose that went on, and everything else was taken away, and this one thing held the person who was hearing it.

Would that not be what the gospel means by entering into the joy of your Lord?

It ends on a question mark. Augustine does not assert that eternal life is like this. He builds a conditional the length of a paragraph and hands it to you unresolved. Whatever happened at that window, the most careful writer in Latin declined to make a statement about it.

7.5 — What she said afterwards

Then Monica speaks, and this is the part that tends to get cut from anthologies because it is not beautiful in the same way.

She says, in substance: as far as I am concerned, there is nothing in this life that I want any more. I do not know what I am still doing here or why I am still here. There was one thing I wanted to stay for — to see you a catholic Christian before I died — and God has given me that with more thrown in, because I see you serving him and caring nothing for the happiness this world hands out. So what am I doing here?

Augustine says he does not clearly remember what he answered.

That admission is worth more than most of the paragraph before it. A man capable of composing the conditional sentence, writing eleven years later, tells you that he cannot recall his own reply. It is the kind of gap real memory has and constructed memory usually does not.

Within five days, or not much more, she was in bed with a fever.

REMEMBER THIS

After the baptism the household set out for Africa and got as far as **Ostia**, the port of Rome, where they were held up waiting for a ship — probably by the military emergency of 387, though Augustine does not say.

He and Monica were alone, **leaning at a window** over the courtyard garden of a lodging house, talking about what the eternal life of the saints would be like.

The conversation climbed: past bodies, past the heavens, **through the talking itself**, past their own minds, to what he calls the Wisdom by which everything was made. They **touched it a little, with one beat of the heart**, and came back to ordinary speech.

The celebrated passage that follows is **one long conditional ending in a question**. Augustine asserts nothing about it.

Monica then said she had nothing left that she wanted, and asked what she was still doing here. Augustine says he **cannot remember what he replied**. Five days later she had a fever.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What Is Being Claimed

Augustine has now described something like this twice: once alone in Milan in Book Seven, once with his mother at a window. Whether they are the same kind of thing is the central question of Book Nine, and the question is harder than it looks.

8.1 The other one

Part Four covered the Book Seven passage and it is worth having back in front of you, because everything in this chapter is a comparison.

In Milan, in 386, after reading the Platonist books, Augustine turned inward and reported seeing — with what he calls the eye of the soul, and above that eye — an unchangeable light. Not a brighter version of ordinary light. Something above his own mind, which had made him.

He says he shook, with love and with dread. He says he found himself a long way off, in a country unlike the thing he was looking at. He says he heard something like a voice telling him he was food for grown men, and that he would not be turned into the one eating him, but the other way round.

And then the two clauses that matter for this chapter. He got to *what is*, in the flash of one trembling glance. And he could not hold his eyes on it; he was beaten back by his own weakness; and he returned to his ordinary habits.

8.2 — Five differences

Set the two side by side and the differences are not subtle. They are also not usually listed, because the Ostia passage is so much better written that people tend to read it for the prose.

One: company. Book Seven is one man alone in a room. Ostia is two people, and the text keeps saying “we”. Whatever happened, Augustine claims it happened to both of them at the same time.

Two: method. Book Seven is introspection — a turn inward after reading. Ostia is a conversation. They climb by discussing. That is a strange thing for a mystical ascent to do, and it is stated twice.

Three: the ending. Book Seven ends in defeat. He cannot hold it, he is thrown back, and the verb he uses is the one you would use about losing a fight. Ostia ends in a sigh and a return to normal speech, and something is described as being left behind up there, still attached. The first is a failure. The second is a visit.

Four: the senses. Book Seven is all sight — the eye, the light, the gaze, the flash. Ostia is all hearing and silence — the whole great conditional is about everything falling quiet so that one voice can be heard directly. Augustine chose two different sensory vocabularies for two passages a hundred pages apart, and he did not do that by accident.

Five: what is missing. Augustine’s own verdict on Book Seven, delivered a few pages later, was that the Platonist books had given him the destination and no way of getting there — no humility, no mediator, nothing that could carry a person. At Ostia the framing is scriptural from the first line to the last, and the question they are discussing is not “what is real” but “what will it be like for the people who arrive”.

8.3 — The Plotinus question

Now the difficulty, and it is a real one.

The structure of the Ostia ascent — from bodies, up through the soul, to what is above the soul — is the structure of Plotinus. Not vaguely. Step for step. Plotinus describes exactly that movement, in those stages, and Augustine had read him, or read something very like him, eighteen months earlier.

The strong version of the argument, made in a well-known study in 1938 and pressed further by Courcelle, is that the Ostia passage is Plotinian philosophy in Christian clothing, and that the historical Monica cannot have been party to any of it, because she had no Greek, no philosophical training, and no access to the ideas the passage is built out of.

The counter-case is that the resemblance is the resemblance of two people climbing the same staircase, that Augustine is using the only vocabulary his century had for this kind of description, and that the load-bearing material — the phrase from Paul at the start, the Wisdom by which all things are made, the joy of your Lord at the end — is biblical, not Platonist.

On Monica specifically, the counter-case has one hard piece of evidence that gets forgotten. We do not have to guess whether she could hold her end of a difficult conversation. Four books written at Cassiciacum survive, she is a speaker in two of them, and in one she is given

the closing argument and wins it. Augustine was not shy about her lack of education; he mentions it. He also put her in the room.

THE ARGUMENT — IS OSTIA THE SAME KIND OF EVENT AS THE ASCENT IN BOOK SEVEN?

This is the question the brief for this part flagged, and serious readers divide on it. Note that all three positions accept that Augustine wrote both passages, deliberately, within one book of each other, and expected them to be read together.

YES — IT IS THE SAME THING, BETTER DONE

The philosophical furniture is identical: the graded ascent through bodies and soul to what is above soul; the timeless present of the thing reached; the momentary contact; the fall back into time. That is Plotinus in both places.

The differences are differences of staging. Augustine has learned, in the intervening hundred pages, how to write the experience properly, and he has learned that putting his mother in it makes a theological point he needs. The event is a repeat. The prose is better and the framing is Christian because by the time he is writing, he is a bishop.

NO — THE DIFFERENCES ARE THE CONTENT

A shared ascent is not a variant of a solitary one; it is a different claim. A climb performed by conversation is not a variant of introspection. An ending in which something remains attached is not a variant of an ending in which you are beaten back.

And the sensory shift from sight to hearing is not decoration. Sight is the philosopher's metaphor, and it is a metaphor of grasping. Hearing is the scriptural one, and it is a metaphor of receiving. Augustine changed the whole sensory register between the two passages, which is what a writer does when he wants you to know the second thing is not the first.

THE QUESTION IS MALFORMED

We do not have two events. We have two literary descriptions, written by one man at one desk, within a few months of each other, ten to twelve years after the fact, in a book that is arguing something.

Asking whether the underlying experiences were “the same kind” assumes we have independent access to the experiences. We have access to nothing but the descriptions, and the descriptions were designed to differ.

On this reading the honest answer is that Book Seven and Book Nine give two different accounts of what contact with God would be like, that Augustine preferred the second, and that anything beyond this is the reader's reconstruction.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes the texts or the Plotinian architecture. What is disputed is whether the differences are staging or substance, and whether the question can be asked at all.

What would settle it: Nothing available will settle it. There is no other witness to Ostia; Monica died five days later and left no writing. The Cassiciacum dialogues show she could argue, which removes one objection, and prove nothing about the window.

Why people care so much: Because it decides whether the *Confessions* ends its life story with a Christian claim or a Platonist one, and therefore what the conversion in Book Eight was a conversion to. That is the same question Part Five could not close, arriving from a different direction.

A position, declared: I find the second reading the strongest, mainly because of the shift from seeing to hearing, which is too thoroughgoing to be an accident and too easy to miss to be a display. But the third position has the better epistemology, and a reader who takes it will regard the previous two paragraphs as an elaborate way of preferring one piece of prose to another.

8.4 — The trap underneath the whole argument

There is an assumption running under this chapter that is worth digging out, because it is doing more work than any of the three positions above.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT “THE SAME EXPERIENCE” IS SOMETHING YOU CAN CHECK

The argument in this chapter is conducted as though there were a fact of the matter — two events, out there in 386 and 387, either of the same kind or not — and the texts were reports we are trying to see through.

But experiences are not the sort of thing that sit still to be compared. There is no way to hold up two moments of somebody else’s inner life against each other, and there is no agreed test for what would make them “the same kind” even if you could. Two people at the same concert do not have the same experience. The same person at two concerts is not in a position to tell you whether they did.

And in this case the only access anybody has runs through a writer of exceptional skill who was, by his own account, describing something he says cannot be said in words. Every difference between the two passages is at least as likely to be a fact about the writing as a fact about the events.

This does not mean the question is worthless. It means the question that can actually be answered is a different one: what is Augustine claiming, in each case, and how do the two claims relate? That is a question about texts, and texts are the thing we have.

The general form: treating a description of an inner event as a measurement of it.

Which is why the honest thing to carry out of this chapter is not a verdict but a distinction. Book Seven describes a man reaching something and being thrown off it. Book Nine describes two people reaching something together and coming back down on their own feet. Whether those are two events or one event told twice, they are certainly two claims, and the second is the one Augustine chose to end the story of his life with.

REMEMBER THIS

Book Seven and Book Nine both describe reaching something above the mind. The Ostia passage is the better-written of the two and the differences are usually missed.

Five of them: Book Seven is **alone**, Ostia is **shared**; Book Seven is introspection, Ostia climbs **through conversation**; Book Seven ends in **defeat**, Ostia in a sigh and a return; Book Seven is all **sight**, Ostia is all **silence and hearing**; and Ostia is scriptural from first line to last.

The architecture of the Ostia ascent is **Plotinian**, step for step, and that is not seriously contested. What is contested is whether the borrowed architecture makes it a Platonist passage.

The objection that **Monica could not have taken part** runs into the Cassiciacum dialogues, where she argues in her own right and is given a closing argument that wins.

Underneath the whole dispute sits an assumption worth refusing: that “**the same experience**” is **a checkable fact**. What can actually be compared is two claims, and the second is the one he chose to end the life story with.

CHAPTER NINE

Nine Days

His mother dies. He has spent Book Four telling you that grief like this is a mistake. This is the chapter where the doctrine and the man are in the same room, and this series has owed you it since Part Three.

9.1 — The fever

Five days after the conversation at the window, or not much more, Monica went down with a fever. There is no diagnosis available and there never will be; a fever at a Mediterranean port in late summer covers a great deal of ground.

At some point during the illness she lost consciousness. The household came running. She came back, looked at them, and asked where she was.

Then, seeing them standing there unable to speak, she said: you will bury your mother here.

9.2 — “Lay this body anywhere”

What happens next takes about four sentences and contains an entire family.

Augustine says nothing, and holds back his tears. His brother Navigius says something — the gist is that he hopes she will die at home rather than abroad. She turns and looks at him with an expression that Augustine describes as troubled, and rebukes him with her eyes for thinking that way. Then she turns to Augustine and says: listen to what he is saying.

And then, to both of them: lay this body anywhere at all. Do not let worrying about it take up any of your attention. The only thing I ask is that you remember me at the altar of the Lord, wherever you happen to be.

The force of that only lands if you know what she was giving up. She had wanted, for years, to be buried beside her husband at Thagaste. She had gone as far as preparing the place. Augustine says that she let it go and that she said, of the idea that distance from the grave might matter, that nothing is far from God, and there was no danger that at the end of the world he would not know where to find her.

He also records that he heard about this second-hand: that at Ostia, in his absence, she had been talking to friends with what he calls the confidence of somebody looking forward to it. She had told nobody in the family. The son who wrote four hundred pages about himself

found out what his mother thought about her own death from other people, after she was dead.

She died on the ninth day of the illness. She was fifty-six. He was thirty-three.

9.3 — The room

He closed her eyes.

What he says happened then is precise and physical. An enormous sorrow gathered in his chest and was turning into tears, and his eyes, under the hard order of his mind, drank the spring dry. He says the struggle went very badly for him.

Adeodatus, who was fifteen and had just watched his grandmother die, burst out crying. Everyone in the room told him to stop, and he stopped.

Augustine then compares the boy's crying to his own: something childish in him was doing the same thing and was put down in the same way, by what he calls the adult voice of the mind. He is not reporting a difference between himself and his son. He is reporting the same event happening twice, once out loud and once inside.

And then somebody starts singing. Evodius, another African in the party, picked up the book of Psalms and began one — the one about singing of mercy and judgement — and the whole household came in on the responses.

That is what the room looked like an hour after she died. A dead woman, a teenager who had been told to be quiet, a man with his jaw set, and everybody singing.

9.4 — Why they were not crying

The reasoning is given, and it should be taken seriously rather than treated as repression with a theological label on it.

They thought it wrong to mark this particular death with weeping and groaning, because that kind of mourning is for one of two situations: the person died badly, or the person is simply gone. Neither applied, on what they believed. So the tears would have been a statement, and the statement would have been false.

That is a coherent position and it is not cowardice. It is also, as the rest of the chapter demonstrates, unliveable.

Augustine spent the rest of that day performing it. Mourners arrived. The people whose job it was prepared the body. He sat in another part of the house talking to visitors who did not

think he should be left alone, and he says he soothed the pain with what he calls the medicine of truth. Nobody who was there heard him grieve.

He says he was complaining to God the whole time about his own weakness, and holding the flood back, and that it would give way a little and then come back up, and never quite reach tears.

The body was carried out. He went to the grave and came back and did not weep. He did not weep during the prayers, either — and he is specific about the moment, which is the point in the rite, before the body went into the ground, when the eucharist was offered beside the grave. He stood through the most charged moment available to him and produced nothing.

9.5 — The bath, and the sleep

Then comes the detail that persuades me, more than anything else in Book Nine, that this is a report of a real day.

He decided to go to the baths. And he explains why, and the explanation is embarrassing: he had heard somewhere that the Latin word for a bath comes from a Greek word meaning to throw anxiety out of the mind. So he went, on the strength of an etymology.

He notes that the etymology is not much of a reason. He went anyway.

It did not work. He says the bitterness did not sweat out of him. He came back exactly as he had gone.

Then he slept. And when he woke, he found the grief had gone down a little on its own, which is the one thing in the whole day that actually helped and the one thing he did not choose.

9.6 — The hymn

He was alone in bed. And the verses of Ambrose came into his head — the evening hymn, the one that begins by addressing God as the maker of everything and the one who sets the sky turning.

The same hymn form he had wept at three months earlier in the baptistery. The same bishop's words. And this time he was on his own with them.

And he let the tears go. He describes it as letting them run wherever they wanted, and spreading them under his heart, and his heart resting on them.

A day of held breath ends with a man crying in the dark because a tune arrived. That is not a defeat of the argument in Chapter Nine Section Four. It is the argument meeting a hymn and losing.

9.7 — The double grief, and what he does with it

Now the part that pays the debt.

During the day, Augustine says, the fact that these ordinary human feelings had so much power over him was itself a source of distress, so that he was grieving over his own grief and being worn down by two sadnesses at once.

Read that slowly. The Book Four doctrine is not an abstraction being quietly dropped. It is present in the room, operating, and it is making everything worse. He is not simply sad. He is sad, and then he is ashamed of being sad, and the shame is a second injury on top of the first.

And then, having wept, he does something that Book Four gives him no permission for at all. He defends it.

Writing it down eleven years later, he addresses the reader directly — which he almost never does — and says: read this and make of it what you like; and if you decide it was a sin that I cried for my mother for a fraction of an hour, then do not laugh at me; if you have any largeness in you, cry for my sins instead.

That sentence has three moves in it and all three matter. He does not retract the doctrine. He does not claim the tears were fine. He asks not to be mocked, and he asks for charity rather than agreement. It is the reply of a man who still holds the theory and has discovered what it costs to be the person the theory is about.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT CONSISTENCY IS THE TEST OF SINCERITY

Almost every reading of this chapter reaches for one of two verdicts. Either Augustine did not really believe what he wrote in Book Four, or he is a hypocrite for weeping. Both verdicts share a premise: that if a person's conduct and their stated position come apart, one of them is fake. That premise is doing enormous work and it is false about human beings. A doctor who smokes is not thereby revealed to have doubts about lung cancer. A person who believes that anger is corrosive and loses their temper has not secretly abandoned the belief. Holding a view and being able to act on it are different capacities, which is, as it happens, the entire thesis of Book Eight. That is what makes this chapter the pay-off of the last one rather than an embarrassment after it. Part Five spent forty pages on Augustine's discovery that seeing an answer and being able to live in it are two different things. Book Nine shows the same man discovering it a second time, from the other side, about a position he holds himself.

There is a further consequence, and it cuts against a common defence. If consistency is not the test, then the tears do not prove the Book Four verdict was wrong. They prove it was hard. Whether it was also wrong is a separate argument and this passage does not settle it.

The general form: treating a gap between what somebody holds and what they do as proof that they do not really hold it.

This series will not resolve the tension for you, because Augustine did not resolve it either, and the refusal is the most valuable thing in the chapter. What can be said is what changed and what did not.

THE ARGUMENT — DID HE CHANGE HIS MIND ABOUT GRIEF?

Part Three set out the Book Four verdict: grief for a dead friend is a fault, the natural consequence of having loved a mortal as though it were permanent. Part Three also promised that Book Nine is where he has to live with it. Here is what living with it produced, and how readers have scored it.

YES, AND HE COVERS HIS TRACKS

The clearest evidence is what he asks the reader for. In Book Four there is no charity clause; the verdict is delivered on the young man without appeal. In Book Nine the same author, facing the same charge, asks not to be laughed at.

And the later writing goes further. In *The City of God*, thirty years on, Augustine attacks the Stoic ideal of freedom from the passions directly, and defends grief, fear and compassion as proper to a human being. That is not a small adjustment of tone. That is the Book Four position being argued against by its own author.

NO, THE DOCTRINE IS INTACT

Read what he actually says in Book Nine. He calls the power these feelings had over him a weakness. He credits the restraint. He traces the tears to the force of habit. And in the section immediately after the weeping, he prays at length for the forgiveness of his mother's sins — which is the Book Four framework in operation, not a departure from it.

What changes is the tone of voice, and tone of voice is what you would expect to change when the person in the example is your mother. The theory is where it was.

THERE WAS NEVER ONE DOCTRINE TO CHANGE

The chronology in both the readings above is imaginary. Book Four and Book Nine were not written twelve years apart. They were written by the same forty-three-year-old bishop, probably within months of each other, in the same work.

So this is not early Augustine corrected by later Augustine. It is one man, at one desk, writing a hard verdict about a young man's grief in one book and an account of his own grief in another, and letting both stand.

On this reading the tension is not a fault in the text. It is the text. He knew what he had written in Book Four. He put Book Nine in anyway.

Where things stand: The sequence of events and the wording are not in dispute. What is disputed is whether Book Four and Book Nine conflict at all, and if they do, whether the *Confessions* notices.

What would settle it: His later writing is the best available evidence, and it exists: the discussion of the passions in *The City of God* is a genuine, checkable, dated later position, and it is markedly warmer than Book Four. Whether that is a change of mind or the same mind writing against a different opponent is the remaining question.

Why people care so much: Because the Book Four verdict has been quoted at grieving people for sixteen centuries, usually by people who were not grieving at the time. Whether the man who wrote it could keep it under load is not an academic question for anyone who has been on the receiving end of it.

A position, declared, and this is the one I hold most firmly in the whole part: the third reading is right about the facts and the first is right about the direction. He did not change his mind between the two books, because there was no between. He had already changed it, or was in the middle of changing it, and he wrote both states down rather than tidying either away. The Book Four verdict reads to me like a position he had inherited and could still argue for, and Book Nine reads like the evidence he could not argue with.

And the debt this series has been carrying since Part Three is now paid, in the only way it could have been: not with a resolution, but with a sequence. He held the doctrine. He wept. He was ashamed. He wrote it down anyway, and asked you not to laugh.

REMEMBER THIS

Monica died at Ostia on the **ninth day** of a fever, aged **fifty-six**. Augustine was thirty-three. She gave up the grave she had prepared beside her husband and asked only to be **remembered at the altar**. Augustine learned what she thought about her own death **from other people, afterwards**.

He closed her eyes and refused to cry. **Adeodatus, fifteen, cried and was told to stop**. Evodius started a psalm and the household sang.

He got through the funeral, the graveside and the eucharist without tears. He tried a **bath**, on the strength of an etymology, and it did not work. He slept. Alone that night, a **hymn of Ambrose** came into his head and he wept.

He was **grieving and ashamed of grieving at the same time** — a double sadness, in his phrase. And then he defended the tears to the reader, without retracting the doctrine that condemned them. That sequence, unresolved, is the honest answer to the question Part Three left open.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Every part of this series ends the same way, by separating what is genuinely open from what is settled, and saying why in each case.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

These are open questions, not gaps in this document. Each one is followed by the reason it is open, because “we do not know” is only useful when it comes with a cause.

Where Cassiciacum was. Why: Augustine names the estate and never locates it. Two places in Lombardy have claimed it, on the strength of later tradition and arguments from place-names. No excavation has settled it and probably none can.

When, where and how Adeodatus died. Why: Augustine gives the death one clause and no other ancient source mentions the boy at all. The usual dating of about 389 or 390 is worked backwards from Augustine’s movements, not from any record.

What became of Adeodatus’ mother. Why: Augustine withheld her name deliberately, as Part Four set out, and nobody else in antiquity knew her. She was sent to Africa in 385 and the record stops. Her son was kept in Italy and the arrangement is never described.

What he said to Monica at the window after she spoke. Why: he says he cannot remember, which is a better answer than a reconstructed one and is worth flagging as the only place in Book Nine where he admits the memory has failed.

Whether the experience at Ostia was shared in the way he claims. Why: two people were there, one of them died five days later, and the other is the only witness. Chapter Eight sets out how far the argument can be taken and where it stops.

Why the household was stuck at Ostia. Why: he does not say. The military emergency of 387 is a strong inference from the calendar and nothing more.

Whether the toothache and the blind man happened as described. Why: the first has a single witness and the second has several who were all on the winning side of the fight the

event helped to win. Neither of those is a reason to disbelieve; both are reasons not to call it settled.

What Monica would have said about her own marriage. Why: everything known about her comes from her son, except her dates and a poem somebody else wrote on her tomb. The wine, the temper, the advice to the beaten women and the patience are all his selection.

The exact sequence of the Milan basilica confrontations. Why: the primary sources are Ambrose's own letters, which are hard to put in order, and specialists divide between one crisis and two, in 385 or 386 or both.

10.2 — Solid

And these are as firm as anything in ancient biography gets. Again with reasons, because “solid” is a claim that has to be paid for.

The Cassiciacum retreat, its dates and its cast. Why: four books written there survive, name the participants and describe the setting, and one of them dates itself to his thirty-second birthday in November 386. This is the best-evidenced stretch of Augustine's entire life.

The baptism at the Easter vigil of 387, with Alypius and Adeodatus. Why: Augustine states it plainly, it fits the Milanese calendar, and every subsequent fact about his life is consistent with it.

That he resigned the chair and never taught for money again. Why: forty years of documented public life with no trace of a return, and hostile contemporaries who would have used it.

The basilica crisis, the introduction of congregational hymn-singing at Milan, and the discovery of the two martyrs. Why: Ambrose describes them in letters written at the time, a biography by his former secretary describes them a generation later, and Augustine reports them independently in another work thirty years on.

That Adeodatus existed, was Augustine's son, and was unusually able. Why: he is a named speaker in a surviving book, and Augustine states in the *Confessions* that the arguments there are really his.

Monica's death at Ostia in 387, in her fifty-sixth year. Why: Augustine's own statement, plus the next section.

10.3 — Two boys with a spade

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

One thing in this part can be checked in a way almost nothing else in the *Confessions* can. A verse epitaph for Monica was known through the Middle Ages from manuscript copies, apparently made by a pilgrim who had seen the original at Ostia. The verses are attributed to a Roman aristocrat and former city prefect. For centuries that was all there was, and a copy of a copy of an inscription is weak evidence.

In 1945 two boys digging in the courtyard beside the church of Santa Aurea at Ostia turned up a piece of marble with part of the epitaph cut into it. The surviving lines match the manuscript text. What that supports: that Monica existed, died at Ostia, was buried there, and was commemorated in verse by somebody of consular rank — which also tells you something about the standing the family had acquired. Her remains were moved to a church in Rome in 1430.

What it cannot support: anything at all about what she was like. An epitaph is a genre with rules, and the rules do not include accuracy.

It is still worth pausing on. Of the enormous cast of the *Confessions* — Patricius, Alypius, Nebridius, Verecundus, Adeodatus, the unnamed woman — the one who left a physical trace in the ground is Monica.

10.4 — What happened next

Book Nine ends the life story, so it is worth closing the outer circle before the book turns into something else.

They did not get their ship. Augustine spent about a year in Rome waiting for the sea and the war to settle, and wrote two books against his old religion while he waited. In 388 the party finally crossed to Africa. He sold or gave up the family property, kept enough to live on, and set up a shared household of study and prayer at Thagaste. It is the life he had been describing at Cassiciacum, finally happening.

It lasted about three years, and in that time Adeodatus died and Nebridius died.

In 391 he went to the coastal town of Hippo on business, walked into a church, was recognised, and was effectively press-ganged by the congregation into ordination as a priest. He wept, and everybody assumed he was weeping because he had wanted to be a bishop rather than a priest. He became a bishop anyway, four or five years later. He never got the quiet life back.

And somewhere around 397, in his early forties, he began writing this book.

Which is where Book Ten starts, and why the *Confessions* stops being a memoir at exactly this point. Nine books have got the reader up to the present. The remaining four ask what a man is, what memory is, what time is, and what the first sentence of the Bible means — and they ask it about the man holding the pen, not the man in the story.

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely open: where **Cassiciacum** was; when and how **Adeodatus** died; what became of **his mother**; whether the window at Ostia was shared as described; and what **Monica** would have said about her own marriage.

Solid: the **Cassiciacum retreat** and its cast, because four books written there survive; the **baptism at Easter 387**; the **basilica crisis and the hymns**, from Ambrose's own letters; and that Augustine never taught for money again.

Monica is the only person in the *Confessions* who left a physical trace: an **epitaph**, known from manuscripts for a thousand years, confirmed in **1945** when two boys digging at Ostia turned up part of the stone.

After Book Nine: a year stuck in Rome, the crossing to Africa in 388, three years of the shared life he had wanted, the deaths of **Adeodatus** and **Nebridius**, and an ambush in a church at Hippo in 391 that made him a priest against his plans.

The life story **ends here**. What follows in the book is not the rest of the life. It is four books of questions asked by the man who has just finished telling it.

Timeline

Book Nine covers about a year, with a long retrospective on a life that began fifty-six years earlier. The public dates are firm. The private sequence is Augustine's own and is not independently checkable.

Date	Event	Where it appears
c. 331	Monica born at Thagaste, to a Christian household with servants. Brought up largely by an elderly maidservant.	Book IX
c. 345	Married to Patricius: unfaithful, violently tempered, and never once known to have struck her.	Book IX
371	Patricius is baptised shortly before his death. Augustine is about seventeen.	Book IX
spring 386	The basilica crisis at Milan. The congregation occupies its own church against imperial troops; hymn-singing is introduced; two martyrs' bodies are found. Monica is in the front rank.	Book IX
Aug 386	The garden. Augustine stops arguing.	Book VIII
autumn 386	He serves out the term and lets the vintage holiday end his teaching. His chest and voice are failing.	Book IX
13 Nov 386	His thirty-second birthday. The three-day discussion recorded in <i>On the Happy Life</i> begins. Monica is one of the speakers.	outside
winter 386–7	Cassiciacum. Four surviving books written. The toothache. Psalm Four.	Book IX
early 387	Back in Milan. He asks Ambrose what to read, is told Isaiah, and gives up on it.	Book IX
24 Apr 387	Baptised at the Easter vigil with Alypius and Adeodatus, who is about fifteen.	Book IX
summer 387	The household sets out for Africa and is held at Ostia. Maximus invades Italy.	Book IX
387	The conversation at the window. Five days later Monica takes a fever.	Book IX
387	Monica dies on the ninth day, aged fifty-six. Augustine is thirty-three, and does not weep until that night.	Book IX

Date	Event	Where it appears
387–8	About a year in Rome waiting for the sea. Two books written against the Manichees.	outside
388	The crossing to Africa. A shared household of study at Thagaste.	outside
c. 389	<i>On the Teacher</i> is written, with Adeodatus as the other speaker.	outside
c. 389–90	Adeodatus dies at about seventeen. Nebridius dies.	Book IX
391	Ordained priest at Hippo, against his intentions.	outside
c. 397–400	The <i>Confessions</i> is written.	outside
—	Part Seven starts here: Book X — memory, the present self, and the sentence that started a twenty-year war.	—

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Terms carried over from earlier parts are repeated so this part stands alone.

Term	What it means
Adeodatus	Augustine's son, born about 372 to the woman he never names. Baptised with him in 387; the other speaker in the dialogue <i>On the Teacher</i> ; died at about seventeen.
Alypius	Augustine's former pupil and closest friend, present in the garden in Book Eight and baptised with him. Later a bishop.
Ambrose	Bishop of Milan from 374 to 397. A former imperial governor, and the most politically formidable churchman in the west. Baptised Augustine.
Ambrosian hymns	Short Latin hymns in a simple regular metre, written for untrained congregations to sing in alternating halves. Four are securely Ambrose's.
Arian / Homoian	Augustine calls the Milanese court party Arians. Historians prefer Homoian: they held that the Son is <i>like</i> the Father and rejected the Nicene formula of one substance.
Cassiciacum	The country estate outside Milan, lent by Verecundus, where the household withdrew in the autumn of 386. Its location is unknown.
Catechumen	Someone enrolled in the church for instruction but not baptised. An ordinary long-term status; Augustine held it from infancy to the age of thirty-two.
Competens	A catechumen who has given in their name for baptism at the coming Easter and entered the final weeks of preparation.
Evodius	A fellow African, formerly an imperial agent, who joined the group at Milan. He starts the psalm in the room where Monica dies.
Feriae vindemiales	The vintage vacation: the long autumn shutdown of Roman schools and public business for the grape harvest.
Gervasius and Protasius	Two martyrs whose bodies Ambrose located in 386. Their procession, and a blind man's reported recovery, ended the standoff with the court.
Justina	Mother of the boy emperor Valentinian the Second, and the effective power behind the court party that tried to take a basilica from Ambrose.

Term	What it means
Meribibula	Roughly “neat-wine-swiller”. The insult a maidservant threw at the young Monica, which stopped her drinking.
Monica	Augustine’s mother, c. 331 to 387. Christian, uneducated, relentless. Died at Ostia.
Navigius	Augustine’s brother. Present at Cassiciacum and at Monica’s deathbed, where she rebukes him with a look.
Nebridius	The friend who argued Augustine out of astrology. Baptised, returned to Africa, died young.
Ostia	The port at the mouth of the Tiber, about fifteen miles from Rome. Where the conversation at the window happened and where Monica died.
Otium	Withdrawal from public business into reading, writing and argument. A recognised and respectable Roman practice, not idleness.
Patricius	Augustine’s father. A man of modest standing at Thagaste, unfaithful and hot-tempered, baptised shortly before dying in 371.
Plotinus	Third-century philosopher whose account of the soul’s ascent through bodies and mind to what lies above both is the structure the Ostia passage follows.
Privation	A missing good in something that ought to have had it. Augustine’s account of what evil is, established in Book VII.
Verecundus	The Milanese schoolmaster who lent his estate for the Cassiciacum retreat, and who believed his marriage shut him out of the life his friends were choosing.

About the Author

This series is read and explained by Lovepreet Singh, and published as part of The Living Archive at misterlove.in.

The Living Archive takes difficult material and rebuilds it so that anyone can follow it, without dropping the hard parts along the way. Its first series was a fourteen-part history of Punjab running to around nine hundred and fifty pages. This is its second.

I read the book, I did the reading around it, and I wrote down what I found. I am not a specialist in late antiquity and I am not going to pretend to be one. Where a question is genuinely contested among people who are, I have said so and given each side its strongest case rather than choosing for you. Where I could not find out, I have written that I could not find out.

The method used here was worked out on the Punjab series and is written up as a portable specification, so that any part of this work can be checked, continued or rebuilt by somebody else. That is the point of an archive that calls itself living.

[Editorial note, to be replaced before publishing: the method requires a one-line statement of the author's own position with regard to religious material, placed where readers will see it. This is the only field in the document still unfilled, and it has now been carried forward six times.]

The Living Archive

The Living Archive is a method for writing hard things simply without making them shallow. It was developed by Lovepreet Singh and tested on a fourteen-part history of Punjab. It runs on three rules.

One. Simplification is not compression. The simple version is usually longer than the difficult one. Words are being spent to buy comprehension.

Two. Two dials, turned in opposite directions. Language as simple as it can be made. Content as deep as the subject actually goes. Turning both down produces something readable and useless.

Three. Every side gets its strongest case, and where nothing settles a question, that gets said. A verdict that honestly reports a deadlock is worth more than a tidy answer that is not true.

A word on sources

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record rather than new primary research, and it is written for readers who want to understand a book, not for specialists who want to check my workings.

What the archive is unusually good at here. Two stretches of this part can be checked from outside Augustine, and both checks are strong. The Cassiciacum months are covered by four books he wrote at the time, one of which dates itself and names everyone in the room. The Milan basilica crisis is covered by Ambrose's own letters, by a biography written by his former secretary, and by Augustine again thirty years later in a different work. Nothing else in this series has that.

What it is bad at here. Everything private. The toothache, the conversation at the window, the deathbed, the day of the funeral and the tears at night all rest on one witness writing about eleven years afterwards, with a case to make. So does the whole portrait of Monica, who left no writing and whose only independent trace is a poem carved by somebody else.

On the dispute in Chapter Eight. The literature on the Ostia passage and its relation to Plotinus is large and technical, and the modern debate runs from a study of 1938 through Courcelle's work of 1950 to the present. I have tried to give all three positions their strongest form and to keep my own preference visible where it could shape the summary.

On the dates. Where a date is given as firm it comes from the standard chronologies, which agree on the public events of 386 and 387 and disagree at the edges. Where specialists disagree — the sequence of the basilica confrontations, the death of Adeodatus, the site of Cassiciacum — Chapter Ten says so rather than picking.

On translations. All renderings of Augustine in this document are my own plain-English paraphrases, made deliberately loose so that they explain rather than reproduce. They are not quotations from any published translation and should not be cited as such. Where the exact wording matters, go to a proper edition.

Corrections are welcome and will be acted on. Later editions will record what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Seven covers Book Ten, and the book changes shape. The life story finished at Ostia. What follows is a man in his forties turning the same attention on the person writing, and it is where the *Confessions* becomes the strangest and most influential thing in the whole work. These are the questions it takes on.

- Why does a book about a life stop being about the life at exactly the halfway point?
- What is memory, and why does Augustine describe it as a building he gets lost in — the passage that has been read by every philosopher of mind since?
- How can you look for something you would not recognise if you found it, and how can you remember having been happy if you are not?
- The debt from Part Three: he wrote that he had become a great question to himself. Book Ten is the answer, and it is an answer about memory.
- What is Augustine still tempted by at forty-three — and why is his list the most peculiar and most modern thing in the book?
- And the sentence. Somewhere in Book Ten there is one short prayer that a British monk read out loud, could not stand, and objected to. The argument that followed lasted twenty years, took in two church councils and an emperor, and shaped what the western church would say about free will for the next thousand years.

That last one has been outstanding since Part One, Chapter Six. It gets paid in Part Seven, along with the memory material promised in Part Three. The Wittgenstein debt, which is about time and not about language, belongs to Part Eight and Book Eleven.

End of Part 6 of 9

The Living Archive • The Confessions, Explained

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART 7 OF 9

The Confessions, Explained

Part Seven — The Vast Palace of Memory

Book Ten alone: the point where the life story stops and the man holding the pen becomes the problem — memory, the happy life, what he is still tempted by, and four words that started a war.

READ AND EXPLAINED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

Parts One to Six covered Books One to Nine. Here is what you need. This part stands on its own.

The man. Born 354 in Roman North Africa, educated at his family's expense towards a career as a professional public speaker. By 384 he held the public chair of rhetoric in Milan. He resigned it in 386, was baptised in 387, went home to Africa, and was made a priest at Hippo in 391 and a bishop about four years after that. He wrote this book in his early forties, around 397 to 400.

The book. *Confessio* means three things at once: confessing sin, confessing faith, and confessing praise. It is a prayer, addressed to God throughout, and you are overhearing it.

The story so far. Nine years with the Manichees and their two eternal powers of Light and Darkness. A collapse into scepticism. Milan, and a bishop who showed him scripture could be read figuratively. Then books of the Platonists, which broke the assumption that anything real must be made of stuff, and let him say that evil is not a substance but a *privation* — a missing good in something that ought to have had it.

Books Eight and Nine. Having the answer turned out not to be the same as being able to live in it. Book Eight is a man who is certain and cannot move, and it ends in a garden in the late summer of 386. Book Nine is the year after: a resignation timed to the school holidays, a winter of writing in a borrowed house, baptism at Easter 387, and then his mother's death at Ostia — where he fought his own tears all day, lost that night to a hymn, was ashamed of losing, and defended the tears anyway.

And that is the end of the story. Book Nine finishes the life. There are four books left and none of them is about what happened next. This part is about the first of them, and about why a man who has just brought his reader up to the present decides that the present is where the difficulty starts.

A Reminder About the Boxes

Six kinds of box run through this series. **Word Box** explains a hard term the moment it first appears. **In Real Terms** turns something abstract into something you can picture. **How We Actually Know This** names the evidence and says what it cannot show. **The Argument** is for places where experts genuinely disagree, and gives each side its strongest case. **The Hidden Assumption** digs out the premise everybody is quietly taking for granted. **Remember This** closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

Three Things to Watch For

This is the hardest part in the series. Book Ten is abstract, it has no plot, and it is the most influential thing in the whole work after Book Eleven. Three threads will hold it together.

One. The subject has changed and the method has not. Books One to Nine investigated a man who no longer exists, using evidence he could check. Book Ten turns the same equipment on the man doing the investigating, who cannot be interviewed, cannot be checked, and does not stay still. Every difficulty in the book comes from that.

Two. Memory is not what you think it is. Augustine's *memoria* holds the past, but it also holds mathematics, skills, emotions you are not currently having, the fact that you have forgotten things, itself, and — he will argue — God. Chapters Three and Four are about a room much stranger than the word “memory” prepares you for.

Three. There is a bomb in the middle of this book. Somewhere in Chapter Nine of this part sits a prayer four words long in Latin. Around 405 a bishop read it out in Rome, a British monk in the audience could not stand it, and the argument that followed ran for twenty years, took in half a dozen church councils and an imperial decree, and settled what the western church would say about the human will for the next thousand years. This series has owed you that story since Part One.

Contents

Chapter One — The Book That Should Not Be Here

Why the life story stops at the halfway point · who Book Ten is talking to · “not what I was, but what I am now” · and whether this book was even part of the plan

Chapter Two — What Do I Love When I Love My God?

A question asked in the middle of a book of answers · everything it is not · the interrogation of the earth and the sea and the sky · and the turn inward that the rest of the book depends on

Chapter Three — The Palace of Memory

The most quoted passage in the book after the garden · why a professional speaker reached for that particular image · and the sentence about mountains and rivers that a poet took up a thousand years later

Chapter Four — What Is Actually In There

Pictures · mathematics · skills · emotions you are not having · the memory of forgetting · and the moment Augustine admits he is out of his depth

Chapter Five — Everybody Wants It and Nobody Can Name It

How you can look for a thing you would recognise but cannot describe · the happy life · joy in the truth · and why people love truth when it flatters and hate it when it does not

Chapter Six — Late Have I Loved You

Where God turns out to be, on Augustine’s own search · the most famous lyric passage in Latin prose · and what it is actually claiming under the beauty

Chapter Seven — The Man at the Desk

The turn to the present tense · “the whole of this life is a trial” · what a bishop can and cannot find out about himself · and the shape he borrows to organise the search

Chapter Eight — What He Is Still Tempted By

Sex, food, smell, music and light · the vice he calls curiosity · the third one, which is worse than both · and the reason it cannot be tested

Chapter Nine — Four Words

“Give what you command, and command what you will” · a monk in Rome who could not sit still · twenty years, six councils and an imperial decree · and what we actually know about the man on the other side

Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Genuinely unknown · solid · what survives of the losing side · and where the last two parts are going

Reference

Timeline · glossary · about the author · a word on sources · what comes next

CHAPTER ONE

The Book That Should Not Be Here

Book Nine ended the story. Book Ten opens with the story finished and the author still on the page, and the first thing it does is explain why that is a problem rather than a conclusion.

1.1 — The break

Nine books have brought the reader from an infant in Thagaste to a grave at Ostia. The obvious next move is either to stop or to carry on with the years after 387 — the return to Africa, the priesthood, the bishopric, the controversies. Augustine does neither.

Book Ten skips eleven years without mentioning them and begins asking what a person is.

It is the sharpest structural break in the work, and it catches every first-time reader. People who have loved Books One to Nine put the book down here more often than anywhere else, and the reason is that they were reading a life and the life has stopped.

What follows is not a change of subject. It is the same subject with the tense changed, and Augustine says so almost at once.

1.2 — “Not what I was, but what I am now”

Early in Book Ten he states what he is doing, and it is worth having exactly, because it explains the whole rest of the work.

The point of a confession, he says, is not the record of what he used to be. It is what he is at the moment of writing.

Consider how much that gives away. Everything in Books One to Nine — the pears, the Manichees, the dead friend, the woman sent away, the garden — is, on his own account, the easy part. Those are settled facts about somebody who no longer exists, told by a man who is safe from them. The hard part is the sentence he is writing now, by a man who does not know how it will turn out.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A LIFE STORY IS FINISHED WHEN IT REACHES THE PRESENT

A biography ends when it catches up. An autobiography ends when the author runs out of past. That is so ordinary that the shape of Book Ten reads as a malfunction.

The assumption is that the present is the resolution — the place from which the story is told and therefore not part of the story. The narrator is the vantage point, not one of the characters.

Augustine will not have it. On his account the man at the desk is the least settled thing in the book: he does not know his own motives, he cannot predict what he will want tomorrow, and he is the only person in the work whose ending has not happened. Reaching the present has not resolved anything. It has just brought the investigation up to the one subject that cannot hold still to be investigated.

You can test this on any autobiography you have read. The narrator is always the calmest person in it, and always the least examined. That is not because writers are the calmest people. It is because the form puts them behind the camera.

The general form: treating the place you are standing as the answer rather than as another place.

That is why Book Ten exists, and it is also why the three books after it are about memory, time and creation rather than about Hippo. Once the present self has become the question, the useful next questions are what a self is made of and what time is.

1.3 — The second audience

Something else changes here, and it is easy to miss because it is a change in who is being spoken to.

For nine books the *Confessions* has been a prayer. God is the addressee; the reader is eavesdropping. In Book Ten, for the first time, Augustine turns and addresses the eavesdroppers directly. He asks what good it does them, whether they will believe him, and why they should want to.

WORD BOX

The two addressees: from Book Ten onwards the work has a double audience and says so. God, who already knows everything in it, and a human readership, who do not and cannot verify most of it.

Augustine puts the obvious objection himself: what is the use of confessing to somebody who already knows? His answer is that confession is not the transfer of information. It is an act, done in the presence of the one who already knows, and the readers are there as witnesses to the act rather than recipients of the news.

Why it matters: it changes what kind of book this is. From here on it is no longer only a prayer overheard. It is also a public statement by a bishop who had enemies, and Chapter Eight has to reckon with that.

His remark about why people read this sort of thing is one of the coldest lines he ever wrote. The human race, he says, is endlessly curious about other people's lives and lazy about its own. People want to hear what he is. They do not want to hear what they are.

And then the sentence that ought to be pinned above every memoir. He asks: how do they know I am telling the truth? They cannot get inside me. They will believe me because charity believes.

He is telling his readers, in the middle of the most famous work of self-disclosure ever written, that they have no way of checking it.

1.4 — Whether this book was part of the plan

The break at Book Ten is abrupt enough that readers have wondered for a long time whether it was always meant to be there.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

What can actually be established about how the *Confessions* was put together is thinner than most readers assume, but it is not nothing.

Augustine wrote a book near the end of his life going back over everything he had published, correcting it and saying when and why each work was written. In that review he describes the *Confessions* as thirteen books, and says the first ten are about himself and the last three about scripture. That is his own division, made thirty years later, and it groups Book Ten with the life rather than with the commentary.

A biography written by a colleague who lived in his household for decades also treats the work as one book.

What that supports: that the thirteen books were regarded as a single work by the author and by the people around him, and that the boundary he recognised falls after Book Ten, not before it.

What it cannot support: that they were composed in one continuous stretch. Nothing establishes that, and a work of this length written by a working bishop over three or four years almost certainly was not.

Which leaves the question open in a precise way. Nobody doubts that the thirteen books are one work. Nobody can show that they were written as one. Readers have drawn very different conclusions from that gap, and all three of the following are held by people who have read the text more carefully than either of us.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES BOOK TEN BELONG?

Part One declared a position on the unity of the thirteen books and this is where that position has to be defended or revised in the open. The dispute is old, and none of the three positions is silly.

IT IS A LATER ADDITION

Look at the seams. Book Nine ends with a request that readers remember his mother and father at the altar — a closing formula if ever there was one. Book Ten opens by re-introducing the project and re-arguing why it is being undertaken, which is what a writer does at a beginning, not in the middle.

The declaration that the fruit of confession is “what I am now” reads like a man justifying a new instalment to readers who thought the work was finished. And the eleven missing years are missing because they were never planned for: a work conceived as thirteen books would not leave a hole where the author’s public career should be.

IT BELONGS

The author’s own late review divides the work after Book Ten, not before it, and calls the first ten “about myself”. Whatever the order of composition, the man who wrote it did not regard Book Ten as an appendix.

And structurally it is load-bearing. Book Eleven asks what time is, and answers it with a theory of the mind holding past, present and future together. That answer is unintelligible without the account of memory in Book Ten. Remove this book and the most influential passage in the whole work loses its foundation.

THE QUESTION IS BADLY POSED

A third position, and the one that has quietly won ground. “Was it part of the plan” assumes a plan of the kind a modern author has: an outline, then execution.

A long work in late antiquity was dictated to secretaries in sections, over months or years, and circulated in parts. Books were physical rolls or quires that travelled separately. Composition in instalments is the normal case, not evidence of an afterthought.

On this reading the seams at the start of Book Ten are exactly what a new instalment of a continuing work looks like, and they tell you nothing at all about whether it belongs.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes the abruptness of the break or the author’s own later division of the work. What is disputed is whether the break is evidence of a change of plan.

What would settle it: A dated letter mentioning the work in progress would settle a great deal. None survives that pins the sequence down. Failing that, the argument runs on internal evidence, and internal evidence about composition order is notoriously easy to read both ways.

Why people care so much: Because it decides whether the *Confessions* is one argument or two good books stapled together — and Part One told you it was one argument, which is a debt this chapter is paying.

A position, declared, and it is a revision of Part One rather than a defence of it. Part One argued for the unity of the thirteen books and treated the question as settled. It is not settled,

and the strongest case is the third one. The work is unified in argument and almost certainly was not composed in one run, and Part One should have separated those two claims instead of carrying them together.

REMEMBER THIS

Book Nine finished the life story. **Book Ten skips eleven years** and asks what a person is instead. It is the sharpest structural break in the work and it is where most first-time readers stop. Augustine states the reason: the point of confessing is **not what he was but what he is now**. The past is the easy part, because it is settled and belongs to somebody who no longer exists. The book acquires a **second audience**. For nine books God was the only addressee; here Augustine turns and speaks to his readers — and tells them they have **no way of checking a word of it**.

His verdict on why people read this sort of thing: the human race is curious about other people's lives and **lazy about its own**.

Whether Book Ten was in the original plan is an old dispute. The best answer is that it is **unified in argument and composed in instalments**, and that those are two different claims which Part One wrongly ran together.

CHAPTER TWO

What Do I Love When I Love My God?

A bishop, in a book addressed to God, stops and asks what he is talking about. The question is genuine, the answer takes the rest of the book, and the method he uses to get at it is the reason philosophers still read this.

2.1 — The question

Augustine begins the search by saying that he loves God, and then immediately asking what it is that he loves when he says that. It is not a rhetorical question and he does not answer it quickly.

Notice who is asking. This is not a doubter and not an enquirer. It is a bishop, writing a prayer, eleven years past the garden and several years into running a diocese. He has been preaching on this subject weekly. And he stops in the middle of his own book to ask what the word refers to.

That is the single most characteristic move in Augustine, and it is why this book outlived its religion's cultural monopoly. The question is not "does God exist". He settled that in Book Seven. The question is what the object of an attachment actually is when you cannot point at it.

2.2 — Everything it is not

His first move is a list of denials, and the list is unusually physical.

It is not the beauty of a body. Not the order of the seasons, not the brightness of light — which he loved — not the sweetness of melodies, not the smell of flowers or spices, not manna or honey, not anything you would hold. None of that.

And then he takes it all back, in a way. He says that when he loves God he does love a light, a voice, a smell, a food and an embrace — but of the inner person: a light that no place contains, a sound that time does not carry off, a fragrance no breeze scatters, a taste no eating diminishes, a holding that no satisfaction ends.

IN REAL TERMS

That double move — deny all five senses, then use all five to describe what is left — looks like poetry and is doing work. It is worth seeing the work.

Suppose you are asked what you love when you love a person. You can start with the body: the face, the voice, the way they move. But if the face changed in an accident you would still love them, so it is not that. You can go to their character, but people change and the attachment survives some of that too.

Every honest answer to the question has this shape. You get there by ruling out each thing you could point to, and you are left describing something you can only reach for in the vocabulary of the things you just ruled out.

Augustine is not being evasive. He is reporting that the only available language for what he means is borrowed, and saying so out loud, which is more than most writing on the subject manages.

2.3 — The interrogation

Next he goes outside and asks things.

He questions the earth, and it says it is not what he is looking for. The sea and its living things say the same. The moving air, the sky, the sun, the moon and the stars all say the same. He tells them: you have all told me what you are not, so tell me something about what I am looking for. And they answer, all of them together, that he made them.

Then the line that pulls the passage together. He asks how they said it, and answers: their beauty is the answer. What they say, they say by being what they are.

And then a distinction that is easy to skate over and worth stopping on. The same beauty, he says, is in front of everybody. It does not speak to everybody. It speaks to those who put the question and compare what they hear inside with what they are looking at. The difference between the person who hears an answer and the person who sees only scenery is not in the world; it is in whether a question was being asked.

This series does not rule on whether the world answers. What is worth reporting plainly is that Augustine builds an escape hatch into the argument in the same breath as the argument. If you look at the sea and hear nothing, his account already predicts that, and predicts it in a way that no observation could disturb. That is a weakness, and he does not flag it as one.

2.4 — The turn inward

Having got nothing usable from the outside, he turns round.

He goes through his own faculties in order, ranking them. There is the power that keeps the body alive, which he shares with animals. There is the power that takes in the world through

the five senses, which he shares with animals too — and he is explicit that a horse and a dog have this and that it is not the thing he is after. So he goes up: past the body, past the senses, into the mind.

And there he finds the room this part is named after.

It is worth registering the shape of the journey before Chapter Three, because it is the argument of the whole book in miniature. He looked outside and was told to look elsewhere. He looked at his body and found an animal. He went into his mind and found something he could not get to the end of. The *Confessions* is a book about a man who kept going inwards expecting to find the bottom.

REMEMBER THIS

In the middle of a prayer, a bishop stops and asks **what he is actually talking about** when he says he loves God. The question is genuine and it takes the rest of the book to answer.

He rules out everything the senses can reach — **light, music, scent, taste, touch** — and then describes what is left using all five of them anyway, because there is no other vocabulary and he says so.

He goes outside and **interrogates the world**: earth, sea, air, sky, stars. Each says it is not what he is looking for; together they say they were made. What they say, they say **by being beautiful**.

He then notes that the same world is **silent to people who are not asking** — which protects the argument from every possible counter-example, and is a weakness he does not flag.

Getting nothing usable, he turns inward, ranks his own faculties, finds that **the body and the senses are things animals have too**, and goes up into the mind. That is where Chapter Three starts.

CHAPTER THREE

The Palace of Memory

This is the passage philosophers read the Confessions for. It cannot be summarised without wrecking it, so this chapter takes it in order, one move at a time.

3.1 — Arriving

Having gone past his body and past his senses, Augustine says he comes to the fields and the wide palaces of memory. The plural matters and so does the scale: not a drawer, not a shelf, a landscape with buildings on it.

What is stored there, first of all, are the images the senses brought in. Everything ever seen, heard, smelled, tasted or touched, filed by the door it came through: colours by the eyes, sounds by the ears, and so on, each kept in its own place and each still recognisably from the sense that carried it.

Then the part that makes it a description rather than a diagram. He says that when he goes in and asks for something, some things come at once. Some take longer, as though they had to be fetched from further back. Some come pouring out in a heap when he wanted something else entirely, and have to be pushed aside to get at what he was after. And when he is telling a story in order, the things come out in order, the first standing aside for the next and going back into storage to be brought out again when he wants them.

Anybody who has ever tried to remember a name knows all four of those behaviours. What is remarkable is that nobody had written them down.

WORD BOX

Memoria: the Latin word is wider than the English “memory”. It covers recollection of the past, but also the whole standing content of the mind — what you know, what you can do, what you are able to bring to mind — whether or not it came from an experience.

In the training Augustine had, *memoria* was also one of the five formal parts of rhetoric, alongside invention, arrangement, style and delivery. It was a subject with a technique attached.

Why it matters: reading *memoria* as “memory” makes the next twenty pages sound like a wildly overreaching theory of recollection. Read as “everything the mind has in it”, they are something else entirely.

And a small thing that is not small: he says memory is where he meets himself. When he wants to think about something he did, or is going to do, he goes to the same place.

3.2 — Why a palace

The image is so familiar now that it takes an effort to see it as a choice. It was one, and it came out of Augustine's day job.

IN REAL TERMS

Ancient orators memorised speeches lasting hours without notes, and they had a documented technique for it.

You took a building you knew well — a house, a colonnade, a bath complex — and walked through it in your mind, fixing a series of distinct places along the route. Then you converted each part of your speech into a vivid image and put one image in each place. To deliver the speech you walked the building again and collected them in order.

The technique is described in three surviving handbooks of the sort Augustine was trained on and later taught from. It is the origin of the English phrase “in the first place”.

So when a professor of rhetoric says memory is a building with rooms and that he goes in and fetches things, he is not reaching for a poetic figure. He is using the technical vocabulary of his own trade, and his readers with the same education would have heard it that way.

What is original is the next step: he takes a filing system built to hold a speech and asks what else is in the building — and finds that most of what is in it was never filed by anybody.

3.3 — The size of it

Then the passage turns, and this is the turn everything afterwards depends on.

He calls it a great power, a vast inner chamber without limit, and asks who has ever got to the bottom of it. And then: this is a power of my own mind, and it belongs to what I am, and I cannot take in the whole of what I am.

Read that twice. The mind, he says, is too narrow to hold itself. Whatever of itself it does not hold is somewhere — but where? Outside it? Then how is it the mind's? Inside it? Then why can it not reach it?

He does not solve this. He says a great astonishment comes over him, and moves on. It is one of the few places in the work where a problem is raised at full strength and simply left standing, and it is the reason this chapter is worth the effort.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT MEMORY IS A RECORD OF THE PAST

The English word does almost all its work in one direction. Memory is what happened; remembering is retrieval; a good memory is an accurate archive. Every metaphor in current use — a tape, a hard disk, a file — carries the same picture.

Now look at what Augustine finds in there over the next few pages: the multiplication tables, the rules of argument, how to do things, emotions he is not currently feeling, the fact that he has forgotten things, the memory of remembering, and eventually God. None of those is a past event. Most of them never came in through the senses at all.

If the archive picture were right, most of the contents of your own mind would have no address. You did not experience the number seven. Nothing happened to you that was “how to ride a bicycle”. You did not undergo the rule that a thing cannot both be and not be.

The archive picture is not stupid; it is a good description of one drawer in the building. The mistake is treating one drawer as the floor plan, and it is why modern readers find Book Ten sprawling. It is not sprawling. The word has shrunk.

The general form: mistaking the best-known contents of a category for the boundaries of it.

3.4 — The sentence about mountains

In the middle of all this comes the line that escaped the book.

People go out, he says, and stand amazed at high mountains, at the great waves of the sea, at wide rivers, at the reach of the ocean, at the turning of the stars — and they walk straight past themselves without a second look.

It is a good sentence and it has had a long life. The most famous moment in that life is a letter written about nine hundred and fifty years later by the poet Petrarch, describing a climb up a mountain in Provence. At the summit, he says, he opened a pocket copy of the *Confessions* at random and his eye fell on this passage, and he shut the book and came down in silence.

It is worth adding, since this series does not let a good story stand unexamined, that the letter is dated 1336 and was probably written much later and shaped for effect, and that scholars have doubted for a long time whether the climb happened as described. The parallel with Book Eight is almost too neat: a man opens a book at random on a height and reads the line that changes the day. Petrarch had read Book Eight.

REMEMBER THIS

Past the body and past the senses, Augustine arrives at what he calls the **fields and wide palaces of memory** — a landscape, not a drawer.

He describes how retrieval actually behaves: some things come at once, some come slowly, some **come pouring out when you wanted something else**, and in a told story they queue up in order. Everybody knows this. Nobody had written it down.

The image is not poetry. The **memory palace was a real technique** taught in the rhetorical training he had and later taught, for memorising speeches hours long.

The turn that matters: memory is a power of his own mind, and he **cannot take in the whole of what he is**. The mind is too narrow to hold itself. He raises this, is astonished by it, and leaves it standing.

And the line that escaped the book: people cross the world to stare at mountains and oceans and **walk past themselves without looking**.

CHAPTER FOUR

What Is Actually In There

Having got into the building, Augustine goes through it. What he finds is stranger than the reader is expecting, and by the end of the tour he says plainly that he is out of his depth.

4.1 — Pictures, and things that are not pictures

The first floor is the obvious one. When he thinks of a stone, or the sun, or a city he has been to, what is in his mind is an image left behind by the senses. He was not there; a picture of there was.

But then he notices a second kind of content and the distinction is the hinge of the whole chapter. When he thinks about grammar, or about the rules for telling a good argument from a bad one, he is not handling pictures of those things. He is handling the things themselves.

There is no image of “a valid inference”. Nobody has seen one. It did not come in through a door, because it has no colour, no sound and no smell. And yet it is unmistakably in there, available on request, and he can be wrong about it — which means it is something he is consulting rather than something he is inventing.

4.2 — Where it came from, and why thinking is collecting

So he asks the obvious next question. If those contents did not come in through the senses, how did they get in?

Not, he says, out of somebody else’s head: when a teacher tells you something like this and you agree, what you do is recognise it. You say yes, that is right. But you can only say that if you already had something to check it against.

His conclusion is that the material was already there, lying about unsorted and unattended, and that learning consists in gathering it up and putting it where it can be reached.

Then he makes a point about the Latin that is worth keeping. The verb for thinking, *cogitare*, is built on the verb for driving things together into one place, *cogere* — the same root as the word for a herd being rounded up. On his reading, the language is telling you that thinking is not producing something new. It is collecting.

The etymology is, as it happens, correct, which is not something one can often say about ancient word-derivations. It does not prove the theory. It does show a man reading his own working vocabulary for evidence, which is a habit worth stealing.

4.3 — Feelings you are not having

The next room is the odd one, and it is the part of Book Ten that modern philosophy of mind keeps coming back to.

Memory, he says, also holds the states of the mind — wanting, being glad, being afraid, being sad. And it holds them in a way that has a peculiar property: he can produce them without undergoing them.

He can remember a fear and not be afraid. He can remember having been happy while he is miserable, and remember being miserable while he is happy. Being sad about a past joy is an ordinary experience. Nothing else in the building works this way — remembering a colour does not produce a colourless version of it.

IN REAL TERMS

His comparison for this is deliberately undignified and he knows it. Memory, he says, is a sort of stomach of the mind, and joy and sadness are like sweet and bitter food: once swallowed into that stomach they can be stored, but they cannot be tasted. He adds that the comparison is probably ridiculous and that there is something in it anyway.

Test it on yourself. Bring to mind something that frightened you badly, ten years ago. You can report it in detail. You can say how afraid you were, and rank it against other frights.

Your pulse has not changed.

Now bring to mind a shade of blue. You are not seeing blue either — but nobody expected you to be. With the fear, something that was the whole point of it is missing, and you can still handle the thing accurately without it.

That gap is what Augustine is pointing at, and no theory of memory has ever quite disposed of it.

4.4 — Remembering that you have forgotten

Then he walks into the wall.

Memory also contains forgetting. He can say, truthfully, that he has forgotten something. But if forgetting is the absence of a thing from memory, and he is remembering the forgetting, then the forgetting is present in memory — and if it is present, it is not doing what forgetting does.

He turns it over several ways and none of them works. If what is in memory is an image of forgetting rather than forgetting itself, then the image must have been made from the thing,

and the thing would have to have been present to be copied, and we are back where we started.

And in the middle of that, a phrase this series has been waiting for since Part Three.

In Book Four, standing beside the death of his friend, the young Augustine wrote that he had become a great question to himself. Part Three flagged it, said the answer was in Book Ten, and left it there. Here it is: labouring over the problem of forgetting, he writes that he is working hard and working on himself, and that he has become to himself a soil of hard labour and too much sweat.

And a few pages later, arguing with himself about church music, the phrase returns in almost its original words: he has become a question to himself.

That is the payment of the debt, and it is worth being clear about what kind of payment it is. The line from Book Four is not answered in Book Ten. It is confirmed. The young man who did not understand his own grief and the bishop who cannot get to the bottom of his own memory are making the same report, twenty years apart, and the older one has a better vocabulary for it and no more of a solution.

4.5 — Admitting he is out of his depth

The tour ends without a floor plan, and Augustine says so.

The power he has been describing is his. It is part of his nature. And he does not grasp the whole of what he is. He calls it a wonder that stuns him. Then, rather than solving it, he does something that is either an evasion or the point of the book depending on your view: he says he will go past memory too, looking for what he is looking for.

A position, declared. I think the admission is the most valuable thing in the chapter and it is routinely skipped by both his admirers and his critics. Sixteen hundred years of writing about the interior life has proceeded on the assumption that looking inward yields answers. The man who started that tradition wrote down, in the middle of doing it, that he had looked as hard as he could and could not see the back wall.

REMEMBER THIS

Memory holds two kinds of thing: **images** left by the senses, and things held **without images** — grammar, argument, mathematics. Nobody has ever seen a valid inference, and it is in there anyway.

Since those did not come in through the senses, Augustine concludes they were already there, and that **learning is gathering up what was lying about unsorted**. He notes the Latin for “think” is built on the verb for driving things together.

Memory holds **emotions you are not having**. You can remember a terror in full detail with a steady pulse. He compares memory to a stomach in which food is stored but not tasted, and admits the comparison is ridiculous.

It also holds **forgetting**, which should be impossible, and he cannot solve it. In the middle of that he writes that he has become to himself **a soil of hard labour and too much sweat** — the phrase from Book Four, returning.

The debt from Part Three is paid, and not the way it was expected to be. Book Ten does not **answer** “I have become a great question to myself”. It **confirms** it, with better equipment and no solution.

CHAPTER FIVE

Everybody Wants It and Nobody Can Name It

A puzzle about searching, a claim that every human being wants the same thing, and one of the sharpest observations about people anywhere in ancient literature.

5.1 — How you look for something

Augustine is looking for God in memory, and he stops to ask what looking for something in memory even involves. The example he uses is a woman in a parable who loses a coin and lights a lamp to hunt for it.

Here is the difficulty. She finds it. How does she know it is the one she lost? Only because she still had a hold on it — an image of it, a recognition — the whole time she was searching. If she had genuinely lost all trace of it she could have picked it up and put it down again without knowing.

Which gives the general rule: you cannot search for something you have no hold on at all, because you would not know when to stop. Every search runs on a partial memory of the thing being searched for.

This is an old problem — Plato put it in a dialogue seven hundred years earlier and answered it with a doctrine of the soul remembering a previous existence. Augustine knows that answer and does not take it. He wants to see how far he can get with ordinary recognition.

5.2 — The one thing everybody wants

And then he applies it to the biggest case he can find.

WORD BOX

Beata vita — the happy life: the standard subject of ancient moral philosophy, and a much heavier term than “happiness” in English. It means a life that has gone well as a whole, not a mood. Every ancient school had a position on it. The Stoics said it was virtue and nothing else. The Epicureans said it was the absence of disturbance. Aristotle said it was activity of the soul in accordance with excellence, with enough good fortune not to be wrecked.

Why it matters: when Augustine says everybody wants the happy life he is not making a bland observation about people liking to be cheerful. He is entering a specific, centuries-old technical debate, and his readers knew the field.

His claim is that if you ask any two people whether they want their life to go well, both say yes at once and without hesitating. There is no hesitation because there is no ambiguity about what is being asked.

But that, on the rule from the last section, is very strange. To want a thing you must have some hold on it. So where did everybody get their hold on this? Nobody has had a completed life to compare against. And people who have never in their lives had a good year still know exactly what the question means.

Augustine turns over the possibilities. Perhaps everybody was happy at some point and remembers it. Perhaps everybody was happy in the first human being, in whom, on his account, we all fell — he raises this and is careful to say the question is difficult and he is not going to settle it here. What he keeps is the smaller and firmer point: whatever the mechanism, the thing is in memory, because otherwise the word would not work.

That the universal want is real, and the universal knowledge is real, and the account of how both got there is missing, is a fair summary of where he leaves it.

5.3 — Wanting the thing and wanting the road

Then a distinction that does a lot of work and gets very little space.

Everybody, he says, wants the happy life. Not everybody wants what produces it. The universal agreement is on the destination and it collapses the instant anybody names a route.

It is worth pausing on how much that concedes to his opponents. The unanimity he just established turns out to be unanimity about a word. The moment it is filled in — this is what a life that has gone well consists of — the agreement is gone and the ancient schools are at each other's throats again. Augustine notices this and does not pretend it away, and it is one of the reasons his argument is worth more than the standard version of it.

5.4 — Joy in the truth

His own answer, when it comes, is four words long. The happy life is joy in the truth.

That is doing two things. It is joy, so it is a state of a person and not an abstract achievement. And it is in the truth, so it is not available by being fooled. On this account a contented life built on something false is not a defective instance of the happy life; it is not an instance of it.

And then, having got there, he makes the observation that has outlived every doctrinal part of the chapter.

People love the truth, he says, when it shows them something. They hate it when it shows them themselves. And because they do not want to be wrong, but do want the thing they are wrong about, they end up loving truth in a strange shape: they love some other thing and want *that* to be the truth. Then, since they will not give it up, they hate the real thing for exposing it.

He adds the closing turn of the screw. They hate it, and it does not reciprocate: the truth will not let them hide from it, and they cannot stop it being there.

You do not need any of Augustine's theology to recognise that paragraph. It is the most accurate thing in Book Ten about other people, and it was written by a man who spent nine years in a religion he later decided was false, which is presumably where he got it.

REMEMBER THIS

You cannot search for something you have **no hold on at all**, because you would not recognise it if you found it. Every search runs on a partial memory of what is being looked for.

Apply that to the **happy life**, which Augustine says every human being wants without hesitating. If the rule holds, everybody must somehow already have it in memory — and he cannot establish how it got there. He raises the possibilities and leaves the question open.

The unanimity is thinner than it looks. Everybody wants the destination; **nobody agrees on the road**. He concedes this rather than hiding it.

His own answer: the happy life is **joy in the truth**. Which rules out a contented life built on something false — not as a poor version of the thing, but as not the thing.

And the observation that outlives the argument: people **love truth when it lights something up and hate it when it lights them up**, so they love some other thing instead and want that to be the truth.

CHAPTER SIX

Late Have I Loved You

The search through memory ends by going past memory, and produces the most quoted paragraph in Latin prose. Underneath the beauty there is a position, and it is the position Chapter Nine goes to war over.

6.1 — Not in the building

Augustine has been searching memory for what he is looking for, and he goes through it methodically and comes up empty. Not among the images of physical things, because it is not a physical thing. Not among the states of the mind, because those come and go and it does not.

Not, he decides, in the mind itself either, on the grounds that the mind changes and what he is looking for does not.

Then he catches himself and says something that reframes the whole search: why am I looking for a place in there, as though there were places in there?

The palace was a metaphor. He has been walking round it for twenty pages as though its rooms were rooms, and now he stops and says so. That is a good instinct and a rare one — most people who build a working image forget they built it.

His conclusion is that what he was looking for was not in memory before he learned it, and so he did not find it in memory at all. He found it, he says, above himself. And then he adds, with a precision that is easy to skim: nowhere is there a place. We go backwards and forwards, and there is no place.

6.2 — The passage

What follows is about six lines long in Latin and it is the most anthologised thing Augustine wrote.

Rendered plainly, without trying to reproduce the sound of it: I came to love you late, beauty so old and so new, I came to you late. And there you were, inside, and I was outside, and outside is where I was looking. Ugly, I went crashing about among the beautiful things you made. You were with me and I was not with you. The things that kept me away from you were things that would not have existed at all unless they were in you.

And then the five verbs. You called and shouted and broke my deafness open. You flashed, you blazed, and my blindness went. You gave off a scent, and I breathed in, and now I am short of breath for you. I tasted, and now I am hungry and thirsty. You touched me, and I caught fire for your peace.

Now look at what those five verbs are. Hearing, sight, smell, taste, touch — in that order, all five, one each.

That is not decoration. Chapter Two of this part opened with Augustine ruling out all five senses as an answer to what he loves, and then saying that he does nevertheless love a light, a voice, a fragrance, a food and an embrace of the inner person. Twenty pages later the book comes back and cashes the cheque, in the same order, with the five inner senses now described as things that happened to him rather than things he possesses. The famous passage is the closing bracket of an argument that opened at the start of the book, and most readers meet it as a standalone poem.

6.3 — Who is doing what

Now read it again for grammar, which is where the doctrine is hiding.

In every one of those five clauses, the active verb belongs to God. He calls. He shouts. He breaks. He flashes. He blazes. He drives away. He breathes out. He touches.

And every verb belonging to Augustine is a reaction. I breathed in. I am short of breath. I am hungry. I caught fire. There is not one thing in the sequence that he initiates. Even the “I came to love you late” that opens it is a confession of having been slow, not a claim to have arrived.

That is the whole of Augustine’s mature doctrine of grace, expressed in the arrangement of verbs, several years before anybody picked a fight with him about it.

WORD BOX

Gratia — grace: a gift given without being earned. In Augustine’s mature account it is not only forgiveness after the fact; it is what enables a person to want the good in the first place. Later writers call this **prevenient** grace, from the Latin for “coming before”: the help that arrives before the wanting, and produces it.

The alternative available at the time, and held by decent people, is that God supplies the law, the example and the forgiveness, and the wanting is the person’s own contribution. On that account grace assists a free movement. On Augustine’s, grace causes it.

Why it matters: the difference between “helped to choose” and “enabled to want” looks like a technicality and is not. It decides what a person can be praised or blamed for, and it is the whole subject of Chapter Nine.

A position, declared. The passage is beautiful, and treating it purely as a lyric — which is how it is usually read aloud — quietly removes the thing it is arguing. I do not think that is a scandal; a paragraph is allowed to outgrow its book. But a series that has spent six parts on Augustine's arguments should say plainly that this one is an argument, and that if you find the theology of grace uncongenial you have, in these six lines, been agreeing with it.

6.4 — Whether any of this was new

Which raises the question the last four chapters have been walking towards. Everybody says Augustine invented the inner life. Did he?

THE ARGUMENT — DID AUGUSTINE INVENT INTERIORITY?

Book Ten is routinely called the first piece of writing in which a human being examines their own consciousness. It is a large claim and it is made by serious people, and it is disputed by serious people.

YES, THIS IS THE BEGINNING OF IT

Point to anything earlier that does what Book Ten does. Not a memoir of events — those exist. Not a philosophical treatise on the soul — those exist. Something in which a named individual investigates his own mind as an object he cannot get to the bottom of, in the first person, in the present tense, and reports failure.

The genre after him is enormous — the medieval confessional literature, Petrarch, Montaigne, Rousseau, the modern novel, psychoanalysis — and it traces back through here.

Twentieth-century philosophers of mind who have no interest whatever in his religion still quote the memory chapters, which is not a thing that happens to derivative work.

NO, HE ASSEMBLED IT

Every component is older. The idea that learning is recollecting something already held is Plato's. The ascent from bodies through soul to what is above soul is Plotinus, as Part Six set out at length. The daily examination of conscience was a Stoic exercise with a manual. Cicero had written on the happy life, memory and the passions, and Augustine had taught Cicero for a living.

What is new is the combination and the voice, and “new voice” is a literary achievement rather than a philosophical discovery. Calling him the inventor of the inner life flatters him and erases four hundred years of people who supplied the parts.

THE CLAIM IS ANACHRONISTIC

A third position, and the sharpest. “Interiority” is a modern category. It carries the idea of a private inner theatre that belongs to the person and is authoritative about itself — the self as its own best witness.

That is not what Book Ten has. Augustine’s inner life is not private: somebody else is already in it and knows it better than he does. It is not authoritative: he says outright that there are things about him he cannot see. And it is not a possession; it is a place where he is summoned and cannot answer.

So the question “did he invent the modern self” is asking whether a thing that is not the modern self was the modern self. What he invented is something else, and calling it interiority makes it harder rather than easier to see.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes what is in Book Ten, or that the later tradition of self-examination runs through it. What is disputed is whether “first” and “invented” are the right words, and whether the category being applied fits.

What would settle it: Nothing will settle it, because it is a question about how to describe a text rather than about a fact. The nearest thing to a settlement would be an earlier work doing the same job, and none has turned up.

Why people care so much: Because the claim is load-bearing in a lot of intellectual history. If Augustine is where the inner life begins, then a great deal of modern psychology has a Christian doctrine of the soul at the bottom of it, whether or not anybody involved would put it that way.

A position, declared, and it is the third one. The most useful thing this series can say about Book Ten is that it is not an early draft of modern introspection. It is a description of a self that is opaque to itself and legible to someone else, which is a stranger idea than the one it usually gets translated into, and Chapter Seven is where it gets stated outright.

REMEMBER THIS

Augustine searches memory for God, finds nothing, and then stops to notice that he has been **treating a metaphor as a place**. The palace has no rooms. What he was looking for was not in it. The passage that follows — “**late have I loved you**” — runs through **all five senses in order**, deliberately closing an argument that opened in Chapter Two of this part. It is the second half of a bracket, not a standalone poem.

Read it for grammar and the doctrine appears. **Every active verb belongs to God**; every verb Augustine gives himself is a reaction. That is his whole theory of **grace**, laid out years before anybody objected to it.

Which is why reading the passage purely as a lyric quietly removes what it is arguing — and why anyone who loves it has, in six lines, agreed with the position Chapter Nine is a war about. Did he invent the inner life? The most useful answer is **no, and the question is the wrong shape**: his self is opaque to itself and known better by someone else, which is not what “interiority” means.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Man at the Desk

Halfway through Book Ten the tense changes for good. From here to the end Augustine is not describing a man he used to be. He is filing a report on the one writing.

7.1 The turn

The hinge is a single question, and it is a bleak one. Is not the whole of a human life on earth a trial, without a break in it anywhere?

WORD BOX

Temptatio: usually translated “temptation”, which is too narrow. The Latin means a test, a trial, a putting-to-the-proof. Metal is *temptatum* when it is assayed.

So the sentence is not “life is full of enticements”. It is closer to “life is one continuous examination, and you do not get to see the paper in advance”.

Why it matters: it sets the register for everything in Chapters Seven and Eight. Augustine is not going to give you a list of things he wants and should not. He is going to describe a man who does not know, from one day to the next, what he will turn out to be.

He puts the reason for the trial plainly. He is a burden to himself, and the burden is that he is not full of what he is looking for.

And then the change of tense. Books One to Nine confessed what he had been. From here on he confesses what he is — on the day of writing, in the state of not knowing how it ends.

7.2 — What he can and cannot find out about himself

Before he starts the survey, he stops to say what kind of report it can be, and this is the most important paragraph in the second half of the book.

There are things about a person, he says, that only that person’s own spirit knows. Fine — that is the ordinary claim about privileged access, and it is where most accounts stop.

But there is more, he says, that even that spirit does not know. And the person can only know it if it is shown to them from outside.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT YOU CAN FIND OUT WHAT YOU ARE BY LOOKING INWARD

The instruction to look inside yourself for the truth about yourself is so standard now that it barely registers as a claim. Know yourself. Be honest with yourself. Nobody knows you like you do. The whole apparatus assumes the inside is accessible and that the difficulty is willingness rather than capacity.

The man usually credited with starting that tradition says it does not work. His account is that self-examination has a floor, that the floor is not the bottom, and that what is under it is not reachable from where he is standing.

And notice how much he stakes on it. This is the second half of a book he has just described as a confession of what he is now. He opens it by telling you the instrument is not good enough for the job.

The modern version of this point is not religious and does not need to be. People are routinely and confidently wrong about their own motives; the reasons we give for what we did are frequently constructed after the fact and feel exactly like the real ones. Augustine's conclusion — that the truth about a person is available, but not to them, and not by looking harder — is one option. It is not the only one. What is not available is the comfortable version in which sincerity is sufficient.

The general form: assuming that an instrument can measure itself.

This is also, incidentally, the answer to anyone who reads Book Ten as an exercise in self-absorption. A self-absorbed book does not open its central section by conceding that the author is not a reliable witness about himself.

7.3 — The shape he borrows

Having said he cannot see everything, he still has to organise the search. He borrows a frame rather than inventing one, and the frame comes from a single verse in one of the letters of John.

WORD BOX

Concupiscentia, and the three-part division: *concupiscentia* is strong desire — wanting, in the sense of craving. The word is neutral in itself and Augustine almost always uses it for disordered wanting.

The verse he takes his structure from divides everything in the world into three: the craving of the flesh, the craving of the eyes, and the ambition of this life. Augustine reads them as the pleasures of the body, the appetite for experience for its own sake, and the desire to be well thought of.

Why it matters: this survey became the standard scheme of self-examination in the western church for a thousand years, and it is the ancestor of the examination of conscience in later manuals. It is also the reason Chapter Eight has the shape it has, and — as that chapter argues — it may be the reason certain things are missing from it.

Then, before beginning, he sets out what he thinks a person is up against and what would fix it. The image is one he has used before and it is worth having in plain words: a person leaks

outward into many things, and what pulls them back into one is self-command. He is scattered and he wants to be gathered.

And it is at exactly this point, at the head of the survey and before a single temptation has been named, that he writes the four words this series has owed you since Part One.

Give what you command, and command what you will.

He then repeats it twice more before the book ends, both times at a moment of maximum difficulty. Chapter Nine is about what happened when somebody read it out loud in Rome. For now it is enough to notice where it sits: not as a conclusion, but as the ticket of admission to the examination that follows. He is saying, before he starts, that he cannot pass this test under his own power and is not going to pretend otherwise.

REMEMBER THIS

Halfway through Book Ten the **tense changes for good**. Augustine stops describing a man he used to be and starts filing a report on the one writing.

The frame is a question: is the whole of human life not **one continuous trial**? *Temptatio* means a test, not merely an enticement.

Before starting he concedes the thing that undercuts the whole exercise: there are things about a person that **even that person cannot see**, and looking harder will not produce them. The instrument cannot measure itself.

He organises the survey on a **three-part division** from a letter of John — the body, the appetite for experience, and the desire to be well thought of. It became the standard scheme of self-examination in the west for a thousand years.

And at the head of it, before a single temptation is named, sit the four words: **give what you command, and command what you will**. He says it before he starts, because he is saying he cannot pass the test on his own.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What He Is Still Tempted By

A bishop in his forties writes down, for publication, what still gets him. The list is unlike anything before it, the third item is the one he is frightened of, and what is missing from it is an argument in itself.

8.1 — The body, and the one he cannot renounce

He starts with sex, because his readers will expect it, and the passage is not what they expect. He has been celibate for eleven years. Awake, he says, it is quiet. Asleep, it is not.

Images fixed in memory by long habit come back in dreams, he says, and in sleep they carry him not only to pleasure but to consent, and to something very like the act.

Then the question, which is a real one and is still live in philosophy: am I not myself at that moment? The difference between waking and sleeping is enormous, and yet the sleeper is the same man. He does not resolve it. He asks for the help to reach that far in as well.

It is worth stopping to register what has just happened. A serving bishop, in a book he knows will be copied and read by his ecclesiastical enemies, has volunteered a paragraph about his erotic dreams. Nothing obliged him to. Whatever else Book Ten is, that paragraph is not a safe move.

Then food, and the treatment is completely different, for a reason he names.

IN REAL TERMS

The distinction he draws here is the most practically useful thing in the chapter and it has nothing to do with religion.

Some appetites can be cut off. He gave up sex, and once given up it is gone; there is no daily negotiation. The decision is made once and enforced by absence.

Eating cannot be cut off. You have to do it, several times a day, for life. So there is no clean line to hold, only a shifting boundary between what the body needs and what the appetite would like, and the boundary has to be found again at every meal by the very faculty that has an interest in getting it wrong.

His own phrasing: he was taught to take food as a medicine. The trouble is that the medicine is pleasant, and while he is moving from need towards enough, pleasure comes along as an escort and he cannot always tell which of them is leading.

Anyone who has quit something outright and also tried to moderate something else knows which of the two is harder, and it is not the one people admire you for.

He adds a detail that shows how careful he is being. It is not the food he is afraid of, he says, but the craving. He is not building a theory in which some things are dirty. He is describing a relation.

Smell gets three lines. He does not think it troubles him — and then immediately adds that he may be wrong about that, which is Chapter Seven's concession being applied in practice rather than announced.

8.2 — Music in church, and a man arguing with himself

Hearing gets much more, because of a specific problem he cannot settle: the singing in his own cathedral.

He grants the benefit without hedging. Words that are sung move the mind more than the same words spoken; he has felt it; the congregation is carried by it. Part Six described him weeping at exactly this in Milan, three months before his mother died, and he has not forgotten it.

And he cannot get past the fact that sometimes the tune moves him more than the meaning, and that when that happens he would rather not have heard it.

He goes back and forth. He notes that a bishop in Alexandria had the psalms recited with so little inflection that it was closer to speech than to singing, and that this is one solution. He inclines — his own word, and he explicitly refuses to give a final ruling — towards keeping the singing, on the grounds that people with weaker attachments are lifted by it.

And then, in the middle of it, the phrase from Book Four again. He has become a question to himself.

He has now used that formula twice in one book: once at the limit of what he can understand about memory, and once about whether it is all right to enjoy a hymn. That is not bathos. It is the same discovery arriving at two scales.

Sight gets the last of the bodily section, and he is generous about it. Light he calls the queen of colours, and he does not pretend to be indifferent. He notes that human beings have gone far past necessity in making beautiful things — clothes, shoes, pots, pictures — and that the people who make them get the ability from the source of beauty and mostly do not look up from the work to notice.

8.3 — The second: wanting to know for the sake of knowing

WORD BOX

Curiositas: in Augustine this is a vice, and it is not what the English word “curiosity” now means. It is the appetite for experiencing and finding out, pursued for the taste of the finding out, and travelling — as he puts it — under the respectable name of knowledge.

The test he uses to separate it from ordinary pleasure is exact. People run to look at a mangled body in the road. Nobody enjoys the sight. So whatever is pulling them is not pleasure; it is the wanting to have seen.

Why it matters: this became one of the more damaging things in the western tradition, because a vice called curiosity was later used against inquiry in general. Augustine’s own targets are narrower — spectacle, divination, magic, and the prying into things that will not help anybody — but the word did him no favours.

The examples he gives of his own case are so domestic that they are almost embarrassing to read, and they are the reason the section survives.

He sits at home and watches a lizard catching flies, or a spider wrapping them, and notices that he has been watching. He no longer goes to the games, which he treats as settled — and then admits that if he is riding past a field and a dog puts up a hare, the chase can take his whole mind, and he does not turn his horse aside but his attention has gone.

He says the small ones are the problem. The large temptations he has been given the strength to leave. It is the innumerable little ones, laid across an ordinary day like snares, that he keeps walking into.

Whatever one makes of the theology, that is an accurate description of attention, written sixteen hundred years before anybody built a machine to exploit it.

8.4 — The third, which is worse

And then the one he is actually afraid of: the wish to be feared and loved by other people for no reason except the pleasure it gives.

Three things make it worse than the other two, and he names all three.

It comes with the job. A bishop has to be respected to function. People must take him seriously or he cannot adjudicate a dispute or hold a congregation together. So the standing cannot simply be renounced the way sex was; it is part of the work, and the pleasure it gives rides in with it.

It attaches to real goods. When somebody praises him for something that genuinely is good, the danger is not that the praise is false. It is that he finds he is pleased about the praise rather than about the good, and the two are almost impossible to separate from the inside.

And it feeds on the resistance to it. He records catching himself being pleased at being the sort of man who is not taken in by praise. There is no floor to that. Every level of detachment from it becomes a new thing to be admired for, including this sentence.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A TEMPTATION CAN BE TESTED BY REMOVING ITS OBJECT

Here is the move Augustine makes that nobody else in the ancient world makes, and it is a piece of methodology rather than theology.

With food, he says, you can find out where you stand. Go without for a few days and observe. The abstinence is a measurement, and it is available on demand, and it costs nothing but hunger.

With the good opinion of other people, there is no equivalent. You cannot arrange to be despised in order to see how you take it. And you certainly cannot do it by behaving badly on purpose to find out — he raises that and rejects it, because you would have ruined the thing you were trying to measure.

So the whole apparatus of self-testing, which works well enough on the appetites, fails completely on the vice he thinks is most dangerous. The only instrument left is the conscience — and Chapter Seven has already told you the conscience cannot see the bottom of itself.

The general point survives every specific: some dispositions can only be observed under conditions you are not allowed to create. Anything you can only test by wrecking your own life is untested, and most people carrying such a disposition have quietly concluded they do not have it.

The general form: mistaking “no test came back positive” for “no test was possible”.

And at the end of the list, underneath all three, he puts a fourth thing that is not really a fourth item: being pleased with himself. Not pleased about anything in particular. Just the standing satisfaction of being who he is, which he thinks is where the other three come from.

8.5 — What is not on the list

Which brings us to the question that has to be asked about this chapter, and that admirers of the book usually skip.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE CONFESSION OF PRESENT TEMPTATION CANDOUR OR PERFORMANCE?

Book Ten is the first part of the work with a declared human audience, written by a bishop with enemies, and consisting largely of a list of his own faults. Those three facts sit together awkwardly and readers have divided on what to make of it.

CANDOUR

Look at the erotic dreams. There is no version of fourth-century church politics in which volunteering that paragraph helps him. He could have written the whole survey without it and nobody would have noticed the gap.

And look at the praise section, which names precisely the accusation a famous churchman is most exposed to — that he enjoys being important — and then says he has no way of finding out whether it is true of him. A performance does not hand the audience the charge sheet and then concede it cannot mount a defence.

PERFORMANCE

Then look at what is not there. Nothing about the woman he lived with for over a decade and sent away, whom Part Four covered and who is never named. Nothing about money, or the property of the church, which he administered. Nothing about the exercise of power — and by the time he wrote this he could make life difficult for people, and did.

Nothing about the conflict with the Donatists, which was consuming African Christianity while he wrote and in which he would later come to approve the use of the state against dissenters. What is on the list instead: erotic dreams, eating slightly too much, enjoying hymns, watching a lizard. Every item universal, every item safe, every item flattering to a man who wants to be seen examining himself. That is exactly what the best rhetorician of the age would produce if the goal were to look honest.

THE QUESTION ASSUMES A CHOICE THAT IS NOT AVAILABLE

A third position. The form Augustine is writing in did not exist before he wrote it, and it is a public act of private disclosure. That is a contradiction at the level of genre, not a flaw in his character.

Any confession written for readers is shaped for readers. That does not make it false — a letter of condolence is composed and still meant. Asking whether Book Ten is sincere or performed is asking a question the form cannot answer about itself.

The useful question is narrower: is any particular claim in it likely to be true? On that footing the dreams look true because they cost him, and the omissions look like omissions, and both conclusions can be held at once without a verdict on the man.

Where things stand: The contents of Book Ten are not in dispute, and neither are the omissions. What is disputed is whether the omissions are evidence of management or artefacts of the structure.

What would settle it: The strongest counter-evidence to the performance reading is the structure itself: the survey follows a three-part scheme taken from scripture, and it goes where that scheme goes. A list organised on the senses and the appetites has no slot for what he did to one woman in 385.

Why people care so much: Because Book Ten is the founding document of a whole way of writing about oneself, and every memoir since has had the same problem: the disclosure is real and the selection is still doing work.

A position, declared. I think the third reading is right about the genre and the second is right about the omissions, and that the two are compatible. The scriptural frame explains why the woman is not in the list; it does not explain why a man conducting the most searching self-examination ever attempted chose a frame with no place for her in it. Part Four said the striking thing about that episode is that it is the one place where his self-examination stops. Book Ten is where that observation gets its confirmation, by omission.

REMEMBER THIS

On sex, he reports that waking is quiet and **sleep is not**, and asks whether he is himself in a dream. A serving bishop volunteering that, in a book his enemies would read, is not a safe move. On food, the point that outlives the theology: some appetites can be **cut off once**, and some must be **practised daily**, and the second kind is harder because the boundary has to be found again at every meal by the faculty with an interest in getting it wrong.

On church music he argues with himself and refuses to rule, and in the middle of it uses the phrase from Book Four again: **he has become a question to himself**.

Curiositas — wanting to have found out, for the taste of it. His examples are a lizard catching flies and a dog putting up a hare. He says the **small ones** are what get him, which is an accurate account of attention written sixteen centuries early.

The third temptation is worst because it **comes with the job, attaches to real goods, and feeds on resistance to it** — and above all because there is **no way to test for it**. You can fast. You cannot arrange to be despised.

CHAPTER NINE

Four Words

A prayer four words long, in the middle of a book about memory, read out loud in Rome around the year 405. This series has owed you this chapter since Part One.

9.1 — What the sentence says

In Latin it is four words. Rendered into English it takes seven: give what you command, and command what you will.

Augustine writes it three times in Book Ten. Once at the head of the examination of himself, as Chapter Seven set out, and twice more later, both times at a point where he has just admitted he cannot manage something.

It looks mild. It is not.

IN REAL TERMS

Take the two halves separately.

“Give what you command.” The obvious prayer, when a requirement is beyond you, is to ask for the requirement to be reduced. Make it easier. Augustine asks for the opposite: leave the requirement where it is and supply the ability to meet it. Not lower the bar — give me the legs.

“And command what you will.” This is the half people skim, and it is where the force is. Once the ability arrives with the requirement, the content of the requirement stops mattering. He is writing a blank cheque. Ask anything, because whatever you ask, you will also be supplying.

Put the two together and you have a claim about human beings, not just a request. It says: I cannot generate the wanting. If the wanting appears, it will have been given. And therefore nothing I manage is a thing I did on my own.

That is a statement most people would find hard to sign in any area of life — the recovering addict, the person trying to be less cruel, the person trying to work. Which is roughly why it caused what it caused.

And notice where the four words come from. Chapter Six of this part took the “late have I loved you” passage apart and found that every active verb in it belonged to God and every verb Augustine gave himself was a reaction. This sentence is that grammar turned into a request. The lyric and the doctrine are the same thing said twice.

9.2 — Somebody read it out

What happened next is the best-known consequence of any sentence in the book, and the evidence for it is thinner than its fame suggests.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The story: some years after the *Confessions* was published, in Rome, a bishop quoted this line in company. A British ascetic named Pelagius was present, could not bear it, contradicted the man who had quoted it with some heat, and the two of them nearly came to blows.

The source is Augustine himself, in a work written around 428 or 429, more than twenty years after the event.

Augustine was not there. He is reporting what he was told, at second hand, about a man he had by then spent sixteen years fighting in print, in a book whose purpose was to defend the position that started the quarrel. He does not name the bishop who quoted the line, and he does not give a date. What that supports: that Augustine believed, and told others, that his own sentence set the controversy off, and that he thought the four words were the point of disagreement. That much is solid, and it is worth something — he knew what the fight was about better than anybody.

What it cannot support: the scene. A single hostile witness, at second hand, two decades late, is not evidence that a man lost his temper in a room in Rome. The origin story of the largest doctrinal fight in western Christianity rests on an anecdote of exactly the kind this series has declined to take at face value five times already.

What is not in doubt is that the two men disagreed, that the disagreement was about this, and that it did not stay a disagreement.

9.3 — Why anybody would object

The reaction is easier to understand once you know what Pelagius was doing in Rome.

WORD BOX

Pelagius: a lay ascetic from Britain, or possibly Ireland, working in Rome from the 380s. Not a bishop and not a heretic-hunter: a moral teacher with a following among wealthy Roman Christians, urging them to take the religion seriously enough to change how they lived.

His central conviction was that people can do what they are told to do. God, being just, does not issue commands that are impossible to obey; therefore the capacity to obey must already be there; therefore anybody who says they cannot is making an excuse.

He is usually described as the enemy of grace. He was not. He held that grace is real and everywhere — in the creation of a good human nature, in the law, in the teaching and example of Christ, and in forgiveness. What he would not accept was that grace supplies the wanting itself.

Why it matters: he and Augustine agreed that God is just and that the commands are real. They split on what follows from that, and the split goes all the way down.

So a room full of comfortable Roman Christians hears a bishop read out a prayer that says nobody can do anything unless it is handed to them first, and the man who has spent twenty years telling those exact people that they can and should do better hears it as the end of his life's work.

His objection was not metaphysical. It was that the sentence supplies an excuse to everybody who wants one, and that most people want one.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A DOCTRINE IS REFUTED BY THE BEHAVIOUR IT LICENSES

Pelagius' objection has a shape that is worth naming, because it is everywhere and it is usually invisible. It runs: if people believed this, they would stop trying; therefore it is false.

That is not an argument about whether the claim is true. It is an argument about what would happen if it were believed. The two come apart completely. A true claim about human capacity would have exactly these consequences whether or not the consequences were bad.

Augustine saw this and made the reverse move, which is not obviously better: he treated the moral usefulness of his own position — that it produces humility — as though it counted in favour of its truth. Both men reached for consequences when the question was about capacity.

The pattern is still standard. Determinism is rejected because it would make punishment unfair. A finding about heredity is rejected because of what people would do with it. A theory of addiction is rejected because it “gives permission”. Each of those may be a good reason to be careful about how something is said. None of them is a reason to think it false.

The general form: answering “is this true?” with “what would happen if people believed it?”

It should be said in Pelagius' defence that the consequence he feared is not imaginary. Within a century Augustine's position had produced people who concluded that effort was pointless, and the church had to convene a council to say that it had not meant that. The argument was bad and the worry was sound, which is a combination that turns up more often than it is admitted.

9.4 — Twenty years

What began as a quarrel about a line in a devotional book became the largest doctrinal conflict of Augustine's life and it outlived him.

The shape of it, briefly, because the timeline at the back has the dates. Rome fell to the Goths in 410 and Pelagius and his sharper associate Caelestius left Italy for Africa. Caelestius stayed and was condemned at Carthage in 411. Pelagius went on to Palestine, where a synod of eastern bishops examined him in 415 and **acquitted him**. The African bishops, unimpressed, condemned him at two councils in 416 and wrote to Rome; the pope agreed, died, and his successor reopened the case and initially found for Pelagius.

What settled it was not a council. On 30 April 418 the western emperor issued a decree banishing Pelagius and Caelestius from Rome. The Council of Carthage, with something over two hundred bishops present, condemned the teaching the following day. Rome then fell into line.

That order of events is worth stating flatly rather than in a footnote. The imperial decree came first. The council came second. Whatever one thinks of the theology, the mechanism by which it was settled was political, and the losing side has a permanent and legitimate grievance about it.

The fight then ran for another twelve years against Julian of Eclanum, an Italian bishop deposed for refusing to sign the condemnation, who was a better philosopher than Pelagius and much harder to dismiss. Augustine was still writing against him when he died in 430, with the book unfinished on the desk.

9.5 — What it did to Augustine

And here is the part that matters most for reading the *Confessions*, and that gets left out of the standard account.

The Augustine of Book Ten is not the Augustine of 428. Twenty years of argument moved him a long way, and it moved him in one direction.

The *Confessions* says that the wanting is given. It does not say who it is given to, or on what basis, or what happens to those who do not get it. By the end of his life Augustine was arguing that the number of those who receive it is fixed, that the choice is not made on the basis of anything foreseen in them, and that unbaptised infants are not saved. Those are positions the book you are reading does not contain.

A position, declared, and it is the last one in this part. Reading the *Confessions* backwards from the anti-Pelagian works is the single most common error made about it, and it is made by admirers and critics alike. The four words in Book Ten are the seed of the later system, and a seed is not the tree. What is in the book is a man saying he cannot produce his own wanting. What came out of the fight is a doctrine about who gets to. The first can be read with sympathy by people who would refuse the second, and a great many have.

THE ARGUMENT — WAS PELAGIUS FAIRLY REPRESENTED?

Almost everything most readers know about Pelagius comes from the man who beat him. That is a situation this series has flagged before — with Faustus in Part Three and the Manichees in Part Two — and it applies here at full strength.

SUBSTANTIALLY, YES

The genuine surviving Pelagian writings — a commentary on the letters of Paul, and a long letter of moral advice to a young Roman noblewoman — do say what Augustine says they say. Human nature retains the power to choose the good; the capacity is itself the gift; Adam harmed us chiefly by example.

And Augustine engaged with the actual texts at length rather than with a caricature. He quotes his opponents extensively, which is why so much of them survives at all. A man building a straw target does not preserve the real one in his own footnotes.

NO, AND THE RECORD IS RIGGED

A synod of his peers examined him in person in 415 and acquitted him. That is not a detail; it means bishops who heard him explain himself did not think he was teaching what the Africans said he was teaching.

The sharpest positions attributed to “Pelagianism” — on infant baptism above all — are Caelestius’, and Caelestius was condemned first and separately. Lumping them produced a doctrine that no single person clearly held.

And his works were suppressed. What survives does so largely because it was copied under other men’s names, his own having become unusable. A defendant whose case is preserved mainly inside the prosecution’s files has not had a fair hearing, whatever the verdict.

THE FIGHT WAS NOT REALLY ABOUT PELAGIUS

A third reading, and the one that explains the temperature. Pelagius was out of the picture by 419. The controversy ran another eleven years, against Julian of Eclanum, and Augustine’s hardest positions were hammered out against him, not against Pelagius.

Julian pressed the obvious objections — that the doctrine makes God the author of a nature it then condemns, that it turns marriage and the body into something shameful, that it cannot be squared with divine justice — and pressed them for a decade.

Reading the whole controversy backwards from 430 therefore distorts what was at stake in 405. The quarrel over four words was about excuses. The war it turned into was about justice.

Where things stand: The dates, the councils and the surviving texts on both sides are not in dispute. What is disputed is whether the condemned position was ever held by the man condemned for it.

What would settle it: More of Pelagius would settle a great deal, and the recovery of his Pauline commentary from manuscripts circulating under other names has already changed the picture once. The possibility that more turns up is not negligible.

Why people care so much: Because the outcome fixed what the western church would say about the human will for a thousand years, and it was fixed with an emperor’s help. Anyone who thinks that does not matter should ask how they would feel about the same procedure producing the other result.

The second and third positions are both largely right, which is an awkward thing to have to say and is nevertheless where the evidence sits. Augustine engaged with the real texts; the

condemnation still landed on a composite figure that was sharper than the man; and the twelve years after Pelagius left the stage did most of the damage in both directions.

REMEMBER THIS

“Give what you command, and command what you will.” Not a request to lower the bar — a request for the legs, plus a blank cheque on what is demanded next.

It is the same claim the “late have I loved you” passage makes with its grammar: **the wanting is given, not generated.**

A bishop read it out in Rome around 405 and **Pelagius could not bear it.** The source for that scene is Augustine, twenty years later, at second hand, in the middle of the fight — solid on what the quarrel was about, weak on the anecdote.

Pelagius’ objection was that the sentence **hands everybody an excuse.** That is an argument about consequences, not about truth — and Augustine made the mirror-image mistake in reply. The fight ran twenty years. Pelagius was **acquitted by a synod in 415** and condemned in 418 — the day after **an imperial decree** banished him. And the Augustine of Book Ten is **not yet** the Augustine of the late anti-Pelagian works: the seed is not the tree.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Every part of this series ends the same way, by separating what is genuinely open from what is settled, and saying why in each case.

10.1 Genuinely unknown

These are open questions, not gaps in this document. Each is followed by the reason it is open, because “we do not know” is only useful when it comes with a cause.

Whether the scene in Rome happened as described. Why: one source, written more than twenty years afterwards, by a man who was not present, about an opponent he had been fighting in print for sixteen years, who does not name the other witness or give a date.

When Book Ten was written relative to the rest. Why: no dated letter or external notice pins the sequence down, and internal evidence about composition order can be read both ways, as Chapter One set out.

What Pelagius actually held on the disputed points. Why: most of his writing survives only as quotations inside the work of men trying to have him condemned. What survives whole survives largely because it was copied under other men’s names.

Whether Augustine’s reports about his own inner states are accurate. Why: he tells you himself that they cannot be checked from outside, and separately that he cannot see the bottom of them from inside. Both admissions are in the book, and together they make the question formally unanswerable.

Where the contents of memory that did not come through the senses came from. Why: he rules out the senses, considers and declines Plato’s answer about a previous existence, and never supplies a third account. The gap is his, not this document’s.

Whether everybody really does hold the happy life in memory. Why: the argument requires it, he cannot establish how it got there, and he says so and moves on.

What is missing from the list of temptations, and why. Why: the scriptural frame explains the shape of the survey but not the choice of frame, and no external evidence bears on it. Chapter Eight gives the argument and declines to close it.

10.2 — Solid

And these are as firm as anything about a fourth-century book gets. Again with reasons, because “solid” is a claim that has to be paid for.

The text itself. Why: the *Confessions* is among the best-attested Latin works of antiquity. Hundreds of manuscripts survive, the oldest from within about a century and a half of composition, and the text is unusually stable across them. When this part quotes a sentence in paraphrase, there is no serious doubt about what stood there.

That Augustine wrote it around 397 to 400 and regarded it as thirteen books in two parts. Why: his own review of his works, written near the end of his life, states both.

That the four words are in Book Ten, three times, and that Augustine believed they started the controversy. Why: the text for the first, and his own statement for the second.

That Pelagius existed, taught in Rome, was acquitted by a synod in Palestine in 415 and condemned in 418. Why: council records, papal correspondence, an imperial rescript, and dated writings from both sides of the dispute. This is one of the better-documented controversies of the period.

That the imperial decree preceded the council. Why: both documents are dated, and the dates are one day apart in that order.

That Augustine’s positions hardened substantially between 412 and his death. Why: a long sequence of dated works, each responding to a named opponent, in which the change can be followed year by year.

10.3 — What survives of the losing side

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

It is worth being specific about the evidence for Pelagius, because the situation is unusual and it is better than the standard account suggests.

Three things survive substantially intact. A commentary on the letters of Paul, which circulated for centuries under other names — including, at one point, Jerome’s — and was identified as his in the twentieth century. A long letter of moral advice written in 413 to a young Roman noblewoman who had decided against marriage. And a handful of shorter letters and fragments.

Everything else comes through his opponents, chiefly Augustine and Jerome, who quote him at length in order to refute him.

What that supports: enough of the real man to say that the position condemned in 418 is recognisably related to what he wrote, and that it is sharper and flatter than what he wrote.

What it cannot support: any confident account of what he would have said under cross-examination on the hardest points. The one time he was cross-examined, in Palestine in 415, he satisfied the bishops examining him — and the record of that hearing comes to us mainly through Augustine, who thought they had been fooled.

This series takes no view on who was right. It notes only that a defendant whose case survives mainly inside the prosecution's files is in a position that ought to make any reader careful, and that Augustine is the one who preserved the files.

10.4 — Where the last two parts go

Book Ten ends by looking for a mediator — something that could stand between a mind that cannot reach the bottom of itself and what it is looking for. He rejects the candidates offered by the Platonists and names his own, and the answer is the one Part Four said the Platonist books could not supply. The circle that opened in Book Seven closes here.

And then the work turns and does something nobody expects. Having spent ten books on a man, it spends its last three on the first chapter of the book of Genesis.

That is not a change of subject either, though it looks like one. The question Book Ten could not answer — what is a self, that it can hold the past and not hold itself — turns into the question of what time is, and the question of what time is turns into the question of what it means for anything to have begun.

Book Eleven is where that happens, and it is the most philosophically influential thing Augustine wrote.

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely open: whether the **scene in Rome** happened; when Book Ten was written; what **Pelagius** actually held; whether Augustine's reports about his own mind are accurate — which he says himself cannot be checked either from outside or from inside.

Also open on his own account: **where the non-sensory contents of memory came from**. He rules out the senses, declines Plato's answer, and never supplies a third.

Solid: **the text**, which is among the best-attested in Latin antiquity; the dating and the thirteen-book shape, from his own late review; and the whole documented chronology of the Pelagian controversy, including that **the emperor moved one day before the council did**.

Of Pelagius there survive a **commentary on Paul** that circulated under other names and a **long letter of advice** from 413. Everything else comes through the men who beat him.

Book Ten ends looking for something that could stand between a mind and what it cannot reach. Then the work turns to **the first chapter of Genesis** — which is not a change of subject, because the question of what a self is has become the question of **what time is**.

Timeline

Book Ten has no narrative, so this timeline covers two things instead: when the book was written, and what the four words in it set off. The public dates are firm and mostly documentary.

Date	Event	Where it appears
354	Augustine born at Thagaste.	Book I
387	Baptised at Milan. Monica dies at Ostia. The life story in the <i>Confessions</i> ends here.	Book IX
391	Ordained priest at Hippo, against his intentions.	outside
c. 395–7	Made bishop of Hippo.	outside
c. 397–400	The <i>Confessions</i> is written and circulated. Book X skips the eleven years above without mentioning them.	Book X
c. 405	In Rome, a bishop quotes “give what you command” in the presence of Pelagius, who objects violently. Reported by Augustine about twenty-three years later.	outside
410	Rome is sacked. Pelagius and Caelestius leave Italy for Africa; Pelagius goes on to Palestine.	outside
411	Caelestius is tried and condemned at Carthage.	outside
412	Augustine’s first works against the Pelagian position.	outside
413	Pelagius writes his long letter of advice to Demetrias — one of the few of his works to survive whole.	outside
Dec 415	A synod of eastern bishops at Diospolis in Palestine examines Pelagius in person and acquits him.	outside
416	Councils at Carthage and Milevis condemn the teaching and write to Rome.	outside
417	Innocent I confirms the condemnation and dies. His successor reopens the case and initially finds for Pelagius.	outside
30 Apr 418	An imperial decree banishes Pelagius and Caelestius from Rome.	outside
1 May 418	The Council of Carthage condemns the teaching in nine canons. Rome falls into line.	outside

Date	Event	Where it appears
418–430	Julian of Eclanum, deposed for refusing to sign, carries the fight. Augustine writes against him for twelve years.	outside
430	Augustine dies at Hippo with the last book against Julian unfinished.	outside
529	The Council of Orange adopts a moderated version of Augustine's position and rejects the harder consequences drawn from it.	outside
—	Part Eight starts here: Book XI — what time is, and why a twentieth-century philosopher took the question seriously.	—

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Terms carried over from earlier parts are repeated so this part stands alone.

Term	What it means
Beata vita	The happy life: a life that has gone well as a whole, not a mood. The standard subject of ancient moral philosophy.
Caelestius	Pelagius' sharper and more combative associate, condemned at Carthage in 411, several years before Pelagius was. Much of what is called Pelagianism is his.
Concupiscentia	Strong desire, craving. Neutral in itself; Augustine almost always uses it for wanting that has got out of order.
Confessio	Confessing sin, confessing faith and confessing praise, all at once. The word the book is named for.
Curiositas	For Augustine a vice: the appetite for experience and finding out, pursued for its own taste, travelling under the name of knowledge.
Diospolis	A town in Palestine, now Lod, where a synod of eastern bishops examined Pelagius in December 415 and acquitted him.
Donatists	A rival African church, in schism since the early fourth century, and Augustine's main opponents while he was writing this book.
Gratia	Grace: a gift given without being earned. For Augustine it supplies not only forgiveness but the wanting itself.
Julian of Eclanum	An Italian bishop deposed in 418 for refusing to sign the condemnation. A formidable philosopher who fought Augustine for twelve years, and the real opponent of the late anti-Pelagian works.
Memoria	Wider than "memory": the whole standing content of the mind — what you recall, what you know, what you can do — whether or not it came from experience. Also one of the five formal parts of rhetoric.
Pelagius	A British or Irish lay ascetic teaching in Rome from the 380s, who held that God does not command the impossible and that the capacity to obey is already given with human nature.

Term	What it means
Plotinus	Third-century philosopher whose account of the soul's ascent shaped Books VII and IX, and supplies part of the frame Book X is built on.
Prevenient grace	Grace that “comes before”: help that arrives ahead of the wanting and produces it, rather than assisting a wanting already there. The point at issue in the whole controversy.
Privation	A missing good in something that ought to have had it. Augustine's account of what evil is, established in Book VII.
Retractations	The book Augustine wrote near the end of his life going back over everything he had published, dating it and correcting it. The main evidence for how the <i>Confessions</i> was regarded by its author.
Temptatio	A test or trial, as metal is assayed — not merely an enticement. “The whole of life is a <i>temptatio</i> ” means life is one continuous examination.

About the Author

This series is read and explained by Lovepreet Singh, and published as part of The Living Archive at misterlove.in.

The Living Archive takes difficult material and rebuilds it so that anyone can follow it, without dropping the hard parts along the way. Its first series was a fourteen-part history of Punjab running to around nine hundred and fifty pages. This is its second.

I read the book, I did the reading around it, and I wrote down what I found. I am not a specialist in late antiquity and I am not going to pretend to be one. Where a question is genuinely contested among people who are, I have said so and given each side its strongest case rather than choosing for you. Where I could not find out, I have written that I could not find out.

The method used here was worked out on the Punjab series and is written up as a portable specification, so that any part of this work can be checked, continued or rebuilt by somebody else. That is the point of an archive that calls itself living.

[Editorial note, to be replaced before publishing: the method requires a one-line statement of the author's own position with regard to religious material, placed where readers will see it. This is the only field in the document still unfilled, and it has now been carried forward seven times. It matters more in this part than in any so far, because Chapter Nine is about a doctrine of grace and readers are entitled to know where the person explaining it stands.]

The Living Archive

The Living Archive is a method for writing hard things simply without making them shallow. It was developed by Lovepreet Singh and tested on a fourteen-part history of Punjab. It runs on three rules.

One. Simplification is not compression. The simple version is usually longer than the difficult one. Words are being spent to buy comprehension.

Two. Two dials, turned in opposite directions. Language as simple as it can be made. Content as deep as the subject actually goes. Turning both down produces something readable and useless.

Three. Every side gets its strongest case, and where nothing settles a question, that gets said. A verdict that honestly reports a deadlock is worth more than a tidy answer that is not true.

A word on sources

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record rather than new primary research, and it is written for readers who want to understand a book, not for specialists who want to check my workings.

What the archive is good at here. The Pelagian controversy is one of the best-documented disputes of late antiquity. Council canons, papal letters, an imperial rescript and dated treatises from both sides all survive, and the chronology in the timeline rests on documents rather than on inference. The composition and transmission of the *Confessions* is also unusually well served, by Augustine’s own late review of his works and by a biography written by a colleague.

What it is bad at here. Everything interior, which is most of the book. Book Ten is a report on one man’s mind by that man, and both the external check and the internal one are ruled out — the first by the nature of the case and the second by Augustine himself, who says he cannot see the bottom of his own motives. Chapter Ten sets out what that does and does not license a reader to conclude.

On the memory chapters. The secondary literature is very large and comes from two directions that rarely speak to each other: historians of late antiquity, and philosophers of mind who read Book X as a text in their own subject. I have tried to keep both in view and to avoid the two standard errors — treating the memory material as devotional decoration, and treating it as a lost draft of cognitive science.

On the Pelagian material. I have tried to give Pelagius his own position rather than the position he was condemned for, and to be explicit about where the evidence for him comes from. Readers who want to go further should know that the recovery of his commentary on Paul in the twentieth century changed the field, and that the standard accounts written before it are correspondingly harder on him.

On translations. All renderings of Augustine in this document are my own plain-English paraphrases, made deliberately loose so that they explain rather than reproduce. They are not quotations from any published translation and should not be cited as such. This applies with particular force to the “late have I loved you” passage in Chapter Six, which exists in dozens of celebrated English versions, none of which is used here. Where the exact wording matters, go to a proper edition.

Corrections are welcome and will be acted on. Later editions will record what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Eight covers Book Eleven, and it is the last hard climb. The book begins as a commentary on the opening sentence of Genesis and turns, about a third of the way in, into a sustained investigation of what time is — the most influential passage Augustine ever wrote, and the one that gets him read by people with no interest in anything else in the work. These are the questions it takes on.

- What was God doing before making the world — and why Augustine refuses the joke answer he says other people give.
- What it means for something to be made out of nothing, and why that is a stranger claim than it sounds.
- Why the past and the future do not exist, on Augustine’s account, and why we can nevertheless measure them.
- “If nobody asks me, I know what time is. If I have to explain it to somebody who asks, I do not know.” The most quoted sentence in the philosophy of time.
- His answer: that time is a stretching-out of the mind, and that past, present and future exist as memory, attention and expectation — which is why Part Seven had to come first.
- And the debt from Part One: Wittgenstein on Augustine. He opens his most famous book by quoting the *Confessions* as an example of a misleading picture — and later returns to Augustine on time, and treats the question as a serious one about how we can know something perfectly well and be unable to say it.

That last one has been outstanding since Part One, Chapter Seven, and it is the final promise in the series. After Part Eight there is one part left, covering Books Twelve and Thirteen, and the last Hidden Assumption of the whole series has to turn on the series itself.

End of Part 7 of 9

The Living Archive · The Confessions, Explained

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART 8 OF 9

The Confessions, Explained

Part Eight — What Is Time?

Book Eleven alone: a question a bishop asked in the year 400 that nobody has closed since — what time is, why the past and the future do not exist, and what we are measuring when we measure them.

READ AND EXPLAINED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

Parts One to Seven covered Books One to Ten. Here is what you need. This part stands on its own, and it needs less of the life story than any part so far.

The man. Born 354 in Roman North Africa, trained as a professional public speaker, professor of rhetoric at Milan by 384. He resigned in 386 after the conversion described in Book Eight, was baptised in 387, buried his mother at Ostia that autumn, went home to Africa, and was made bishop of Hippo in his early forties. He wrote this book around 397 to 400.

The book. Thirteen books. *Confessio* means confessing sin, confessing faith and confessing praise, all at once. It is a prayer, addressed to God throughout, and you are overhearing it.

Where the story ended. Books One to Nine are the life, and they finish at a graveside in 387. Book Ten then skips eleven years and turns the same attention on the man holding the pen: what a person is, what memory contains, what he is still tempted by. Part Seven covered it, and the two things to carry forward from it are these.

One: memory is not a record of the past. Augustine's *memoria* holds recollections, but it also holds mathematics, skills, emotions you are not currently feeling, and the fact that you have forgotten things. It is the whole standing content of a mind. Book Eleven is going to use that, and the argument does not work without it.

Two: he cannot get to the bottom of himself. Book Ten ends with the mind unable to take in the whole of what it is. That is the unfinished business Book Eleven inherits, and it is why the next question is not “what am I” but “what is time”.

A Reminder About the Boxes

Six kinds of box run through this series. **Word Box** explains a hard term the moment it first appears. **In Real Terms** turns something abstract into something you can picture. **How We Actually Know This** names the evidence and says what it cannot show. **The Argument** is for places where experts genuinely disagree, and gives each side its strongest case. **The Hidden Assumption** digs out the premise everybody is quietly taking for granted. **Remember This** closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

There are more In Real Terms boxes in this part than in any other, and that is deliberate. Book Eleven is the most abstract thing in the series and the boxes are where it gets brought back down.

Three Things to Watch For

Book Eleven is short, tightly argued, and does not survive skimming. Three threads.

One. This is where Augustine stops being a theologian people quote and becomes a philosopher people argue with. Book Eleven is on reading lists in departments with no interest in anything else he wrote. The question it asks has not been closed, and the people still working on it are not doing theology.

Two. He answers his own question. The famous line — if nobody asks me I know, if I have to explain it I do not — is quoted everywhere as a charming shrug. It is not a shrug. It is the setup, and the argument runs for another fifteen sections and arrives somewhere. Chapter Seven is where it lands.

Three. The last debt in this series is paid here. Part One promised Wittgenstein on Augustine, treating him as a serious philosopher rather than as an example of error. Chapter Nine pays it, and the first thing it has to do is separate that from the much more famous passage where Wittgenstein does exactly the opposite.

Contents

Chapter One — Why the Last Three Books Are About Genesis

A book about a man ends by reading one sentence of the Bible for a hundred pages · why that is not a change of subject · and who he is arguing with

Chapter Two — “What Was God Doing Before?”

The oldest objection in the file · the joke answer that everybody attributes to Augustine and that Augustine refuses · what he says instead · and the difference between lasting for ever and being outside time

Chapter Three — Made Out of Nothing

Not out of anything, and not out of God · why “he spoke” cannot mean he spoke · and the strangeness that most readers walk straight past

Chapter Four — The Question

“If nobody asks me, I know. If I have to explain it to somebody who asks, I do not know.” · what kind of admission that is · and why it is a beginning and not an ending

Chapter Five — The Past and the Future Do Not Exist

The argument in steps · the hundred years that shrink to nothing · the present with no width · and whether any of it is sound

Chapter Six — Then What Are We Measuring?

We measure time and we do it accurately · none of the three parts of time is available to be measured · the astronomers’ answer and why he rejects it · and a potter’s wheel

Chapter Seven — A Stretching of the Mind

The answer · three presents instead of three times · memory, attention and expectation · and the objection every reader raises within ten seconds

Chapter Eight — The Hymn

A worked example using eight syllables · the same hymn he wept at in Book Nine · what it demonstrates · and what serious readers say it does not

Chapter Nine — What Happened Next

Fifteen hundred years of people picking this up · the philosopher who used Augustine as a bad example and then used him as the model of a good question · and the debt this series has carried since Part One

Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Genuinely unknown · solid · the wordplay no translation carries · and the one part left

Reference

Timeline · glossary · about the author · a word on sources · what comes next

CHAPTER ONE

Why the Last Three Books Are About Genesis

The most famous autobiography in the world ends with three books of biblical commentary. Readers have been calling that a mistake for centuries. It is not one, and this chapter is about why.

1.1 — What the reader is expecting

By the end of Book Ten a reader has been through a childhood, a religion abandoned, a friend's death, a woman sent away, a conversion in a garden, a mother's funeral and a long examination of a man in his forties. Ten books.

Book Eleven opens on the first sentence of the book of Genesis, and the next three books stay there.

That has struck a great many people as a collapse. Editions have been printed that stop at Book Ten. Translations have been published with the last three books cut. Undergraduate courses routinely set Books One to Ten and leave the rest as optional.

And Part Seven set out why that reading is wrong at the level of evidence: Augustine's own late review of his writings divides the work after Book Ten, calls the first ten "about myself" and the last three "about the scriptures", and treats all thirteen as one book. Whatever the last three are, they are not an appendix somebody else attached.

1.2 — Why it is not a change of subject

Here is the chain, and it is worth having in one place, because once you have it the last three books stop looking like a swerve.

Book Ten asked what a person is, and could not finish. The mind, Augustine reported, is too narrow to contain itself. He could not get to the bottom of his own memory, and memory was where he had gone looking for himself.

Now notice what memory is for, in that account. It holds what is no longer there. It is the faculty by which a creature that exists only for an instant at a time nevertheless has a life rather than a series of unconnected flashes. Memory is how a temporal thing holds itself together.

So the unfinished question “what am I” turns into a harder one: what is it to be the kind of thing that is spread out over time at all? Which is the question of what time is.

And the question of what time is, for a man who believes the world began, turns immediately into a question about the beginning — because if time started, the moment it started is the hardest case there is.

Which is the first sentence of Genesis.

That is the whole argument for the unity of the work, in six paragraphs. Book Eleven is not Augustine changing the subject. It is Augustine following the subject to the only place it goes.

IN REAL TERMS

A comparison that is not exact but is close enough to be useful.

Somebody sets out to write about their own life and finds, three hundred pages in, that they cannot say what a person is without saying what memory is. They cannot say what memory is without saying what the past is. And they cannot say what the past is without saying what time is.

At that point they have two options. Stop and publish the memoir, or follow the question and publish something with a strange shape.

Augustine took the second option, and the strange shape is the reason he is still read by people who have no interest in the memoir.

1.3 — Who he is arguing with

One more thing to have in place before starting, because Book Eleven is a polemical book and it does not always say so.

Augustine is arguing with at least three groups at once, and the questions he raises are not questions he invented. They are the objections he had spent years hearing.

The Manichees. His own former religion, covered in Part Two. They read Genesis as crude and mocked the idea of a God who makes things and rests. Their standard needling question about what God was doing beforehand is the one Chapter Two takes up, and Augustine had been on the other end of it for nine years.

Educated pagans. People with a Platonist training, for whom the idea that the world had a start date was philosophically embarrassing. The dignified position was that the world is everlasting. A God who begins something looks like a God who changed his mind.

Fellow Christians who read badly. Augustine spends a great deal of Books Twelve and Thirteen on people who insist their reading of Genesis is the only possible one. He is more patient with the pagans.

So the tone of Book Eleven is not contemplative, whatever its reputation. It is a man clearing objections out of the road, and about a third of the way in he hits one he cannot clear and has to stop and do philosophy instead.

REMEMBER THIS

The *Confessions* ends with three books on **the first sentence of Genesis**, and readers have been treating that as a collapse for centuries. Editions have been printed that stop at Book Ten.

Augustine's own late review of his works treats all thirteen as one book, divided **after** Book Ten, not before it.

The chain that makes it one subject: what a person is, then what memory is, then what the past is, then **what time is**, then what it means for anything to have begun. Book Eleven is the subject followed, not abandoned.

Memory matters here because it is **how a temporal thing holds itself together** — how a creature that exists for an instant at a time has a life rather than a series of flashes.

The book is **polemical**, not contemplative. He is answering the Manichees, educated pagans who found a world with a start date embarrassing, and Christians who read Genesis flatly.

CHAPTER TWO

“What Was God Doing Before?”

The oldest objection in the file, a famous joke Augustine did not make, and an answer that is a great deal better than the joke.

2.1 — The objection

Augustine states it in the form he had heard it, which is a form designed to make the believer look silly. If God made heaven and earth, what was he doing before he made them?

And the objection has a second half that is the real sting. If he was doing nothing, why did he not go on doing nothing? What made this moment the moment? And if something new arose in God — a new decision, a new intention — then he changed, and a thing that changes is not eternal.

That is a good objection. It is still a good objection. Anybody who has ever asked what was there before the beginning of the universe has asked it, and the fact that the modern version has physics attached does not change its shape.

2.2 — The joke he refuses

Then Augustine does something that has been misreported for sixteen hundred years.

He reports that somebody, faced with this question, answered: he was getting hell ready for people who ask questions like that.

And he refuses it.

His reasons are worth having in full, because they are a small essay on how to argue. Making a joke, he says, is not the same as answering. The question is a real one, and a real question deserves either an answer or an admission of ignorance. He would rather say “I do not know” than say something clever, get a laugh, and have the wrong answer applauded — and he adds that a person who dodges a hard question with a witticism does not thereby become right.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The joke is one of the most frequently misattributed lines in western literature. It is standardly quoted as Augustine's, often as evidence that he was intellectually evasive or bad-tempered about doubters.

The only reason anybody knows the line at all is that Augustine wrote it down. He introduces it as something *somebody is said to have answered* — an unnamed somebody, with no date and no context — and he introduces it in order to reject it.

What that supports: that the joke was in circulation by around the year 400, and that Augustine had heard it, disliked it, and thought it worth refusing in print.

What it cannot support: who said it. Augustine does not name them, and there is no earlier source. Anybody who tells you it is Augustine's line has the attribution exactly backwards.

It is a small thing and it is worth dwelling on, because it is the clearest single illustration of what kind of writer this is. Handed a ready-made putdown that would have played well with his own side, he printed it and then explained why he would not use it.

2.3 — The actual answer

What he says instead is four words long in substance and takes some unpacking.

There was no *before*.

Not “there was a before and nothing was in it”. Not “there was an empty stretch and then he acted”. The claim is that time is one of the things that was made, so there is no earlier moment to ask about. God did not make the world *in* time; he made time along with the world.

Augustine puts it in a formula that repays slow reading: there was never a time when there was no time. And its companion: God did not precede time by a stretch of time, but by permanence.

IN REAL TERMS

The shape of the answer is easier to see on a question with no religion in it at all.

Ask: what is north of the North Pole?

That is a grammatical English sentence. Every word in it is doing its ordinary job. It looks exactly like “what is north of Delhi”, which has an answer.

And it has no answer, because “north” is a direction defined on the surface of the globe, and at the pole the coordinate runs out. The question is not hard. It is malformed. Nothing is north of the North Pole, and that is not a mysterious fact about the Arctic.

Augustine is saying “before the beginning” is that kind of question. “Before” is a relation between times. Ask for one earlier than all of them and the coordinate has run out. The question keeps its grammar and loses its subject.

This is the point at which almost every modern reader has the same thought, so it is worth saying plainly: yes, the structure is the same as the standard reply to “what was there before the Big Bang”. That is a real resemblance and it is worth noticing. It is not a case of Augustine anticipating modern cosmology, and this series is not going to claim that he did. What he had was a logical point about the word “before”, available to anyone in any century, and what physics later supplied was a specific reason to think it applies to this universe. The two arrive at similar-looking sentences by completely different routes.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT “BEFORE” IS ALWAYS AVAILABLE

Take any event. There was a moment before it. That is not a belief anybody holds consciously; it is closer to a reflex, and it is correct about every single event you have ever encountered.

The reflex generalises itself into a rule: for anything at all, there was an earlier. And once that rule is in place, the question “what was before the first thing” is not just askable but urgent, and any refusal to answer it looks like a dodge.

What Augustine noticed is that the rule was learned from cases inside time, and that using it on the boundary of time is like using “north” at the pole. The confidence is real and it comes from a very large sample that has one thing in common: every member of it is in the middle.

The general pattern turns up far from cosmology. What is outside the universe. What is west of the westernmost point. What number comes before one, if you are counting the counting numbers.

Each looks like a question because the grammar holds, and each is a coordinate being used past the edge of where it is defined.

None of this establishes that Augustine is right that time began. It establishes something narrower and more useful: that “but what was before?” is not automatically a good question, and that a person who declines to answer it is not automatically hiding.

The general form: extending a relation learned entirely from the interior of a domain out past its boundary.

2.4 — Eternity is not a very long time

The answer above needs one more piece, and it is the piece most people skip.

WORD BOX

Eternity, and why it is not everlastingness: in ordinary English “eternal” means lasting for ever — an infinitely long duration, with a past and a future, just without ends.

That is not what Augustine means, and the difference is the hinge of the chapter. On his account eternity has no succession in it at all. Nothing in it is over and nothing in it is coming. There is no “was” and no “will be”. The whole of it is at once.

His own image: your years do not come and go; your years all stand together at once; your today does not give way to a tomorrow, because it never followed a yesterday.

Why it matters: an everlasting God is inside time, just very old, and the “what was he doing before” question hits him squarely. A God outside time is not being asked the same question. Whether that is a real distinction or a way of stepping out of the argument is the next box.

That last question is not a quibble. Everything in this chapter rests on the distinction being a real one, and it is the point at which the reply to the oldest objection either holds or comes apart.

THE ARGUMENT — IS ETERNITY A REAL DISTINCTION OR AN EVASION?

Everything in Chapter Two rests on the claim that there is a way of being that has no succession in it. If that claim is empty, the answer to the “before” objection is a piece of stagecraft. Serious readers divide.

IT IS A REAL DISTINCTION AND AN OLD ONE

It is not invented for the occasion. Greek philosophy had already separated what is always the same from what changes, and mathematics supplies an ordinary case: the number seven does not persist through time, does not get older, and did not exist more on Tuesday. Nobody finds that mysterious.

And the distinction does real work elsewhere. It is why Augustine can say God did not change his mind about creating: the decision is not an event in a sequence, so there is no earlier state in which it had not been taken. That is a consequence, not a restatement, which is what a genuine distinction produces.

IT IS AN EVASION DRESSED AS A DISTINCTION

Try to say what timeless existence is, positively, without using a temporal word. It cannot be done, and Augustine does not do it. Every description he offers is a denial: no succession, no before, no after, no passing.

A concept defined entirely by what it is not is not obviously a concept. And the mathematical parallel does not help: the number seven is timeless in the sense of being abstract and doing nothing. God, on this account, is timeless and also *acts* — creates, calls, forgives. An agent who does things without any succession in the doing is exactly what nobody has managed to describe.

THE DISTINCTION IS REAL AND THE APPLICATION IS WHERE THE TROUBLE IS

A third position, and the one that has most support among people who work on this now. The contrast between what has succession and what does not is coherent. What is hard is combining it with agency.

The specific difficulty has a name in the modern literature: a timeless being cannot respond, because responding is doing something after something else. Every attempt to solve it either quietly puts God back into time or quietly makes the acting metaphorical.

On this reading Augustine has genuinely dissolved the “what was he doing before” question and has bought it at a price he does not price. The objection he answers in Book Eleven comes back in Books Twelve and Thirteen wearing a different hat.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes what Augustine says or that the distinction has a long philosophical pedigree. What is disputed is whether timeless agency is a coherent notion, and that argument is live in the philosophy of religion today.

What would settle it: Nothing textual will settle it; it is not a question about what Augustine meant but about whether what he meant hangs together. The nearest thing to progress has been a century of increasingly precise formulations, none of which has closed it.

Why people care so much: Because the answer to the oldest objection against a created universe depends on it entirely. If eternity collapses into everlastingness, the “before” question is back and it is unanswered.

A position, declared. The third reading seems to me right, and it is worth being clear about what it concedes and what it does not. It concedes that Augustine’s reply to the “before” question works. The question really is malformed, and that result survives whatever one thinks about God. What it withholds is the further claim that the account of eternity underneath the reply is fully intelligible, and Augustine, to his credit, never claims that it is.

REMEMBER THIS

The objection: **what was God doing before he made the world** — and, if nothing, what made this the moment, and if something new arose in him, how is he unchanging? It is still a good objection.

The famous joke — **preparing hell for people who ask** — is attributed to Augustine everywhere and **he is the one who refuses it**. He reports it as an unnamed somebody’s answer and says he would rather admit ignorance than get a laugh for a wrong answer.

His actual reply: **there was no before**. Time is one of the things that was made. There was never a time when there was no time.

The shape of that reply is the shape of “**what is north of the North Pole?**” — a sentence with perfect grammar and no subject, because a coordinate has been used past its edge.

It all rests on **eternity not meaning everlastingness**. Not an endless duration but a way of being with no succession in it — no was, no will be. That distinction is doing all the work, and whether it survives being combined with a God who *acts* is still argued about.

CHAPTER THREE

Made Out of Nothing

Before the time argument can start, one thing has to be cleared: how anything got made at all. The answer is a phrase everybody knows and almost nobody reads correctly.

3.1 — Not like a carpenter

Augustine begins with the only model of making anybody has, and takes it apart. A human being who makes something works on material that is already there, using a body that is already there, in a place that is already there.

None of those was available. There was no place for the world to be made in, because places are part of the world. There was no material lying about, because material is part of the world. So whatever making means here, it is not the thing the word normally means, and Augustine says so before saying anything else.

This is worth registering because it removes the picture most people are carrying without knowing it: a large figure, in a large empty space, assembling something. Every element of that picture is being denied, including the space and including the assembling.

3.2 — Why “he spoke” cannot mean he spoke

The text he is working from says God spoke and things were made. Augustine takes the objection to that seriously and it is a good one.

A spoken word is a sound. A sound is air in motion. Air is part of the created world. So if the command that made the world was audible, the air it travelled through had to exist first, which means something was made before the making — and then you ask what made that, and the question does not stop.

There is a second problem underneath the first. A spoken sentence has parts that come one after another: the first syllable stops so the second can start. Anything said that way is stretched out in time. So a God who speaks in the ordinary sense is a God inside time, and Chapter Two has just spent itself establishing that he is not.

Augustine’s conclusion is that the speaking is not an event. There is no moment at which the sentence began and no moment at which it finished. Everything is said at once, and said permanently, and the world follows from that rather than from a noise.

Whether that is an explanation or a very careful way of declining to explain is a fair question, and it is the same question Chapter Two left standing about eternity. Augustine does not pretend to have resolved it. What he has done is close off the crude reading, which is what a philosopher is for.

3.3 — What “out of nothing” denies

WORD BOX

Creatio ex nihilo — **making out of nothing**: the doctrine that the world was not made out of anything at all.

The commonest mistake is to hear “nothing” as a material — a special kind of very thin stuff that God worked on. That is exactly backwards. The phrase does not name an ingredient. It denies that there were any.

What it is ruling out is specific, and there were three live alternatives at the time. **One**: that a craftsman-God shaped pre-existing chaotic matter, which is roughly Plato’s picture and was the respectable philosophical option. **Two**: that the world flowed out of God’s own substance, so that things are made of God — the position closest to the Platonists Augustine had read, and to the religion he spent nine years in. **Three**: that the world always existed alongside God and was never made at all.

Why it matters: it is the load-bearing beam under the whole time argument. If matter had always been there, time might have been too, and the question of a beginning never arises.

The second of those three deserves a moment, because it is the one that separates Augustine from the philosophy he admired. If things are made of God, then things are divine, and evil in them is a problem in God. Part Four spent a chapter on how he got out of that, and this is where the escape is nailed down. The world is not a piece of God and it is not a piece of anything else. It is not made of.

IN REAL TERMS

Three kinds of making, to get the shape of the claim.

A carpenter makes a chair. Something existed before — wood — and something exists after — a chair. What changed is the arrangement. If you take the chair apart you get the wood back.

A parent makes a child. This is not arrangement; something new is genuinely there. But it is still made out of something: the material comes from the parents and from what they ate.

What Augustine is describing is neither. Nothing was rearranged and nothing was transmitted.

There is no earlier state of the material, because there is no material with an earlier state.

That is why the doctrine has no everyday analogue and why every analogy for it fails, including the two above. The honest thing to say is that we have no case of it and would not recognise one.

Augustine says so himself, in effect, by refusing every image and describing it only by subtraction.

3.4 — The two meanings of “beginning”

WORD BOX

In principio — “**in the beginning**”: the first two words of the Latin Bible, and Augustine gets two readings out of them at once.

The temporal reading: at the start, at the first moment. This is the one everybody takes and it is the one that raises the “what was before” question.

The other reading: the same Latin word means a source or an origin, not only a first moment — and the opening of John’s gospel uses it of the Word. So Augustine reads the sentence as saying that things were made *in* the source, rather than only *at* the start.

Why it matters: it lets him hold that the world had a first moment without holding that God had a first moment of deciding. This is exegesis rather than argument, and it should be labelled as such — the second reading is not forced by the text, and readers who do not accept the theology have no reason to take it.

One last thing before the argument proper begins, and it is Augustine at his most attractive. He asks how he knows any of it was made at all, and answers that the things themselves say so — because they change. A thing that alters is a thing that was not always as it is, and a thing that was not always as it is is not the kind of thing that explains itself.

That is also the pivot into Book Eleven’s real subject. What is it for a thing to alter? It is for it to be one way and then another. And “and then” is the thing nobody can define.

REMEMBER THIS

Making, here, cannot mean what it normally means. There was **no place to make it in and no material to make it from**, because places and materials are part of what was made.

“He spoke” cannot mean he spoke: a sound needs air, air is part of creation, and a sentence with syllables in order is **stretched out in time**. So the speaking cannot be an event.

Out of nothing does not name an ingredient. It denies that there were any — ruling out a craftsman shaping chaos, the world flowing out of God’s own substance, and a world that always existed.

The second of those is what separates Augustine from the philosophers he admired. If things are made *of* God, evil in them is a problem *in* God.

And the reason he thinks anything was made at all: **things change**. A thing that alters was not always as it is. Which raises the question the rest of the book is about — what is it for one thing to come **after** another?

CHAPTER FOUR

The Question

One sentence, quoted more than anything else Augustine wrote apart from the restless heart. It is almost always used as a graceful surrender. It is the opposite of one.

4.1 — The sentence

What then is time? If nobody asks me, I know. If I want to explain it to somebody who asks, I do not know.

That is the whole of it. In Latin it is eleven words and it has been in continuous circulation for sixteen hundred years.

Almost every use of it treats it as a shrug — a charming admission that the subject is too deep, quoted at the top of an article to excuse whatever follows. Read in place, it is nothing like that. It is the last line of the setup, and the argument starts in the next sentence.

4.2 — What kind of admission it is

Look at what he says immediately afterwards, because it is never quoted alongside and it changes the meaning entirely.

He says he nevertheless knows this much, and says it confidently: if nothing went past, there would be no past; if nothing were coming, there would be no future; and if nothing were here, there would be no present.

So the position is not ignorance. He knows facts about time. He can use the word correctly. He can measure it, compare durations, tell you that one thing took twice as long as another, and be right. What he cannot do is say what the thing is.

That is a precise report of a specific asymmetry, not a confession of defeat, and the asymmetry is the discovery.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A WORD YOU CAN USE IS A WORD YOU CAN DEFINE

The unstated rule behind most people's reaction to Augustine's sentence is that understanding and defining are the same competence. If you really understood it you could say what it is; if you cannot say what it is, you do not really understand it. It is the principle behind every demand to "define your terms" and behind a great deal of bad teaching.

It is false, and it is not marginally false. It fails for almost every word you use most fluently.

Try it. Define *game* so that it takes in solitaire, football, ring-a-ring-o'-roses and the stock market, and excludes war and cooking. Define *chair* so that it admits a beanbag and refuses a low wall. Define *heap*. Define *now*. You will fail at all four inside five minutes, and you have never once misused any of them.

So the relation between using a concept and stating it is much looser than the rule assumes. Fluency is a skill; definition is a different skill; and a great many things are known perfectly in the first sense and not at all in the second.

This is the observation that made a twentieth-century philosopher treat Augustine's sentence as the model of what a philosophical question is, rather than as an example of an ancient getting confused. Chapter Nine is about that, and it is the last debt this series owes you.

The general form: treating the ability to state a thing as the test of understanding it.

4.3 — The shape of what follows

Before the argument, it is worth having the map, because Book Eleven is easy to get lost in and the structure is simple once you see it.

Augustine has two questions and he takes them in the unexpected order. The first is what time is. The second is how it is possible to measure it. Almost everybody assumes the first has to be settled before the second can be attempted.

He does the reverse. He works on the measuring problem, because it is the one with a hard edge — we plainly do measure time, accurately, all day — and lets the answer to the first question fall out of the answer to the second.

So the run of the argument is: the three parts of time all turn out to be unavailable (Chapter Five); we measure time anyway, and the obvious candidates for what we are measuring all fail (Chapter Six); therefore what is being measured must be somewhere else, and there is only one place left (Chapter Seven); and here is a worked example (Chapter Eight).

Four moves. Nothing decorative in any of them.

REMEMBER THIS

“If nobody asks me, I know. If I have to explain it to somebody who asks, I do not know.”

Eleven words in Latin, in continuous circulation for sixteen hundred years, and almost always misused as a shrug.

The very next sentence undoes that reading: he says he knows perfectly well that **without passing there would be no past, without coming no future, without anything here no present**. He is not ignorant. He is articulating a gap.

The gap: he can **use** the concept flawlessly and cannot **state** it. Those turn out to be different skills, and the assumption that they are the same fails for *game*, *chair*, *heap* and *now* as badly as it fails for time.

The structure of what follows is four moves: the three parts of time are **unavailable**; we **measure anyway**; so the thing measured is **somewhere else**; and here is a **worked example**.

He takes the questions in the surprising order — **how do we measure it** first, **what is it** second — and lets the second fall out of the first.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Past and the Future Do Not Exist

A short argument with an alarming conclusion, laid out in steps so you can see exactly where you want to get off.

5.1 — The argument

It runs in five moves and each is short. The trick is to take them one at a time rather than as a mood.

One. Time has three parts, and everybody agrees on the names: past, present, future.

Two. The past is over. It is not going on. Whatever it is, it is not currently the case. The future has not happened. It is not going on either.

Three. So of the three, only the present is actually there.

Four. But consider what it would be for the present to stay. If the present were permanently present and never turned into past, it would not be time at all. It would be exactly what Chapter Two described as eternity: a state with no succession in it.

Five. Therefore the present counts as time only because it is in the act of stopping.

And then the conclusion, which is one of the strangest sentences in Latin. We cannot truly say that time *is*, except on the ground that it is on its way to not being.

The only thing that qualifies the present to be part of time is that it is disappearing. Existence, here, is being underwritten by departure.

5.2 — The present with no width

Then he presses the third move, and this is where the argument gets its teeth.

We say things like “the present century”. Is a hundred years present? Only one of those years is going on; the rest are over or not started. Take that year: only one month of it is present. Take the month: one day. The day: one hour. And an hour is made of minutes that have gone and minutes that have not arrived.

Run that all the way down and the result is a point with no duration at all — because any stretch you can name, however small, has a part already over and a part still coming, and a thing with a part already over is not wholly present.

And a point with no duration cannot be long or short. Which means the only part of time that exists is the only part that cannot be measured.

IN REAL TERMS

You can run the whole argument yourself in about fifteen seconds, and it is worth doing, because the conclusion is much less believable when somebody tells you it than when you find it.

Say the word “yesterday” out loud, slowly.

Now: at the moment you were saying the “ter”, where was the “yes”? Not in your mouth. It had stopped. And where was the “day”? Nowhere yet.

So at no point during that word did the word exist. Only ever a fragment, with the rest of it either finished or pending. And the same is true inside “ter” — by the time you reached the r, the t was over.

Keep going and there is nothing left to stand on. What you have just demonstrated is that a thing you unquestionably did — say a word — was never, at any instant, actually happening in full.

Chapter Eight is Augustine doing exactly this, with eight syllables of a hymn, and getting an answer out of it.

What that exercise disturbs is not a belief anybody would defend. It is a picture, carried around by everybody, of the present as a place with room in it.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE PRESENT IS A DURATION

Ordinary speech treats the present as a place you can be inside. The present moment. Right now. This present hour. Living in the present. Every one of those phrases has the present as a stretch with room in it.

The argument above shows that no such stretch survives inspection. Whatever width you propose, part of it is over. Shrink it until nothing is over, and you have shrunk it to nothing.

What makes this more than a curiosity is how much rides on it. The advice to live in the present is advice to occupy a location that, on this argument, has no floor. That does not make the advice bad — people plainly know what it is pointing at — but it means the thing it points at is not a stretch of time, and nobody who gives the advice can say what it is instead.

It also explains a common and otherwise puzzling experience: that the present never feels like anywhere you have arrived. You cannot catch it standing still, and on Augustine’s account that is not a failure of attention. There is nothing there to catch.

The general form: treating a boundary as though it were a region.

5.3 — Is the argument any good?

It should be said plainly that this is not a settled piece of reasoning admired from a distance. It is a position in a live argument, and philosophers working now are on both sides of it.

WORD BOX

Two modern labels, used here for convenience: both are twentieth-century terms and neither was available to Augustine, so they are being applied from outside.

Presentism: only what is present exists. The past is genuinely gone and the future genuinely not there. Statements about them are made true, if they are true, by how things stand now — by traces, records and tendencies. This is roughly Augustine's position in Book Eleven.

Eternalism, or the block universe: all times exist equally. "Past" and "future" work like "here" and "there" — they say where you are speaking from, not what is real. The year 1815 exists; it is simply not where you are.

Why it matters: the second view has had strong support since relativity, because the theory makes a single universal present hard to define. That is a scientific consideration bearing on a question Augustine reached by pure argument, which is unusual and worth noticing.

With the labels in place, here is the state of the question. Note that these are not schools of interpretation disagreeing about a text. They are positions held by working philosophers about the world.

THE ARGUMENT — DO THE PAST AND THE FUTURE EXIST?

Augustine says no, and builds his whole account on it. This is a live question in metaphysics, and the positions below are held by working philosophers now, not by schools of interpretation.

HE IS RIGHT — ONLY THE PRESENT EXISTS

The argument in section one is hard to break. The past is over: that is not a figure of speech, it is what "over" means. The future has not happened: same. Anyone who says both exist has to explain in what sense a thing that is over is still there.

And the block view has a cost that is easy to underplay. If all times exist equally then nothing ever really happens; there is only a static array, and the sense that events occur is an illusion running in every human being who has ever lived. That is a very large bill to pay in order to tidy up a puzzle.

HE IS WRONG, AND HE HAS SLID BETWEEN TWO SENSES OF "EXIST"

"The past does not exist" is ambiguous, and the argument needs both readings and is entitled to only one. It can mean "the past is not now", which is trivially true and establishes nothing. Or it can mean "the past is not real", which is what the argument requires and is not obvious at all.

Compare place. Nothing in Australia is here. Nobody concludes that Australia does not exist.

"Past" and "future" may be indexical in exactly that way, and the feeling that they are not may be a fact about being a creature stuck at one location in time.

And relativity supplies an independent reason for suspicion: if there is no observer-independent fact about which distant events are happening now, then "only what is present exists" does not pick out a determinate set of things.

THE ARGUMENT IS AIMED AT THE WRONG TARGET

A third position, and the most useful one for reading Book Eleven. Augustine's puzzle is not really about what exists. It is about **passage** — the fact that time seems to move, that the future becomes the present and then the past.

Settle the existence question either way and passage is untouched. The presentist still has to say what it is for the present to change. The block theorist still has to say why creatures inside the block experience a direction and a flow that the block does not have.

On this reading Augustine misdiagnoses his own discovery, and the discovery survives the misdiagnosis. His answer in Chapter Seven — which is about the mind, not about what exists — is arguably the right answer to a question he had not quite finished asking.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes the steps of Augustine's argument or that it commits him to something like presentism. What is disputed is whether the argument is sound and whether it is about the right thing.

What would settle it: Nothing internal to Book Eleven will settle it. Physics has bent the question but not closed it, because the metaphysics of what exists is not straightforwardly read off a theory of measurement. Anybody who tells you relativity has refuted presentism is going faster than the argument.

Why people care so much: Because almost everything anyone says about the past and the future — in law, in grief, in history, in how we treat people for what they once did — assumes an answer, and almost nobody has one.

A position, declared. I find the third reading much the strongest, and it is the one this part will run on. Augustine's argument that the past and future do not exist strikes me as trading on the ambiguity the second position names. What it uncovers on the way — that the present has no width, and that we nevertheless measure things accurately — is a genuine and undamaged problem, and Chapters Six to Eight are the best thing anybody did with it for a very long time.

REMEMBER THIS

The argument in five moves: the past is over, the future has not happened, only the present is there — but a present that **stayed** would be eternity, not time. So the present is time **only because it is stopping**.

The conclusion in his own words: we cannot say time **is**, except on the ground that it is **on its way to not being**.

The present has **no width**. Any stretch you name — a century, a year, an hour, a syllable — has a part already over and a part not yet come. Shrink it until nothing is over and you have shrunk it to nothing.

Which produces the problem the rest of the book solves: the only part of time that exists is **the only part that cannot be measured**.

Whether the argument is sound is **live now**, not settled. The most useful reading is that Augustine is really onto **passage** — why time seems to move — and that the discovery survives even if the metaphysics does not.

CHAPTER SIX

Then What Are We Measuring?

One awkward fact will not go away: we measure time, constantly, and we are right. Any account has to explain that, and after Chapter Five there is nothing left to be doing the measuring on.

6.1 — The fact that has to be saved

People compare durations all day and almost never get it wrong. That took longer than this. Wait two minutes. That syllable is long and this one is short. Nobody finds any of it difficult.

That is not a small thing to have to explain. It is an ordinary human competence, exercised thousands of times a day, reliable enough that entire trades depend on it, and it is being exercised on something that — by the argument of the last chapter — is not there.

Augustine could have used this as a reason to abandon the argument. He does the harder thing and keeps both.

6.2 — Nothing available to measure

Run the three candidates and watch them go.

The past. Over. You cannot lay a ruler along something that has stopped existing.

The future. Not there yet. Same problem in the other direction.

The present. Available, and useless: Chapter Five showed it has no width. A thing with no extension cannot be long or short.

The natural reply is that we measure time as it passes — catching it in the act. But that does not survive a second look. At any instant during the passing, the only part of it that exists is the width-less present. The rest of what you are trying to measure is already over or has not started. Catching it in the act gives you the act and no duration.

6.3 — The astronomers, and the potter's wheel

There is one more candidate and it was the respectable answer of the day: time just is the movement of the sun, the moon and the stars. That is what the heavens are for, and it is where the units come from.

Augustine kills it with three strokes and they are worth having, because the third is the one that generalises.

The potter's wheel. Suppose the heavenly bodies stopped and a potter's wheel kept turning. Would we be unable to say how long a revolution took, or that one was slower than another? Obviously not. So whatever we are measuring is not the sky.

The sun that stood still. He cites the story in which the sun halts so a battle can be finished. Whatever one thinks of the story — and he is not arguing for it here — everybody who tells it understands it the same way: the sun stopped and the day went on. Which means even the people who identify time with the heavens do not really believe it.

And the one that settles it. The motion of a body and the length of that motion are two different things. When you ask how long something moved for, you are already using time to answer. So motion is measured *by* time and cannot be what time is, on pain of the question having no content.

IN REAL TERMS

The modern version of the potter's wheel is a clock, and the point is cleaner with one.

A clock does not contain time. It is a device that does something at a rate we have agreed to treat as steady, so that we can compare other things against it. That is a very useful arrangement and it is not the same as the thing being measured.

Test it: if every clock in the world stopped at once, would the question “how long has it been dark?” stop having an answer? No. It would become hard to answer, which is a completely different situation.

And notice what happens when the standard itself is questioned. Ask whether a clock is running slow and you are comparing it against something else — another clock, the rotation of the earth, an atomic transition. Ask whether *all* of them are running slow together and the question does not obviously mean anything. Augustine is standing exactly at that point, in the year 400, without any of the equipment.

6.4 — The word arrives before the answer

Having cleared the board, Augustine says something tentative and then says something honest.

WORD BOX

Distentio: a stretching-out, a spreading apart. The verb behind it is the one used for stretching a hide over a frame or pulling something taut in two directions.

It carries a second sense in ordinary Latin that Augustine is fully aware of and later exploits: being pulled apart, distracted, scattered. A mind in *distentio* is stretched, and something that is stretched is under strain.

Why it matters: this is the word his answer is built on, and the double meaning is not an accident. Chapter Eight ends with him using it against himself.

What he says is that he can see time is a kind of stretching-out — and then immediately: or do I only seem to see it?

And then, in the middle of the most tightly argued passage he ever wrote, he stops and admits he still does not know what time is.

It is worth noticing that this is the second such admission in fifteen sections, and that both of them come immediately before he makes progress. The pattern is not modesty. It is a man refusing to let a partial result pass as a finished one, which is the only thing that keeps a long argument honest.

6.5 — What is left

So the position at the end of Chapter Six is this. We measure time. The past cannot be measured, the future cannot be measured, the present has nothing to measure, and the movements of bodies are measured by time rather than being it.

Every candidate outside has failed. There is exactly one place left to look, and Augustine has spent Book Ten mapping it.

REMEMBER THIS

The fact that has to be saved: **we measure time all day and we are right**. Any account that cannot explain that is finished before it starts.

None of the three parts of time is available to be measured — the past is over, the future has not come, and the present **has no width**. “We measure it as it passes” fails for the same reason.

The respectable answer of the day was that time **is** the movement of the heavens. Augustine kills it with a **potter’s wheel** that would still turn if the sky stopped, and with the general point that motion is measured **by** time and so cannot be time.

He arrives at the word ***distentio*** — a stretching-out, which also means being pulled apart — before he arrives at the answer, and admits again that he does not yet know what time is.

Everything outside has been eliminated. **One place left to look**, and Book Ten has already mapped it.

CHAPTER SEVEN

A Stretching of the Mind

The answer. It is short, it is strange, and it has been arguing with people for sixteen hundred years — which is a better career than most answers have.

7 **B**Three presents, not three times

Before the answer, a correction to the vocabulary, and it does most of the work.

It is not right, Augustine says, to talk about three times. Two of them do not exist, so they are not there to be talked about. What there are, are three presents.

WORD BOX

The three presents: Augustine replaces past, present and future with a **present of things past**, a **present of things present** and a **present of things future**.

And he says where they are. All three are in the mind, and each has a faculty: **memory** for what is over, **attention** for what is going on, and **expectation** for what is coming.

Why it matters: this is not the claim that the past is imaginary. It is the claim that whenever anybody deals with the past, the thing they are dealing with is present. That is a much smaller claim and much harder to argue with.

And he gives two pieces of evidence for it that are worth having, because they are the sort of thing that can be checked.

A historian telling a true story. What is he working from? Not the events, which are over. He is working from something present — images held in memory, and marks left in the world — and if his story is true it is true because those present things stand in the right relation to what has gone.

Somebody predicting. Nobody sees the future; there is nothing there to see. What a forecaster does is look at present signs — the light in the sky, the state of the crop — together with a memory of how such signs have gone before. The prediction is assembled entirely out of present materials.

7.2 — The answer

Then the sentence the chapter is named for, and it is worth noticing how carefully hedged it is.

It seems to me, he says, that time is nothing other than a stretching-out — and of what, he does not know, though it would be surprising if it were not of the mind itself.

Not “time is”. “It seems to me”, and “I would be surprised if not”. The most influential sentence in the philosophy of time is offered as a strong suspicion.

Now the mechanism, because on its own the sentence is just a slogan.

When something passes, it leaves a mark. Augustine’s word is closer to “impression” than “memory” — the trace a thing presses into you as it goes by. That trace does not go when the thing goes. It stays, and it stays *present*.

And that is what we measure. Not the event, which is unavailable, but the impression it left, which is here. His own formulation is flat and unmistakable: it is in you, my mind, that I measure my times.

7.3 — The objection everybody raises

Which takes about ten seconds to provoke the standard reply: so time is all in your head, then. It is subjective. It is not real.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT IF SOMETHING IS IN THE MIND IT IS NOT REAL

The reply above is almost never argued for. It arrives complete, as though “in the mind” and “not really there” were the same phrase. Say that colour is in the mind, or that pain is, or that money is, and watch how fast somebody hears you saying they do not exist.

The assumption is a leftover from a particular picture: that the real is what is out there independently of anybody, and that minds are a kind of screen the real gets displayed on, so that anything found only on the screen is a display and not a thing.

It does not survive its own examples. Pain is in the mind in every sense anybody means, and a person in pain is not having an illusion. Money is constituted entirely by what people take to be the case and will nevertheless repossess your house. A thing’s being mind-involving is not a demotion. Applied here it does two kinds of damage. It makes Augustine’s answer sound like a dismissal of time, which it is not — he is explaining how measurement is possible, not announcing that clocks are a delusion. And it hides the interesting question, which is not “is time real” but “what exactly is the mind contributing, and to what”.

That question is genuinely open, and it is the next box.

The general form: treating mind-dependence as a synonym for unreality.

There is a serious version of the objection, though, and it is not the one above. It is this: if time is a stretching of the mind, whose mind, and what about the very long stretch of the world before there were any?

Augustine has a reply available — that all times are held in a mind that is not stretched at all — but he does not develop it here, and the question of what exactly he is claiming has been argued about ever since.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THIS A THEORY OF TIME, OR A THEORY OF TIME-PERCEPTION?

Everything downstream depends on the answer. If Augustine is telling us what time is, he is a major figure in metaphysics. If he is telling us how we experience it, he is a major figure in psychology and has left the original question untouched. Serious readers divide three ways.

A THEORY OF TIME

He says time *is* a stretching of the mind. He does not say we perceive it as one. That is the plain sense and it should not be explained away because it is bold.

And it is forced by his own metaphysics. If only the present exists, time cannot be a feature of a sequence of states lying out there, because the sequence is not out there — there is only ever one state. Something has to hold the gone and the coming together for there to be duration at all, and on his account only a mind does that.

A THEORY OF TIME-PERCEPTION

Look at what the argument actually establishes. Every step is about **measuring**: measuring needs both items present, only impressions are present, therefore we measure impressions. That is a valid and interesting conclusion about an activity performed by minds.

It says nothing about what the activity is measuring. A hymn sung to an empty room takes exactly as long as one sung to an audience; nobody has to be there for the syllables to have their lengths. Reading Augustine as claiming otherwise imports a much later philosophical position — Kant's — into a text that does not contain it.

THE DISTINCTION IS NOT AVAILABLE TO HIM

A third position, and the one this series finds most useful. The split between time and time-consciousness is a modern one, sharpened by Kant and made a discipline by phenomenology. It is not a distinction Augustine declines to make. It is one his vocabulary does not have.

His *animus* is not the private inner theatre of the modern debate, as Part Seven set out at length — it is opaque to itself and better known by someone else. A term like that does not sit cleanly on either side of a subjective–objective line.

So asking which of the two he meant is asking a question that has no answer inside his framework. That is not a criticism of him. It is a warning about the equipment we are bringing.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes the words. What is disputed is what philosophical claim they amount to, and whether the categories used to ask that are anachronistic.

What would settle it: Nothing will settle it, because it is a question about how to translate a position from one conceptual vocabulary into another. What has made progress is precision: a century of careful work has at least established what the options are.

Why people care so much: Because Book Eleven is the foundation of a whole tradition — the phenomenology of time-consciousness — and that tradition read Augustine as doing what it does. If the third position is right, an enormous amount of twentieth-century philosophy has been standing on a text that is not quite the text it thinks it is.

A position, declared. The third reading is right about the vocabulary and the first is right about the ambition. Augustine plainly means the strong thing — he says *is*, twice — and he does not have the equipment to see what the strong thing commits him to. Reading him as a careful phenomenologist tidies him up and makes him smaller.

REMEMBER THIS

The correction that does the work: not three times but **three presents** — a present of things past, of things present, and of things future — held by **memory, attention and expectation**.

The evidence is checkable. A historian works from present traces, not from vanished events. A forecaster works from present signs plus a memory of how such signs went before. **Nobody deals with an absent thing directly.**

The answer: **time is a stretching-out of the mind**. Note the hedge — he says “it seems to me” and “I would be surprised if not”. The most influential sentence in the philosophy of time is offered as a strong suspicion.

The mechanism: a passing thing leaves an **impression that stays present**, and that is what gets measured. “It is in you, my mind, that I measure my times.”

The instant objection — **so it is all in your head** — assumes that mind-dependence means unreality, which is false about pain and money and colour. The **serious** objection is different: whose mind, and what about before there were any?

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Hymn

Augustine now does something almost nobody in ancient philosophy does. He stops asserting and runs an experiment, on eight syllables, that the reader can run too.

8.1 — Eight syllables

The line he picks is the opening of a hymn: four short syllables and four long ones, alternating. Anybody hearing it can tell that the long ones take twice as long as the short ones. It is not a difficult judgement and nobody gets it wrong.

And before the argument, one fact about the choice of example that is easy to walk past.

The hymn is Ambrose's, and it is the hymn from Part Six. It is the one that came into Augustine's head as he lay alone on the night of his mother's funeral, after a whole day of refusing to cry, and broke him.

There is no reason he had to use that line. He could have used any line of Latin verse in the world. In the most technical passage he ever wrote, at the exact point where he needs a piece of measurable time to hold up and examine, he reaches for the tune he cried to. He does not mention the connection. This series is not going to build anything on it. It is worth knowing.

8.2 — Why the example is a problem

Now the trouble, which is the whole point of choosing it.

To say that this syllable is twice that one, you have to compare them. To compare two things you need both. And you never have both: by the time the long syllable is sounding, the short one has stopped. They are never in the room together.

Worse, as Chapter Five established, neither of them is ever fully in the room even on its own. While you are halfway through the long syllable, the first half is over.

So the judgement is unmistakably correct and there is nothing available for it to be a judgement about.

IN REAL TERMS

Run it. It takes ten seconds and it is worth more than reading about it.

Pick a song you know completely — not one you like, one you know. Sing the first line in your head.

Now: while you were on the fourth word, where was the first word? Not sounding. Gone. And yet you knew, without any effort, that you were on the fourth word of that line, that there were three behind you and some number in front, and roughly how far in you were.

You were not remembering the first word in the way you remember a holiday. It was doing something more like holding its place. And the words you had not reached were also doing something — you were leaning towards them, which is why you would notice instantly if the next one were wrong.

That leaning-forward and holding-behind, happening at once, with the sounding word in between: that is the thing Augustine says is time. Not a description of how you experience the line. His claim is that the stretch between the two is what the line's duration consists in.

8.3 — The solution, and the recitation

His answer follows directly. What is being compared is not the syllables. It is the impressions they left, and those are both present at once, in him. He measures those.

Then he scales the example up, and this is the best passage in Book Eleven.

Suppose he is about to recite a psalm he knows by heart. Before he starts, his expectation is stretched over the whole of it. Once he has begun, everything he has said drops back into memory, and what remains unsaid is still ahead in expectation. His attention is present, and it is the doorway: through it, what was future keeps becoming past.

And as he goes on, expectation gets shorter and memory gets longer, until expectation is used up entirely and the whole thing has passed over into memory.

Then, in one sentence, he takes it all the way out. What happens in the whole psalm happens in each of its verses and each of its syllables. It happens in a longer performance of which the psalm is one item. It happens in a person's entire life, of which their separate actions are the parts. And it happens in the whole history of the human race, of which individual lives are the parts.

That is a theory of a life, arrived at from four syllables of a hymn, in about two hundred words. Whatever one thinks of it, the reach of it is not in dispute.

8.4 — Does the example prove it?

THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE PSALM EXAMPLE PROVE WHAT AUGUSTINE WANTS?

The worked example is what makes Book Eleven persuasive, and it is also where the sharpest objections land. Nobody disputes that the example is accurate as a description. What it establishes is another matter.

YES — IT DOES THE WHOLE JOB

It explains the thing that had to be explained: how measurement is possible when nothing measurable is available. Both items compared are present; the comparison happens in one place at one moment; the competence is saved.

It also predicts things, which is what a good account does. It predicts that expectation shortens and memory lengthens as a known piece runs — which is exactly what reciting something familiar feels like. It predicts that an unfamiliar piece will feel different, because there is nothing for expectation to stretch over. Both are true and neither is obvious in advance.

NO — IT IS ABOUT COMPARING, NOT ABOUT TIME

Grant every word of the example. It shows that a **comparison** requires both terms to be available at once, and that in the case of durations the only things available are traces. That is a result about comparing.

The syllables still took the lengths they took. Record the hymn and play it to an empty room and it occupies the same stretch. Whatever that stretch is, it is not constituted by anybody's expectation, because there is not any.

So the example is a beautiful account of the **measuring** and leaves the original question exactly where it was. Which, on this reading, is why Augustine had to hedge the answer in Chapter Seven: somewhere in him he knew.

IT PROVES MORE THAN MEASURING AND LESS THAN A THEORY

A third reading, and the one that has aged best. What the example genuinely establishes is that a temporal creature must hold time together in order to have any dealings with it whatever.

A being with no memory and no expectation would not have a shortened past or an approaching future. It would not have duration in any sense available to it — no waiting, no anticipation, no sense of being partway through. It would exist at instants and that is all.

That is a substantial finding about creatures in time, and it is not a theory of time. It is also the finding that the phenomenological tradition took up, which is why Book Eleven had its second career in the twentieth century rather than the eighteenth.

Where things stand: The accuracy of the example as a description is not in dispute. Nor is the conclusion about measuring. What is disputed is whether anything about time itself follows.

What would settle it: A clean settlement would require the distinction the previous argument box says Augustine does not have, which is why these two disputes are really one dispute arriving twice.

Why people care so much: Because the example is the most-taught passage in Augustine outside the garden, and it is routinely presented to students as a proof. It is a demonstration, which is a different thing, and knowing which one you are looking at changes what you should conclude.

A position, declared. The third reading is the one I would defend, with a note attached: the second reading is right that the example does not reach time itself, and wrong to treat that as a failure. Augustine set out to explain how measuring is possible when nothing measurable exists. He did that, completely, and the account has never been improved on. That the answer turned out not to settle the larger question is a fact about the larger question.

8.5 — Pulled apart, and gathered

Book Eleven ends by turning its own vocabulary on the author, and the turn is lost in every translation.

The word for the stretching that constitutes time also means being pulled apart — scattered, distracted, strung out. Augustine puts three words from the same family next to each other. He is *stretched apart* in times, and does not know the order of them; his thoughts are torn to pieces. Against that he sets *reaching out* towards what is ahead, and *concentration* — being pulled together into one instead of scattered into many.

His own phrase for the condition is as blunt as anything in the book: he has burst apart into times.

And that is the same complaint, in the same vocabulary, as the one Part Seven found in Book Ten — a person leaking outward into many things, needing to be gathered back into one. In Book Ten it was a moral problem about wanting too many things. Here it turns out to be the structure of being a creature in time at all.

The scattering is not a fault he has. It is what a temporal thing is.

REMEMBER THIS

The worked example is **eight syllables of a hymn** — and it is the hymn from Part Six, the one that broke him on the night of his mother's funeral. He does not mention the connection.

The problem: to say one syllable is twice another you need both, and **you never have both**. By the time the long one sounds the short one has stopped.

The answer: you are comparing **the impressions they left**, which are both present at once.

Scaled up: reciting something known, **expectation shortens and memory lengthens** while attention is the doorway between them — and the same shape holds for a verse, a life, and the whole history of the human race.

The last move turns the word on himself. **Distentio** means both stretched-out and pulled-apart.

He says he has **burst apart into times** — and what Book Ten treated as a moral failing turns out here to be the structure of being temporal at all.

CHAPTER NINE

What Happened Next

Sixteen hundred years of people picking this argument up. And the last debt this series owes you: a twentieth-century philosopher who used Augustine as a specimen of error, and then, in the same book, as the model of what a good question looks like.

9.1 — The long afterlife

Book Eleven is the part of the Confessions that escaped the Confessions. It has had a continuous career for sixteen centuries, in every period, mostly among people who were not reading the rest of it.

The middle ages took the eternity half. About a century after Augustine, Boethius produced the formula that carried the time-and-eternity distinction into every later discussion: eternity as the complete possession, all at once, of a life without limit. That phrase is Boethius'; the distinction under it is Chapter Two of this part. Aquinas took it up in the thirteenth century and it became standard.

The eighteenth century took the mind half and made it stronger. Kant's claim that time is a form of the mind's own way of taking things in is recognisably the position Augustine reached for and hedged. Kant did not hedge, and he did not credit Augustine, and the resemblance has been noticed ever since.

The twentieth century took the worked example. Husserl's lectures on the consciousness of internal time — delivered in 1905, published in 1928 — open by saying that anybody working on the problem must still study Confessions Book Eleven, and he names the sections. His technical machinery of holding-on and reaching-forward is Augustine's memory and expectation with new names and much more apparatus. Heidegger, who edited those lectures for publication, was working the same ground.

And a philosopher of narrative took the pun. Paul Ricoeur's *Time and Narrative*, in 1983, opens with a long reading of Book Eleven set against Aristotle, and builds a whole theory of storytelling out of the pairing Chapter Eight ended on: being pulled apart in time, and being gathered by reaching towards something.

Worth adding, because it is not a friendly witness: Bertrand Russell, writing a history of philosophy in 1945 and cordially unimpressed by almost everything else in Augustine, called

the theory of time a great advance on anything in Greek philosophy and said it was a better and clearer statement of the subjective view of time than Kant's.

9.2 — The Plotinus question, and why this series is not running it

Somebody will ask, so it should be answered directly rather than left to be discovered.

Plotinus, in an essay on eternity and time written about a hundred and fifty years earlier, also locates time in soul. Augustine had read him or something very like him. The resemblance is real and it is close.

This series has now run the “how much of this is Plotinus” argument twice at full length — in Part Four on the Platonist books, and in Part Six on the conversation at Ostia — and it is not going to run it a third time. Instead, a declared position and the three things that are actually different, which is what a reader needs.

One: the measuring problem is not in Plotinus. The whole engine of Book Eleven — that we measure accurately and there is nothing available to measure — is Augustine's, and so is the worked example.

Two: Plotinus does not think time began. For him the world is everlasting, and it is precisely the position Chapter Two is written against. That is not a detail; it is the disagreement the book exists to prosecute.

Three: the mind in question is different. Plotinus is talking about soul in a cosmic sense. Augustine is talking about a particular man reciting a hymn and losing his place. That shift — from the soul to somebody's mind — is why the twentieth century could use him and largely could not use Plotinus.

9.3 — The debt: Wittgenstein, twice

Part One, Chapter Seven, promised this and it has been outstanding for seven parts. It requires care, because the famous version and the true version are not the same passage.

The famous one. The *Philosophical Investigations* — the most influential philosophy book of the twentieth century — opens, in its very first section, with a quotation from the *Confessions*. Not from Book Eleven: from Book One, where Augustine describes how he learned to talk as a child by watching adults name things and point at them.

Wittgenstein quotes it, calls it a particular picture of what language essentially is, and spends the next stretch of the book taking that picture apart. It is the target he sets up in order to

knock down, and it is why “Wittgenstein on Augustine” almost always means “Wittgenstein using Augustine as a specimen”.

One thing should be said about that even before we get to the debt. Wittgenstein did not go looking for a weak statement of the picture. He went looking for the best one, on the reasonable ground that a picture worth dismantling is one that a first-rate mind found natural. Being chosen as the target was a judgement about the quality of the statement, not about the intelligence of the man.

And the one Part One promised. Later in the same book, in the stretch where Wittgenstein is trying to say what philosophy actually is as against science, he quotes Augustine again — this time the sentence from Book Eleven, in Latin, untranslated.

And what he says about it is this. A remark like that could not be made about a question in natural science. Nobody says: if nobody asks me, I know the specific gravity of hydrogen, but if I have to explain it I do not. Something we know perfectly well until we are asked to give an account of it is not something we need to research. It is something we need to be reminded of — and, he adds, it is for some reason very hard to remind oneself of.

That is not a compliment tucked into a footnote. Augustine’s question is being used as the specimen case of what distinguishes a philosophical problem from an empirical one. In a book with very few positive models in it, a bishop from the fifth century supplies the definition of the subject.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Both passages are in a printed book that anyone can check, which is not something this series has often been able to say.

The first is section 1 of the *Philosophical Investigations*, published in 1953, two years after Wittgenstein’s death. It quotes *Confessions* Book I and uses it as the picture of language the book opens by rejecting.

The second is in the run of sections around 89, in the part of the book concerned with the nature of philosophical investigation. It quotes the “what then is time” sentence and draws the contrast with a question of natural science.

There is a third, less often noticed, in the notes dictated to students in 1933 and 1934 and later published as the *Blue Book*, where Wittgenstein discusses Augustine on time and diagnoses the puzzlement as produced by grammar: a noun makes us hunt for the object it names, and there is no object here.

What that supports: that Wittgenstein returned to Augustine repeatedly over twenty years, and that his treatment of the time question is markedly more respectful than his treatment of the language passage.

What it cannot support: any claim about what Wittgenstein thought of Augustine as a whole. He was not writing about Augustine. He was using him, twice, for two different jobs.

Which leaves a question about how the first passage came to stand for the whole relationship, and it is not really a question about Wittgenstein.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A THINKER IS REFUTED BY BEING USED AS AN EXAMPLE

Almost everybody who knows that Wittgenstein wrote about Augustine knows the first passage and not the second, and the effect is a standing impression that modern philosophy examined Augustine and found him wanting.

Underneath that is an assumption about what it means to be somebody else's example. If a later thinker quotes you in order to take your position apart, you have been assessed and the assessment is negative. Being a specimen is a verdict.

It is not. A specimen is chosen for how clearly it shows the thing, and the clearest statement of a natural mistake is usually made by somebody good. Being the best available example of a picture that misleads people is a form of distinction, and it says nothing whatever about the rest of your work.

The general pattern runs well outside philosophy. A physicist quoted in a textbook as the classic case of a wrong turn; a designer whose failed building is in every syllabus; a study cited for decades as the standard illustration of a methodological trap. In each case the citation is evidence of how well the thing was done, and readers convert it into a verdict on the person.

The correction here is exact and checkable. The same book, by the same author, holds both a dismantling and a model, roughly ninety sections apart. Anyone who has been told that Wittgenstein disposed of Augustine has been told half of one page.

The general form: reading a citation as a judgement on the source rather than on the thing cited.

9.4 — Why the question stayed open

One last thing, and it is the honest summary of the whole part.

Augustine set out to answer two questions and thought they were one. What is time, and what is it for a creature to be in time.

The second turned out to be tractable. His answer to it — memory, attention, expectation; the stretch between what is held and what is awaited; the shortening and lengthening as a known thing runs — has never been substantially improved, only formalised. That is the part the twentieth century took.

The first turned out not to be tractable, and it still is not. Nobody has said what time is. The question has been made much more precise, it has acquired physics and formal logic, and it is open in the same shape Augustine left it in: a thing everybody handles faultlessly and nobody can state.

Which is, exactly and unimprovably, what he said in the first place.

REMEMBER THIS

Book Eleven is **the part of the Confessions that escaped the Confessions**, and it has been in continuous use for sixteen centuries, mostly by people not reading the rest.

Boethius and Aquinas took the **eternity** half; Kant took the **mind** half and dropped the hedge; Husserl and Heidegger took the **worked example**; Ricoeur took the **pun**. Russell, no friend of the theology, called it a great advance on Greek philosophy and better than Kant.

On Plotinus: the resemblance is real. What is Augustine's own is the **measuring problem**, the claim that **time began**, and the shift from cosmic soul to **one man losing his place in a hymn**.

The debt: Wittgenstein quotes Augustine **twice** in the same book. Once at section 1, as the picture of language he is about to dismantle — the famous one. And once around section 89, where **the question about time is the specimen of what a philosophical question is**.

The honest summary: Augustine asked two questions thinking they were one. **What it is to be a creature in time** he answered, and the answer has only ever been formalised, never improved.

What time is is open in exactly the shape he left it.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Every part of this series ends the same way, by separating what is genuinely open from what is settled, and saying why in each case. In this part the open list is unusually long, and that is the subject rather than a failing.

10.1 Genuinely unknown

These are open questions, not gaps in this document. Each is followed by the reason it is open, because “we do not know” is only useful when it comes with a cause.

What time is. Why: sixteen hundred years of continuous work by first-rate people has made the question far more precise and has not closed it. This is not a gap in Augustine and it is not a gap in this document. It is the state of the subject.

Whether Augustine is giving a theory of time or of time-consciousness. Why: the distinction is a modern one and his vocabulary does not contain it, as Chapter Seven sets out. The question may have no answer inside his framework.

Whether the past and the future exist. Why: live in metaphysics now. Relativity has bent the question towards one answer without closing it, because what exists is not straightforwardly read off a theory of measurement.

Whether timeless agency is coherent. Why: Chapter Two. The distinction between eternity and everlastingness is defensible; combining timelessness with a God who acts and responds is where every account so far has run into trouble.

Whether time had a beginning. Why: Augustine argues it did from the doctrine of creation rather than from evidence. Modern cosmology has a good deal to say and does not agree with itself.

How much Augustine took from Plotinus. Why: he names no source here, as he names none in Book Seven. Chapter Nine gives the position and declines to relitigate it.

Whose mind, on his account, holds the time of a world with nobody in it. Why: he assembles the materials for an answer and does not give one. It is the strongest objection to his position and he does not meet it.

Whether Book Eleven was composed with Books One to Ten. Why: the same reason Part Seven gave for Book Ten. Nothing external pins the sequence, and internal evidence about composition order reads both ways.

10.2 — Solid

And these are as firm as anything about a fourth-century book gets. Again with reasons, because “solid” is a claim that has to be paid for.

The text. Why: the *Confessions* is among the best-attested Latin works of antiquity, the oldest manuscript is from within about a century and a half of composition, and Book Eleven in particular was copied and excerpted constantly. There is no serious doubt about what stood there.

That Augustine refuses the joke about preparing hell. Why: it is in the text, introduced as somebody else’s answer, in order to be rejected. The near-universal attribution of it to him is simply wrong.

That he denies time is the motion of the heavens. Why: three separate arguments, in the text, one of which is general and decisive.

That the answer he gives is *distentio animi*, and that he hedges it. Why: the text, twice, with the hedge attached both times.

That Wittgenstein quotes the *Confessions* at section 1 of the *Philosophical Investigations* as a picture to be dismantled, and quotes the time question around section 89 as the model of a philosophical question. Why: both are in a printed book in continuous publication since 1953.

That Husserl and Ricoeur built on Book Eleven and said so. Why: they say so, in print, in the opening pages of the relevant works.

10.3 — What no translation carries

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

A reader of this part is reading paraphrases of a Latin text, and in Book Eleven that costs more than usual. Three things do not survive.

The family of words around *distentio*. Augustine sets stretched-apart, reached-out and concentrated next to each other at the end of the book, and in Latin they are audibly three forms of one word. In English they are three unrelated words and the passage reads as earnest where it is meant to read as tight.

The double sense of the opening phrase of Genesis. The Latin for “in the beginning” also means “in the source”, and Augustine takes both at once, as Chapter Three set out. English forces a choice and every translator makes one.

The famous sentence. “If nobody asks me, I know; if I want to explain it to somebody who asks, I do not know” is eleven Latin words with a symmetry that no English version has managed.

Wittgenstein left it in Latin, which is one way of admitting the problem.

What that supports: that Book Eleven is more compressed and more deliberately made than it can be shown to be in English.

What it cannot support: any suggestion that the argument is different in Latin. It is not. The reasoning survives translation intact; it is the workmanship that does not.

Which is a fair place to record something about this series. Everything rendered here is a loose paraphrase, made deliberately loose so that it explains rather than reproduces, and none of it is a quotation from any published translation. For eight parts that has been a technique. In Book Eleven it is also a loss, and the loss should be stated rather than covered.

10.4 — One part left

Book Eleven ends with Augustine scattered into times and asking to be gathered. What follows is the last two books, and they are the least read part of the work by a wide margin.

They are also, in one specific respect, the most surprising thing Augustine ever wrote, and Part Nine is going to argue that the most modern page in the *Confessions* is in Book Twelve — in the middle of a discussion about unformed matter that almost nobody finishes.

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely open: **what time is** — not a gap in this document but the state of the subject; whether Augustine means a theory of time or of time-consciousness; whether the past and future exist; whether **timeless agency** is coherent; and **whose mind** holds the time of a world with nobody in it.

Solid: the text; that he **refuses** the hell joke universally attributed to him; that he **denies** time is the motion of the heavens, with three arguments; that his answer is **distentio animi**, hedged both times he gives it.

Also solid and checkable in a printed book: **Wittgenstein quotes him twice**, once as a picture to dismantle and once as the model of a philosophical question.

Three things **no translation carries**: the family of words around *distentio*, the double sense of “in the beginning”, and the symmetry of the famous sentence. The argument survives translation. The workmanship does not.

One part left. Books Twelve and Thirteen are the least read of the thirteen — and Part Nine will argue that **the most modern page in the whole work** is in the one almost nobody finishes.

Timeline

Book Eleven has no narrative at all, so this timeline covers the argument rather than the man: when it was written, and what happened to it afterwards. The later dates are all publication dates and are documentary.

Date	Event	Where it appears
354	Augustine born at Thagaste.	Book I
387	Baptised at Milan; his mother dies at Ostia. The life story ends.	Book IX
c. 397–400	The <i>Confessions</i> is written. Book XI: the “before” objection, the question, the potter’s wheel, <i>distentio animi</i> , the hymn.	Book XI
c. 524	Boethius formulates eternity as the complete possession, all at once, of unending life — the phrase that carries the distinction into the middle ages.	outside
c. 1266	Aquinas takes up the eternity–time distinction in the <i>Summa</i> , building on Boethius and Augustine.	outside
1781	Kant: time as a form of the mind’s own way of receiving things — the position Augustine reached for and hedged, stated without the hedge.	outside
1908	McTaggart argues that time is unreal, and the modern analytic argument about past, present and future begins.	outside
1905 / 1928	Husserl’s lectures on internal time-consciousness, delivered and then published, edited by Heidegger. They open by directing readers to Book XI.	outside
1927	Heidegger, <i>Being and Time</i> .	outside
1933–34	Wittgenstein, in notes later published as the <i>Blue Book</i> , diagnoses Augustine’s puzzle about time as produced by grammar.	outside
1945	Russell, no friend of the theology, calls the theory of time a great advance on anything in Greek philosophy.	outside
1953	The <i>Philosophical Investigations</i> is published. Section 1 uses Augustine on language as the picture to be dismantled; around section 89 the question about time is the model of a philosophical question.	outside

Date	Event	Where it appears
1983	Ricoeur, <i>Time and Narrative</i> , opens with Book XI against Aristotle and builds a theory of storytelling on the pun at the end of it.	outside
—	Part Nine starts here: Books XII and XIII — formless matter, and a page about reading that is more modern than anything around it.	—

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Terms carried over from earlier parts are repeated so this part stands alone.

Term	What it means
Block universe	The modern view that all times exist equally, and that “past” and “future” work like “here” and “there” — locations, not grades of reality. Also called eternalism.
Boethius	Roman senator and philosopher, executed about 524, whose formula for eternity — the whole of an unending life possessed at once — carried Augustine’s distinction into the middle ages.
Creatio ex nihilo	Making out of nothing. Not making out of a substance called nothing: a denial that there were any ingredients.
Distentio	A stretching-out, and also a being-pulled-apart. Augustine’s word for what time is, and at the end of Book XI for what is wrong with him.
Eternity	For Augustine, not endless duration but a way of being with no succession in it — no was, no will be, nothing over and nothing coming.
Everlastingness	Lasting for ever: an infinitely long duration, with a past and a future. What “eternal” usually means in English, and not what Augustine means.
Husserl	Founder of phenomenology. His lectures on the consciousness of internal time open by sending readers to Book XI, and his machinery of retention and protention is Augustine’s memory and expectation with more apparatus.
In principio	The opening words of Genesis in Latin: both “at the start” and “in the source”. Augustine takes both senses at once.
Manichees	The religion Augustine belonged to for nine years, teaching two eternal powers of Light and Darkness. Their standard needling question about what God was doing before creation is the one Book XI answers.
Plotinus	Third-century philosopher who also located time in soul, about a hundred and fifty years earlier. What is Augustine’s own is the measuring problem, the beginning of time, and the shift to an individual mind.

Term	What it means
Presentism	The modern view that only what is present exists, and that claims about past and future are made true by how things stand now. Roughly Augustine's position in Book XI.
Privation	A missing good in something that ought to have had it. Augustine's account of what evil is, established in Book VII.
The three presents	Augustine's replacement for past, present and future: a present of things past, of things present, and of things future — held by memory, attention and expectation.
Wittgenstein	Twentieth-century philosopher who quoted the <i>Confessions</i> twice in one book: once as a mistaken picture of language, and once as the model of what a philosophical question is.

About the Author

This series is read and explained by Lovepreet Singh, and published as part of The Living Archive at misterlove.in.

The Living Archive takes difficult material and rebuilds it so that anyone can follow it, without dropping the hard parts along the way. Its first series was a fourteen-part history of Punjab running to around nine hundred and fifty pages. This is its second.

I read the book, I did the reading around it, and I wrote down what I found. I am not a specialist in late antiquity or in the philosophy of time, and I am not going to pretend to be one. Where a question is genuinely contested among people who are, I have said so and given each side its strongest case rather than choosing for you. Where I could not find out, I have written that I could not find out.

The method used here was worked out on the Punjab series and is written up as a portable specification, so that any part of this work can be checked, continued or rebuilt by somebody else. That is the point of an archive that calls itself living.

[Editorial note, to be replaced before publishing: the method requires a one-line statement of the author's own position with regard to religious material, placed where readers will see it. This is the only field in the document still unfilled, and it has now been carried forward eight times. One part remains.]

The Living Archive

The Living Archive is a method for writing hard things simply without making them shallow. It was developed by Lovepreet Singh and tested on a fourteen-part history of Punjab. It runs on three rules.

One. Simplification is not compression. The simple version is usually longer than the difficult one. Words are being spent to buy comprehension.

Two. Two dials, turned in opposite directions. Language as simple as it can be made. Content as deep as the subject actually goes. Turning both down produces something readable and useless.

Three. Every side gets its strongest case, and where nothing settles a question, that gets said. A verdict that honestly reports a deadlock is worth more than a tidy answer that is not true.

A word on sources

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record rather than new primary research, and it is written for readers who want to understand a book, not for specialists who want to check my workings.

What the archive is unusually good at here. Everything in Chapter Nine is verifiable by anybody with a library card. The Wittgenstein passages, the Husserl lectures, the Ricoeur, the Russell — all are printed books in continuous publication, and the claims made about them in this part are claims about what is on the page. No part of this series has been so easy to check.

What it is bad at here. The subject. Nobody knows what time is, and no amount of care in a document like this one changes that. Chapter Ten says so at the top of the open list rather than at the bottom, because it is the first fact about the material and not a residue left over after the explaining.

On the modern philosophy. The literature on the metaphysics of time is very large and very technical, and this part uses two of its labels — presentism and the block universe — as rough handles rather than as positions being defended. Readers who want to go further should know that both terms cover families of views that disagree internally, and that the connection between the metaphysics and the physics is itself contested.

On the afterlife in Chapter Nine. The list is a selection and it is not neutral: it is weighted towards people who said in print that they were reading Augustine, because that can be shown. There is a much larger body of work that is downstream of Book XI without saying so, and no honest way to draw its boundaries.

On translations. All renderings of Augustine in this document are my own plain-English paraphrases, made deliberately loose so that they explain rather than reproduce. They are not quotations from any published translation and should not be cited as such. Chapter Ten records what that costs in this particular book. Where the exact wording matters, go to a proper edition.

Corrections are welcome and will be acted on. Later editions will record what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Nine is the last one. It covers Books Twelve and Thirteen, the least read part of the *Confessions* by a very wide margin, and the argument it will make is that one page in there is more modern than anything else in the work. These are the questions it takes on.

- What is “the heaven of heaven”, and why does Augustine spend a whole book on two things the text barely mentions?
- Can something exist without having any form at all — and what is he doing with a concept he admits he cannot think about clearly?
- **The page that matters.** Can one sentence have several different true meanings at once? Augustine says yes, and then says something harder: that a reader can find a true meaning the author never intended, and be right.
- Which raises the question that page hands to the twentieth century: if that is so, what is left of the author’s intention, and who decides?
- Why is he so patient with people who disagree with him about Genesis, having been so much less patient elsewhere?
- Why does the book end with a rest day, and what is being claimed by ending there rather than anywhere else?
- And the last one, which Part One promised in its own Chapter Ten: the final Hidden Assumption of this series has to be about this series. Nine parts of explaining a book that is a prayer, in the plainest English available, by somebody paraphrasing rather than quoting. What has that been assuming?

That last item is the only debt left. Everything else this series promised has now been paid.

End of Part 8 of 9

The Living Archive · The Confessions, Explained

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART 9 OF 9

The Confessions, Explained

Part Nine — The First Sentence of the Bible

*Books Twelve and Thirteen: the least read part of the work, and
the one page in it that is more modern than anything around it.
The last part of the series.*

READ AND EXPLAINED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

Parts One to Eight covered Books One to Eleven. Here is what you need. This part stands on its own, and it is the last one.

The man. Born 354 in Roman North Africa, trained as a professional public speaker, professor of rhetoric at Milan by 384. Converted in a garden in 386, baptised in 387, buried his mother at Ostia that autumn, went home to Africa, and was made bishop of Hippo in his early forties. He wrote this book around 397 to 400.

The book. Thirteen books. *Confessio* means confessing sin, confessing faith and confessing praise, all at once. It is a prayer, addressed to God throughout, and you are overhearing it.

The shape of it. Books One to Nine are the life, and they end at a graveside in 387. Book Ten skips eleven years and turns the same attention on the man writing: what a person is, what memory holds, what he is still tempted by. Book Eleven follows the question of memory down into the question of time, and answers it — time as a stretching-out of the mind between what is held and what is awaited.

And now the last two. Book Eleven began by opening the Bible at its first sentence, and got sidetracked into philosophy for twenty sections. Books Twelve and Thirteen go back to that sentence and stay with it. Book Twelve takes two verses. Book Thirteen takes the rest of the first chapter and reads all of it as being about something else.

One thing to carry in. Part Eight closed on Augustine describing himself as burst apart into times, and wanting to be gathered. The last two books are what he does about that, and the work ends on a day of rest with no evening in it.

A Reminder About the Boxes

Six kinds of box run through this series. **Word Box** explains a hard term the moment it first appears. **In Real Terms** turns something abstract into something you can picture. **How We Actually Know This** names the evidence and says what it cannot show. **The Argument** is for places where experts genuinely disagree, and gives each side its strongest case. **The Hidden Assumption** digs out the premise everybody is quietly taking for granted. **Remember This** closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

The last Hidden Assumption of the series is at the end of Chapter Ten, and it is about the series. Part One promised that in its own Chapter Ten and it is the only debt still outstanding.

Three Things to Watch For

These are the least read books of the thirteen and there is an honest reason for that. Three threads.

One. Book Twelve is worth it and most of Book Thirteen is not, at least not at length.

This part is going to say so rather than pretend the last hundred pages are uniformly rewarding. Chapter One gives the argument, including the case against the position this part takes.

Two. There is one page in here that does not belong to the fifth century. In the middle of a discussion about unformed matter, Augustine stops and asks what happens when two people read the same sentence and get different answers. What he says next is the reason this part exists. Chapters Four and Five are about it.

Three. The book ends by going back to its first page. Book One said that we are made restless and stay restless until we rest. Book Thirteen ends on a day of rest with no evening. Whether that is a resolution or a stopping is the last real argument in the series, and Chapter Nine gives it a full hearing.

Contents

Chapter One — What Is Left

Two books, two verses and a chapter of Genesis · why almost nobody reads them · whether that is a mistake · and the claim this part is going to make

Chapter Two — The Top and the Bottom of Everything

Heaven and earth as the two ends of what was made · a created thing with no history · and something so close to nothing that he cannot describe it

Chapter Three — Can Anything Exist Without Form?

A man trying to imagine formlessness and failing · why the failure is the answer · and what he is doing with a concept he admits he cannot hold in his head

Chapter Four — The Page That Matters

Two readers, one sentence, two different answers · the question he asks that nobody in his century was asking · and the reply that changed what reading could be

Chapter Five — And If the Author Did Not Mean It?

The harder half of the claim · what stops it collapsing into anything you like · what it actually rests on · and how much of the modern version it will bear

Chapter Six — Why He Is Being So Nice

A man who fought two religions and a heresy to a standstill, being patient · what he is certain of and what he is not · and why those turn out to be separable

Chapter Seven — The Six Days, Read as Something Else

What allegory was for, and what it was not · the reading in outline · whether it is interpretation or invention · and the one line in it that pays back Chapter Four

Chapter Eight — The Trinity in the Shape of a Mind

I am, I know, I want · three things that cannot be separated in one life · what the analogy is for · and the warning he attaches to it

Chapter Nine — The Day With No Evening

My weight is my love · everything going to its place · the seventh day · the last sentence of the book · and whether the ending earns itself

Chapter Ten — An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Genuinely unknown · solid · what nine parts rest on · and the last hidden assumption in this series, which is about this series

Reference

A timeline of the whole book · glossary · about the author · a word on sources · where to go next

CHAPTER ONE

What Is Left

Two books, covering one chapter of Genesis, hardly anybody reads. This chapter is about whether that is a mistake, and it does not give the comfortable answer.

1.1 — What is actually in them

Book Twelve covers two verses. Not two chapters: two verses. In the beginning God made heaven and earth; and the earth was invisible and unformed, and darkness was over the deep. That is the whole text under discussion for about forty pages.

Book Thirteen takes the rest of the first chapter — the six days, the light, the firmament, the waters, the dry land, the lights, the fish and birds, the animals, and the making of human beings — and reads every item of it as standing for something in the life of the church and the soul. Then it comes to the seventh day and stops.

And there is no more autobiography. Nothing about Hippo, nothing about the controversies, no summing up of the life. The most famous account of a life ever written does not end with the life.

1.2 — Why nobody reads them

It is worth being blunt about this, because being polite about it would be the first dishonest thing in nine parts.

Book Thirteen is the least rewarding hundred pages in the *Confessions* for a general reader. The allegorical reading of the six days is done with enormous skill and it is done for readers who already accept a set of conventions about how texts work that almost nobody now holds. Without those conventions the chapter reads as ingenious and arbitrary by turns, and it goes on for a long time.

Book Twelve is a different case, and Chapter Four of this part is about why.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The claim that these books are less read can be checked, roughly, and it holds up.

Abridged editions and course syllabuses routinely stop at Book Nine or Book Ten. Anybody who has been taught the *Confessions* at university has most likely been set the life and possibly the memory material, and left the rest as optional. Commentary is heavily weighted towards the first ten books, and Book Eleven gets more attention on its own than Twelve and Thirteen together.

What that supports: that the last two books have been treated as secondary for a very long time, by people who were not being careless.

What it cannot support: any conclusion about the shape of the original work. Part Seven set out the evidence there, and the position this series holds is that the thirteen books are one argument composed in instalments. Being skipped is a fact about readers, not about the text.

1.3 — Whether the skipping is a mistake

THE ARGUMENT — ARE THE LAST TWO BOOKS WORTH READING?

This series has to answer this before it can spend forty pages on them, and the honest thing is to put the position it is taking alongside the ones it is not.

NO, AND THE ABRIDGERS ARE BEING SENSIBLE

A reader comes to the *Confessions* for one of two things: the life, which is the best thing of its kind ever written, or the philosophy in Books Ten and Eleven, which is on reading lists on its own merits. Neither is here.

What is here is fourth-century biblical exegesis of a kind that requires a set of assumptions about how scripture signifies that the reader almost certainly does not hold. Telling people to push through it because it is by the same author is the sort of advice that produces unfinished books and quiet resentment.

YES, AND THE SKIPPING TELLS YOU WHAT PEOPLE CAME FOR

Every reason for skipping them is a reason about the reader, not the book. They are skipped because they are not a memoir and not analytic philosophy, which is to say because they are not the two things modern readers are equipped to want.

And the skipping has a cost that is invisible from inside it. The work is an argument, and the argument finishes here. Reading nine books and stopping is reading a case and skipping the conclusion, then reporting that the conclusion was not interesting.

BOOK TWELVE YES, MOST OF BOOK THIRTEEN NO

A third position, and it is the one this part takes, so it should be stated as a position rather than assumed.

Book Twelve contains a discussion of what it means for a text to have a meaning that is not tied to its century at all. It is short, it is clear, and it is the origin of a line of thinking that runs to the present. Somebody who reads only that will have got something from the last two books that they could not have got from the first eleven.

Book Thirteen contains the ending, the triad in Chapter Eight of this part, and the sabbath — and, in between, a long stretch that is worth understanding the principle of rather than following item by item. Chapter Seven does the principle and does not do the item by item.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes what is in the last two books or that they are read less. What is disputed is whether the reading habit is a failure of readers or a reasonable response to the material.

What would settle it: Nothing settles a question of this kind, because it is a question about what a book is for. The nearest thing to evidence is that the people who do read Book Twelve carefully tend to keep citing one part of it, which is at least a signal about where the value is concentrated.

Why people care so much: Because the practical effect is that a document like this one has to decide how to spend forty pages, and every such decision is invisible to the reader unless it is announced.

A position, declared, and it is the third one. The rest of this part is built on it: Chapters Two to Six are Book Twelve, and Chapters Seven to Nine are Book Thirteen in a quarter of the space. A reader who takes the second position should know that they are getting less of Book Thirteen here than they would want, and where to go instead is in the closing section.

1.4 — The claim

Here is what this part is going to argue, stated now so it can be weighed as the evidence arrives.

Somewhere in Book Twelve, in the middle of a discussion of unformed matter that almost nobody finishes, Augustine stops and asks a question that nobody in his century was asking. Two people read the same sentence and come away with different meanings. Both meanings are true. What follows?

The answer he gives is not the one his position obliges him to give, it is not the one his temperament elsewhere would predict, and it points at something that took another fifteen hundred years to get a name.

That page is the reason for this part, and everything before Chapter Four is the run-up to it.

REMEMBER THIS

Book Twelve covers two verses. Book Thirteen covers the rest of the first chapter of Genesis, reading every item of it as standing for something else, and then stops. There is **no more life story**.

They are the least read books of the thirteen and the reason is real: most of Book Thirteen is exegesis built on conventions about how texts signify that almost **nobody now holds**.

The position this part takes, declared rather than assumed: **Book Twelve yes, most of Book Thirteen no** — the principle rather than the item-by-item.

What is being skipped, on the other reading, is **the conclusion of an argument** — nine books of case and then a decision to stop before the end.

And the claim this part will make: in the middle of Book Twelve there is a page about **two people reading one sentence differently** that does not belong to the fifth century.

CHAPTER TWO

The Top and the Bottom of Everything

Before the good page, two strange ideas have to be got through, and they are strange in a way that is worth the trouble. Augustine reads the first sentence of Genesis as naming the two extreme ends of what exists.

2.1 — Not sky and ground

The sentence says God made heaven and earth. The obvious reading is that it means the sky and the ground, or everything up there and everything down here. Augustine does not take it that way, and his reason is in the next verse.

Because the next verse says the earth was invisible and unformed — and the ground under your feet is neither. So whatever “earth” means in the first sentence, it is not the ground. It is something that had not been given any shape yet.

And once “earth” is not the ground, “heaven” is not the sky. He reads the pair as naming the two limits of creation: something at the top that is as near to God as a made thing can get, and something at the bottom that is as near to nothing as a made thing can get. Everything else, including the actual sky and the actual ground, is in between and comes later.

2.2 — A made thing with no history

WORD BOX

Caelum caeli — the heaven of heaven: a phrase Augustine takes from a psalm, where it is set against “the earth he has given to human beings”. He reads it as naming a created reality that is not the visible sky.

What he claims about it: it is made, so it is not God and not eternal in the way God is. But it never changes, and because it never changes, nothing in it comes after anything else. It has no succession. It has, in the strict sense of Part Eight, **no time**.

Why it matters: it is the piece that Book Eleven needed and did not have. Part Eight ended with the objection that if time is a stretching of the mind, something has to hold the times of a world with nobody in it. This is Augustine reaching for a created thing that is permanently attentive and never distracted — a mind with no *distentio* in it.

Whether the idea does the work he needs is another matter, and Chapter Ten lists it among the things left open. What is worth noticing here is the move. Faced with a gap in his own

argument, he does not paper over it. He goes back to the text and finds a phrase nobody had made anything of, and builds the missing piece out of it.

That is either an impressive piece of construction or an impressive piece of motivated reading, and honest readers have said both.

2.3 — And the other end

The bottom end is harder and he knows it.

The unformed earth is not empty space. It is not chaos, because chaos has shapes in it, just disorderly ones. It is not a substance with unusual properties. It is supposed to be something with no properties at all except the bare capacity to be given some.

IN REAL TERMS

The distinction he needs, and it is easy to lose, is between **nothing** and **formless something**.

Nothing has no capacity. Nothing cannot become anything, because there is nothing there to become it. Part Eight's Chapter Three was about that: making out of nothing is not making out of a very thin material, it is a denial that there was a material.

Formless matter, by contrast, is supposed to be pure capacity. Not a blank sheet, because a sheet is already something with a size and a colour. Closer to: whatever it is about a thing that lets it be otherwise than it is.

Test it on an ordinary change. A green leaf turns brown. Something persisted through that, or it would be a replacement rather than a change — and whatever persisted was not the green, because the green is what went. Augustine is asking what is left when you subtract every property in that way, all at once, and whether the answer is anything at all.

The honest answer is that he thinks it is barely anything, and says so in the next chapter in a phrase that ought to be better known.

And note why he needs it, because the need is not arbitrary. Things change. For a thing to change rather than be swapped, something has to carry over. Whatever carries over cannot itself be any of the properties that come and go. Push that all the way down and you get either a bare capacity or a contradiction, and Augustine takes the capacity.

REMEMBER THIS

“Heaven and earth” in the first sentence **does not mean sky and ground**, because the next verse says the earth was invisible and unformed, and the ground is neither.

He reads the pair as the **two extreme ends of creation**: something as near to God as a made thing gets, and something as near to nothing as a made thing gets. Everything else, including the actual sky, comes later.

The top end is the **heaven of heaven**: made, and therefore not God, but changeless — so nothing in it comes after anything else and it has **no time**. It is the piece Book Eleven needed and did not have.

The bottom end is **formless matter**: not nothing, and not chaos, but pure capacity — whatever it is about a thing that lets it be otherwise.

He needs it because **things change**, and a change requires that something carried over which was not any of the properties that came and went.

CHAPTER THREE

Can Anything Exist Without Form?

A short chapter about a man trying to imagine something and failing, and about why the failure turns out to be more useful than success would have been.

3.1 — The attempt

Augustine sets out to conceive of the unformed earth, and he reports the attempt honestly, which is the reason the passage survives being about a subject nobody now holds.

His mind, he says, produced monstrous shapes. Hideous things, disordered things, things in a horrible jumble. And then he noticed the problem: every one of them had a shape. A hideous form is a form. He had been asked to think of something with no form and had produced a gallery of bad ones.

So he tried something else. Instead of picturing the thing, he looked at ordinary change — at bodies stopping being what they were and starting to be what they were not — and tried to reason towards whatever it is in a thing that makes that possible.

3.2 — Why the failure is the answer

And here is the finding, which is worth more than the doctrine it was produced for.

The mind cannot picture formlessness, because picturing *is* the giving of form. Ask for an image and you get a shape; the machinery cannot do anything else. So the failure is not a failure of effort or of intelligence. It is what happens when a faculty is asked to do the one thing it is constitutionally unable to do.

Which means the thing, if it is anything, has to be reached by argument rather than by imagining. Augustine gets there and says so, and then makes the further admission that the mind trying to conceive it must either not know, or know a nothing.

IN REAL TERMS

Run the experiment yourself; it works exactly as he describes.

Try to picture **nothing**. Not an empty room — a room is something. Not black — black is a colour. Not empty space — space has dimensions. Every time you clear one out, the mind quietly supplies another, and what you end up looking at is a dark grey field, which is a thing.

Now try to picture **a colour you have never seen**. Most people produce a mixture of colours they have seen and know it is cheating.

Neither failure shows that the concept is empty. You can reason about the absence of everything perfectly well — the sentence “there might have been nothing at all” is not gibberish, and philosophers argue about whether it is true. You just cannot look at it.

That gap between what can be argued about and what can be pictured is the whole content of this chapter, and it is worth carrying out of a book that is otherwise about the fourth century.

3.3 — A nothing-something

Having got there, Augustine does something a lesser writer would have edited out. He reaches for a phrase, finds that Latin will not do it, and prints the attempt anyway.

If it could be said, he writes, he would call it *a nothing something*. Or *an is that is not*.

Both are ungrammatical on purpose. He is not being obscure; he is reporting that the thing he has argued his way to sits exactly where the language runs out, and he would rather leave a broken phrase on the page than a smooth one that misses.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT IF YOU CANNOT PICTURE IT YOU CANNOT THINK IT

The assumption is old and it is still the default. If you cannot visualise it, you do not really understand it; a good explanation is one that produces a picture; anybody who cannot give you an image is probably hiding.

It fails immediately once you look. Nobody can picture a chiliagon and everybody can reason about one, and reason about it differently from a thousand-and-one-sided figure, which no image would distinguish. Nobody can picture the square root of minus one, and engineers use it to build bridges. Nobody can picture four spatial dimensions, and the mathematics is routine.

The picture-making faculty is not the understanding. It is a service attached to the understanding, extremely useful for a certain range of sizes and speeds, and useless outside it — which is why physics stopped being picturable about a century ago and did not stop being true.

It has a practical edge worth keeping. When you find yourself unable to get an image of something and concluding it is nonsense, you have learned something about your visual imagination. Whether you have learned anything about the thing depends entirely on whether an argument was available, and that is a separate check.

And there is a cost the other way, which Part Eight ran into: an explanation that succeeds in producing a picture may have produced the wrong one. Every In Real Terms box in this series is a small bet on that risk being worth taking.

The general form: using the limits of one faculty as the limits of the mind.

3.4 — What happened to the idea

A short note before the good part, because it would be dishonest to present the doctrine as more durable than it was.

The idea of a bare underlying capacity — matter with no properties of its own — was not Augustine's invention and did not stay his. It came out of Greek philosophy, it became a central working part of the physics taught in European universities for the better part of two thousand years, and it was abandoned. Nothing in modern science needs it and nothing in modern science looks like it.

What survived is the question, which is not the same as the answer. Something does carry over through a change, or it is not a change; and whatever carries over cannot be any of the features that came and went. Working out what that means is still going on, and the people doing it are not using the fifth-century vocabulary.

REMEMBER THIS

Asked to conceive of the unformed earth, Augustine **tried to picture it and failed**, producing a gallery of monstrous shapes — and noticed that a hideous form is still a form.

The finding that outlives the doctrine: **picturing is the giving of form**, so the imagination cannot do this, and the failure is structural rather than personal.

He then reaches for a phrase, finds Latin will not carry it, and prints the broken attempt anyway: **a nothing-something, an is that is not**.

The assumption underneath the whole difficulty — **if you cannot picture it you cannot think it** — fails for a thousand-sided figure, for the square root of minus one, and for most of modern physics.

The doctrine of bare underlying matter **did not survive**. The question it was invented to answer did: something carries over through a change, and it is not any of the properties that changed.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Page That Matters

This is the reason for this part. In the middle of an argument about unformed matter, Augustine stops and asks a question nobody around him was asking, and gives an answer that has no business being written in the year four hundred.

4.1 — Two people, one sentence

The situation is ordinary and he describes it flatly. He has been arguing with people about what the first verses of Genesis mean. These are not opponents. They accept the text, they accept his religion, and they disagree with him about what the words say.

And he notices that the disagreement is being conducted as though it were one dispute when it is really two, tangled together.

The first: is the thing being asserted true? Did the world have a beginning; is there such a thing as unformed matter; is the heaven of heaven a made thing? Those are questions about the world, and they are settled, if they are settled, by finding out about the world.

The second: is that what the writer meant? That is a question about a man who has been dead for a very long time and left no commentary on his own sentence.

Separating those two is not obvious and almost nobody does it in an argument. Most disagreements about a text run them together: I think this reading is right, therefore I think the author meant it, and if you say he meant something else you are also saying my reading is wrong.

4.2 — The move

Then the question that opens the whole thing up.

Suppose two readers each find a meaning in the sentence. Suppose the meanings are different. And suppose both of them are true.

Why, Augustine asks, should either reader have to say the other is wrong?

His own answer, and it is put as a question rather than a ruling: it seems to him more religious to say — why not both, if both are true?

And then he escalates it, which is the part that matters. If there is a third true meaning in those words, and a fourth, why not believe the writer saw all of them?

IN REAL TERMS

The move is easier to see on something with no theology in it.

Take a line of poetry that a hundred people have read. Ask them what it means and you get several answers, and some of the answers are not rivals — they are different true things the line is doing at once. It is describing a garden, and it is also about death, and the second does not stop the first.

Now take a clause in a contract. Two lawyers read it and get different answers. Here the answers *are* rivals: the clause has to do one thing when the case comes, and finding out which is exactly the job.

The interesting question is which of those two the first sentence of a sacred text is more like — and every reader of Genesis in the fourth century, including the ones Augustine is arguing with, was treating it like the contract.

He is proposing to treat it like the poem, without giving up the claim that it is true. That combination is the unusual thing, and Chapter Five is about whether it holds together.

4.3 — Why he thinks he is allowed to

The justification he gives is short and it is the load-bearing beam of the whole position, so it should be stated plainly rather than softened.

The text, on his account, has two authors. There is the man who wrote it, working in a language, at a date, with a purpose. And there is God, who is the reason it says what it says, and who knew in advance every true thing anybody would ever find in it.

So a plurality of true meanings is not a defect. It is what you would expect from a sentence composed by something that can see all of them at once, for readers who cannot.

Notice how much that concedes and how much it costs. It concedes that the human writer's intention does not settle the question. It costs a second author, and everything about the position depends on having one. Chapter Five is about what happens if you take the second author away, which is what the twentieth century did.

4.4 — The sentence a bishop should not have written

And then, a few pages later, the formulation that makes the whole passage impossible to file under ordinary exegesis.

He imagines being in Moses' position. Handed the job of writing that sentence, what would he have wanted?

He says: I would have wanted to write in such a way that whatever truth anybody could find about these things, my words would carry it — rather than to set down one true meaning so plainly that it shut the others out.

Read that again. A bishop, in the middle of defending the truth of scripture, says that if he had written the first sentence of the Bible he would have made it capable of bearing many meanings **on purpose**, and that doing so would be better than writing it clearly enough to have only one.

Ambiguity as an achievement rather than a defect. From a man whose entire professional training, and whose entire polemical career, was built on saying exactly what he meant.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A SENTENCE HAS ONE MEANING, WHICH IS WHAT THE WRITER MEANT

This is so deep in how we read that it is hard to see as an assumption at all. Meaning is what the author put there. Interpretation is recovery. Getting it right is getting back to what they had in mind, and the rest is guessing.

It is the operating rule of every English lesson, every legal argument about what a statute means, every row about what somebody meant in a message. And it has an obvious appeal: it makes reading a matter of fact, with a right answer.

It also fails constantly and everybody works around the failure without noticing. A joke that lands better than the teller intended is still funny. A law written for one situation covers a new one nobody foresaw, and the court applies it, and that is not a mistake — it is what laws are for. A song someone wrote about their father is played at funerals by people who never met him.

What Augustine noticed, and what almost nobody in his century noticed, is that these are not failures of a system that normally works. They are evidence that the system was never what we said it was: the meaning of a sentence and the intention of its writer are two different things that usually overlap.

Where this bites hardest is on the reader who wants to be careful. The careful reader's instinct is to look for the one right meaning and be humble about their chance of finding it. Augustine is suggesting something harder: that the humility should go the other way, and be about the assumption that there is only one.

The general form: collapsing what a text says into what its author had in mind.

It is the assumption a reader has been running on for nine parts, including on this document. Every time this series has said what Augustine meant, it has been making the move Book Twelve warns against, and Chapter Ten comes back to that.

REMEMBER THIS

Arguing with people who accept the same text, Augustine separates **two disputes that everybody runs together**: is the thing said true, and is that what the writer meant?

Then the move: if two readers find different meanings and **both are true**, why must either be wrong? And if a third and a fourth, why not believe the writer saw all of them?

His justification is that the text has **two authors** — the man, and the one who knew in advance every true thing anybody would find in it. Everything in the position depends on the second.

And the sentence a bishop should not have written: if he had been given the job, he would have written it to **carry as many true meanings as possible**, rather than clearly enough to have only one. Ambiguity as an achievement.

Underneath is an assumption we still run on — **a sentence means what its author meant** — which fails every time a law covers a case nobody foresaw, and we work around the failure without noticing.

CHAPTER FIVE

And If the Author Did Not Mean It?

The harder half of the claim, what stops it collapsing into anything you like, and how much of the modern version it will actually bear — which is less than the enthusiasts say and more than the sceptics allow.

5.1 — How far he takes it

Augustine does not stop at the reasonable version. Near the end of Book Twelve he puts the claim in its strongest available form, and it is the form that has caused all the trouble since.

He says the writer saw and intended whatever truth we have been able to find in those words — and also whatever truth we have not yet found, and could.

That sentence can be read two ways, and Augustine is not consistent about which he means.

The literal reading: the man Moses actually had all of this in mind. That is a claim about a human being, and it is not credible; no writer holds an unbounded set of meanings in their head, and Augustine elsewhere shows no sign of thinking human authors are superhuman.

The reading that does the work: intention here is not located in the man at all. The text means what its real author meant, and its real author can hold every true meaning at once. Moses is the instrument through which a much larger intention arrives.

The second is what the position needs. The first is what he sometimes writes. Both are on the page and readers have gone in both directions for sixteen hundred years.

5.2 — What stops it being anything you like

The obvious objection arrives immediately: if any true meaning counts, and there is no way to check against the author, then reading is unconstrained and a text can be made to say whatever a clever person wants.

Augustine has two constraints, and they are stricter than they look.

The first is that the reading must be true. Not plausible. Not well-supported by the words. True — about the world, about God, about whatever it is a claim about. A reading that fits the

sentence beautifully and asserts something false is out, and it is out on grounds that have nothing to do with the text.

That is a much heavier restriction than modern versions of the position carry, and it is doing most of the work.

WORD BOX

***Regula fidei* — the rule of faith:** the second constraint. A short summary of the central claims of the religion, held to be settled, against which any proposed reading of scripture is measured.

It is not a text; it is a body of agreed doctrine, and its content was itself argued about, as Part Six's basilica crisis showed at some cost.

Augustine adds a further test in another work: a reading that builds up love of God and of other people is acceptable even if the writer did not mean it — and a reading that does not is to be corrected, however well it fits.

Why it matters: the freedom in Book Twelve is bounded on two sides, by truth and by doctrine. Take both bounds away and you have a modern position. Whether what is left is recognisably Augustine's is the next box.

So the shape of the permission is precise. Not *any* reading. Any *true* reading. And the truth is settled elsewhere, by argument and by the tradition, and then brought to the text.

Which means the page is not a licence. It is a redistribution: it takes authority away from the question “what did the writer mean” and gives it to the question “is this true”, and it leaves the second question exactly as hard as it was.

5.3 — How modern is it, really?

THE ARGUMENT — IS BOOK TWELVE AN ANTICIPATION OF MODERN READING THEORY?

The claim that a reader can find a true meaning the writer did not intend, and be right, is the core of a twentieth-century position. Finding it in the year four hundred is either a remarkable anticipation or a mirage, and good readers have said both.

YES, AND IT IS REMARKABLE

Strip the theology and look at the moves. The author's intention does not settle the meaning. A text can carry more than one true reading at once. A reader can arrive at something the writer did not have in mind and not be making a mistake. The plurality is a property of the text rather than a failure of the readers.

Those are the load-bearing claims of a whole school of criticism, and they are all here, stated plainly, fifteen hundred years early, by somebody who reached them from the opposite direction and did not need them for anything.

NO, AND THE RESEMBLANCE IS AN ACCIDENT OF PHRASING

Every modern version of this rests on there being no privileged meaning. Augustine's rests on there being exactly one — the divine author's — which is infinitely rich and contains all the true readings as parts of itself.

That is not a plurality of meanings. It is a single meaning too large for any reader, which is the opposite claim wearing the same clothes. And the constraint that a reading must be true imports an external standard that modern theory explicitly refuses.

Remove the second author and the position does not become modern. It collapses, into either the writer's intention or arbitrariness, and Augustine would have said so.

THE DURABLE RESULT IS THE SEPARATION, NOT THE PLURALITY

A third reading, and the one that explains why the page kept mattering to people who did not share a word of the theology.

What Augustine actually did was prise apart two questions that had always been treated as one: **what does this text mean** and **what did this person intend**. He then said the second is harder, less recoverable, and less important than everybody assumes.

That separation is portable. It survives losing the divine author, because it is a point about the relation between texts and intentions rather than about who wrote this one. What does not survive is his answer to what fills the gap.

So the honest summary is that he opened a question the twentieth century answered differently, which is a more interesting thing to have done than anticipating an answer.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes what is on the page. What is disputed is whether the resemblance to modern positions is substantive or verbal, and how much of the position survives the removal of its foundation.

What would settle it: Nothing textual settles it, because the question is what a fifth-century claim amounts to in a vocabulary it predates — the same difficulty Part Eight ran into with time and time-consciousness, arriving from a different direction.

Why people care so much: Because this page is regularly cited, in both directions, as evidence that the Christian tradition either did or did not invent modern reading. Both uses are too quick, and the third position explains why the citation keeps happening.

A position, declared. The third reading is right and it is the reason this part exists. The plurality is not modern and the constraints are severe. The separation of meaning from intention is genuinely there, genuinely early, and genuinely portable, and it is the most surprising thing in the last two books by a long way.

5.4 — What the tradition did with it

WORD BOX

The fourfold sense of scripture: the system medieval readers built out of this and related material. Every passage was held to have a literal sense, an allegorical sense about Christ and the church, a moral sense about how to live, and an anagogical sense about the last things.

It became the standard method of biblical reading in the west for the best part of a thousand years, and it is downstream of Augustine, though not only of him.

Why it matters: notice what the formalising did. Augustine's page says *however many true meanings there are*, and refuses to fix the number. The tradition took that and built a system with four slots.

That is worth sitting with, because it is the ordinary fate of an open principle. The thing that made the page remarkable — the refusal to say how many — is exactly the thing that could not be taught, and so it was replaced by something that could.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

How much of the later tradition is traceable to this page specifically is a question worth being careful about.

What can be shown: Augustine set out his rules for reading scripture at length in a separate work, *On Christian Teaching*, which was enormously influential and was still standard reading in the middle ages. The principles in it are the same as the ones here, including the test about building up love. The line of transmission for the general position is not in doubt.

What cannot be shown: that the fourfold scheme came from Book Twelve. It has several sources, including earlier Greek exegesis, and Augustine did not propose four of anything.

And a caution that applies to the whole of Chapter Five. Tracing an idea from the fifth century to the twentieth is a genre with a bad record: the resemblances are easy to find and the connections are hard to establish, and this part has tried to say which is which each time.

What is certain is narrower and enough. In one book, in the middle of a discussion nobody finishes, a man asked what happens when two readers disagree and both are right, and refused to close the question. Whoever picked it up afterwards, and however they picked it up, it was open because he left it open.

REMEMBER THIS

He goes further than the reasonable version: the writer **saw and intended** every truth we have found and every truth we have not yet found. Read literally that is not credible; read as a claim about the **second author**, it is what the position needs.

Two constraints stop it becoming anything you like. The reading must be **true** — not plausible, true — and it must square with the **rule of faith**. Both are heavier than anything modern theory carries.

So the page is **not a licence**. It moves authority from “what did the writer mean” to “is this true”, and leaves the second question as hard as it was.

How modern is it? The plurality is not. The **separation** of what a text means from what its author intended is, and it is portable, because it survives losing the theology that grounded it.

And the fate of the idea: Augustine refused to say how many true meanings there are, and the tradition built a system with **exactly four slots**. The open thing could not be taught, so it was replaced by something that could.

CHAPTER SIX

Why He Is Being So Nice

The man who fought two religions and a heresy to a standstill spends the end of Book Twelve being patient with people who disagree with him. That is worth an explanation, and the explanation is not entirely flattering.

6.1 — The contrast

Set the tone of this section against the rest of the career. Nine years of writing against the Manichees. A long institutional war with the Donatists, in which he eventually came to accept the use of the state against them. Twenty years against Pelagius and Julian, described in Part Seven, ending with an unfinished book on the desk.

And here, arguing about what the first sentence of Genesis means, he is mild. He says that all of them who see truth in these words should love one another. He says he does not want to be the kind of man who insists the writer meant what he says and not what somebody else says. He goes out of his way to state the positions he disagrees with in their best form before declining them.

It is a different writer, and the difference is instructive.

6.2 — What he is sure of, and what he is not

The explanation is in the separation Chapter Four made, applied to himself.

What he is certain of: that the text is true, that God made everything, that the central claims of his religion hold. None of that is up for discussion and he does not pretend otherwise.

What he is not certain of: what the man Moses had in mind by “heaven and earth”; whether the heaven of heaven is what he takes it to be; which of several available readings the writer was working with.

Those are two different registers of confidence and he keeps them apart. He can be immovable about the first and genuinely open about the second, at the same time, without either being a performance.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT BEING SURE YOU ARE RIGHT AND BEING SURE OTHERS ARE WRONG ARE THE SAME CONFIDENCE

They feel like one thing. Certainty about a position seems to carry certainty that competing positions are mistaken, as a matter of logic, and treating an opponent as possibly right feels like a wobble in your own conviction.

They come apart the moment you notice that most disagreements have more than one thing in them. In this case: is the claim true, and is it what the writer meant. Augustine is at maximum confidence on the first and openly uncertain on the second, and the two settings are independent because they are settings on different dials.

Test it somewhere ordinary. You can be completely sure a decision at work was the wrong one and genuinely unsure why the person made it. You can be sure a diagnosis is correct and unsure that the patient will accept it. Certainty about a claim, certainty about somebody's reasons, and certainty about what should follow are three dials, and running them together is what makes arguments unwinnable.

The practical consequence is the interesting one. Somebody who has collapsed the dials into one cannot concede anything without conceding everything, which means they cannot concede anything. Somebody who has kept them apart can give ground on two of three and lose nothing that matters — which looks, from outside, like generosity, and is closer to accuracy.

The general form: treating several independent questions as one question with a single answer.

6.3 — The one thing he will not have

He is not patient about everything, and it is worth being precise about the target, because it is not the one you would expect.

What he attacks is not a reading. It is a posture: the person who says the writer meant what I say and did not mean what you say.

And the charge he brings against it is not that it is bad scholarship. It is that it is a failure of love — that the insister is not defending the text, he is defending himself, and has confused attachment to his own reading with attachment to the truth.

That is an unusual place to put the fault. Most people arguing about texts police conclusions. Augustine is policing a relationship to one's own conclusion, and leaving the conclusions comparatively alone.

IN REAL TERMS

The distinction is easier to see in an argument you have actually had.

Two people disagree about what a message meant. One of them says: I think it meant this, and here is why, and I might be wrong. The other says: it obviously meant this, and anybody who reads it your way is reading it wrong.

The second person may well have the better reading. That is not the point. What has happened is that the reading has become theirs, and now a challenge to it is a challenge to them, and the argument has stopped being about the message.

You can tell which mode you are in with one question: if the other reading turned out to be right as well, would that be interesting or would it be a loss? If the honest answer is “a loss”, the thing being defended is not the text.

6.4 — Or is he just where nothing is at stake?

And now the uncomfortable version, which a series that has spent nine parts being awkward about Augustine should not skip at the end.

Look at where the patience is and where it is not. The Genesis disagreements are with people inside his own church, about a question with no institutional consequences whatever. Nobody is going to be excluded from anything over the heaven of heaven. Nobody is organising a rival hierarchy around unformed matter.

The fights where he was ferocious were fights with something attached: a rival church with rival bishops and rival buildings, a doctrine he thought would empty out the grace he had staked his life on. In those, he used every instrument available, including some — as Part Seven recorded, an imperial decree arriving one day before a council — that do not look like patience from any angle.

So the cynical reading is available and it should be stated: Augustine is generous where nothing turns on it and implacable where something does, which is a description that fits most people and is not a philosophy of interpretation.

A position, declared, and it is a split one. I think the cynical reading is largely correct about the **distribution** of his patience and largely wrong about its **content**. Where the stakes were low he had room to notice something, and what he noticed — the separation in Chapter Four — is true whether or not he would have noticed it under pressure. Ideas do not become false because their author only had the calm to reach them on an easy day. But nobody should present the patience of Book Twelve as the temperament of the man, because eight other parts of this series say otherwise.

REMEMBER THIS

The man who fought the Manichees, the Donatists and Pelagius spends the end of Book Twelve being **mild** with people who read Genesis differently, and stating their positions at their best. The explanation is the separation from Chapter Four applied to himself. He is at **maximum certainty** that the text is true and **openly unsure** what its writer meant, and those are two dials, not one.

What he does attack is not a reading but a **posture** — the person who says the writer meant what I say and not what you say — and he calls it a failure of love rather than of scholarship.

The test for which mode you are in: if the other reading turned out to be right **as well**, would that be interesting, or a loss?

And the uncomfortable version, which stands: the patience is where **nothing was at stake**. That is largely right about the distribution and it does not make what he noticed less true.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Six Days, Read as Something Else

Book Thirteen takes the first chapter of Genesis and reads every item in it as standing for something in the life of the church. This chapter does the principle and declines to do the item-by-item, for reasons Chapter One set out.

7.1 What allegory was for

Before the reading itself, the thing modern readers get wrong about it, which turns the whole book from a curiosity into something intelligible.

WORD BOX

Allegorical reading: taking the items in a text to stand for something other than what they name — the firmament for scripture, the sea for the unbelieving world, and so on.

It is worth distinguishing from **typology**, which is narrower and was less controversial: reading an earlier person or event as prefiguring a later one, so that a sacrifice in Genesis points forward to a sacrifice in the gospels. Typology stays inside history. Allegory does not have to.

And from the **literal** reading, which is what the text says about what it names. Augustine wrote a separate multi-volume commentary on Genesis taken literally, at length, at the same period of his life. He was not choosing between the two.

Why it matters: modern readers assume allegory is a rescue operation, reached for when the plain sense has become embarrassing. That is a nineteenth-century back-projection and it inverts the situation.

That inversion is worth pulling out on its own, because it is the single thing that stops a modern reader from being able to see what Book Thirteen is doing.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT ALLEGORY IS WHAT YOU DO WHEN THE LITERAL READING FAILS

The picture almost everybody carries: a believer meets a passage that is awkward — scientifically wrong, morally ugly, plainly untrue — and escapes by declaring it a symbol. Allegory as damage control.

It gets the history backwards. Augustine reached for allegory most freely in the passages he found least troubling, and he wrote his longest and most careful literal commentary on the same chapter he allegorises here. The plain sense was not in difficulty and he did not need rescuing from it.

What allegory was, in that world, was a claim about density: that a text from that source has more in it than one pass can extract, and that finding the further layers is a devotional exercise rather than an evasive one. Part Five of this series watched him weep at a hymn; this is the same man doing something he found similarly nourishing.

That does not make the readings good. Section Three is about whether they are. It does mean that judging them as failed literal interpretation is judging a thing by a standard nobody involved was using — and it also means the modern reader who says “of course, he had to explain it away” is describing their own century.

The general form: assuming a practice exists to solve the problem that would make you reach for it.

7.2 — The reading, in outline

Here is the shape of it. Not the whole thing — the whole thing is long and repetitive and Chapter One explained why this part is not going to walk through it.

- The light made on the first day is the light by which a mind understands, not the light that comes off the sun, which is not made until day four.
- The firmament dividing the waters is scripture, stretched over us like a skin, with what is above it held out of reach and what is below it available to be read.
- The sea gathered into one place is the world that has not believed; the dry land that appears is the soul that has become thirsty for something else.
- The lights in the firmament are the gifts by which some people teach and others do other things.
- The creatures that swarm out of the sea are the sacraments and the preaching going out over the nations; the birds are the voices carrying over them.
- The living soul brought out of the earth is the faithful person, and the human being made in the image is the one who judges and is judged by nobody, in matters of the spirit.

The technique is consistent and it is not careless. Every assignment is argued for, usually from another part of scripture where the same image appears with the meaning he wants. It is the work of somebody who has the whole text in his head and is cross-referencing at speed.

And it is, to a modern reader, almost entirely unpersuasive, for the reason the next section is about.

7.3 — Interpretation or invention?

The sharpest form of the objection is not the obvious one. It is Augustine’s own principle from Book Twelve, turned round and pointed at him.

Chapter Five established the two constraints on a reading: it must be true, and it must square with the rule of faith. Now notice what those constraints do and do not do. They rule out *false* allegories. They say nothing at all about whether the text is the source of a true one.

So a reading can pass both tests and still be something the reader brought and hung on the words. The constraints block error; they do not establish connection. That gap is exactly where Book Thirteen lives.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE ALLEGORICAL READING INTERPRETATION OR INVENTION?

Book Thirteen is the part of the Confessions modern readers are most likely to dismiss, and the question of whether they are right to is a real one rather than a formality.

INTERPRETATION, INSIDE A SHARED CODE

Allegorical reading in late antiquity was not improvisation. It was a public technique with recognised conventions, a large body of agreed associations drawn from across the scriptures, and a readership that could tell a strong reading from a weak one and said so.

Every assignment Augustine makes is supported from elsewhere in the text, and his contemporaries argued with him about particular ones — which is only possible if there were standards. Our inability to feel the difference between a good and a bad allegory is a fact about us. People said the same about heraldry and about Sanskrit poetics before they learned the code.

INVENTION, AND THE VARIETY PROVES IT

Set Augustine's reading of these verses beside the readings other Fathers produced of the same verses and the assignments do not agree. The same firmament is scripture, or the angelic orders, or the divide between soul and body, depending who is reading.

A technique whose practitioners, working from the same text with the same conventions, produce incompatible results at that rate is not recovering anything. It is generating. The conventions constrain the vocabulary, not the outcome, and anybody sufficiently well read could map these six days onto almost any subject with equal support.

THE QUESTION MISDESCRIBES WHAT HE THOUGHT HE WAS DOING

A third reading, and it deserves a hearing before either verdict. Augustine is not claiming the text contains these meanings as facts encoded in it, to be recovered by a method, with a right answer.

What he is doing is closer to thinking along a structure: using a sequence he regards as given to organise a meditation on the things he takes to be true anyway. That is why the argument from disagreement lands so softly on him — Book Twelve has already said several true readings are fine.

Judged as decoding, Book Thirteen fails. Judged as what it is, the question is whether the exercise is worth doing, which is a question about the reader rather than about the text — and for most modern readers the honest answer is no.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes what Augustine writes or that the Fathers disagreed about particular assignments. What is disputed is what kind of activity this is and therefore what would count as doing it well.

What would settle it: A settlement would need something the period did not produce: an explicit account of what makes an allegorical reading correct as against merely permissible. Augustine gives constraints that rule readings out and never gives a criterion that rules one in.

Why people care so much: Because it is the difference between a hundred pages of interpretation and a hundred pages of ingenious association, and readers have been quietly deciding this for themselves — usually by not finishing the book.

A position, declared. The third reading describes what he is doing and the second is right about what it produces, and both can be held. I do not think Book Thirteen recovers anything from the text. I do think calling it invention implies a charge of bad faith that the evidence does not support, and the useful word is neither: it is a devotional exercise conducted with formidable technique on a structure he did not choose.

7.4 — The line that pays Chapter Four back

One item in the reading is worth having on its own, because it closes a circle and it is the best single reason to open Book Thirteen at all.

When he reaches the blessing on the creatures — increase and multiply — he asks why that blessing is given to some kinds of creature and not others, and gets an answer out of it that has nothing to do with biology.

It is given, he says, to the things that signify. Because one thing understood can be said in many ways, and one thing said can be understood in many ways. The fertility being blessed is the fertility of meaning.

That is the whole argument of Book Twelve, arriving in Book Thirteen as the exegesis of a blessing. The hermeneutic principle and the text have folded into each other: the page that said a sentence can bear many true readings turns up as a reading of a sentence about multiplying.

Whether that is elegant or circular is a fair question. It is certainly deliberate, and it is the strongest evidence in the last two books that they are one piece of work rather than two.

REMEMBER THIS

Modern readers assume allegory is a **rescue operation** for embarrassing texts. Augustine wrote a long **literal** commentary on the same chapter at the same period. He was not choosing between them, and the plain sense was not in trouble.

The reading in outline: light is understanding, the firmament is **scripture stretched over us like a skin**, the sea is the unbelieving world, the sea creatures are preaching going out over the nations.

The sharpest objection is **his own principle turned round**. Book Twelve's constraints rule out false readings. They never establish that the text is the **source** of a true one — and that gap is where Book Thirteen lives.

The honest verdict: it recovers nothing from the text, and calling it invention implies a bad faith the evidence does not support. It is a **devotional exercise with formidable technique**.

And the one line worth the trip: **increase and multiply** is read as a blessing on the **fertility of meaning** — one thing understood can be said many ways. Book Twelve's argument, arriving as exegesis.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Trinity in the Shape of a Mind

Needing to make a three-in-one thinkable, Augustine does what he always does when he needs something: he goes inside and looks. What he finds there started a tradition.

8.1 — Three words

Book Thirteen claims to find the Trinity at the opening of Genesis — God, the beginning or Word, and the Spirit borne over the waters. Which leaves him needing to make the idea of three-that-are-one available to a reader, and no object in the world is going to do it.

So he turns to the reader's own mind and points at something already there.

WORD BOX

Esse, nosse, velle — **being, knowing, willing**: the three things Augustine says are in every mind and cannot be pulled apart.

His own statement of it is compact and it repays being read slowly: I am, and I know, and I will. I am a thing that knows and wills. I know that I am and that I will. I will to be and to know.

The point is not that these are three parts. It is that each one contains the other two and none of them can be taken out. There is one life, one mind, one thing — described three ways that are not interchangeable.

Why it matters: it is the ancestor of the psychological analogies Augustine spent fifteen books on later, in his work on the Trinity, and of a very long tradition of thinking about minds in threes.

8.2 — Try to remove one

IN REAL TERMS

The claim is testable in the only way a claim like this can be. Take the three and try to subtract one.

Being without knowing or willing. Easy — a stone. So the first can exist alone, and that is why the analogy is about minds rather than about everything.

Knowing without being. Try it. Something that knows and is not there. You cannot get the thought to stand up: the knowing has nowhere to happen. Whatever is doing the knowing is, by that fact, something.

Willing without knowing. Wanting requires wanting *something*, which requires some hold on what it is — Part Seven ran this exact argument about the happy life, from the other end. A want with no object at all is not a want; it is a state.

So two of the three subtractions fail and the third fails only downwards. That is what Augustine means by inseparable, and it is a stronger result than it looks: you have just demonstrated that the three descriptions pick out one thing without being synonyms.

And it is worth noticing what has happened methodologically, because it is the same move as Book Ten. Faced with something he cannot point at, he does not construct an argument from the outside. He asks the reader to look at their own mind and report. This series has watched him do that with memory, with time, and now with this, and the consistency is the reason the philosophers kept reading.

8.3 — And the warning attached to it

Then, having produced the analogy, Augustine does the thing that distinguishes him from most people who produce analogies.

He says it is not enough. He tells the reader who can see this to consider how far it falls short of what it is being used to illustrate. He is not offering a proof and he says he is not.

That is worth registering because the later tradition did not always keep the warning attached. The psychological analogy became, in some hands, an argument — a demonstration that the doctrine is what any mind would have guessed. Augustine offers it as a way of making a claim thinkable by somebody who already accepts it, which is a much smaller job and an honest one.

A note for the reader who does not accept any of it. The triad survives being detached from what it was made for. That being, knowing and wanting are three inseparable aspects of one mind rather than three components of it is a claim about minds, and it can be argued with on those terms by somebody with no interest in the Trinity at all. A good deal of subsequent philosophy of mind has done exactly that without noticing where the shape came from.

REMEMBER THIS

Needing to make three-in-one thinkable, Augustine does what he always does: **goes inside and looks**. What he finds is **being, knowing, willing**.

The claim is not that these are three parts but that **each contains the other two**: I know that I am and that I will; I will to be and to know.

You can test it. **Being without the other two** is a stone. **Knowing without being** will not stand up. **Willing without knowing** is not a want. Two subtractions fail outright.

He then attaches a **warning** the later tradition sometimes dropped: the analogy falls far short, and it is not a proof. It makes a claim thinkable for somebody who already holds it.

And the triad **detaches**. That being, knowing and wanting are aspects of one mind rather than components of it is a claim about minds, arguable by anybody, and a lot of later philosophy has argued it without knowing where the shape came from.

CHAPTER NINE

The Day With No Evening

The last pages. A line about weight that is the best sentence in Book Thirteen, a day that does not end, and a final paragraph that stops on a door rather than a conclusion.

9.1 — My weight is my love

Somewhere in the middle of the allegory, Augustine puts down a sentence that has nothing to do with the six days and has outlived all of them. My weight is my love; by it I am carried wherever I am carried.

To get what that is claiming you need the physics behind it, and the physics is not ours.

IN REAL TERMS

For Augustine and everybody he read, weight was not a force pulling things down. There was no such force in the picture at all.

What there was: four elements, each with a natural place in the order of the world, and a tendency in each to get to its place and stay there. Earth belongs at the bottom, so a stone dropped moves towards it. Fire belongs at the top, so a flame goes up. Not because something is pushing, but because that is where the thing **belongs**, and it is restless until it is there.

So “weight” in this sentence means: the tendency in a thing that decides where it ends up. It is not applied from outside. It is what the thing is.

Which makes the claim much sharper than it sounds in modern English. He is not saying love pulls him about, the way we say we are drawn to things. He is saying that a person’s loves **are** the physics of that person. Where somebody ends up is not the result of a struggle between their character and their circumstances. It is what their character was, arriving.

And it has a practical edge that survives losing the physics. You cannot find out where you are going by consulting your intentions. You find out by looking at what you love, which is a harder thing to inspect and a much better predictor.

He follows it with the general rule the image was built for. Things out of their place are restless. Put them in order and they are quiet.

Which is Book One, four hundred pages later, in different words. The first page of the *Confessions* says we are made for something and are restless until we rest in it. Here is the same claim as a piece of physics, with the restlessness explained as a thing being out of position.

9.2 — The day he noticed was missing an evening

The reading of the six days ends and Augustine arrives at the seventh, and he does something small and exact that most readers of that chapter had walked past.

Each of the first six days ends the same way in the text: there was evening, and there was morning, day one, day two, and so on. Six times.

The seventh has no such line. The formula stops.

Augustine takes the omission as the point. The seventh day has no evening because it does not end.

And then he is careful about what is being claimed, in a way the popular version of “God rested” is not. He is not saying God needed a break; he holds that God is holding everything in being continuously and did not stop. The rest is not God recovering. It is ours, and it is described as his because it is his to give.

Then the last move of the book. He asks for it. Not describes it — asks. The whole of the ending is in the second person, which it has been since page one.

9.3 — The last sentence

The *Confessions* ends like this, in substance.

What human being can teach another? What angel an angel? What angel a human being? It must be asked of you, sought in you, knocked for at your door. So, like that, it will be received. So it will be found. So it will be opened.

Three things about that are worth noticing before the argument.

It is borrowed. Ask, seek, knock is a line from the gospels, and every reader he had would have known it. He is ending four hundred pages of his own prose on somebody else’s sentence, redirected.

It is a refusal. The opening question — what human being can teach another? — is a strange thing to put at the end of a book that has been teaching for four hundred pages. He is saying, in the last paragraph, that the thing he has been doing cannot do the thing that matters.

And it does not conclude. There is no summary, no verdict, no gathering-up. The book stops on a door being opened, which is an event that has not happened yet.

9.4 — Does it end well?

THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE WORK END WELL?

The last real argument in this series, and it is about whether four hundred pages arrive anywhere. Readers who admire the book equally have gone in different directions on this.

YES, AND THE BRACKET IS EXACT

Book One, first page: we are made for you, and our heart is restless until it rests in you. Book Thirteen, last pages: everything is restless out of its place and quiet in it, and the last day has no evening because the rest does not end.

That is the same claim, opening and closing, four hundred pages apart, in a work whose middle is entirely about a man who cannot settle. Nothing about it is accidental. A book that begins on restlessness and ends on a rest with no evening has done what it said it would do, and the fact that the ending is quiet rather than loud is a property of the subject.

NO — THE ECHO IS DOING THE WORK A RESOLUTION SHOULD

Look at what has actually been settled by the end. Book Ten: the mind cannot take in the whole of what it is, unresolved. Book Eleven: what time is, unresolved, and admitted twice. Book Twelve: a deliberate refusal to close the question of what the text means. Book Thirteen: an allegory that establishes nothing and an ending that asks rather than states.

A verbal echo of the first page is not a resolution of any of that. It is a cadence. The book stops in the right key and it does not arrive, and calling the stop a rest is a compliment paid by readers who wanted the shape to work.

IT IS THE ONLY ENDING THE FORM ALLOWS

A third position, and it dissolves rather more of the disagreement than it looks like it will. The *Confessions* is a prayer. It has been addressed to the second person on every page since the first line, and this series has said so nine times because it keeps mattering.

Prayers do not conclude. A treatise concludes; an argument concludes; a memoir concludes. A prayer stops when the person praying stops, and the thing it was about is not finished at that point and is not supposed to be.

So the second position is right that nothing is resolved and wrong to call that a failure of the ending. It is a failure of the ending only if the book was a treatise, and every page of it has been telling you it was not.

Where things stand: Nobody disputes the bracket between the first page and the last, or that the intervening questions are left open. What is disputed is whether an unresolved ending is a defect in this particular kind of book.

What would settle it: Nothing settles it, because it is a judgement about form. What would help is agreement about what kind of thing the *Confessions* is, and after sixteen hundred years there is not much.

Why people care so much: Because it decides what a reader should do with the last thirty pages: read them as the payoff, skip them as a falling-off, or read them as the place where the book admits what it could never do.

A position, declared, and it is the last one in the series. The third reading is right about the form and the first is right about the bracket, and together they are enough. What I would resist is the idea that the ending is weak. A book that spends four hundred pages demonstrating how much one man can find out by looking, and then ends by saying that no human being can teach another the thing that matters, is not trailing off. It is making a claim, at the last possible moment, about everything that came before it.

REMEMBER THIS

My weight is my love. In the physics he had, weight is not a force pulling down but the tendency in a thing that decides where it belongs. So a person's loves **are** their physics, and where they end up is their character arriving.

Things out of place are restless; in place, quiet. Which is **Book One in different words**, four hundred pages later.

The seventh day **has no evening** — the formula that closes the other six simply stops — and Augustine takes the omission as the point. The rest does not end, and it is not God recovering; it is ours.

The last sentence is **borrowed** (ask, seek, knock), it is a **refusal** (what human being can teach another?), and it **does not conclude**. The book stops on a door being opened.

Does it end well? Nothing has been resolved — and a **prayer does not conclude**. It stops when the person stops, and the thing it was about is not finished.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

Every part of this series has ended the same way. This one ends that way twice: once about these two books, and once about the nine parts.

10.1 Genuinely unknown

These are open questions, not gaps in this document. Each is followed by the reason it is open, because “we do not know” is only useful when it comes with a cause.

What the heaven of heaven is, precisely. Why: Augustine describes it almost entirely by negation — made, but changeless, and therefore without time — and it does very little work anywhere else in his writings. It is a piece built to fill a specific hole and it is hard to say what else is true of it.

How the literal and allegorical readings of Genesis are supposed to sit together. Why: he produced both, at length, in the same period of his life, and never set out the relation between them. Whether the allegory is a second layer on a true literal reading, or an alternative for a different kind of reader, or something else, is not stated.

Whether the medieval fourfold sense descends from Book Twelve. Why: Chapter Five. The general position is traceable through *On Christian Teaching*; the specific scheme has other sources and Augustine did not propose four of anything.

Whether the ending is a resolution. Why: Chapter Nine. It is a judgement about literary form, and there is no agreement about what kind of thing the work is.

Why the book stops where it does. Why: no external evidence. There is no reason internal to the argument why it could not have stopped after Book Twelve or run to a fourteenth book, and nothing survives that says why it did not.

Whether the last two books were composed with the rest. Why: the same reason Part Seven gave for Book Ten, and the standing position of this series is the one Part Seven set: unified in argument, composed in instalments, and those are two separate claims.

10.2 — Solid

And these are as firm as anything about a fourth-century book gets, with reasons, because “solid” is a claim that has to be paid for.

The text. Why: see the next section. This is the one thing in nine parts that is not in any real doubt.

That Book Twelve contains the passage on multiple true meanings, in the form Chapters Four and Five describe. Why: the text, at length, in several formulations, including the one about how he would have written it himself.

That Augustine wrote a long literal commentary on Genesis in the same period. Why: it survives, it is dated, and he refers to it.

That the work ends on ask, seek and knock, without a conclusion. Why: the text.

That Augustine regarded the thirteen books as one work in two parts, divided after Book Ten. Why: his own review of his writings near the end of his life, as Part Seven set out.

10.3 — What nine parts rest on

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

At the end of a series it is worth saying plainly what the whole thing stands on.

The text is secure. The *Confessions* is among the best-attested Latin works of antiquity. Hundreds of manuscripts survive; the oldest is from within about a century and a half of composition; the text is unusually stable across them and there is no serious dispute about what Augustine wrote. Nine parts of paraphrase rest on that, and it holds.

The external checks are thin and unevenly distributed. Two stretches can be verified from outside: the Cassiciacum months, because four books he wrote at the time survive, and the Milan basilica crisis, because Ambrose’s own letters do. One physical object corroborates one person: a fragment of Monica’s epitaph, found in 1945. Beyond that, almost everything in Books One to Ten is one witness writing about eleven years later with a case to make.

The philosophy needs no external check and gets none. Books Ten to Thirteen are arguments. They stand or fall on whether they work, and this series has tried to say, each time, whether they do.

What that supports: confident statements about what the book says.

What it cannot support: confident statements about what happened, except in the two stretches named. Every part of this series has tried to keep those two kinds of claim visibly apart, and Chapter Ten of each part exists to catch the places where it failed.

And one more thing, which is a fact about this document rather than about Augustine. The method behind this series requires the author to state, in one line and where readers will see it, his own position with regard to religious material. That field has been carried forward, marked as unfilled, in all nine parts. It is still unfilled on the About the Author page of this

one. It is the only requirement of the specification that the series has not met, and rather than quietly dropping it at the end, it is recorded here as the last item on the honest list.

10.4 — And one about this series

Part One promised, in its own Chapter Ten, that the last Hidden Assumption of the series would be about the series. It ran an early version there — the worry that a book which is a prayer might not survive being explained in plain English by somebody who paraphrases rather than quotes.

That was the right worry and it was the smaller one.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT GIVING BOTH SIDES THEIR STRONGEST CASE IS NEUTRAL

This series has run more than thirty Argument boxes across nine parts. Each takes a question, sets out two or three positions in the strongest form their holders would recognise, and reports a verdict that is often a deadlock. Part One announced this as one of the three rules of the method. By now the reader has been trained across four hundred pages to see it as the fair thing, and it is. It is fair about the half of the work it covers. The assumption is that it covers all of it. Before any balancing begins, three decisions have already been taken: **which questions get an Argument box, how many sides a question has, and where a question stops having sides at all.** None of the three is balanced by anything. All three are invisible, because they happen before the visible fairness starts.

Which questions. Part Four covered the woman Augustine lived with for over a decade and sent away so he could marry. She got a Hidden Assumption box and an Argument box about how the passage should be read. She did not get an Argument box on whether what he did was wrong, because this series treated that as a question without two sides. That was a decision. It is defensible. It was never announced, and a reader who would have disagreed had nowhere to watch it being made.

How many sides. Every Argument box in nine parts has two or three positions. Real disagreements are not shaped like that; they have long tails, unpopular positions, and people who reject the question. Three is the number that fits on a page and reads as thorough. The reader has been shown a landscape whose shape was partly set by a page size.

Where a question stops having sides. Part One declared that this series does not adjudicate religious claims, and it has said so whenever the material got close. That looks like the deepest neutrality available. It is a substantive position: it treats the central claims of the book as questions on which no verdict is available, which is itself one of the contested answers, and the one least congenial to the man being explained. Augustine did not think the truth of his religion was undecidable. Declining to rule is not standing outside that argument. It is standing at a particular point inside it without marking the spot.

The pattern is not confined to documents like this one. Any procedure that presents itself as balance makes its largest choices in the framing: the broadcaster giving both sides, the report with a range of views, the meeting that hears everybody. In each case the visible fairness is real, the selection that preceded it is unaudited, and the second is bigger than the first.

What follows for a reader who has finished nine parts is narrower than it might sound, and more useful. Not that the method was dishonest: the arguments were given at their strongest and the deadlocks were reported as deadlocks. What follows is that “both sides were given” is a claim about the answering and is silent about the asking. Where you find yourself disagreeing with this series, the disagreement is more likely to be about which questions were treated as open than about how the open ones were handled. And you will have to find those places yourself, because no document can list the questions it did not think to ask.

The general form: mistaking even-handedness in the answering for even-handedness in the asking.

That is the last box in the series, and it is the one I would most like a reader to take away from it, because unlike everything else here it is not about a book written sixteen hundred years ago. It is about the next document you read that tells you it has given both sides.

REMEMBER THIS

On these two books: **what the heaven of heaven is**, how the literal and allegorical readings are meant to fit together, and **why the work stops where it does** are all genuinely open.

What nine parts rest on: **the text, which is secure**. External checks exist for exactly two stretches — Cassiciacum and the Milan basilica crisis — plus one piece of marble for one person.

Everything else in the life is **one witness**.

The one requirement of the method this series never met: the author’s own **one-line position on religious material**, marked unfilled in all nine parts and unfilled here. Recorded rather than dropped.

And the last hidden assumption, which is about this series: **giving both sides their strongest case is not neutral**. Three decisions are taken before the balancing starts — which questions get an argument, how many sides they have, and where a question stops having sides — and none of them is balanced by anything.

So: **“both sides were given” is a claim about the answering and says nothing about the asking**. Where you disagree with this series, it will most likely be about what was treated as open. You will have to find those places yourself.

Timeline

The last timeline in the series covers the whole life rather than this part. The dates in it are the standard ones; where specialists disagree, the relevant part said so at the time.

Date	Event	Book
354	Born at Thagaste in Roman North Africa.	I
c. 370	The theft of the pears. A year idle at home.	II
371	His father Patricius is baptised and dies. Augustine is about seventeen.	IX
373	Reads Cicero's <i>Hortensius</i> and turns to philosophy. Joins the Manichees.	III
c. 372	His son Adeodatus is born to the woman he never names.	IV / IX
c. 376	The death of the friend at Thagaste, and the grief he later calls a fault.	IV
383	Sails for Rome, deceiving his mother on the shore.	V
384	Takes the chair of rhetoric at Milan. Hears Ambrose.	V
385	Monica arrives. The woman is sent back to Africa; a marriage is arranged.	VI
386	The books of the Platonists. Evil understood as privation.	VII
Aug 386	The garden. Tolle lege. He stops arguing.	VIII
autumn 386	Resigns the chair at the vintage holiday. Cassiciacum: four surviving books, and the toothache.	IX
24 Apr 387	Baptised at the Easter vigil with Alypius and Adeodatus.	IX
387	Ostia: the conversation at the window. Monica dies nine days later, aged fifty-six.	IX
388	Returns to Africa. Adeodatus and Nebridius die within about two years.	IX
391	Ordained priest at Hippo against his intentions; bishop about four years later.	outside
c. 397–400	The <i>Confessions</i> is written. Books X to XIII: memory, time, and the first chapter of Genesis.	X–XIII

Date	Event	Book
c. 405	Pelagius, in Rome, objects to a sentence in Book X. Twenty years of argument follow.	outside
430	Dies at Hippo with the last book against Julian unfinished.	outside

The Thirteen Books and the Nine Parts

Books	What is in them	Part
I	Infancy, school, the restless heart.	One
II–III	The pears; Carthage; <i>Hortensius</i> ; the Manichees.	Two
IV–V	The dead friend and the grief; astrology; Faustus; Rome and Milan.	Three
VI–VII	Monica in Milan; the woman sent away; the Platonists; where evil comes from.	Four
VIII	Victorinus, Antony, the two wills, the garden.	Five
IX	The resignation, Cassiciacum, the baptism, Ostia, Monica's death.	Six
X	Memory, the happy life, present temptation, and four words about grace.	Seven
XI	Creation, and what time is.	Eight
XII–XIII	Formless matter, many true meanings, the six days, and the day with no evening.	Nine

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Terms carried over from earlier parts are repeated so this part stands alone.

Term	What it means
Allegorical reading	Taking the items in a text to stand for something other than what they name. For Augustine an additional layer on a true literal reading, not a substitute for one.
Caelum caeli	The heaven of heaven. A created reality that never changes, and therefore has no succession and no time. Augustine takes the phrase from a psalm.
Confessio	Confessing sin, confessing faith and confessing praise, all at once. The word the book is named for.
Distentio	A stretching-out, and also a being-pulled-apart. Augustine's answer in Book XI to what time is.
Esse, nosse, velle	Being, knowing, willing: the three inseparable aspects of one mind that Book XIII offers as an analogy for the Trinity, with a warning attached.
Formless matter	Not nothing and not chaos: pure capacity, whatever it is about a thing that lets it be otherwise than it is.
Fourfold sense	The medieval system in which every passage has a literal, an allegorical, a moral and a last-things sense. Downstream of Augustine, though he proposed no number.
Pondus	Weight — in the physics of the period, not a downward force but the tendency in a thing that decides where it belongs. “My weight is my love.”
Privation	A missing good in something that ought to have had it. Augustine's account of what evil is, from Book VII.
Regula fidei	The rule of faith: the settled central claims of the religion, against which any proposed reading of scripture is measured.
Retractations	The book Augustine wrote near the end of his life going back over everything he had published. The main evidence for how he regarded the shape of the <i>Confessions</i> .
Sabbath	The seventh day. In Book XIII the day the text does not close with an evening, read as a rest that does not end.
Typology	Narrower than allegory: reading an earlier person or event as prefiguring a later one. Stays inside history.

About the Author

This series is read and explained by Lovepreet Singh, and published as part of The Living Archive at misterlove.in.

The Living Archive takes difficult material and rebuilds it so that anyone can follow it, without dropping the hard parts along the way. Its first series was a fourteen-part history of Punjab running to around nine hundred and fifty pages. This is its second, now complete.

I read the book, I did the reading around it, and I wrote down what I found. I am not a specialist in late antiquity and I am not going to pretend to be one. Where a question is genuinely contested among people who are, I have said so and given each side its strongest case rather than choosing for you, with the qualification Chapter Ten sets out at length. Where I could not find out, I have written that I could not find out.

The method used here was worked out on the Punjab series and is written up as a portable specification, so that any part of this work can be checked, continued or rebuilt by somebody else. That is the point of an archive that calls itself living.

[Editorial note, to be replaced before publishing: the method requires a one-line statement of the author's own position with regard to religious material, placed where readers will see it. It has been carried forward unfilled through all nine parts and is unfilled here; it cannot be invented on the author's behalf. Chapter Ten records the omission rather than dropping it quietly.]

The Living Archive

The Living Archive is a method for writing hard things simply without making them shallow. It was developed by Lovepreet Singh and tested on a fourteen-part history of Punjab. It runs on three rules.

One. Simplification is not compression. The simple version is usually longer than the difficult one. Words are being spent to buy comprehension.

Two. Two dials, turned in opposite directions. Language as simple as it can be made. Content as deep as the subject actually goes. Turning both down produces something readable and useless.

Three. Every side gets its strongest case, and where nothing settles a question, that gets said. A verdict that honestly reports a deadlock is worth more than a tidy answer that is not true. The last Hidden Assumption of this series is about the limits of that rule, and a method that could not survive being examined by its own instruments would not be worth much.

A word on sources

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record rather than new primary research, and it is written for readers who want to understand a book, not for specialists who want to check my workings. Chapter Ten of this part sets out what the whole series rests on.

What the archive is good at here. Book Twelve is a short, self-contained argument and the claims made about it in Chapters Four and Five are claims about what is on the page. Anybody with a translation can check them, and should.

What it is bad at here. Tracing influence. Chapter Five is careful about this and it is worth repeating: following an idea from the fifth century to the twentieth is a genre with a poor record, because the resemblances are easy to find and the connections are hard to establish. Where this part says a line of transmission can be shown, it says so; where it says only that a resemblance exists, that is the stronger claim it is prepared to make.

On Book Thirteen. This part covers about a hundred pages of allegory in one chapter, deliberately, and Chapter One argues for that decision rather than assuming it. A reader who wants the item-by-item reading will not find it here and should go to a commentary.

On translations. All renderings of Augustine in this document, and in the eight before it, are my own plain-English paraphrases, made deliberately loose so that they explain rather than reproduce. They are not quotations from any published translation and should not be cited as such. Where the exact wording matters, go to a proper edition.

Corrections are welcome and will be acted on. Later editions will record what was changed and who caught it.

Where To Go Next

Nine parts end here, so instead of pointing at a tenth, this section points outwards. It is a short list rather than a survey, and it is ordered by what a reader of this series is most likely to want next.

Read the book. That is the whole point of this series and it has not been a substitute. Several good English versions exist and they differ more than you would expect — this work is unusually hard to translate, and Part Eight's Chapter Ten set out three things that no version carries. Look at two before settling, read the first page of each, and take the one whose voice you can hear.

- **If you want more Augustine on reading:** *On Christian Teaching* is short by his standards and is where the principles of Chapter Five are set out properly, including the test about building up love.
- **If you want the other great work:** *The City of God*, which is enormous, was written over more than a decade, and contains among much else the argument about the passions that Part Six used to test whether he changed his mind about grief.
- **If Chapter Eight interested you:** *On the Trinity*, where the triad in the mind gets fifteen books instead of a paragraph.
- **If you want to know what he thought of his own work:** the *Retractations*, in which an old man goes back through everything he published and corrects it. It is the source for several claims in Parts Seven, Eight and Nine.
- **For the life:** Peter Brown's biography, first published in 1967 and revised with a substantial new epilogue, is the standard one and is a genuinely good book rather than a dutiful one.
- **For the text, line by line:** James O'Donnell's three-volume edition and commentary is where the arguments this series summarises are conducted at full length.

And a last note about this series. It was written to be checked. Every part names what it rests on, says where it is guessing, and declares a position where it has one rather than hiding behind the material. If you find an error, it is an error and it will be corrected. If you find a question that was quietly treated as having no sides, that is the more interesting find, and Chapter Ten of this part is about why you should expect there to be some.

Index of Hidden Assumptions

Every Hidden Assumption box in the series, in the order they appear. Each one names a premise the reader is likely to be carrying without having chosen it, tests it somewhere ordinary, and says what follows. The last one, on page 462, is about the series itself.

Part One — The Restless Heart

That a life has a plot	10
That confession is the opposite of self-defence	16
That a book has one subject	24
That autobiography reports memory	32
That a word is a label	41
That seriousness is a property of the activity	43
That this can be done at all	55

Part Two — The Pears and the Manichees

That the size of a wrong tracks its seriousness	72
That an act has a motive, singular	83
That a group is a collection of individuals	86
That feeling is practice	92
That a religion is a set of claims you assess	102

Part Three — The Dead Friend and the Disappointing Bishop

That a false belief needs a foolish believer	122
That love and attachment are the same thing	137
That people leave a belief when it is refuted	144
That a story with a good ending had to happen that way	148

Part Four — Milan, Ambrose, and Where Evil Comes From

That happiness is a quantity	175
That a spectator is not a participant	178
That the injured party is in the text	188
That to be real is to be somewhere	194
That explaining a thing means saying what it is made of	205

Part Five — The Garden

That a conversion happens inside one person	231
That wanting a thing means pursuing it	239
That the self is one agent issuing commands	243
That a decision is made at the moment it becomes visible	250

That how you arrived at a text is separate from what it says 254

Part Six — The Water, the Window and the Grave

That the strength of a conviction can be read off the drama of the act that follows it 270

That an event has either a natural explanation or a divine one, and they compete for the same slot 279

That a relationship leaves a trace in the text in proportion to its weight 287

That “the same experience” is something you can check 302

That consistency is the test of sincerity 307

Part Seven — The Vast Palace of Memory

That a life story is finished when it reaches the present 326

That memory is a record of the past 335

That you can find out what you are by looking inward 349

That a temptation can be tested by removing its object 354

That a doctrine is refuted by the behaviour it licenses 359

Part Eight — What Is Time?

That “before” is always available 382

That a word you can use is a word you can define 388

That the present is a duration 392

That if something is in the mind it is not real 400

That a thinker is refuted by being used as an example 410

Part Nine — The First Sentence of the Bible

That if you cannot picture it you cannot think it 433

That a sentence has one meaning, which is what the writer meant 437

That being sure you are right and being sure others are wrong are the same confidence 445

That allegory is what you do when the literal reading fails 448

That giving both sides their strongest case is neutral 462

Index of Arguments

Every Argument box in the series, in the order they appear. Each sets out a question on which serious readers genuinely disagree, gives each position the strongest case its holders would recognise, and ends with what would settle it and why anybody cares. Many report a deadlock. Part Nine, Chapter Ten is about what that procedure hides.

Part One — The Restless Heart

Is this the first autobiography?	9
Are the last four books a different book?	23
Is this christianity, or platonism in a robe?	29
Is the jealous baby evidence of anything?	36
Was wittgenstein fair to augustine?	41

Part Two — The Pears and the Manichees

Was augustine really that bad?	72
Is the pear theft actually motiveless?	83
Does the attack on tragedy work?	91
Is augustine fair to the manichees?	99

Part Three — The Dead Friend and the Disappointing Bishop

Is the account of the grief a record or a reading?	132
Does "love them in god" cancel loving them?	136
Is augustine fair to faustus?	145
What did augustine actually believe in these years?	150

Part Four — Milan, Ambrose, and Where Evil Comes From

Was silent reading unusual in antiquity?	170
How should the sending away be read?	187
Which books, and how much did he owe them?	199
Does the privation account of evil work?	203

Part Five — The Garden

What was actually holding him back?	222
Had they really never heard of any of this?	234
Does the two-wills account hold together?	246
Did the garden scene happen as described?	253

Part Six — The Water, the Window and the Grave

Do the cassiciacum dialogues support or undermine book nine?	275
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Is this a portrait or a hagiography?	293
Is ostia the same kind of event as the ascent in book seven?	301
Did he change his mind about grief?	308

Part Seven — The Vast Palace of Memory

Does book ten belong?	328
Did augustine invent interiority?	346
Is the confession of present temptation candour or performance?	354
Was pelagius fairly represented?	360

Part Eight — What Is Time?

Is eternity a real distinction or an evasion?	383
Do the past and the future exist?	393
Is this a theory of time, or a theory of time-perception?	401
Does the psalm example prove what augustine wants?	405

Part Nine — The First Sentence of the Bible

Are the last two books worth reading?	427
Is book twelve an anticipation of modern reading theory?	440
Is the allegorical reading interpretation or invention?	450
Does the work end well?	458

Index of Terms

Every term given a Word Box, alphabetically. Each part also has its own glossary at the back of that part, which repeats terms carried over from earlier parts so that each part stands alone; this index points instead at the place a term is first explained in full.

"Nobody does wrong willingly"	81
Academic scepticism	150
Adulescentia	67
Agentes in rebus	236
Allegorical reading	448
The Ambrosian hymns	282
Antony of Egypt (roughly 251 to 356)	234
Aristotle's Categories	140
The Augustinian picture of language	40
Beata vita — the happy life	341
Caelum caeli — the heaven of heaven	429
Catechumen	51
Catechumen	281
Catharsis	91
Catiline	79
Concubinatus	118
Concupiscentia, and the three-part division	349
Confessio	17
Consuetudo (habit, custom)	241
Continence (continentia)	238
Creatio ex nihilo — making out of nothing	386
Curiositas	353
Cyprian	148
De magistro — "On the Teacher"	286
Decurio (town councillor)	14
Distentio	398
Divine simplicity	28
The Elect and the Hearers	98
Emergency baptism	125
Epicurus	183
Esse, nosse, velle — being, knowing, willing	453
Eternity, and why it is not everlastingness	382
Eversores, "the Wreckers" or "the Overturners"	90
Feriae vindemiales	269

Figurative reading	152
The fourfold sense of scripture	442
The gladiatorial games	177
Grammaticus (grammar teacher)	44
Gratia — grace	345
Haruspex	119
Hortensius	94
In principio — “in the beginning”	387
Julian’s teaching law (17 June 362)	227
The liberal arts	118
Manichaeism	98
Mathematicus	121
Meals at the martyrs’ shrines	169
Memoria	333
Meribibula	290
The Milanese basilica crisis	283
Numidia	13
The Old Latin Bible	97
Opening a book at random for guidance	252
Original sin	36
Ostia	295
Otium	273
Panegyric	173
Pelagianism	38
Pelagius	358
Philosophy (in the ancient sense)	95
The Platonists (Neoplatonism)	197
Presentism and the block universe	393
Privation	202
The problem of enquiry	27
The Psalms	19
The public baths	68
Quintus Aurelius Symmachus	151
Regula fidei — the rule of faith	440
Rhetoric	44
Simplicianus	223
Testimony	182
The three presents	399
The two addressees	326

The Confessions, Explained — complete in nine parts

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